An Introduction to Japanese Syntax, Grammar & Language

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Secondly, many people from the online community helped me in learning how to phrase myself so that explanations were understandable, and corrected me when I got things wrong — something that definitely improves anyone's skill at anything by reinforcing that some things shouldn't be what you thought them to be. Many of these were from the IRC channel "#nihongo" on the irchighway network, and while some people have since moved on, others have stuck around and it remains a nice source of conversation concerning Japanese and other matters to this day.

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Preface

You are reading the first revision (or if you bought this, also the first print version!) of the Japanese grammar book that I started writing while I was still taking classes in Japanese... and consequently failed at (the book, not the courses). I have to admit, I was a bit overzealous. While I enjoyed learning and through the process of explaining the things I had learnt to others via what became www.nihongoresources.com, I was still a first year student with not exactly a lot of weight or experience under my belt. The first version of my book I offered to my teacher to scrutinise, and scrutinise he did. In retrospect, it's a good thing he did, because it took forever to get from the draft version to an edited final version. Instead, in 2005 I decided that the information I was offering the world was somewhat out of date, and needed a rewrite. I also knew that I had to do something with the book: I had promised many people by now I would finish it and I didn't like the idea of letting those people down. As such, I began to write what ended up as a permanent draft copy of a grammar book, freely available from the nihongoresources.com website, in 2005-2006.

Three years later, the book has certainly proved its popularity. Well over a hundred thousand downloads later, and with over fifteen thousand hits on it per week still, the time has finally come to revise it, and give everyone what they've been asking for for some time now: a proper paper version in addition to the digital copy.

It's taken close to a year to go from deciding to revise the old grammar book to being able to offer you a restructured, reworked, and more than half rewritten book on the Japanese language, but hopefully the wait was worth it. I've spent as much time on it as I could, in between my normal job and spending time on vacations in Canada to be with the person who has helped me tremendously in getting this book done and keeping me motivated to do so, and I hope the result is something you feel was worth paying money for. Or, if you didn't buy it but are reading this as a digital copy, then I hope you might find it good enough to want to have it sitting on your shelf as paper copy as well.

This book was written in several phases, using several programs. The first full-content version was based on the original "An Introduction to Japanese Syntax, Grammar and Language" written in 2005, which was written in plain text using Textpad, after which it got turned into DocBook XML using XMLmind XML Editor. This was then converted to WordprocessingML using a custom script, and final styling was done in Microsoft Word, before converting that to PDF form using Adobe's Acrobat PDF building tools.

The new process is actually much more fun, and allows me to automate the whole book-making process in the future, when errata must be processed, and new content is added.

The data itself now lives on the internet, and can be found on http://grammar.nihongoresources.com as a dokuwiki documentation project. Because dokuwiki stores its data as plain text files, I wrote a set of conversion scripts to turn the dokuwiki code into LaTeX code, which then gets run through the XeLaTeX processing engine, which results in a fully indexed, cross-referenced, ToC-ed and for all intents and purposes publication-ready PDF file.

In the end, I had fun rewriting the book, and putting together the technologies to turn the book content into something you can actually read, and I hope you will have fun reading this, and find it aids you in your studies of Japanese. Thank you for making writing this worth while, and good luck!

Mike "Pomax" Kamermans

Chapter 1

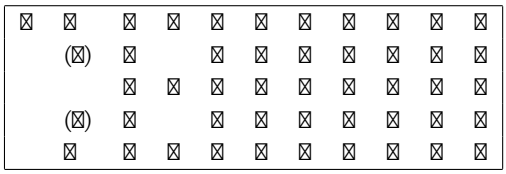
The english

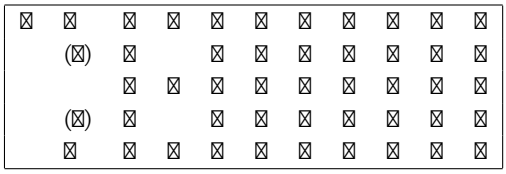
glossary in the Japanese language comes in several parts. From the lowest to the highest, we see the *glossary* and *glossary*, used to compose words, which are used to compose sentences, which in turn function as the building blocks of the spoken and written language. We will look at each of these "blocks" in order, and look at how they all come together to form the Japanese language.

1.1 The kana

1.1.1 The basics

What the alphabet is to western languages, the japanese, "gojuuon", is to Japanese. This Japanese english is a collection of 46 *glossary* (roughly half of which have 'voiced' counterparts) that act as english in the Japanese language. Arranged in the traditional way, and read top-down, right-to-left, these 46 english can be written in either of two scripts: english and english:





Transcribing these tables into western, and more specifically English, sounds, the table looks roughly as follows:

n	wa	ra	ya	ma	ha	na	ta	sa	ka	a
	(wi)	ri		mi	hi	ni	chi	shi	ki	i
		ru	yu	mu	fu	nu	tsu	su	ku	u
	(we)	re		me	he	ne	te	se	ke	e
	(w)o	ro	yo	mo	ho	no	to	so	ko	o

These tables seem to contain 48 syllables instead of 46, but the two syllables 'wi' and 'we', (english/☒ and ☒/☒) have not been in use since the Japanese language was revised following shortly after the second world war. They have been included here only for completeness, and in modern Japanese do not appear in the *glossary* table. The ☒ is still very much in use, but only as a grammatical particle that is pronounced as ☒, and so the only accurate transcription is as 'o'. However, in names it may be pronounced as 'wo', and so we find the consonant in parentheses in the table of transcriptions.

We can look at these tables in two ways. Firstly, as arrangements in columns. When doing so, the first column (going right to left rather than left to right) is called the ☒—column, the second column the ☒—column, and so forth. We can also look at them as arrangements of rows, in which case the first row is called the ☒—row, the second one the ☒—row, followed by the ☒—, ☒— and ☒—rows. Thus, the katakana symbol ☒ for instance can be found on the ☒—row of the ☒—column.

Some of these columns have 'voiced' variants. english is a linguistic term used to indicate consonants that are pronounced with air running past the english. In Japanese, the ☒-, ☒-, ☒- and ☒—columns (ka, sa, ta and ha) can be given a special english*glossary* mark, called 'dakuten' (japanese) to indicate they are voiced rather than plain, changing their *glossary*:

☒/☒	☒/☒	☒/☒	☒/☒
☒/☒	☒/☒	☒/☒	☒/☒
☒/☒	☒/☒	☒/☒	☒/☒
☒/☒	☒/☒	☒/☒	☒/☒
☒/☒	☒/☒	☒/☒	☒/☒

Which is transcribed as:

ba	da	za	ga
bi	dzi	ji	gi
bu	dzu	zu	gu
be	de	ze	ge
bo	do	zo	go

A note about 'dzi' and 'dzu': while these are technically the correct transcriptions for ◎ and ◎, these syllables have been rendered obsolete in current Japanese, with words that used to use ☒ now using ☒, and words that use ☒ now using ☒. This will be explained in a bit more detail in the section on pronunciation.

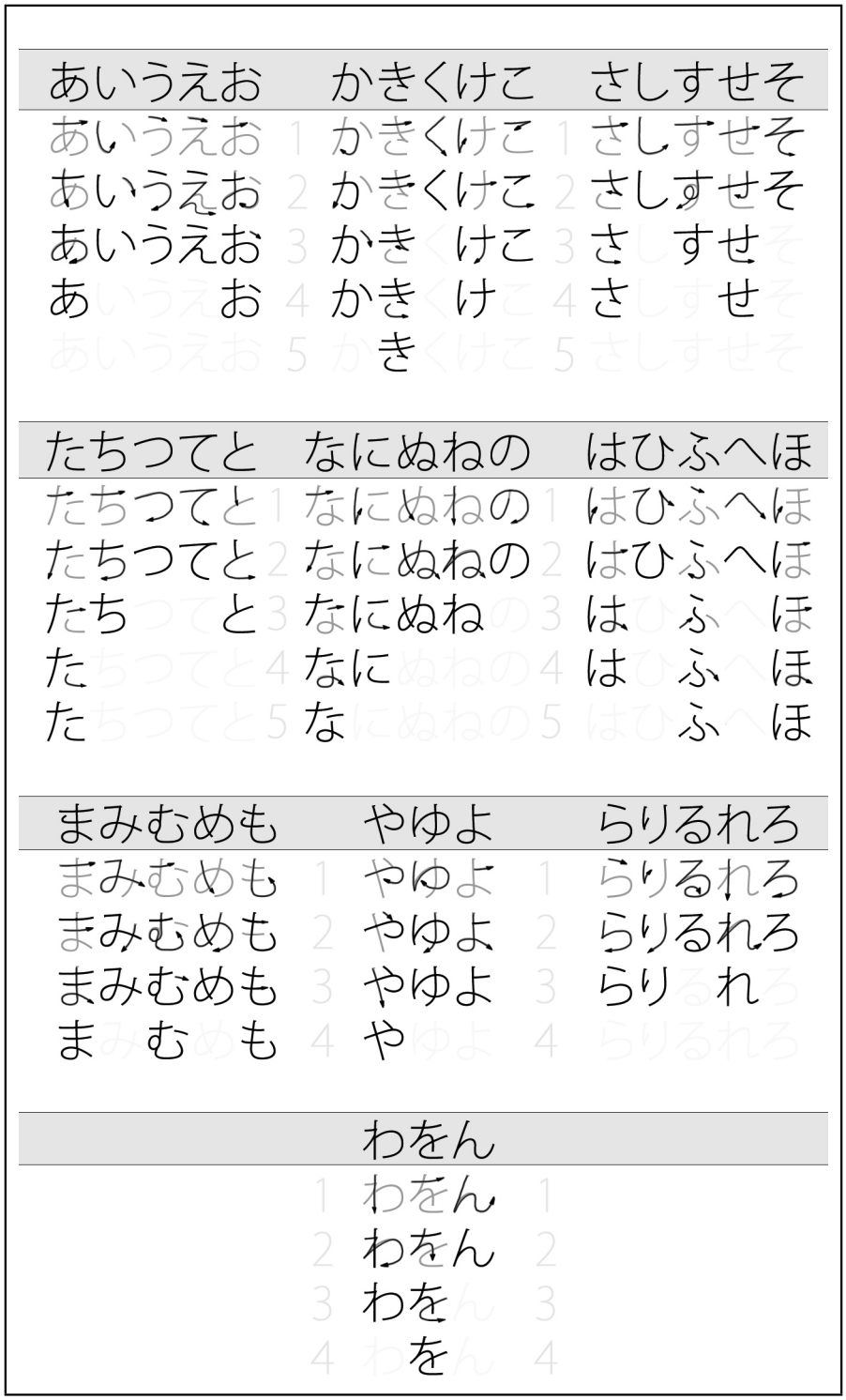
In addition to this regular voicing, the ☒—column has a secondary voicing, indicated with a small circle english mark, called 'handakuten' (japanese), which rather than producing

a ‘b’ sound, produces a ‘p’ sound:

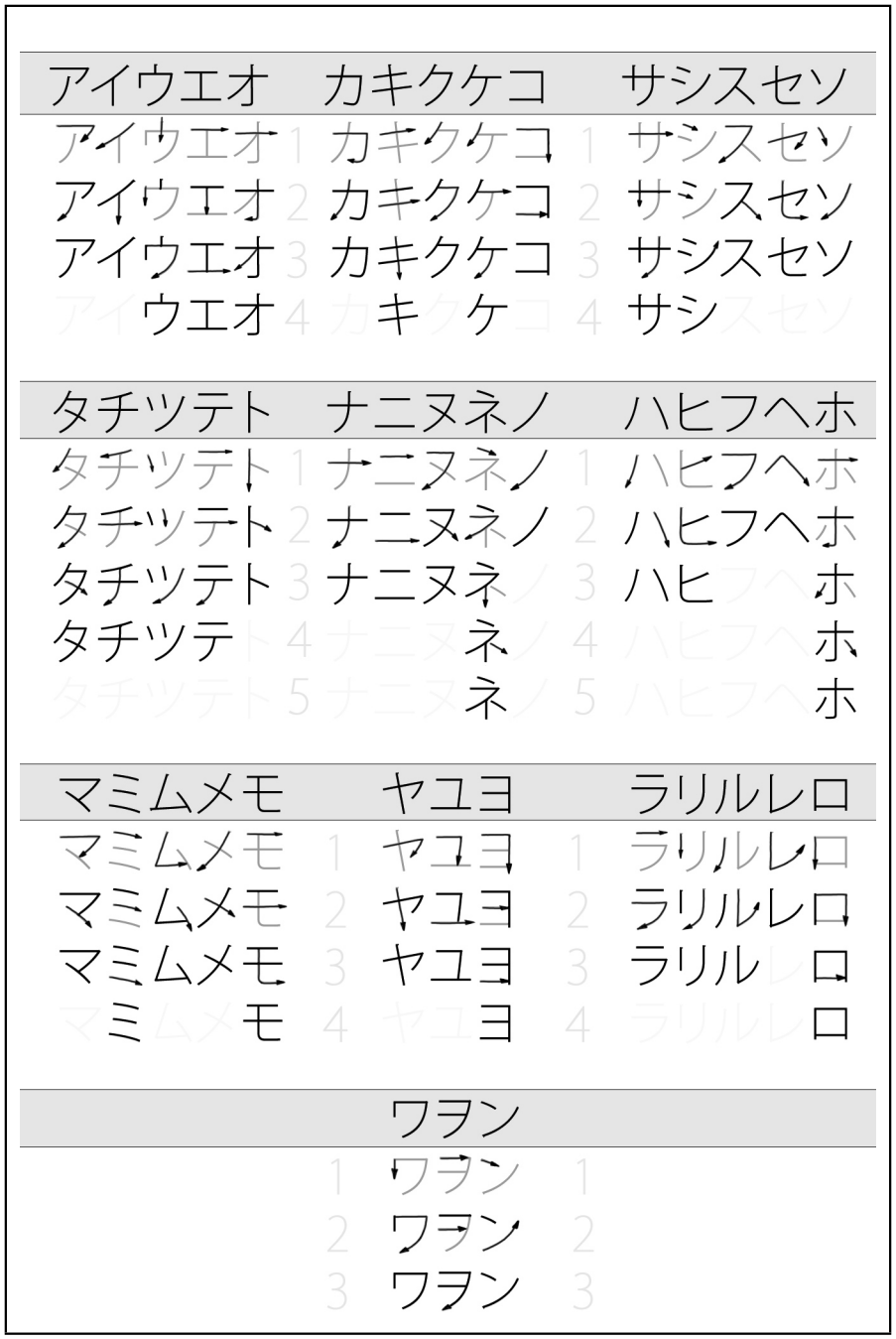
□/□	pa
□/□	pi
□/□	pu
□/□	pe
□/□	po

1.1.2 Writing the kana

Both hiragana and katakana may be relatively simple scripts compared to the complex Chinese characters also in use in Japanese, but they both have specific ways of writing each syllable. The following tables show how to write both hiragana and katakana the proper way. Note that these written versions look different in places from print form.



Stroke diagrams for hiragana



Stroke diagrams for katakana

1.1.3 Pronouncing Japanese

english wise, each of these syllables is equally long. This is traditionally explained by referring to the pronunciation of Japanese as english, a linguistic term meaning "the time required to pronounce an ordinary or normal short sound or syllable". In Japan, this concept of mora is usually explained with the easier concept of englishs: each basic syllable is one beat long, with certain combinations of kana lasting one and a half or two beats.

The vowel sounds of Japanese, □, □, □, □ and □ do not all have English equivalents; □ is actually identical to the initial vowel sound in "I" or "eye" — that is, the 'a' sound without the finalising 'i' sound. The □ is a little easier, sounding like the 'ee' in 'creep'. The ◎ is particularly annoying, because there is no English equivalent. It is identical to the vowel sounds of properly Scottish 'you' or 'do', or the Dutch open 'u' such as in 'huren'. ◎ is pronounced like in the English 'help', and the □, finally, is pronounced like the 'o' in 'or'.

While for most kana the english sound is reasonably approximated by the transcribed consonant as listed in the earlier tables, there are a few notable exceptions. For instance, while romanised as "hi", □/□ is usually pronounced with a consonant that doesn't sound like an 'h', but more like the German or Scottish "ch" as found in German words such as "ich" (meaning "I") and Scottish words such as "loch" (meaning "lake").

Also in the ◎-column, the syllable □/□ does not have an 'h' as consonant sound, or even the 'f' consonant sound that it is typically transcribed with, but rather uses only pure english as initial sound. This is mostly unknown in western languages, and will be the hardest to get right for people starting out with Japanese. Rather than being formed in the mouth, the syllable □ starts being formed at the english, while breathing out. Paired with the lips shaped as if casually blowing out a match or candle (rather than tightened for whistling), this rush of air is then given a vowel sound, and the syllable is complete.

In the □—column we also see an interesting pronunciation 'quirk': while ◎ and ◎, strictly speaking, have voiced versions, written □ and □, over the years the difference in pronunciation between □ and □, and □ and □, has all but disappeared, leading to an official move towards replacing these □ and □ with □ and □ entirely. However, there are (quite a number of) exceptions to this move for replacement: if the two first kana of a word are the same, but the second one is voiced, the same kana are used (for example, □□□ and □□□□). Also, in compound words in which voicing occurs, the original kana form is used (for instance, □ + □□ □ □□□ and □ + □ □ □□). This exception only applies when the compound word can be considered a combination of words. Both □□□ and □□ derive their meaning from their constituent words, but in a word like □□, meaning "lightning", the first kanji refers to rice plants, and the second kanji refers to (someone's) wife. In these words, even if the affixed compound would normally have a □ or □, the voicing is written as □ or □ in modern Japanese, rather than □ or □.

That said, voicing in compound nouns is a bit strange in that there are no rules to tell when something will, or will not voice, so the best strategy — which applies to learning words in general anyway — is to learn words as word first, then learn them as combinations, rather than the other way around.

Finally, the □—column can be a problem because for most western listeners, different people will seem to pronounce the initial consonant in this column differently. While in many western languages the consonants “d”, “l”, and “r” are considered quite distinct, in Japanese this distinction is far less; any syllable starting with a consonant ranging from a full fledged “l” to a rolling Spanish “r” will be interpreted as a syllable from the □—column, with the “standard” pronunciation being somewhere between a “d” and an “r”.

Not pronouncing Japanese

This sounds like an oddly named section, but some bits in written Japanese are actually not really pronounced at all. In fact, not infrequently you will hear Japanese that does not seem to reflect the written form, with the verb “desu” seemingly being pronounced “des”, the adjective “hayaku” seemingly being pronounced “hayak”, the command “shiro” seemingly being pronounced “sh’ro”, and many more of such vocal omissions.

In fact, many syllables with an □— or □—sound tend to have these vowel sounds left almost unpronounced. I say almost, because the vowel sound is typically preserved by virtue of the consonants used. For instance, the word □□□, transcribed as ‘soshite’ is typically pronounced in such a way that it can be considered transcribable as “sosh’te” instead. However, forming “sh” means also forming a pseudo-vowel sound. In fact, even in this “omitted vowel” there is room for variation, so that a “sh” can sound like it was supposed to become “shi” or “shu”, and it is this feature that is exploited quite heavily in Japanese.

This leads to a small problem. Because it sounds like the vowel is entirely missing, you might be tempted to mimic this sound, but end up genuinely omitting the vowel entirely because that’s what your ears — which are not yet accustomed to Japanese phonetics — think is happening. However, this also makes your Japanese highly unnatural, because to a Japanese ear the vowel is only mostly omitted, not entirely.

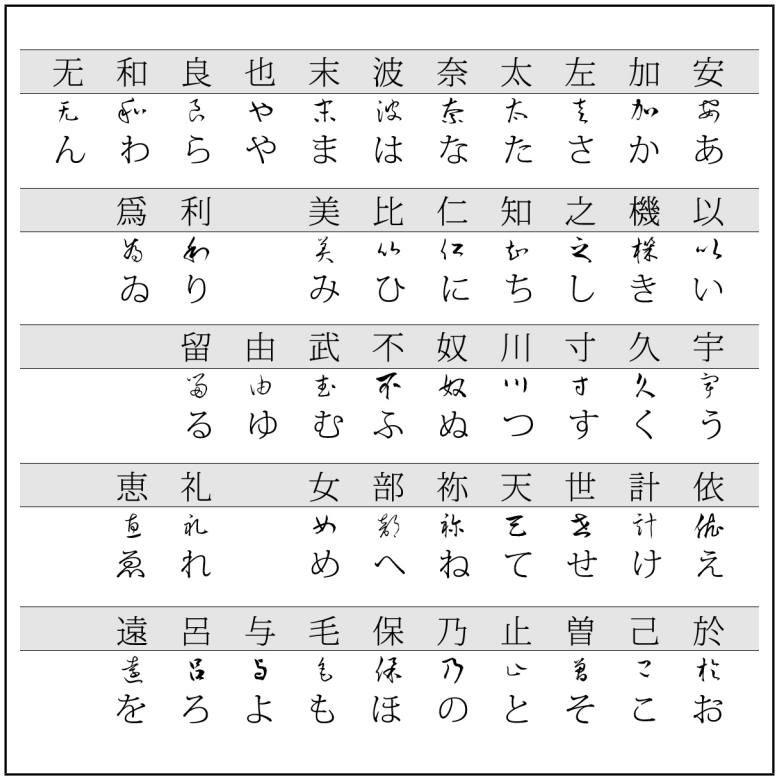
The problem then is one of hearing: when learning a new language it is important to “unlearn” how to hear language. Much like how we have learned to see the world in a way that it’s actually not (you will consider a brown table with a light shining on one end, brown, instead of brown on one end, and a completely different colour where the light is hitting it), as infants we learn to disregard any and all sounds that don’t feature in the languages we’re raised with. As such, remarkable as this may sound, we unlearn how to hear things accurately, and instead learn how to map what we hear to what we know the language is supposed to sound like. While highly effective when learning a language, or a family of languages with similar pronunciations, it’s disastrous when learning a language that has a different phonetic system.

The best advice with regards to this is to simply listen to a lot of Japanese. It takes time and effort to unlearn the unconscious mapping your brain does for you. You’re going to get it wrong, but as long as you know you are, you’ll be on the right track.

1.1.4 Hiragana and katakana differences

If hiragana and katakana sound exactly the same, why then are there two different scripts?

When the Japanese first developed a written system, it was based on the characters used in China for the Chinese language, in which for the most part the meaning of the characters were subservient to what they sounded like: if a word had an “a” sound in it, then any english that sounded like “a” could be used for it, without any real regard for its meaning. This “using certain characters for their sound only” became more widespread as the number of characters per syllable dropped from quite many to only a handful, and as writing became more widespread two englishs developed. One, which simplified english by omitting parts of them lead to what is today called english. Another, which simplified phonetic kanji by further and further reducing the complexity of the cursive forms for these kanji, has become what is known today as english. We can see this illustrated in the next figure, which shows the characters the hiragana came from, and the highly stylistic cursive form characters had, highlighting the degree of simplification that cursive writing brought with it.



The hiragana derivations from cursive script

Katakana got a slightly different treatment, in that these are actually fragments of characters, rather than stylistic simplifications. The second derivations figure illustrates this,

with a note that the fragments were lifted from handwritten characters, so that the "logic" is mostly found in the cursive line of characters.

These two scripts have differed in roles throughout history, and in modern Japanese hiragana is used for anything Japanese that does not use (or need) kanji, and katakana is used in the same way that we use italics in western language, as well as for words that have been imported into Japanese from other languages over the course of history. The only genuine difference between the two scripts is the way in which long vowel sounds are written, as we shall see in the next section.



The katakana derivations

1.2 Writing spoken Japanese

Using the kana as basic building blocks, Japanese pronunciation consists of a few more things beyond basic syllables: in addition to "simple" syllable sounds, it contains englishs, englishs

and englishs.

englishs, contrary to the name, do not always mean "the same vowel, twice as long". Strictly speaking, a long vowel in Japanese is a combination of two vowels, pronounced over two "englishs". In katakana, long vowels are really just that, a vowel with a dash to indicate the sound has been doubled in length, but in hiragana the doubling is different. Of the five basic Japanese vowel sounds (□, □, □, □ and □) the first three have fairly simple long vowel counterparts in hiragana, simply doubling in writing, but the latter two are more complicated, having two different written forms:

	hiragana	katakana
□	□□	□□
□	□□	□□
□	□□	□□
□	□□, □□	□□
□	□□, □□	□□

While the pronunciation for □□, □□ and □□ are intuitive (same sound, twice as long), the pronunciations for □□, □□, □□ and □□ and more subtle. The first, □□, may be pronounced as a "same sound, twice as long" □, but may also be pronounced as □□, which is similar to the '-ay' in the English 'hay'. For ◎◎, the pronunciation is like "oa" in "oak", with □□ often sounding the same, but when pronounced slowly, having a distinct hint of "u" at the end.

This doubling is the same for syllables with consonant sounds, so that for instance vowel doubling for the syllables from the □—column look as follows:

	hiragana	katakana
□	□□	□□
□	□□	□□
□	□□	□□
□	□□, □□	□□
□	□□, □□	□□

In addition to long vowels, Japanese words may contain "englishs". Being considered *glossary* of ◎—row syllables with any one of the three syllables ◎, □ and □, glides are written as the □—row syllable, normal sized, and then the □, □ or □ syllable at either half height (for horizontally written Japanese) or half width (for vertically written Japanese). To illustrate:

	kana	pronunciation	as glide	pronunciation
□ + □	□□	kiya	□□	kya
□ + □	□□	shiyu	□□	shu
□ + □	□□	chiyo	□□	cho
□ + □	□□	miya	□□	mya
□ + □	□□	hiyo	□□	hyo

	kana	pronunciation	as glide	pronunciation
□ + □	□□	niyu	□□	nyu
□ + □	□□	riyo	□□	ryo

While a written combination of two syllables, the glide it represents is only a single "english" long, just as the regular syllables. Thus, the word □□□□ is three beats long: spelled out, it will be pronounced □□, □ and □.

Finally, the last feature of spoken Japanese reflected in writing is what is known as the "english": a reasonably recent change to the way Japanese is written (in the sense that this change occurred sometime during the medieval period, when written Japanese had been around for a little under a millennium) which indicates that a particular consonant has a short pause before it is actually pronounced. This consonant doubling is found in a number of western languages as well, such as in Italian, where words like 'tutti' have a written double consonant while in terms of pronunciation there is simply a pause before the consonant. In Japanese, because there are no actual 'loose' consonants, the doubling is represented by a special character: a □ (or □) written either half height (in horizontal writing) or half width (in vertical writing) to indicate the pause. To illustrate the difference between this small □/□ and the regular form, a few example words:

small □	pronunciation	meaning
□□□	"hakka"	ignition
□□□	"shikke"	humidity
□□□	"makka"	intensely red

normal □	pronunciation	meaning
□□□	"hatsuka"	20 days/20th day
□□□	"shitsuke"	upbringing
□□□	"matsuka"	the 'Pine' family of trees

This "◎/◎ as a pause" is also applied when a english*glossary* is needed in for instance an exclamation, "◎◎!", which is an exclamation with a "cut off" rather than long vowel sound.

1.2.1 Katakana specific

As english has been used to write out words imported from other languages into Japanese, it has a few extra "rules" that do not apply to written hiragana, including a number of ways to produce normally english: syllables that do not fit in the Japanese table of syllables, but are found in foreign words nonetheless. Examples of these are for instance the initial syllable "fi" in the English word "fire", or the "swe" in "Sweden".

The table of approximating writing is as follows, observing English pronunciation rules (combinations with normal Japanese orthography are omitted):

	a	e	i	o	u
ch		□□			
d			□□		□□
f	□□	□□	□□	□□	
fj/fy					□□□
j		□□			
q	□□	□□	□□	□□	□
s			□□		
sh		□□			
sw	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
t			□□		□□
v (1)	□□	□□	□□	□□	□
w		□□	□□	□□	□
x	□□□	□□□	□□□□	□□□	□□□
y		□□	□		
z			□□		

Note that 'wo' is not □ (as that is pronounced □), and that for the 'x' series, the leading □ is the consonant doubling symbol.

In addition to these, there are also a number of consonants which, in terms of pronunciation, already have Japanese counterparts:

consonant	column
c, pronounced as 's'	uses the □—column
c, pronounced as 'k'	uses the □—column
l	uses the □—column
v (2)	uses the □—column. Preferred to 'v (1)' in the above table.

Due to the fact that most english have come from some specific language, many of which are not English, Japanese loan words may have a different written form than expected. For instance, Brussels is written as □□□□□□, "buryusseru", rather than □□□□□, "buraseruzu", and English (the people) is written as □□□□, "igirisu", rather than □□□□□□□, "ingurisshu".

1.2.2 english and writing

Of course, in addition to a "letter" script, there is english*glossary* — symbols that indicate pauses, stops, quotes and other such things. In Japanese, the following *glossary* symbols are common:

	symbol
english	□
english	□
englishs	□ and □
englishs	□ and □
english	□ and □
english	□
englishs	□ and □
english	□
english	… (usually written twice: ……)

Less used, but always good to have seen are the following:

	symbol
english	□
englishs	□, □
englishs	□, □
kanji english	□

And then there are western englishs which have Japanese counterparts, but tend to be expressed differently instead:

The symbol ? is written the same way as in English, but typically the particle □ is used instead. This particle □ serves both as english, as well as a marker for parts of a sentences, indicating they are questioning instead of stating. Similarly, the symbol ! is written the same way as in English, but typically englishs are simply avoided. Instead, emphasis particles such as □ or □ may be used for effect, but these do not signify real exclamation.

Finally, not quite interpunction but important nonetheless are the two ways to emphasise parts of written language in the same way we use english or english in western composition: english and english. In horizontal writing, words will have dots over each syllable or kanji, or a line over the entire emphasised section. In vertical writing, the dots and lining is placed on the right side of text.

In addition to knowing the basics about which symbols can be used, Japanese (as well as some other Asian languages such as Chinese) has the unique problem of deciding in which direction to write. For all its modernising, some things such as english remain unchanged. As such, for the most part printed Japanese (as well as handwritten material) is written top down, right to left. In contrast, most Japanese material on the internet is typically written in a western fashion, with the text running left to right, top to bottom.

To make matters more interesting, in recent history, Japanese could also be written horizontally right-to-left. This practice has pretty much disappeared except in shipping (ship names may still be written in this way) and for 'older style' shop signs. You will not encounter full texts written in this way in modern or even just post-Meiji older Japanese.

There are a few differences between horizontal and vertical writing, most notably in terms of where to place half size characters and interpunction:

	horizontal	vertical
half size characters	english	english, right aligned
comma, full stop	lower left: [□], [□]	upper-right: [、], [。]
opening quotes	corner in the upper left (「)	corner in the upper right (□)
closing quotes	corner in the lower right (」)	corner in the lower left (□)
parentheses	left and right: i.e. (and)	above and below: i.e. □ and □
dotting	above characters	to the right of characters
lining	above characters	to the right of characters
drawn sound, hyphen	horizontal (□, □)	vertical (□,◎)
ellipsis	horizontal (…)	vertical (⋮)

1.3 Kanji

One of written Japanese's most well-known features is that it comprises three writing systems: the two kana scripts, and a third script called english, translating as "english", which are englishs that over the course of history made their way from China to Japan. One of the biggest problems with kanji is that there aren't just many, but each one can have a multitude of englishs dependent on which words the kanji is being used for. To look at why this is, a brief history of how modern Japanese got the kanji that are used today is in order.

Early Japanese evolved as a purely spoken language. Without a written form, indeed seemingly without having discovered writing at all, the first instances of writing in Japan were in fact not Japanese at all, but Chinese: after having come into contact with the Chinese and their intricate writing system, writing in early Japan (circa the late sixth century) was restricted to immigrant scribes, who wrote official records in english. While initially a rarity, the english of the mid-seventh century changed all that.

Reforming Japan to a more Chinese-inspired state, based on centralisation of government and Confucian philosophy, the need for a state clergy transformed the largely illiterate Japanese society to one with literacy as an essential part of court and intellectual life. The prestigious rank of scribe became a hereditary rank, and so as generations of scribes came and went, the Chinese that was used slowly drifted away from proper Chinese, and more towards a english of Chinese and the form of Japanese as it was used at the time. However, the readings used for Chinese characters were more or less fixed, and the readings that survive from that period are known today as english, english, readings.

Then, in the seventh and eighth century, during the Chinese english, there was another cultural exchange between Japan and China, leading to a second influx of readings for Chinese characters. As China changed rulers, so too did the dominant dialect for the Chinese language, and the readings that were brought back to Japan from this second exchange were in some cases radically different from the initial readings the Japanese had become familiar with. Readings for kanji from this period are known as english, english, readings.

Finally, in the fourteenth century, during the most famous of Chinese dynasties — the english — there was another influx of Chinese. This influx came from two fronts: firstly, the merchants doing business with the Chinese brought back home readings that are referred to as english, english, and secondly from Zen monks who went to study english in China and

brought back readings that are referred to as english, english. Rather than a single exchange, this was an ongoing effort, and so ⊠⊠ readings tend to span from the late thirteenth century to well into the english (japanese, english), also known as the english (japanese, english), named after the first Edo shogun Tokugawa Ieyasu (⊠⊠⊠⊠), which lasted until the late nineteenth century.

The naming for these readings, however, can be slightly confusing. ⊠⊠ readings are known as english. However, this name does not refer to the Wu dynasty (which spans the first two centuries a.d.) but simply to the region the readings are believed to have come from (⊠ being the name of the Wu region in Jiangnan, ⊠⊠, in modern China). The ⊠⊠ readings are called english, but have essentially nothing to do with the Han Dynasty, which spanned the late third century BCE.

The ⊠⊠ readings, equally confusing, are referred to as Tang readings, even though this name would be more appropriate for the ⊠⊠ readings, which actually derive from Tang Chinese. Rather, ⊠⊠ derive their readings from Chinese as it was used during the Sung dynasty and onward.

In addition to these changes to Chinese readings, the written language itself slowly moved away from Chinese proper, through a Chinese-Japanese hybrid written language, to what is essentially the Japanese we know today: mixed Chinese characters with english (itself derived from Chinese characters being used phonetically) with different readings for Chinese characters typically indicating different interpretations of the characters used.

While there had been no written language before the introduction of Chinese, there had certainly been a language, which survived throughout the ages by virtue of the commoners not needing to bother with writing, and thus not incorporating Chinese into their language as much as royals and officials would. This eventually led to native Japanese pronunciation being applied to written Chinese, giving us two different reading "systems": the japanese, "english", which are the english, and the japanese, "english", which are the english.

A major problem with kanji is that without a knowledge of the kanji in question, it is not always clear when to use which reading. There are no rules that state that certain kanji are read in a particular way when used on their own, or when part of a word, and so the only real way to make sure you are using the right reading for a kanji is to look it up and then remember the reading for the *glossary* the kanji was used in.

This usually leads to the question of why kanji are still being used, when other languages only use englishs. The Japanese *glossary* syllabic scripts from Chinese for english, so why the continued reliance on kanji? While it seems odd that Chinese characters are still being used in a language that also has a phonetic script, the main reason it still uses Chinese characters is because of a key aspect of the Japanese language: it is english.

Words in the English language, for instance, are essentially distinct. While there are a number of words that sound the same but mean different things, the vast majority of words in the English language only mean one thing. In Japanese we see quite the opposite: there are only 71 distinct single syllable sounds, but there are close to 300 words which can be written using a single syllable. It is easy to see that this means that for any single syllable word you can think of, there will be (on average) at least three other words that you can write in exactly

the same way. How do you know which is meant if you don't use kanji or additional notes?

For two syllable words, we see the same thing; there are a bit over 2000 combinations possible when using two syllables (not all combinations of two syllables are actually used in Japanese) but there are over 4000 words with a two syllable pronunciation. That means that on average, for every two syllables you write, you can be referring to one of two words. Even with three and four syllables, the problem persists, with a greater number of words available than there are possible readings.

Because of this, Japanese is known as a "homophonic" language - a language in which a large number of distinct words will share the same pronunciation. For instance, a word pronounced "hare" can refer either to 'fair weather', or a 'boil/swelling'. The word "fumi" can mean either 'a written letter', or 'distaste'. The word "hai" can mean either 'yes', 'actor', 'ash', 'lung' or 'disposition', and that doesn't even cover all possible words that are pronounced similarly: without the use of kanji, it would be incredibly hard to decipher written Japanese.

Of course, one can argue that spoken Japanese doesn't rely on kanji, so it must be possible to do away with them in the written language too, but this ignores the fact that just because a simplification can be made, it might make things harder in other respects. For instance, there are no capital letters, spaces, full stops, or all those other syntactic additions in spoken Western languages either, and yet we still keep those in for ease of reading. Similarly, the use of kanji has clear benefits to Japanese as a written language: they act as english indicators, allow readers to get the gist of a text by quickly glossing over them, and solve the problem of needing to apply english all the time like one has to in spoken Japanese.

However, just because they are useful, there have been "improvements" in terms of their use in written Japanese. At the turn of the 20th century, written Japanese was as complicated as written Chinese in terms of kanji use, and even more complicated as a written language on its own, because kana did not reflect pronunciation. In this english, a word written as 'sau' would be pronounced as a long 'so', and something like 'kefu' would instead be pronounced as a long 'kyo'. When, after the second world war, the Japanese english reformed the written language, they didn't just get rid of this discrepancy between written and spoken Japanese, they also got rid of some 7000 kanji, restricting the number of kanji to be used in daily life to around 3500, and designating a set of less than 2000 kanji as part of general education (initially known as the japanese, 'english', kanji, and after refinement to the set in 1981, became known as the japanese, 'english', kanji). This still sounds like a lot, but given that the average English speaker knows around 12,000 words, with academics knowing on average anywhere up to 17,000 words, having to know 2000 kanji in order to understand the vast majority of your written language isn't actually that much.

1.3.1 Types of Kanji

One of the things that one notices after having looked at kanji for a while is that a great number of kanji use a great number of simpler kanji as their building blocks. Similar to how kana syllables can be combined to form words, kanji have throughout

history been combined to form more complex kanji, and complicated kanji have been reduced to combinations of simple kanji for the sake of remembering them, as well as organising them.

Traditionally, kanji are organised in four classes, and two categories, following the convention that was introduced in the very first comprehensive Chinese character dictionary, at the beginning of the Western calendar's second century. The four classes relate to the way in which characters are composed:

1. english (japanese, english) — Hieroglyphic characters that look like what they mean (numbers ☒, ☒, ☒, or ☒ for 'mountain')

2. english (japanese, english) — Characters that represent things in some visual way, divided into two subclasses:

   (a) Simple ideographs (japanese, english), such as ☒ and ☒ (for 'above' and 'below' respectively), and

   (b) Compound ideographs (japanese, english), such as ☒, 'rest', consisting of the compounds ☒, 'person', next to ☒, 'tree')

3. englishs (japanese, english) — These characters combine two kanji into a single character, with one of the two indicating a root meaning, and the other indicating (at least one of) the reading(s) for the character.

The two categories are related to how characters are actually used:

1. english (japanese, english) — These are characters of which the meanings are derivations, or extensions, of the character's original meaning.

2. english (japanese, english) — These are characters which are used purely phonetically, ignoring their original meaning, or characters that are consistently used "wrongly". This class includes those kanji that had to be made up "on the spot" in order to accommodate words and concepts imported into Japanese from foreign languages for which no pre-existing kanji form was available.

To make matters even more interesting, there are also characters which fall in either the third or fourth class, but for which certain meanings have become tied to certain readings. An example of this is the character ☒, which can mean "music" when pronounced as "gaku", but mean "comfort" or "enjoyment" when pronounced as "raku".

1.3.2 Writing Kanji

Writing kanji follows relatively strict rules. Because kanji are mostly composed of smaller kanji, there is a uniform way of writing that allows people to remember kanji as combinations of simpler kanji, rather than as combinations of english that only once finished, form a kanji. There are a limited number of strokes that are used for drawing kanji.

english

stroke	drawing order	examples
一	left to right	二, 十
丨	starting at the lower left	中
丶	called a “tick mark”, starting upper left	主, 丸, 丹
丿	starting at the top	人, 入
乙	starting at the top	九
亅	starting at the top	小
𠃌	starting at the top, with a serif to the left at the end	口, 山
𠃍	starting upper left, and then pulling back at the end	又
𠃑	starting at the top, with an upward serif at the end	巴, 已

english

stroke	drawing order	examples
丨	top to bottom, then left to right, as one stroke	十, 干
丩	left to right, then top to bottom, then left to right	収
亅	left to right, then a hook curving down left	予
丁	left to right, then top to bottom with a serif to the upper left	下, 可
凵	left to right, then top to bottom	出
丅	top to bottom, then left to right with a serif upward at the end	下
𠂇	top left to right, then down right with an upward serif at the end	左, 𠂉

english

stroke	drawing order	examples
丆	top to bottom, then the same as 一	示
丄	top left to right, then the same as 一	上
丅	top left to right, top to bottom, then the same as 一	下, 丈
丌	a connected stroke consisting of 一 and 丌	元

Composition

Several compositional rules apply when a kanji consists of more than one stroke:

1. Strokes that do not intersect each other, follow each other in a top to bottom, left to right fashion.

2. Kanji used to form more complex kanji also follow this rule. For instance, 林 is written as first 木, which in turn is first 一, then 丨, and then 木 is placed underneath.

3. When strokes intersect, the following rules apply:

(a) For a vertical/horizontal intersection where the vertical stroke does not protrude at the bottom, such as in □, draw the top horizontal first, then the vertical (forming □), then the rest.

(b) For a vertical/horizontal intersection where the vertical stroke does protrude at the bottom, such as in □, □ or □, draw all horizontals first, and finally the vertical.

(c) For □ crossed strokes such as in □ or □, the stroke that runs upper-right to lower-left is drawn first.

(d) Strokes that intersect complete shapes, such as the vertical in □ or the horizontal in □, are written last.

4. Box english, such as in □, are written left□first, then followed up with □ to form □, then have their content drawn, and are then closed at the bottom with □.

5. Semi enclosures, such as around □ in □ or around □ in □, are written last, after the semi-enclosed component.

There are a few exceptions to these rules (of course), so when learning kanji, one should always have some reference on how to draw kanji.

1.3.3 Reading kanji: english

One problem with kanji is that there is no "built-in" way to tell which pronunciation of a kanji is being used. For instance, when a text has the word □□□ in it, then it's clear how to pronounce the hiragana part, "tta", but whether the kanji □ should be pronounced as 'i' or as 'okona' is not clear. The context will help, but sometimes for verbs, and often for nouns, that's not enough to figure out how to pronounce a kanji. Because of this, Japanese has a unique aspect to its written language: furigana.

Furigana, japanese, literally means "sprinkled kana", and refers to english text written over or alongside kanji to indicate the specific reading a reader should use. You have seen several examples of furigana already in this book, where whenever a Japanese term was used involving kanji, its pronunciation was written above it in small lettering. This is not something particular to this book, but a common occurrence in Japanese written material, used most often to help the reader disambiguate or pronounce "hard" words, but also for stylistic or even comic effect.

As an illustration of comic effect, one might consider the case of long words that are used with some frequency in a text. These words might only be given two phonetic guide texts throughout the writing: a first time with the 'proper' pronunciation, and a second time with the pronunciation 'are' instead — a pronoun with the contextual meaning "whatever I wrote last time".

While comic effect is perhaps an added bonus to using furigana, it is certainly widely used for stylistic effect. For instance, while the word □□ does not exist in Japanese, the kanji mean "neck" and "sword" respectively. A Fantasy novelist could use this "made up" word, and add a phonetic text to note that it should be pronounced as □□□□□□□□□□□□□,

"ekusakyuushion soodo", a *glossary* of the English words "execution sword" into Japanese. While this doesn't make ◎◎ a real word, it does allow a writer to paint with words - using the kanji as "pictures" to instil a sense of meaning, and adding an explicit pronunciation so that the sentence can be pronounced as well as written.

Another, even wider used application of furigana is the kind employed in sentences such as □□□□□□, "I dislike that person". In this sentence, the kanji □ is used with the phonetic guide text "hito", meaning "person". However, this is not the real pronunciation of □, which is normally pronounced "yatsu", and doesn't just mean "person", but is a derogatory version of the word instead. In essence, while the reading reflects what the speaker is saying, the kanji form of the word expresses what the speaker is actually thinking. This "being able to express both what is being thought and what is being said at the same time" is something that is impossible without this particular feature of written Japanese.

1.3.4 Reading quirks: compound words

As mentioned in the section on kana pronunciations, there's an odd quirk involving the pronunciation of compounds words. This is best illustrated with an example. If we combine the noun ◎, "ki", meaning 'spirit', or 'attention', with the verb □□, "tsuku", to form the compound verb □□□, then its pronunciation is not "kitsuku". In fact, the second compound voices, leading to the pronunciation being "kidzuku" (or according to modern spelling, "kizuku"). Why this voicing occurs is, sadly, completely and entirely unknown. There are no rules that say when compound words are "supposed" to voice, nor are there any rules we can abstract from all the words that do — any rule that seems to explain half of all voicings that occur in Japanese, seems not to apply to the other half.

The best advice here is simply: "learn compound words as complete words". Even though they can be analysed as compounds, their meaning is typically different from what the compounds individually mean, so learning them as combinations of loose, smaller words, makes very little sense anyway.

1.3.5 Looking up kanji

If we wanted to look up kanji like □, □ and □, then one very obvious feature we see is that all three seem to share a similar structure: □ to the left, and something else to the right. This is not a coincidence: most kanji can be described as some bit that is used by a number of other kanji, plus a unique part that identifies that particular kanji. The bit of kanji that is shared by several (or in some cases lots of) kanji is called a "english*glossary*", and can be used to look up a kanji if you have no idea what it means or even how to pronounce it.

The very first Chinese character dictionary — the english, published in the year 121 — used 214 such characters as indexing shapes, calling them bùshǒu. (a name that the Japanese copied to the best of their ability, calling them english, japanese). While this scheme was thought up almost two millennia ago, amazingly this method of organising kanji has not been fundamentally altered ever since: while written Chinese, and later Japanese,

changed over the centuries, the only thing that has really changed is the number of indexing radicals. Current indices list around 400 shapes as radicals, compared to the original 214, mostly due to many shapes being considered "variations" of the classic radicals these days. For instance: while originally only 𠂇 was considered a radical (radical number 49, in fact), Chinese characters have changed over the course of centuries so that now the shapes 𠂇 and 𠂇 are also used, and are considered variations of the original 𠂇. Kanji that use any of these three shapes may thus be found grouped together.

Some variations on the english radicals are simple, such as 𠂇 changing ever so slightly to become 𠂇, the only real difference being that the lower horizontal stroke is slanted a little. However, some variations are more drastic, such as 𠂇 becoming 𠂇; the top stroke has disappeared. The most drastic changes we see, however, are those where a radical is no longer readily recognisable as stemming from a particular kanji. For instance, if you didn't know anything about kanji, you would be hard pressed to imagine that 𠂇 is actually considered the radical form of 𠂇. Or that 𠂇 in kanji such as 𠂇 is actually the radical form of the kanji 𠂇. Probably the most confusing of all radicals are the radical forms of the kanji pair 𠂇 and 𠂇, which both turn into 𠂇, but on different sides of kanji: 𠂇 is indexed by 𠂇, while 𠂇 is indexed by 𠂇!

1.3.6 Styles

There are several writing "styles" for Japanese, each associated with different uses. The most commonly used style by far is the english, japanese, style, or "print" style. Textbooks, novels, newspapers, webpages, virtually all material intended for mass reading consumption uses this style. There are a few different variants of this form, of which the english, japanese, and english, japanese, variants are the most common. The Minchou variant is characterised by fine lines and serifs (the font that was used for the Japanese in this book is a Minchou variant of the kaisho style, for instance), while the gothic variant is characterised by thick, clear lining without any serifs. This variant is often used for signs and pamphlets, as well as a visually offset style contrasted to Mincho (performing the same role italic scripts do for most Western languages).

To show the difference, let us look at two images using minchou and gothic versions of the kaisho typeface. These examples use the 𠂇𠂇𠂇 poem as text, which can be considered a Japanese equivalent of an alphabet song, containing each basic syllable only once (although some are voiced). Observing the "proper" writing style and reading top-down, right to left, this poem is written as follows:

englishjapanese

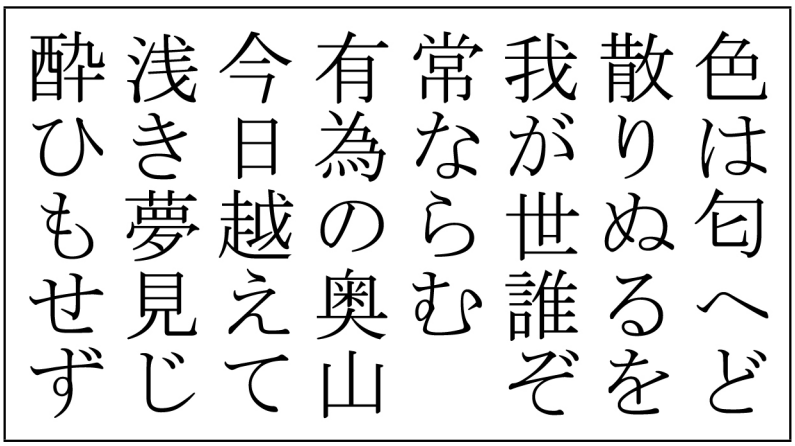
色(いろ)は匂(にほ)へど
散(ち)りぬるを
我(わ)が世誰(よたれ)ぞ
常(つね)ならむ
有為(うゐ)の奥山(おくやま)
今日越(けふこ)えて
浅(あさ)き夢見(ゆめみ)じ
酔(ゑ)ひもせず

The [illegible] poem, with classical kana transcription

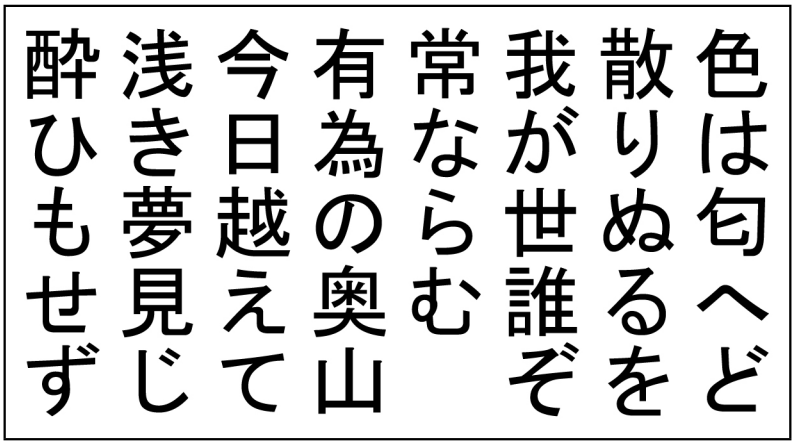
There are many translations possible, given the classical nature of the poem. However, a translation offered by professor Ryuichi Abe in his 1999 work *"The Weaving of Mantra: Kûkai and the Construction of Esoteric Buddhist Discourse"*, published by Columbia University Press, is as follows:

Although its scent still lingers on —
the form of a flower has scattered away.
For whom will the glory —
of this world remain unchanged?
Arriving today at the yonder side —
of the deep mountains of evanescent existence,
we shall never allow ourselves to drift away —
intoxicated, in the world of shallow dreams.

Written in Mincho and gothic styles, this poem looks like:



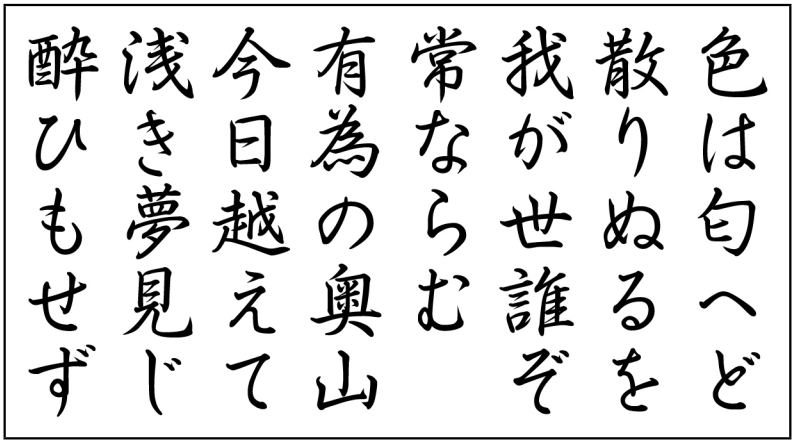
The [illegible] poem, in the [illegible] variant of [illegible] style



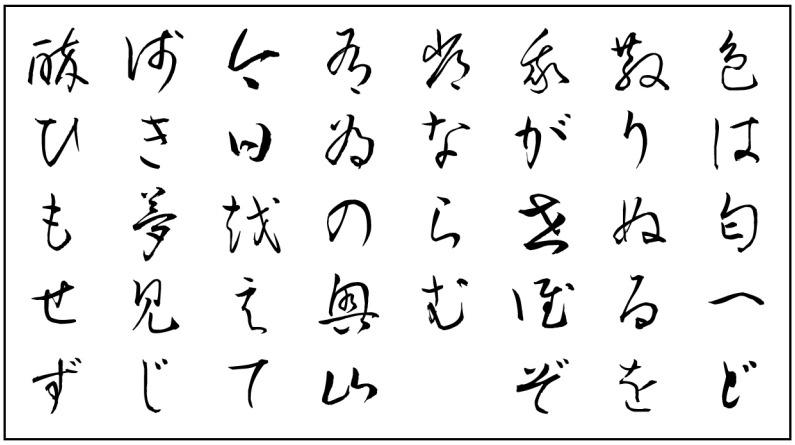
The ▨▨▨ poem, in the ▨▨▨▨ variant of ▨▨ style

In addition to the kaisho style, there are the two "cursive" styles called english, japanese, and english, japanese, which are "simplified" forms of written Japanese. The simplification here refers to the fact that these two styles connect many strokes into single strokes, or in extreme cases, even simplify entire kanji to single strokes. However, this does not make them simpler to read - far from it, the simplifications can make it much harder to tell certain kanji apart, or look up in a dictionary.

Gyousho is usually associated with handwriting: while we can all write letters the way they come rolling out of a printer, we have a special way of writing everything if we do it by hand, and in Japanese this is expressed through a slightly more flowing form of kanji and kana, connecting strokes but, quite often, preserving most of the looks of a kanji. Sousho, on the other hand, is the highly stylised simplifications associated with brush calligraphy — shapes are simplified according to reasonably rigid rules, but these simplifications look drastically different from the original shape, and certain shapes are simplified in such a way that it is nearly impossible to tell one from another without having received some form of education in reading and writing brush calligraphy. Illustrating this again using the ▨▨▨ poem:

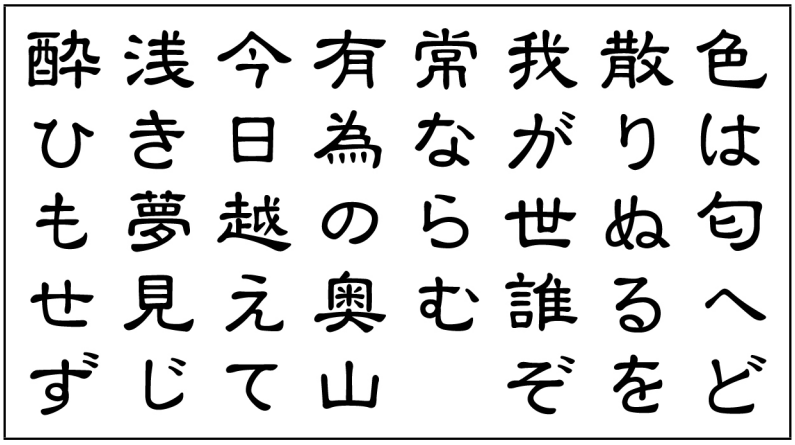


The ▨▨▨ poem, in ▨▨ style

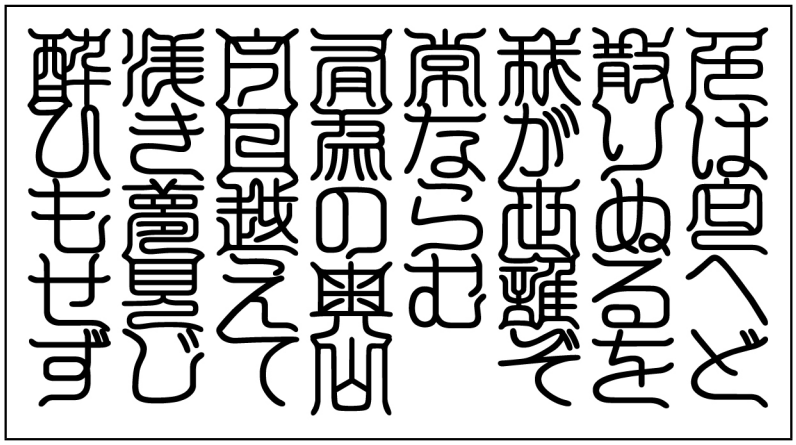


The ⊠⊠⊠ poem, in ⊠⊠ style

Lastly, there are two "traditional" styles that you only find used in very specific applications: english, japanese, "english" or "english", and english, japanese, "english". These two styles are not just traditional but "ancient" styles, in that they are styles found used far back in Japanese history on official records and seals (respectively). Reisho is associated with the style of carved kanji on woodblocks (explaining its 'block style' name), and is still in use today for things such as traditional signs. Tensho is also still used in modern Japan, featuring most prominently in personal stamps — in Japan, you do not sign documents with a signature, but you put your personal stamp on the document. Everyone who has ever signed something has one of these, and you'll probably know them from the distinctive red-ink kanji-in-a-circle or kanji-in-a-square signs on Chinese and Japanese paintings and brush works. Illustrating these two styles using the ⊙⊙⊙ again:



The ⊙⊙⊙ poem, in ⊠⊠ style



The ◎◎◎ poem, in ⊠ style

Special dictionaries exist that list kanji in their different forms. These come in the form of english, japanese, which list kaisho, gyousho and sousho forms ("santai" meaning three forms), and english, japanese, which list all five forms for a kanji ("gotai" meaning five forms). There are even reference works which don't so much list the forms in a neatly ordered fashion, but show you different interpretation that artists have of the gyousho and sousho forms of kanji, which makes them more "artbook" than reference book, even when they are invaluable resources to students of Chinese and Japanese calligraphy.

1.4 Words and word classes

With all this talk about lettering, one would almost forget that just letters hardly get us anywhere if we don't know any words to write with them. However, Japanese doesn't have quite the same words as most western languages have. You may have heard the terms "noun" and "verb", and you may even be familiar with terms like "prepositions" and "adverb", but there are quite a number of these word types, and we'll look at all of these in terms of whether or not Japanese uses them, and what they look like.

1.4.1 english

This is a group of words that you rarely think about as real words: in English, "the", "a" and "an" are *glossary*english. They precede a word to tell you whether it's an undetermined 'something' (by using "a" or "an") or a specific 'something' (by using "the"). Japanese, on the other hand, doesn't have articles at all. It's not just that it uses a different way to indicate the difference between for instance "a car" and "the car": there are no simple words you can use to show this difference. This might sound like a rather big stumbling block, but there are many languages which do not have articles, and the people that use those languages can get the meaning across just fine without them - as we will see when we talk about context later in this chapter.

1.4.2 english

Verbs are words that represent an action either taking place or being performed, and can be modified to show things like negatives or past tense. In English, words like "fly" and "float" are verbs for actions that are being performed, and we can make them negative or past tense: "not fly", "not float", "flew" and "floated" respectively. Similarly, words like "walk" and "eat" are verbs for actions that can be performed, and we can make them negative or past tense too: "not walk", "not eat", "walked" and "ate" respectively. Verbs also have a regularity: walk and float are regular verbs in that they follow the same rules: past tense is "… + ed", but "fly" and "eat" are *glossary*: they do not become "flyed" and "eated", but "flew" and "ate".

Finally, verbs can be english, or english. The verb "walk", for instance, is something that you just do. You walk. When you see this kind of construction in a sentence, we say that the verb is used "intransitively" - in contrast, "eat" is a verb you can either use *glossary* ("What are you doing?" - "I'm eating") or *glossary*: "I eat an apple". In this use, you're applying the verb's action to something: "I throw the ball", "I eat an apple", "I fly a plane" are all examples of this. However, there is something funny about transitivity: some verbs, like "walk", you can only use intransitively (we don't say that we "walked the street", for instance), but many verbs can be used either intransitively or transitively, like "eat".

There are also a number of verbs that can only be used transitively, but these are special verbs, typically called *glossary*. In English, "have" and "want" are examples of these. Without an additional "something", these verbs do not have any meaning on their own: saying "I have." or "I want." is grammatically incorrect. At the very least, you'd need to say something like "I have it." or "I want that." for the verbs to be used correctly.

Japanese verbs are characterised by a high degree of regularity as, except for three verbs, all verbs are regular. These regular verbs fall into two categories, namely the "five grade" verbs called english, japanese, and the "single grade" verbs, called english, japanese. These two categories inflect (take on different *glossary*, *glossary*, etc) in the same way on almost all possible *glossary*, but of course differ on some (otherwise there wouldn't be two categories, but just one).

With respect to transitivity, Japanese verbs can be a little problematic. Rather than being labelled intransitive or transitive, Japanese verbs are labelled as being japanese or japanese, literally "verb that works on its own" and "verb that works paired with something". Quite often these two verb classifications map to the roles of "intransitive" and "transitive", respectively, but sometimes they don't. For instance, traversal verbs (such as 'walk', 'run', 'fly', 'sail', etc.) are intransitive in English, but are ⊠⊠⊠ in Japanese: they can be used with an object to indicate what is being walked or run over, what is being flown through, what's being sailed in, etc. As such, while in English one does not "fly the sky" or "swim the ocean" (at the very least you'd need a preposition such as "through" or "in" to make those correct English), in Japanese this is exactly what you're doing.

◎◎◎ on the other hand do not have a "verb object"; they operate on their own. For instance, in English we can say "I understand the text", and if we look at the sentence from a grammatical point of view we can say that 'the text' may be considered the verb object

for the verb 'understand'. However, in Japan the verb for understanding, □□□, is a □□□ verb, and so even though you're used to thinking of "understanding" as a transitive verb action, you suddenly have to get used to it being an intransitive verb action in Japanese. Particularly at first, this can be somewhat confusing, but like all foreign languages, exposure to frequently used verbs means you'll quickly develop a sense of how to use them properly (even if you can't remember the terms 'intransitive', 'transitive', □□□ and □□□!).

1.4.3 Nouns

glossary are words that are used to name "somethings", although those somethings don't need to be things you can actually hold in your hand and look at: "car", "New York", "magnification" and "ambiguity" are all nouns, but while you can touch a car, or point at New York, it's impossible to point at something and go "that is magnification" or "that is ambiguity". A good rule of thumb is "if you can say it's 'something else', it's a english":

"This car is old."
"New York is hot."
"The magnification is high."
"This ambiguity is omnipresent."

These are all examples where the noun is said to be something else (and that something else is known as an "adjective"). This even works with things that you might think are verbs, but actually aren't: "walking" for instance looks like it's a verb, because "walk" is a verb, but there are instances when "walking" is most definitely a noun. Of the following two sentences, the first uses "walking" as a verb, while the second uses "walking" as a noun:

"I went to work walking."
"I like walking."

We can verify that in the first sentence we're using a verb, and in the second a noun, by replacing "walking" with a word which we know is a noun, like "cheese":

"I went to work cheese."
"I like cheese."

The first sentence suddenly makes no sense at all anymore, while the second sentence is still perfectly fine. This "words can belong to multiple classes, and which it is depends on how it's used in a sentence" is something quite important to remember when dealing with Japanese, as well as learning foreign languages in general.

As a last bit of noun related information, in Japanese (as in English, in fact) nouns do not inflect. They usually need verbs to indicate negative, past tense, and other such things: in English we can say "This is not a book" or "This was a book", but the negative and past tense comes from inflections of the verb "be", not the noun itself.

1.4.4 english

There is a special class of words called "pronouns" in English, which act as if they're nouns, but are used to replace nouns in sentences. The best known pronoun in the English language is the word "english", but words like "this", "that" as well as "you" or "we" are all examples of *glossary*. Rather than constantly referring directly to what we're talking about, it is far more natural to use pronouns instead:

> "I bought a really good book. I had already read it, having borrowed it from the library last month, but I saw it in the book store on discount, so I decided to buy it."

In this sentence, the pronoun "it" is used quite a number of times, replacing "the book" at every instance:

> "I bought a really good book. I had already read the book, having borrowed the book from the library last month, but I saw the book in the book store on discount, so I decided to buy the book."

This sounds unnatural to English ears, even though grammatically speaking there is nothing wrong. In Japanese, pronouns are part of a class of words *glossary* referred to as "english", japanese, for the fact that they all start with either "ko-", "so-", "a-" or "do-" depending on their level of proximity (for instance, 'this' vs. 'that') and whether they are stative or interrogative ('that' vs. 'what').

1.4.5 Nominalisers

Japanese has an extra class pertaining to nouns, known as the english: words that, when used with other words or phrases, turn these words or phrases into something that can act as if the whole construction is a noun. In English, an example of this is the collection of words "the way in which":

> "The way in which the government is handling the issue of criminal law is questionable."

In this sentence, "the way in which" is used to turn "the government is handling the issue of criminal law" into a single noun construction. As such we can replace "the way in which the government is handling the issue of criminal law" with a simple pronoun if we wish to talk about it in later sentences:

> "The way in which the government is handling the issue of criminal law is questionable. It does not seem to be motivated by sound principles, but by back-office politics."

Japanese has quite a number of these *glossary*, each with its own meaning and nuance, and we shall look at these nominalisers in the chapter on language patterns, too.

1.4.6 Adjectives

As we saw in the section on nouns, any word that can be used to be "more specific" about a noun is called an adjective. Words like "big", "cold", "square" can all be used as english to be much more specific about, for instance, the noun "box":

> "This is a box."
> "This is a square box."
> "This is a big, square box."
> "This is a big, cold, square box."

In Japanese, there are two types of adjectives, namely "*glossary*" adjectives and "nominal" adjectives, the difference being that the first type can — unlike in English — be inflected without relying on a *glossary* verb. In English, we have to say "The car was fast", but in Japanese this "was fast" does not use a copula verb such as 'was', but the adjective itself can convey this meaning. In essence, in Japanese we get something akin to "The car is fast-in-past-tense". The copula stays the way it is, but the adjective itself changes, something which trips up many beginning students of Japanese.

The english behave in the same way English adjectives do, needing a copula to change. "It was a square box" is the same in Japanese as it is in English, with "is" becoming "was", and the adjective staying the way it is.

While we can use adjectives to be more specific about a noun, they cannot be used to be more specific about a verb. As an example, in the next two sentences the word "fast" is used as an adjective in the first, but is used as a different kind of word in the second sentence:

> "This is a fast car."
> "I walked quite fast."

In the first sentence, the word "fast" is used to be more specific about the noun "car",

but in the second sentence, the word "fast" is used to be more specific about the verb action "walk". While they look like the same word, their use falls in different word classes. When used to be specific about a noun, a word is called an adjective. When used to be specific about a verb, it's called an *glossary*.

1.4.7 english

Using words to be specific about verbs and verb actions is called using them adverbially. In fact, in that sentence the word "adverbially" is an adverb, letting us be specific about the way in which "using" is used. While in English it can sometimes be confusing as to whether a word is being used as an adjective or as an adverb, in Japanese this overlap does not exist: both verbal and nominal adjectives are modified (in different ways) so that they can be used as adverbs instead. Because of this, there is no way to mistake whether a word is used as adjective or adverb when you look at a sentence.

In addition to adjectives-turned-adverb, Japanese also has words that are only adverbs. The most important of these are the english, which include things like "a lot", "not so much" and "often".

1.4.8 english

Japanese has an extra word class that isn't found in most western languages: the *glossary* class. Words in this class fulfil a wide variety of roles: denoting grammar explicitly, adding emphasis, disambiguating, marking how parts of a sentence bear relation to each other, supplying reason, contradiction, logical arguments, you name it — there is probably a particle that can be used for it.

Most particles are english, so that when you use a particle to indicate for instance a contrast between two things, it gets added after the first thing, rather than adding it in front like in English.

> English: While (X is the case), (also Y).
> Japanese: (X is the case) while, (also Y).

Within this word class, there is an important subclass known as the english. Like Chinese, but very much unlike most western languages, counting in Japanese requires not just a knowledge of numbers, but also of which particle to use in order to describe the category of things you are counting. In the same way that you can ask for two mugs of beer or two glasses of beer in English, you need to use the *glossary* for "mugs" or "glasses" in Japanese. However, while you can ask for "two teas" in an English establishment, this kind of request is impossible in Japanese. You have to order "two (units of) tea", where the counter that you chose for your units makes the difference between whether you're asking for two cups or tea, two bags of tea, or are accidentally asking for two sheets of tea.

1.4.9 english

Some particles, as well as some common concept markers, are *glossary* rather than *glossary* — they are placed in front of words belonging to certain word classes. A handful of special prefixes are used for things like marking words as english*glossary*, performing "inherent" english (an English example of which is "the house was windowless" rather than "the house had no windows"), indicating englishs ("rereading a book") and acting as category marker for categories such as "new", "big" or "most", as well as some more exotic categories such as extents or limits. These will be discussed in detail in the chapter on particles, in the section on prefixes.

1.4.10 english and english

Two final word classes which are important to know when dealing with Japanese are the *glossary*, and the *glossary*. Quite a mouthful, onomatopoeia (from the Greek onomato-, "name", and poi- "to make") are words that are used to reflect the sounds that things make. For instance, "The heavy rock splooshed into the lake" is an example of an onomatopoeic verb. It doesn't tell us what the rock actually did — namely, fall into the water — but implies it by virtue of the sound we know a rock falling in water makes: "sploosh".

In addition to such english, there are also english, which do not indicate a particular sound, but indicate a particular property. Rare in English, an example of this would be the word "gloopy" when describing something. Calling something "gloopy" doesn't tell you something objective about it, but you can surmise it's probably of a viscous liquid gel-like consistency, as well as unpleasant to the touch.

While in English (and in most other western languages) using these words is considered a sign of a poor grasp of the language (after all, why use a word like "gloopy" when you can call something a "liquid, but viscous, unpleasant gel"), and mainly associated with "children's language", in Japanese using onomatopoeia is essential to natural sounding language: with thousands of these words available to choose from, each with its own *glossary* and *glossary*, picking the right onomatopoeia or mimesis at the right time is something that demonstrates a high level of competency in the language.

Onomatopoeia, called japanese ('english', in which the 'gi' part means 'to mimic', the 'on' part means 'sound', and the 'go' part means 'word') and mimesis, called japanese ('english', in which 'tai' means condition or state), are some of the hardest words to learn, as they usually carry very specific nuances in meaning. For instance, in relation to a leaking tap, a Japanese person might say "the water was dripping out", picking one specific word from among a great number of possible onomatopoeia to indicate whether the dripping was intermittent or continuous, whether the drips were light or heavy, whether their impact in the sink was almost silent or accompanied by backsplash noises, each of these qualities being represented by a different onomatopoeic word.

Because of this, onomatopoeia and mimesis are an unofficial yardstick when it comes to learning Japanese: if you can use the right onomatopoeic expression at the right time, you have mastered a crucial element to speaking natural sounding Japanese.

1.4.11 english

This is technically not a word class, but a language feature: in some languages several words can be combined into single words with more meaning that just the individual parts. This practice, called compounding, is something that some languages have a knack for, and some languages simply do not bother with. English, for instance, is a language in which *glossary* words are rare — although not unheard of. A common English compound word is the word "teapot", for instance. A combination of the nouns "tea" and "pot", this would have to be a pot for tea. However, it's not really a pot, it's more a decanter. Similarly, the "tea" in question is never dry tea leaf, even though that's also called "tea" in English; it has to be boiled water infused with tea leaf. So, the single compound noun "teapot" has more meaning than if you looked at the meaning of just the two nouns it was built from.

This "joining up two (or more) words to form new, single words" is one of the major dividing lines we can use when trying to classify languages: English is a language sparse in compound words, as are French, Spanish and Italian, but German, Danish, Dutch, Finnish, Polish, Hungarian, Arabic, and also Japanese, are languages in which compound words are frequently used.

In Japanese, nouns are not the only compound words available — compound adjectives as well as compound verbs are also quite common.

1.5 english

In addition to knowing which word classes are used in a language, we can also look at languages in terms of how sentences are structured. The most simplistic categorisation of languages in this respect is by looking at the "*glossary*, *glossary* and *glossary*" ordering. This categorisation looks at how languages order these three words classes, leading to the conclusions that English, for instance, is an english, while Japanese is an english: in English, most sentences are of the form "we do something", where the subject ("we") precedes the verb ("do") which in turn precedes the object ("something") for that verb. Japanese, in contrast, follows a different ordering: most sentences are of the form "we, something do" (with the comma added purely for ease of reading) where the subject precedes the object for the verb, after which the actual verb is used. There are also VSO languages, such as formal Arabic or Welsh, where the sentence structure is predominantly "do, we, something" and VOS languages, such as Malagasi (used in Madagascar) and Fijian (used in Fiji) where the structure is predominantly "do something, we".

However, while this terminology allows us to broadly categorise languages, based on what the 'typically used' pattern looks like, it doesn't tell us anything about how correct or incorrect sentences are if they do not adhere to these S/V/O "rules". For instance, while "we ate some cake" is a normal English sentence, a slightly less conventional but still grammatically perfectly valid English sentence could be "cake; we ate some". This sentence does not fall in the SVO category that is associated with English, but that doesn't mean it's an incorrect sentence — it just means the SVO label doesn't tell the whole story.

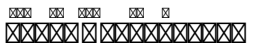
This becomes particularly apparent when we look at what "minimal sentences" may look like in different languages.

In English, a english (that is, one that isn't considered an expression like "hi!" or "hmm") consists of a subject and a verb: "I ate" or "she runs" are examples of minimal sentences. Trying to shorten a sentence further — without making the sentence context sensitive — yields broken English, which is arguably simply not English. This notion of context is important: if we are asked "How many cookies are left?" and we answer with "four", then this "four" is technically a sentence comprised of a single word, and sounds natural. However, if we were to use the sentence "four." on its own, it is impossible to tell what we mean by it. This means that while English is an SVO language, it's really an SV(O) language: you need an S, you need a V, and if you use an O, it comes last, but you're not obliged to have one.

When we look at Japanese we see the S/V/O category crumbling even further. Rather than just being an SOV language, it's actually an (S)(O)V language: You need a verb, but you don't need a subject or object at all to form a correct minimal sentence in Japanese. While in English saying "ate" is considered not enough information to make sense of, Japanese is a language in which competent listeners or readers fill in these blanks themselves, choosing which subject and object make the most sense, given what they know about the speaker. This is what makes Japanese hard: most of the time, in every day Japanese, subjects and objects will be omitted left and right because, as a competent listener, you should know what they should have been — Japanese relies heavily on people's ability to guess what someone else is talking about, something which can only come through regular exposure to, and use of, the language.

1.5.1 english

While it's all well and good to know that minimal Japanese is an (S)(O)V language, it's also important to know that in Japanese, grammar is put directly into the sentence through the use of particles. While in English grammar only becomes apparent through the positioning of words, in Japanese words are "tagged", as it were, with their grammatical role. To illustrate this, an example sentence:



kinou wa inu ga watashi no gohan o tabemashita.

This sentence is composed of several "blocks": ㊀㊀㊀, 'kinou wa', indicates the noun 'kinou' ("yesterday") as context. In ㊀㊀, 'inu ga', the noun 'inu' ("dog") is marked as verb actor, in 𠮟, 'watashi no', the noun 'watashi' ("I"/"me") is made *glossary* (forming "my") and linked to ㊀㊀㊀, 'gohan o', the noun 'gohan' ("dinner") marked as direct verb object, with the final word 'tabemashita' being the past tense of the verb "eat":

"Yesterday, (a/my/our) dog ate my dinner."

In English, there is very little position variation possible in this sentence: "A dog ate my dinner, yesterday" is still okay, but rearranging the sentence to read "Yesterday, my dinner ate a dog" completely changes the meaning of the sentence from something unfortunate to something unsettling. In Japanese, the explicit presence of grammar markers in a sentence means that rearranging the "blocks" doesn't change the meaning of the sentence at all:

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
kinou wa watashi no gohan o inu ga tabemashita.
"Yesterday: my dinner, (a/my/our) dog ate."

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
watashi no gohan o, kinou wa, inu ga tabemashita.
"My dinner — yesterday — (a/my/our) dog ate."

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
kinou wa inu ga tabemashita, watashi no gohan o.
"Yesterday (a/my/our) dog ate; my dinner."

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
tabemashita, inu ga, watashi no gohan o, kinou wa.
"Ate, a dog (did), my dinner, yesterday."

All of these are perfectly valid sentences in Japanese, because all the words with meaning are explicitly tagged with the role they play in the sentence. While some of these sentences will sound more usual than others, they all mean the same thing. However, once we start moving the particles around, pairing them with words from different blocks, the same problem arises as we saw for English:

□□□(□□)(□□□□)□□□□□
kinou wa inu ga watashi no gohan o tabemashita
"Yesterday, (a/my/our) dog ate my dinner."

□□□(□□□)(□□□□)□□□□□
kinou wa gohan ga watashi no inu o tabemashita
"Yesterday, (the) dinner ate my dog."

In summary, it is not so much english that inherently gives meaning to a sentence in Japanese, but the 'english' of words, paired with specific particles. Their combination tells

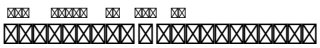
you what the block means, and what role it plays in a sentence. As long as the pairings are preserved, you can order these blocks in any way you like and maintain the same sentence meaning. Which blocks go where, finally, depends entirely on what you believe is the most important bit of the sentence, as is highlighted in the next section.

1.5.2 Emphasis

Another feature of languages is where english lies in a sentence. In English, we tend to put the most pressing bit of information early in the sentence, and then say whatever is further relevant to this information later in the sentence. The previous sentence is a good example of this: the main point is that "important information comes early", which is found earlier in the sentence than the additional information. In Japanese, things are the other way around: the more important the information is, the later it will be placed in a sentence.

A rather simple example is the following pair of sentences:

"I fell off my bike while riding home today."



kyou wa jitensha de kaerichuu de korondeshimaimashita.

While the English sentence is up front with the emphasis, namely that we fell off our bike, the Japanese sentence doesn't actually tell you what happened until the very last word, 'korondeshimaimashita' — "(I) (regrettably/unfortunately) fell down".

Being unfamiliar with this difference in emphasis (point, then details in English vs. details, then point in Japanese) can lead to confusion when dealing with words in which this ordering is important, such as indicating englishs: in English, "while". If someone asks "what are you doing?" and we answer with "eating some dinner while watching TV", then the main activity is eating dinner. The "watching TV" is additional information, but not strictly speaking required for the answer to be complete. In Japanese, with the same core information and details used, the placement is opposite: the Japanese answer "terebi o minagara, gohan o tabemasu" lists "watching TV" first ('terebi o mi-'), then adds the marker for english ('nagara') and then concludes with "eating dinner" ('gohan o tabemasu'). Both in English and Japanese, the concise answer would simply have been "eating dinner", or "gohan o tabemasu".

Another, more common example is the use of "rather": "I would rather have X than Y" is a well known sentence pattern in English, listing the thing with most preference first. This becomes even more obvious in the shortened pattern, "I would rather have X". In Japanese, the 'rather' construction uses the particle 'yori' and, like before, the order is quite opposite:

Y yori X no hou ga ii to omoimasu

Trying to project the way 'rather' works in English onto what 'yori' means can easily lead to confusion: the English word 'rather' assumes that the most important bit is on the left, so if we think 'yori' does the same — because we know it can be translated as 'rather' — we might mistakenly believe that this sentence says "I would rather have Y than X", instead of what it really means, "I would rather have X than Y". While potentially confusing at first, this reversal of placement for emphasis becomes more intuitive the more one practises Japanese.

However, having important information at the end of a sentence leads to a unique problem when interpreting or translating Japanese: how does one deal with trailing sentences? In English, when the latter part of a sentence is left off, the most important information has already been presented, so when the sentence is cut off we might be missing the details, but only the details. In Japanese, and other languages where more important information comes later in the sentence, leaving off the latter part of a sentence leaves a reader or listener with the details, but no knowledge of what these details actually apply to!

While, of course, this doesn't lead to problems for people who grew up using a language in which emphasis comes later in a sentence, this 'feature' can be a great pain for people who grew up with "important bits first". To them, it feels very much like the language is based on the concept of "filling in the blanks", without any indication of what can be used to fill them in. Sadly, this too can only be remedied through continued exposure to, in this case, Japanese, so that one becomes intuitively familiar with which words might be implied if they're left off.

1.6 english and englishs

Linguistically speaking, Japanese - like various other Asian languages such as Thai or Chinese - uses syllable *glossary* to place *glossary* in words. Quite often you will find this explained as Japanese being a language with two pitch levels, high and low, which makes it relatively easy to learn compared to a more complicated language (in terms of pitch) such as Chinese, which has four pitch levels for english, and at least six for english. However, this creates the false impression that there are only two tones at which you should pronounce Japanese, which is simply not true. Instead, accent through pitch in Japanese is best described in terms of english:

1. If a word has its accent on the first syllable, then the pitch of the word starts at a high tone and then drops in pitch at the second syllable. After this, the pitch may remain either constant, or (slowly) go down as the rest of the word is pronounced. Due to this relatively large difference between the first and second syllable, the first syllable is considered accented by the Japanese ear.

2. If a word has its accent on a syllable other than the first or the last, the pitch may remain constant or rise gradually until the syllable after the one that is accented, where the pitch goes down suddenly to create the pitch difference that is considered an accent in Japanese.

3. If a word has its accent on the last syllable, the pitch may remain constant or rise gradually until the last syllable, which is pronounced at a notably higher pitch, marking it as accented to the Japanese ear.

4. If a word has no accent, the pitch may remain constant or rise gradually. This covers the majority of Japanese words and while the pitch may change, the lack of sudden discontinuous change makes this sound unaccented to the Japanese ear.

The presence and order of pitch change can make the difference between rain (□) and candy (□), both pronounced "ame" but with their accents on the first and second syllable respectively, or more drastically between an umbrella (□) and syphilis (□), both pronounced "kasa" but again with their accents on the first and second syllable respectively.

For sentences, too, pitch plays an important role. A sentence ending with a high and then a low syllable, compared to the same sentence ending with the last two syllables in neutral pitch, will be experienced as a question rather than as a statement, for instance. Anger, lecturing, boredom, and a wide variety of emotions can be told from the pitch pattern of a sentence, not unlike in most Western languages. However, while in western languages pitch only adds emotion, in Japanese, a misplaced pitch may also change the meaning of the words being used.

1.7 english

Due to the different *glossary* levels in Japanese, a particular style of speech is often associated with a particular gender — the more polite and english being associated with english, and the more brash and forward english being associated with english. While this is an understandable association, the problem with associating english with genders is that people often mistakenly apply backward logic: if the female speech pattern is reserved, then reserved speech is female speech.

This isn't how it works, though. Typically, speech patterns fall into categories such as polite reserved speech, plain *glossary* or english, which are used by a particular gender more than the other by virtue of statistics. However, this does not mean that what is considered "female speech" is never used by men, or what is considered "male speech" isn't used by women, as there is no such thing as exclusively male or female speech. A more accurate distinction is to consider speech patterns as *glossary* versus *glossary* or *glossary* versus *glossary*. Women tend to be more reserved and use less direct speech, and men tend to be more assertive and use more direct speech. However, when the situation warrants it, there is nothing to prevent men from using reserved indirect speech, or women from using assertive direct speech. It's all about what the social setting warrants.

This said, there are a few words (not speech patterns) that are genuinely *glossary* or english*glossary*, such as the english *glossary* particle □□□, or the masculine personal pronoun □. It is important to notice that the labels used here are "effeminate" and "masculine", and not "female" and "male". Very effeminate men (such as transvestites or homosexuals) may very well use very effeminate words, and hardcore business ball-busting career women

may very well use very masculine words to demonstrate their dominance. Again, it's all about the social setting.

1.8 Context language

As mentioned in the section on sentence structure, Japanese is a *glossary* english language, relying heavily on the reader or listener to be able to keep track of information during a conversation, and omitting any information once it has become contextual. Before we look at an example of this, we will look at how a "english" differs from a "english", as this can cause some confusion: in our day-to-day experience of language, the words 'context' and 'subject' refer to the same thing. If a public speaker at some convention is talking about the physics of Star Trek, then we can say that "the subject of his talk is the physics of Star Trek", or that his talk should be interpreted within the context of "the physics of Star Trek", making the two refer to essentially the same idea — a *glossary*.

Grammatically, the terms are much further apart. Rather than both "subject" and "context" being able to refer to some english, the two mean wildly different things. A "context" is the overall topic of some text or conversation; it doesn't necessarily have to be mentioned, but it is clear what the text or conversation is all about. A "subject", on the other hand, refers to specific words in individual sentences within a text or conversation. The best way to indicate the difference when we use the words "context" and "subject" from a grammatical perspective is as follows:

> "A sentence says something about a subject, within a certain context."

For instance, given that this section talks about "context", the sentence "It can be a problematic 'feature' of Japanese for people who only know English" is readily interpreted as meaning "Context can be a problematic 'feature' of Japanese for people who only know English". You know what "it" refers to because of the context you're reading it in. Had this sentence been in a section on the sparsity of language, then you would have understood "it" to refer to "the sparsity of Japanese".

In Japanese, this concept of "sentences say things about subjects within a certain context" is taken further than in English. The following conversation may illustrate this:

A: [redacted]
B: [redacted]
A: [redacted]
B: [redacted]
A: [redacted]

Transcribed, this reads:

A: atashi no koppu o mikakemasen deshita ka?
B: aa, mitemasen.
A: okashii wa. tsui sakki made mottetandesukedo.
B: ima no teeburu ni oitekiteshimatta no dewanai deshou ka.
A: a… soukamoshiremasen, ne.

This conversation can be translated to natural sounding English in the following manner:

A: "You haven't seen my cup, have you?"
B: "No, I haven't seen it."
A: "That's odd. I just had it a moment ago."
B: "Perhaps you left it on the table in the living room?"
A: "Ah! That might be."

In this translation there are a number of englishs: "you" has been used to refer to a specific person, "it" has been used to contextually refer to the cup in question, and "that" has been used by speaker A to refer to what speaker B said. In Japanese, rather than using contextual words like this, they are simply omitted entirely. If we do a literal translation to English, we see a rather different, context-heavy kind of conversation:

A: "Haven't seen my cup?"
B: "Indeed, haven't seen."
A: "Odd… had just a moment ago."
B: "Could be left on living room table?"
A: "Ah! Might be so."

It's not just "it" which has been omitted, even personal pronouns are typically left out. This makes for a seemingly very sparse language, which can be hard to interpret, especially when one is just starting out with the language. For this reason, some textbooks and courses will present Japanese sentences with all the contextual information in them — while this does not violate Japanese grammar, it does lead to highly artificial sentences, existing only in textbooks rather than reflecting the language as it is actually used. Because of this, all the examples in this book will try to use "natural" Japanese phrases, with contextual words required for the sentence to make sense in translation added in parentheses. For instance:

A: okashii wa. tsui sakki made mottetandakedo.
A: (That's) odd. (I) just had (it) (a) moment ago.

And with that, we are finally able to move on from introductory text to the language itself: let's sink our teeth in some grammar!

Chapter 2

Verb grammar

As mentioned in the introductory chapter on syntax, there are two classes of verbal words in Japanese: *glossary*, and *glossary*. Both of these can be considered to consist of two parts: a verbal *glossary*, called the "english" (japanese), which indicates what the core meaning of a verb or verbal adjective is, and some additional hiragana called "english" (japanese), which is used to indicate inflection.

Unlike English, where verb stems are already usable on their own — the verb stem of "walk" is "walk", for instance — verb stems in Japanese require an inflection indicator in the form of okurigana, so before we move on to the actual rules of grammar concerning Japanese verbs and verbal adjectives, we must look at how verbs and verbal adjectives are composed in Japanese. We will first be deconstructing the verbs, after which we'll deconstruct the verbal adjectives.

Note that in this chapter, as well as all following chapters, Japanese will no longer be romanised. So, if you haven't learned the hiragana script yet: now would be a good time to start!

2.1 Inflecting

In English, we are used to thinking of verb englishs in terms of 'the verb' plus some text that indicates the inflection. We consider "walked" to consist of "walk" with "-ed" tacked on the end, and "passing" as being "pass" with "-ing" added to it. However, many verb forms in English actually use helper verbs, so things like "will help", "let's dance", "be able to dive" are considered verb chains, with the helper verb(s) indicating the tense, mood and aspect.

In Japanese, all verb inflections are in fact chains of helper verbs and verbal adjectives, but rather than being a long list of separated verbs like in English, they are added to the base verb one by one until all the englishs, englishs and englishs have been dealt with. For instance, the verb construction □□□□□□□□□ means "(I) had been made to wait". While hard to tell without spaces or a knowledge of verbal grammar at this point, this is actually a series of six verbs chained together in a very specific way:

First, we see (□)□, the *glossary* base form for □□, "wait". This base form is used when forming the negative, passive, causative or 'pseudo-future' form of a verb. Then we see □□, the *glossary* base for the helper verb for causatives, □□□. This base form is a general purpose 'intermediate form' for a great number of inflections. Then □, the continuative base for the helper verb for conjunction, □. Then □, the continuative base for the verb □□, "to be" for animate objects. Combined with □ it forms the "-◎◎◎" form, which marks a verb as present progressive. Then □□, the continuative base for the helper verb for politeness, □□. Then finally □, the terminal base for the helper verb for past tense, □.

We can see two things in this *glossary*. First, the 'core' verb is all the way at the beginning, and the helper verbs follow each other in inflection order: first the causative of "wait" is formed, then that is made a present progressive, this is then made polite, and then finally the whole construction is turned from present to past tense. Second, all the verbs are in some "base" form; this is the crucial difference between Japanese verbal grammar and most other languages.

There are five "english" which are used in combination with specific inflections, and knowing how to identify these base forms makes verbal grammar significantly easier, because it lets us view complex verb *glossary* in terms of a series of simple "base form" + "helper" rules. For the past tense progressive causative for instance, we see a huge inflection that's really composed of four fairly simple rules, applied one after another:

inflection	rule	example
causative	imperfect base + □□□	□□ □ □□ + □□□
progressive	continuative base + □□□	□□□□□ □ □□□□ + □□□
polite	continuative form + □□	□□□□□□□ □ □□□□□□ + □□
past tense	continuative form + □	□□□□□□□□ □ □□□□□□□□ + □

All complex verb constructions can be described in this way, being a series of fixed-order simple rules being applied. What's more, because the two different verb classes in Japanese mostly differ in what their base forms look like, inflecting verbs in Japanese is mostly a matter of picking the right base form, and then applying the same rules for both verb classes, making most inflections the same for the two. Verbal adjectives also rely on this concept of "base form" + "helper", and as will become apparent when looking at the rules of grammar for verbal words, some inflections are formed by adding verbal adjectives to verbs, while others are formed by adding verbs to verbal adjectives.

Without getting ahead of the material, let us first examine which base forms are used by verbs and verbal adjectives, and what they look like for each of the verbal word classes.

2.1.1 english

Traditionally, there are english "*glossary*" for Japanese verbal words, of which five are still used in modern Japanese. This traditional scheme is called japanese, english, and is associated with

english, while the modern scheme is called japanese, english, and is associated with normal english. Because it is always a good idea to look at where a language has come from, in order to understand why it does what it does in its current form, the relation between classical and modern Japanese will be mentioned wherever possible.

First, let's look at which base forms are used in classical and modern Japanese:

◎◎	◎◎	Base for…
english	◎◎◎	english constructions, such as negative form and 'pseudo-future', as well as passive, potential, honorific and causative forms.
english	◎◎◎	english and english constructions, covering the majority of constructions involving helper verbs, as well as joining up sentences and forming nouns.
english	no longer used	english form. In modern Japanese, this role has been assumed by the ◎◎◎ instead.
english	◎◎◎	english constructions (using verbs like adjectives), and in modern Japanese, finalised form.
english	◎◎◎ (english)	english*glossary* constructions. In modern Japanese this form is only used for hypothetical constructions, which is why it's colloquially known as the ◎◎◎, "assuming" form.
english	◎◎◎	english constructions, such as commands and prohibitive commands.

The way these bases are formed for the two classes of verbs and the verbal adjectives is the major difference between these verbal classes. Verbs in Japanese are mostly regular (there are only a handful of verbs with irregularities), and fall into one of two classes: "english", japanese, or 'five grade' verbs, and "english", japanese, or 'single grade' verbs. Both verb classes end, in their "dictionary" form, on one of the ◻—row syllables (although not ◻, and consequently ◻, and not ◻ or ◻), so that any verb you may encounter can be found in a dictionary to end on ◻, ◻, ◻, ◻, ◻, ◻, ◻, ◻ or ◻ (the "dictionary" form mentioned here is a common descriptor used in literature on Japanese, and is synonymous with the ◻◻◻ form of verbs or verbal adjectives.

The ◻◻ verbs (also referred to as "english", "english" or "english" in literature) can end on any of the aforementioned syllables, but ◻◻ verbs (also referred to as "english", "english" or "english" in literature) only end on ◻. english — the class of adjectives in Japanese that inflect just like regular verbs do — only come in one class and always end on the syllable ◻, which is why they are also referred to in literature as "english" (a second class of adjectives, the adjectival nouns, are commonly referred to as "english"). However, while it is useful to know on which syllables verbs and verbal adjectives can end, bear in mind that just because verbs

end on □—row syllables and verbal adjectives end on □, not everything ending on an □—row syllable is a verb, and not everything ending on □ is a verbal adjective — "all cats have four legs, but not everything with four legs is a cat".

Let us look at how the bases for both verbs and the verbal adjectives are formed. Looking at them as a combination of verbal stem and some final syllable(s), the following table describes each of the bases for these word classes:

Base	□□□ □□ verbs	□□□□ □□ verbs	verbal adjectives
stem (□□□ □□)	remove □—row syllable	remove □	remove □
□□□	stem + □—row syllable	stem	stem + □
□□□	stem + □—row syllable	stem	stem + □
□□□	stem + □—row syllable	stem + □	stem + □
□□□	stem + □—row syllable	stem + □	stem + □□
□□□	stem + □—row syllable	stem (+ □/□ *)	(stem + □□*)

In this table, the □□□ for the □□ verbs and verbal adjectives are starred, to indicate there's something special about them. First, the □□ verb □□□ is a bit of a problem: the word □□□ can refer to either the grammatical base form, or to the actual verb inflection as it is used in sentences. In classical Japanese, both interpretations of the □□□ were "stem + ◎"; the grammatical base form was the same as the final inflected form. However, in modern Japanese the final inflected form is either "stem + ◎", if you're in an area that adheres to ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎ ◎◎◎, 'standard Japanese' (the kind spoken in Tokyo), or fairly uniformly "stem + ◎", if you're not. This raises the problem that either the ◎◎◎ is listed as two separate forms — something I'm not too fond of — or listing it as just the stem, and then telling you the final inflected forms are either □□□ + □ or □□□ + □ depending on where you are. In this book, I've taken the latter approach.

In addition to this, the verbal adjective □□□ is a point of contention. In english, verbal adjectives came in two types: □ adjectives and □ adjectives. Both of these had a regular form, as well as a form involving a *glossary* with the verb □□, meaning "to be", forming □□□ adjectives. Because of this, the □ and □ versions were 'pure' adjectives, in that they had no *glossary* or *glossary* form; for adjectives those would make no sense. However, because of □□, the □□ variants did have these forms, instead missing a finalising and perfect form. This gave rise to the following rather elaborative set of bases in □□:

Base	□□ form	□□□ form	□□ form	□□□□ form
□□□	-	stem + □□	-	stem + □□□
□□□	stem + □	stem + □□	stem+□□	stem + □□□
□□□	stem + □	-	stem+□	-
□□□	stem + □	stem + □□	stem+□□	stem + □□□
□□□	stem + □□	-	stem + □□□	-

Base	□□ form	□□□ form	□□ form	□□□□ form
□□□	-	stem + □□	-	stem + □□□

This is a lot of inflectional potential, but as classical Japanese transitioned to modern Japanese, all these forms have essentially become merged, leading to a single inflectional scheme that mixes forms from the 'pure' versions of adjectives with the □□-contracted versions of those adjectives, leading to the question of which forms are to be considered belonging to the adjective as it exists now, and which belong to the verb □□, which happens to work together with verbal adjectives a lot. In this book, we'll consider the final inflected ◎◎◎ for verbal adjectives to be a contraction of the verbal adjective's ◎◎◎ and the ◎◎◎ for the verb ◎◎, which is □□. This gives us "verbal adjective stem + ◎" + "◎◎" → "verbal adjective stem + ◎◎◎", where □□ contracts to □, giving us a final rule "stem + ◎◎". So, in this book, verbal adjectives are considered not to have a genuine □□□ of their own, instead relying on the helper verb □□ for one. However, other books list it as being simply "stem + ◎◎", and so for completeness it has been included in the earlier table of bases.

Having covered the "what they look like", let's look at what this means for a number of verbs from both classes, and for verbal adjectives:

□□ verb	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□

There are two things worth noting in these tables. Firstly, the □□□ for □□ is not a typographical error; it really is □, not □. This is a left-over from classical Japanese: □□ verbs ending on □ used to be verbs ending on □ and □ (being 'wu', rather than 'u'), which inflected respectively as -□, -□, -□, -□, -□ and -□, -□, -□, -□, -□ (english and □ being the now obsolete

Japanese syllables for 'wi' and 'we', which have not been in use since the written language was reformed in 1946 by cabinet order). However, both were pronounced as -□, -□, -□, -□ and -□. When these two verb classes were simplified to today's □□ verbs ending on the modern □, the □□□ pronunciation □ was kept, as well as its written form.

The second thing worth noting in the table is the seemingly disproportionate number of examples for □□ verbs ending on -□. The reason for this is that for some verbs ending on □, just looking at the verb's dictionary form is not enough to determine whether it's actually a □□ or an □□ verb, so a few examples are needed to show how to tell the two apart. If a verb ends on □, and the syllable preceding it in the □—, □— or □—row (such as is the case for □□□, □□ and □□□) then this is always a □□ verb. However, if the syllable before the □ is in the □— or □—row, then it might be an □□ verb instead. The annoying thing is that without actually looking up the verb in a dictionary, or seeing it used in some inflected form that lets you spot the difference between a □□ base and an □□ base being used, there is no way to tell what kind of verb you're dealing with. Luckily, telling the difference when we do have an inflected form is really easy, as we can tell from the following □□ inflection examples (taking note that the □□□ as used in this book is just the stem):

□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□
□ □□	□	□	□□	□□	□ (□/□)
□ □□□	□□	□□	□□□	□□□	□□ (□/□)
□ □□□	□□	□□	□□□	□□□	□□ (□/□)

Comparing this table with the previous one shows that for any inflection involving the □□□, □□□ or □□□, which cover most verbal inflections, we can readily tell the difference between a □□ and □□ verb. The only cases that can leave us uncertain are the □□□ and □□□ forms. In these cases, we'll just have to resort to checking a dictionary to be sure of which verb class we're dealing with.

Lastly, a list of examples for the verbal adjectives is quite uniform:

adjective	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	(□□□)
□□ □□	□□	□□	□□	□□□	(□□□)
□□ □□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□□	(□□□□)
□□ □□	□□	□□	□□	□□□	(□□□)
□□ □□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□□	(□□□□)

Of course, the examples of verbal adjectives wouldn't be complete without one very curious verbal adjective:

adjective	㊇㊇㊇	㊇㊇㊇	㊇㊇㊇	㊇㊇㊇	(㊇㊇㊇)
㊇㊇㊇ ㊇㊇㊇	㊇㊇㊇	㊇㊇㊇	㊇㊇㊇	㊇㊇㊇㊇	(㊇㊇㊇㊇)

Normally, verbal adjectives end on □, preceded by either an □—, □—, □— or □—row syllable. However, □□□ is the only verbal adjective in Japanese that ends in an □—row syllable + □. This is in fact so unusual that it is virtually never used, and you will likely not find this adjective in most dictionaries. So, because there's only the one, we can safely state that if you find something that ends in □ but it has an □—row syllable preceding it, it is virtually certain not to be a verbal adjective.

2.1.2 englishs

Throughout the course of this section we will look at basic inflections for verbs and verbal adjectives, as well as look at a small number of particles that are intricately interwoven with verbal grammar. We shall also look at the basic use and formation of nouns and adverbs, so that this chapter in effect covers the minimal basics of "english". We will start by looking at which particles are essential in order to understand basic verb grammar, and will move from there to simple verb forms: present and past tense, as well as *glossary* and *glossary* forms. In order to get an overview of the basic concepts involved without offering too much information at once, polite verbal grammar will not be introduced until the next chapter, after basic grammar has been covered.

english

Verbs and verbal adjectives are used in combination with a number of particles to explicitly mark parts of a sentence as relating to them. For verbs, these are the particles □, □ and □, and for verbal adjectives this is just the particle □.

First off, english (pronounced as □). This particle is used to mark a transitive verb's english. This particle is fairly straightforward and does what one expects from it given this explanation. In "I eat an apple" the noun "apple" is the *glossary* for the verb "eat", and in the corresponding Japanese sentence, □□□□□□□, the word □□□ ('apple') is the direct object to the verb □□□ ('eat'). However, not everything that is considered a direct object in Japanese is considered a direct object when translated to English. For instance, in Japanese an aeroplane can "fly the air", whereas in English aeroplanes just fly.

Second is english, which broadly speaking marks english. Translating a sentence using □ to English yields the parts marked with □ as becoming englishs, englishs or even englishs. Anything that is "not the english, or the direct object", but adds more details to the verb action, will be marked with □. For instance, the Japanese sentence □□□□□□□□□□□□ translates to the English sentence "I bought flowers for Mary", with □ mapping to the word 'for', which in English indicates an indirect object. This is hardly its only 'meaning'; the Japanese sentence □□□□□ translates to "I'll be there at nine", with □ mapping to the *glossary* 'at'. Moreover, in the Japanese □□□□□□□, translating to the English "to divide cleanly", the □ marks the adjective □□□, "clean/neat/tidy", as being used adverbially, "neatly, cleanly".

Finally, the particle english is an interesting particle. When used with verbal adjectives, it marks the thing the adjective applies to. For instance, in the English sentence "that car is fast", the adjective "fast" pertains to "that car". Similarly, in the corresponding Japanese sentence ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯, the verbal adjective ▯▯ ('fast') pertains to ▯▯▯ ('that car'). This concept is carried over to verbs, too. Some verbs have what would in English be considered a direct object, but in Japanese are not considered direct object because the verb does not 'impart' its action on it. For instance, in "I throw the ball", the throwing action is imparted on the ball. However, in "I know the textbook's material", knowing is not an action imparted 'on' the material — in these cases, rather than ▯, ▯ is used in Japanese, so that for instance "I understand Japanese" is not expressed as ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯ but as ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯. This is particularly obvious when using verbs in passive mode, changing for instance "I eat the cake" to "the cake is being eaten by me". In the corresponding Japanese sentences, the particle changes from ▯ to ▯: ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯ becomes ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯. In addition to this, ▯ may mark a verb's actor: ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯ translates to "(The) car is running". In this role it is effectively doing the same thing as what it does when it is used to link nouns to adjectives.

In addition to these three particles, you will also often see the particle english (pronounced as ▯) being used in example sentences. This particle acts as a english when a sentence would otherwise be confusing in terms of who or what it was about, or what it was in relation to. For instance, ▯▯▯▯ and ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯ translate to "I do not walk" and "I won't be walking today" by virtue of the second sentence disambiguating the context from as broad as possible (i.e., 'in general'), to 'just today' (▯▯). This can have some perhaps unexpected side effects, too: when saying ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯, "I do not swim", the explicit presence of ▯▯ means that you apparently felt that you needed to english the statement, which means any listener will suddenly wonder who then 'does swim', as opposed to you. On the other hand, ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯ merely means "I do not swim", using ▯ to mark yourself as verb actor for ▯▯.

Verbal grammar - english

Before we look at how to form the *glossary*, a note. There is no distinction between present tense such as "I walk" and indicative english such as "I will walk". Both roles are performed by the same verb form in Japanese: the japanese. Any verb or verbal adjective in ▯▯▯ is automatically in present/indicative *glossary*. Listing this form for example words from all three verbal classes, we see the following:

	▯▯▯	meaning	plain present affirmative
▯▯ verb	▯▯	walk	▯▯▯: ▯▯
▯▯ verb	▯▯	see	▯▯▯: ▯▯
verbal adjective	▯▯	high, expensive	▯▯▯: ▯▯

Some examples of the present tense used in simple sentences:

□□□
□□□□□□
Today (I'll) walk.

□□□□□□□
(I) watch TV.

□□□□□□
This is expensive.

english

Having covered the present affirmative tense, the next important basic inflection is the negative form. In Japanese, negative verb and verbal adjective forms are created with the english, japanese (□□), or using the rather classical verb □ which will be discussed after polite forms have been introduced later in this chapter.

□□ is actually a verbal adjective, and so inflects like any other verbal adjective:

bases	form
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□□

This helper is combined with both verbs and verbal adjectives by joining up with the □□□, or imperfect base:

	□□□	meaning	plain present negative
□□ verb	□□	walk	□□□+□□: □□□□
□□ verb	□□	see	□□□+□□: □□□
verbal adjective	□□	high, expensive	□□□+□□: □□□□

Recycling our example sentences from the present tense section, we get the following sentences:

□□□
□□□□□□□□
Today (I) don't/won't walk.

□□□□□□□□
(I) don't/won't watch TV.

□□□□□□□□
This isn't expensive.

However, please note that this rule does not apply to the special verb □□, which we shall treat in the next section. Rather than becoming □□□□, it is simply replaced with □□.

(On a final note, it is imperative this □□ should never be confused with another adjective pronounced □□, □□, as that means "deceased")

2.1.3 Basic inflections for english and verbal adjectives

There are three irregular verbs in Japanese that we need to look at before moving on to further inflections, being japanese, "do"/"decide on", japanese, "come" and japanese, "exist" (for *glossary* things).

The irregular verb □□

Looking at japanese, 'do', first, we see the following bases and inflection table:

base	form
□□□	□, □, □
□□□	□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□(□), □(□), □□

	affirmative	negative
plain	□□□	"◎"—◎◎◎+◎◎; ◎◎◎

We see that □□ actually has three different □□□ forms, as well as three different □□□ forms — which of these gets used is fully determined by which inflection you're going for, making this verb a bit trickier than any of the other verbs in the language. Luckily, it's such a common verb that even though it's highly irregular you will most likely become familiar with all its inflections fairly quickly by virtue of them popping up almost as often as all other verbs put together.

Technically, □□ is considered a □—□ verb, or "irregular verb, operating on the □ column". For the most part, it inflects as an □□ verb, but there are rules for what pronunciation to use when using which base, which makes it a truly irregular verb.

□□ has two common "variations": japanese and japanese. Both of these are typically found used as a verb in a noun/verb compound (meaning they are paired with a noun without using any particles), and only constitute a small number of all verbs in

Japanese. However, while only used in a small number of verbs, some of those verbs are quite common and frequently used, so knowing how to inflect these two verbs is not unimportant.

base	□□	□□	□□
□□□	□, □, □	□, □, □	□
□□□	□	□	□
□□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□	□(□), □(□), □□	□(□), □(□), □□	□(□, □)

	affirmative	negative
□□	□□□	"◎"—◎◎◎+◎◎: ◎◎◎
□□	□□□	"◎"—◎◎◎+◎◎: ◎◎◎
□□	□□□	"◎"—◎◎◎+◎◎: ◎◎◎

For □□, the "◎" and "◎" □□□ are actually not used a lot in modern Japanese anymore. Instead, you will find □ used for virtually all □□□ constructions, with □ and □ indicating respectively classical and non-classical older style Japanese, instead.

The irregular verb □□

japanese ('come') on the other hand, inflects like any normal □□ verb (except for a slightly different □□□), but shares □□'s irregularity: the pronunciation for its stem changes for each base. However, unlike for □□ there is only one pronunciation for each base, so inflection doesn't involve "picking the right pronunciation", but merely remembering it:

base	kanji form	pronunciation
□□□	□	□
□□□	□	□
□□□	□□	□□
□□□	□□	□□
□□□	□□	□□

	affirmative	negative
plain	□□□	□□□+□□: □□□

As is evident from the table of bases, and the table of inflections, this verb is virtually indistinguishable from any other □□ verb. However, in spoken language its irregularity is plainly obvious.

The irregular verb ☒☒

Finally, the verb japanese, “exist” (for inanimate things) has seemingly normal bases, but its inflection is quite special:

base	form
☒☒☒	☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒

	affirmative	negative
plain	☒☒☒	japanese

This verb is irregular in all its negative forms: rather than using the ☒☒☒+☒☒ rule, just ☒☒ itself is used. Thus, we see the following:

☒☒
☒☒☒☒☒
“There is a book.”

☒☒☒☒☒
“There is no book.”

The irregular adjective ☒☒

In addition to these verbs, there is the irregular verbal adjective japanese, “good”, which is actually the irregular verbal adjective japanese:

base	form
☒☒☒	japanese
☒☒☒	☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒, ☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒☒

	affirmative	negative
plain	☒☒	☒☒☒+☒☒: ☒☒☒☒

The only irregularity for this verbal adjective is its ☒☒☒, which is technically ☒☒, but is almost always used as ☒☒ instead. Of the two, ☒☒ is actually considered the plain pronunciation, and ☒☒ a formal variant. Not knowing that these two are actually the same adjective can lead to confusion in more complex inflections, such as when the adjective ☒☒ turns into the past

tense japanese.

english

The last basic inflection we will look at on its own in this chapter is the *glossary*, which relies on the classical helper verb for past tense, japanese. This helper verb has the following bases:

base	form
□□□	□□
□□□	□
□□□	japanese

This verb has no □□□ (it doesn't make sense to mark something as a past tense and then continue inflecting it to something else), nor does it have a □□□ (because one cannot command someone to do something in the past). It is combined with verbal □□□ forms, being wholly unremarkable for the □□ verbs, simply pairing up with the □□□, but being not quite so unremarkable for □□ verbs. While in classical Japanese, the same rule applies as for □□ verbs, in modern Japanese most past tenses for □□ verbs have become contracted, as we can see in the following table:

□□	□□□	english	english	change 'rule'
□□	□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: no change
□□	□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□□	□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□	□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□□	□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□	□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□	□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□	□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□	□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□□□	□□□	□□□+□: □□□□	□□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□□	□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□

These rules for contraction in □□ verbs (luckily) do not just apply to the past tense, but to several other inflections (namely the continuative english, which is tremendously important to know, the representative japanese form, and the *glossary* japanese form), so that this is not a set of rules you will need to remember for a single inflection, but applies to a number of often used inflections, making the exception itself somewhat 'regular'.

Of course, there are a few exceptions to these rules. First up, □□, which follows the "wrong" rule:

verb	□□□	classical past tense	modern past tense
japanese	□□	□□□+□	japanese

The verb □□, pronounced □□ or japanese (the first being used in every day life, the latter being used in poetry and song lyrics), does not follow the contraction rule for □□ verbs ending on □. There is no real reason for this, other than "that's just how people use it". In all other respects, □□ is just another □□ verb. Luckily, this is not some obscure verb you will run into only occasionally and will have forgotten this exception for: □□ means "go", and is used so frequently you will not get a chance to forget it has an irregular past tense.

Secondly, there is a (very small) set of verbs that have a rather abnormal past tense, based on adding □ to the □□□ instead of the □□□. These verbs are mostly used in writing, and in formal speech, but since there are only two (with two kanji forms each) it cannot hurt to look at them:

verb	meaning	past tense
□ □□	ask, question, accuse	□□□
□ □□	□	□□□
□ □□	ask	□□□
□ □□	□	□□□

These verbs can, technically, also be inflected like regular □□ verbs, but since they are mostly reserved for formal spoken and literary written Japanese, if you encounter them you will most likely encounter them as □□□ + □.

For □□ verbs things are a lot simpler, and we see a regular table of inflection:

□□	□□□	past tense
□ □□	□	□□□+□: □□
□ □□□	□□	□□□+□: □□□
□ □□□	□□	□□□+□: □□□

And for the irregular verbs we see the same, bearing in mind that the stems have a different pronunciation:

irregular verb	□□□	past tense
□□	□	□□□+□: □□
□ □□	□	□□□+□: □□

To form the plain past negative, rather than just the plain past, we have to take the plain present negative based on japanese, and turn this into a past tense, which means we need to look at how to form the past tense for verbal adjectives in general first.

For verbal adjectives, rather than a plain inflection, the adjectives work together with

the verb japanese ("to be", for inanimate objects and concepts). However, because □□ is a □□ verb, it contracts: the classical past tense □□□ has become □□□, and it is this that the verbal adjective itself contracts with. Again for reasons mostly due to "that's just what people ended up using", the verbal adjective □□□ paired with □□□, […]□□□, has become contracted over the course of linguistic history to become […]□□ in modern Japanese:

adjective	meaning	□□□	+ past tense of □□	resulting past tense
□□ □□	high, expensive	□□	□□ + □□□	□□□□
□□ □□□	fun, enjoyable	□□□	□□□ + □□□	□□□□□
□□ □□	thin, light	□□	□□ + □□□	□□□□
□□ □□□	big	□□□	□□□ + □□□	□□□□□

irregular verb	meaning	□□□	+ past tense of □□	resulting past tense
□□	good	□□	□□ + □□□	japanese

negation	meaning	□□□	+ past tense of □□	resulting past tense
□□	-	□□	□□ + □□□	japanese

english

So now we can also form the plain past negative for verbs, using □□□ + "past tense of ◎◎", □□□□, noting that for the verb □□ things are (of course) different:

□□	□□□	negative	past negative tense
□□ □□	□□	□□□□	□□□□□
□□ □□	□□	□□□□	□□□□□
□□ □□	□□	□□□□	□□□□□
□ □□	□□	□□□□	□□□□□
□□ □□	□□	□□□□	□□□□□
□ □□	□□	□□□□	□□□□□
□ □□	□□	□□□□	□□□□□
□ □□	□□	□□□□	□□□□□
□ □□□	□□□	□□□□□	□□□□□□

□□	□□□	negative	past negative tense
□ □□	□	□□□	□□□□□
□ □□□	□□	□□□□	□□□□□□
□ □□□	□□	□□□□	□□□□□□

irregular verb	□□□	negative	past negative tense
□□	□	□□□	□□□□□
□□	□	□□□	□□□□□
□□	□□	□□	□□□□

Again, of the irregular verbs □□ is the most irregular, its past negative form simply being the past form of □□, rather than the typical □□ inflection □□□□. In several major dialects this isn't actually the case, and for instance in the english dialect (where the word english is used instead of □□) □□ inflects like any other □□ verb, with a negative form english. Why standard Japanese has this 'dual nature' for □□ is mainly because of historic use (languages serve the people using them, and if that use changes, the language changes). However, we can at least look at why this duality can even exist in the first place: □□ means "to be", for inanimate objects and concepts, and □□ is an adjective for non-existence, which is in concept the complete opposite. So, while they belong to different word classes, □□ and □□ can be considered two sides of the same coin. This is also the reason why □□ only half counts as an irregular verb; all affirmative inflections work in exactly the same way as normal □□ verbs. It also counts as a half irregular verbal adjectives, because all the negatives for □□ are just affirmative inflections of □□. It's little things like this that make languages interesting.

2.1.4 In summary

In summary, we can draw up tables for verbal inflection, plus the irregularities:

inflecting □□ verbs

	affirmative	negative
present	□□□	□□□ + □□
past	□□□ + □ (c)	□□□ + □□□□

In this scheme, (c) indicates that a contraction occurs, with what the contraction looks like being dependent on which of the □, □, □, □, □, □, □ or □ □□ verbs is being inflected.

inflecting □□

	affirmative	negative
present	□□□	□□□ + □□
past	□□□	□□□ + □□□□

inflecting □□

	affirmative	negative
present	□□□	□□
past	□□□ + □ (c)	□□□□

inflecting □□ verbs, including □□

	affirmative	negative
present	□□□	□□□ + □□
past	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□□

Observing that the stem for □□ changes: its □□□ is □, its □□□ is □, and its □□□ is □.

inflecting □□

	affirmative	negative
present	□□□	□—□□□ + □□
past	□□□ + □	□—□□□ + □□□□

inflecting □□ and □□

present	□□□	□—□□□ + □□
past	□□□ + □	□—□□□ + □□□□

inflecting verbal adjectives

	affirmative	negative
present	□□□	□□□ + □□
past	□□□ + □□□ (c)	□□□ + □□□□

inflecting □□ (□□)

	affirmative	negative
present	□□, □□	□□□ + □□
past	□□□ + □□□ (c)	□□□ + □□□□

Of the two possible □□□, □□ is considered normal, while □□ is considered formal, but for both, the □□□ and □□□ are □□.

inflecting □□ (□□)

	affirmative	negative
present	□□	theoretically, □□□ + □□
past	□□□ + □□□ (c)	theoretically, □□□ + □□□□

'Theoretically' is used here, because often it doesn't make a lot of sense to negate the adjective for negation itself. We'd end up with ◎◎ again.

2.2 english

We need to spend some extra time looking at verbal adjectives, and adjectives in general, because they can do something verbs cannot do, and that's to indicate properties. With that, we get the added bonus that they let us compare properties, allowing us to say something is red, redder than something else, or the reddest thing we've ever seen. While in English these are three distinct concepts, Japanese shows itself to be a sparse language yet again, using the □□□ for both the english as well as english*glossary* forms:

A: □□□ □□ □□□ □□□□□□
□□□□□

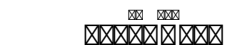
A: □□□□

that indicate something in addition to the root noun, like *glossary* or possession. Instead, everything is either done by marking nouns (or indeed entire noun phrases) with particles, or by using copula verbs in Japanese.

2.3.1 english

There are three important particles that we can use when dealing with noun inflection/declension, being ☒, ☒, and ☒.

The particle english is generally explained as being used to english link nouns, but that doesn't tell us what it really does. In Japanese, genitive is expressed as either marking english (english or english), english, or a english construction. In English, examples of these would be 'my car' in "this is my car", 'love song' in "this is a love song", and 'old story' in "that's just an old story", but while in English these are seemingly different constructions, in Japanese they all use ☒:

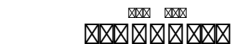

"This is my car."

In this sentence, which illustrates ☒ being used for possession, the function is fairly obvious: "english" means "[X]'s [Y]" or "[Y] of [X]". This is the simplest use of ◎. However, things get more complicated when we look at the other three functions.


"This is a love song."

In this sentence, the idea behind the pattern is slightly more complicated, because it's related to a pattern of thought that we're generally not used to in English. In the sentence, the "song", ☒, is considered a specific kind of song, which we can explain by saying "it genitivally stems from ◎", meaning that as a whole, the word derives its core meaning from ☒, but its nuance from ☒. This is a complicated way to look at what's going on in a seemingly simple particle, so it is usually easier to note the specific interpretation instead: we can say that ☒ describes ☒, or that ☒ acts as context for ☒, and that this construction is closely related to the idea of a compound noun.

In this interpretation, "[X]◎[Y]" typically translates to "[X] [Y]" in English, so that ☒☒☒ becomes "love song", and for instance ☒☒☒ becomes "old story" (with ☒ being a noun meaning 'long ago', and ☒ meaning 'story'). If we use this in a slightly bigger, more interesting sentence, we see the following:


"(That)'s just an old story."

This sentence is particularly interesting because it uses ⊠ twice. ⊠⊠⊠[X] means "just X", with ⊠⊠ meaning 'just' or 'merely', and [X] being any noun phrase, in this case "⊚⊚⊚". This kind of chaining can be taken to extremes, such as in the following example:

⊠⊠ ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠「 佐崎(ささき) 」⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚
"My sister's friend, Sasaki, came over (today)."

Let us analyse what happens in this chain. It usually makes most sense to analyse long chains like these by looking at the [X]⊠[Y] patterns in a last-to-first order, because (as always) the most important words come last:

[X]⊠[Y]	translation
⊠⊠⊠「 ⊚⊚ 」	(my/your/his/her/our/their) friend, Sasaki
⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠	(my/your/his/her/our/their) sister's friend
⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠	(my/our) sister

While this sounds like an artificial example, it is actually quite common to find three or even four nouns linked through ⊠ to create a single, more and more specific noun phrase. The main issue with learning to use these patterns, and more importantly, understanding them while listening to native speakers, is that the most important information comes last, so you have to keep track of all the context nouns before the final *glossary* noun gets used.

The other two particles, english and english, are much simpler to understand than ⊠: ⊠ links nouns to form an english, while ⊠ forms a english. For instance, if someone went to the supermarket and bought orange juice, milk and tea, and that's all they bought, then we can list all these things with ⊠:

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠ ⊠⊠ ⊠⊠ ⊠ ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
"(I) bought juice, milk and tea."

However, if they instead bought a lot of refreshments (say they were planning a party), then the following sentence would be easier than listing every individual item on the shopping list:

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
"(I) bought juice, milk, tea (and the like)."

That's the only difference between ⊚ and ⊚ (for the purpose of noun listing). Both form a list of items, and by using ⊠ you imply that what you describe is the whole

list, while if you use □ you imply that even though it's a list, it's not the whole list, just a representative snippet. Of course, it (almost) goes without saying that you cannot mix □ and □.

2.3.2 Inflection

Actual inflection of nouns relies on copula verbs, as it does in English. While in English only the verb "to be" fulfils the role of copula, in Japanese there are a number of copulae to pick from. So, for the moment, we will look at the two most common englishe: the plain form japanese and its polite counterpart, japanese. Technically, these are both verbs, although □ is somewhat more complex than □□. If we look at their verb bases, we see the following:

	□□	□	copula
□□□	□□□	□□	□□
□□□	□□	□□ (□)	□
□□□	□□	□	□□/□
□□□	□□	□	□□/□
□□□		□□	□□

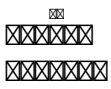
First, there is no □□□, which kind of makes sense — one cannot order something to all of a sudden have some property; chairs don't become red because you order them to, people don't become angry just because you tell them to, and it doesn't suddenly become night because you ordain it so. At least not without superpowers of some sort, which are beyond the scope of this book.

Secondly, the "copula" column is a bit special: it tells you which form is typically used when a certain base form is relied on. When we need a □□□ copula, we can use either □ or □□ depending on whether we want plain form or polite form, but when we need a continuative (which will be explained in the next chapter), modern Japanese uses japanese.

Third, there is a □□□ entry, which most modern verbs do not use. The reason it exists for (this) copula is that □ is relatively special: when used to end noun phrases, its □□□ is used, and so it uses the form □. However, when used attributively (effectively turning nouns into adjectives), which uses the □□□, the classical □□□ is used and we end up with japanese. Although the language reforms of the 20th century have for the most part merged the functions of □□□ and □□□, this particular instance of separate form has been preserved, rather than gotten rid of. Luckily you will rarely, if ever, need to recite the bases for □□ or □, but □ is used attributively so frequently that you should have little problem remembering when to use □ and when to use □.

english

The present tense for □ and □□ are just as simple as for any other verb:

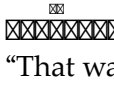

“This is a book.”

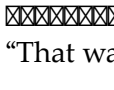
There is no difference in meaning between those two sentences, the only difference is the perceived politeness, with ⬚⬚ being neutral polite, while ⬚ is plain form.

english

The past tenses for both ⬚ and ⬚⬚ are also reasonably straightforward, although we do need to know a little bit more about where ⬚ came from. The common explanation for ⬚ is that it came from ⬚, the continuative of ⬚⬚, and the verb ⬚⬚, to form the copula japanese. This copula is actually still used in modern Japanese in formal settings. However, the ⬚+⬚ in this ⬚⬚⬚ has contracted over time, to form ⬚⬚, which explains the ⬚⬚⬚ for ⬚, which is ⬚⬚. It also explains its past tense: ⬚⬚⬚, since ⬚⬚ is a normal ⬚⬚ verb and thus contracts in its past tense.

For ⬚⬚ the story is a bit simpler: its ⬚⬚⬚ is ⬚⬚, and so its past tense is ⬚⬚⬚.


“That was a book.”

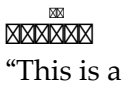

“That was a book.”

Again, there is no difference in meaning, only in perceived politeness.

english

The negative forms for ⬚ and ⬚⬚ are more interesting. For ⬚, the plain negative is japanese, which is japanese plus the adjective for negation that we already saw for verbs, ⬚⬚. Again we see evidence of the presence of ⬚⬚. However, what is this ⬚⬚?

Interestingly, ⬚⬚ is (and not just for this particular inflection, but in general) the “particle” ⬚, which is the ⬚⬚⬚ for ⬚⬚, and the disambiguating particle ⬚ (pronounced ⬚). This japanese can either be used by itself (and frequently is), or its contraction ⬚⬚ can be used, with the only difference between the two being that ⬚⬚ is more formal than ⬚⬚. To illustrate:


“This is a book.”

□□□□□□□□□□
“This isn’t a book.”

□□□□□□□□□□
“This is not a book.”

There is no difference in meaning between the latter two sentences, just in formality.

For □□ the story gets more complicated, because instead of using the negative form of □□ itself, the polite form japanese is used in polite form, using the polite negative of □□ instead of □□, which means we need to introduce the classical helper verb of politeness: japanese.

bases	form
□□□	□□ (□□□)
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□ (□□□)
□□□	□□

This helper verb is used in combination with verbs in their □□□, so that the polite form of □□ becomes □□+□□, and the polite negative is formed by taking this japanese and making □□ negative using the super classical negative “◎”: ◎◎◎◎+◎. While the explanation might be more complicated than you might have expected, the final result should sound familiar, since the polite negation —□□□, and the general statement japanese, are used constantly in modern Japanese.

With this, we can form the polite negative of the copulae: japanese, or more formally, japanese

□□□□□□□
“This is a book.”

□□□□□□□□□□□□
“This is not a book.”

□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“This is not a book.”

english

For □, the present negative □□□□ (□□□□) is placed in past tense, turning □□ into □□□□: japanese (japanese).

□□□□□□□□
“This was a book.”

□□□□□□□□□□□□
“This was not a book.”

□□□□□□□□□□□□
“This was not a book.”

For □□, things get really weird: the polite negative □□□□□ in japanese (japanese) is placed in past tense by adding the past tense for □□, □□□, at the end: japanese (japanese).

□□□□□□□□
“This was a book.”

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“This was not a book.”

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“This was not a book.”

While, again, this derivation is rather complicated, the important bit is that you remember the copula inflection table.

In summary

The best way to reiterate the different inflections for the copulae is in the form of a table:

	affirmative	negative
plain present	noun + □	noun + □□□□
		(noun + □□□□)
polite present	noun + □□	noun + □□□□□□□
		(noun + □□□□□□□)
plain past	noun + □□□	noun + □□□□□□
		(noun + □□□□□□)
polite past	noun + □□□	noun + □□□□□□□□□□
		(noun + □□□□□□□□□□)

2.4 english: japanese

In addition to regular nouns, Japanese has a set of words which are often (but mistakenly) labelled pronouns. These are colloquially known as the □□□□, and they're called this because they come as series of four, starting with □-, □-, □- and □-, to refer to (conceptually or physically) close to the speaker, close to the listener, close to neither, and as a question word.

To properly understand this, the concept of a *glossary* is important: the Japanese do not separate locations in just "here" and "there", but in "here", "there" and a conceptual location akin to "yonder". Words starting with ◎ refer to things in the speaker's personal zone, words starting with □ refer to things in the listener's personal zone, and words starting with □ refer to things that are neither in the speaker's nor the listener's personal zone. Finally, words starting with □ are the question words for the series, known as english*glossary*.

I mentioned that the □□□□ are often mistakenly called pronouns, because many series in the □□□□ actually work together with nouns rather than replacing them, as they would if they were genuine pronouns.

The most frequently used □□□□ series are the following:

□□□□	meaning
japanese[noun]	english [noun]
japanese[noun]	english [noun]
japanese[noun]	that [noun] over there
japanese[noun]	english [noun]

with examples:

□□□ □□
□□□□□□□□
"This car is fast."

□□
□□□□□□□□□
"That car is black."

□□
□□□□□□□□
"That car (over there) is broken."

□□□□□□□
"Which car do you like?"

It should be obvious that this series is not actually a pronoun series, since it doesn't replace the noun in question. However, that said, there are a few □□□□ series that act as a genuine series of pronouns, such as:

⊠⊠⊠⊠	meaning
japanese	english.
japanese	english.
japanese	that over there.
japanese	english.

with examples:

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
“This is fast.”

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
“That’s black.”

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
“That (over there)’s broken.”

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
“Which do you like?”

Notice the periods after the English translations for the individual ⊠⊠⊠⊠; these have been added to make sure you understand that these words are “done.” They are replacement nouns, and cannot be used in conjunction with a noun.

The rest of the common ⊠⊠⊠⊠ series are:

⊠⊠⊠⊠	meaning
japanese[noun]	english [noun]
japanese[noun]	english [noun]
japanese[noun]	that kind of [noun] over there
japanese[noun]	english [noun]

Beginning students often confuse ⊠⊠⊠ with the word japanese which means “english”, when thinking of dialogues such as: “I bought a velour pillow” - “wow, what does that feel like?”. While the English dialogue uses the word “what”, the Japanese question would actually be “which/what kind of feeling does that have?”

⊠⊠⊠⊠	meaning
japanese	english/english.
japanese	english/english.
japanese	that direction/that honourable person over there.
japanese	english/english.

This series can mean two things, depending on context. Since personal pronouns are avoided as much as possible in Japanese, it is considered polite to refer to someone by referring to the direction in which they are located, relative to the speaker, similar to using the English indirect way of referring to someone: "Over here we have Mr. Carver", rather than just saying "This is Mr. Carver".

◎◎◎◎	meaning
japanese	english/english.
japanese	english/english.
japanese	that direction over there/that person over there.
japanese	english/english.

Since this is a contracted version of the previous set, it cannot be used to refer to people respectfully - you don't use colloquially contracted words when you're being respectful. You can, technically, use this word to refer to people, but then only in a familiar conversation.

□□□□	meaning
japanese	english
japanese	english
japanese, english	english
japanese	english

The location □□□□, like the □□/□□/□□/□□ series, acts as a pronoun. There is an irregularity with the "not near me, not near you" version, which has two possible pronunciations, neither of which use just an □ rather than a □, □, or □; instead, they have an additional syllable, being either □ or □. Both these versions are accepted Japanese, although □□□ is slightly more 'proper' than □□□.

□□□□	meaning
japanese	english/english.
japanese	english/english.
japanese	that way/manner (referring to something distal).
japanese	english/english/english.

Notice the seeming irregularity for □□ here. I say seeming, because this □□□□ series is actually each of the four "prefixes" with a long vowel sound — for □, □ and □ this is a □, for □, this is (clearly) not a □ at all, but another □.

Finally, there is also a somewhat more classical series, of which the □- variant should sound familiar:

□□□□	meaning
japanese	english (I/me/you/him/he/her/she).
japanese	english (him/he, her/she).
japanese	that person over there (you).
japanese	english (english).

Since this set is a tad classical, there are a few things to notice. First of all, □□□ refers to a third person (he/she), while □□□ refers to second person (you). Also, while somewhat classical, this set is still used in formal settings. However, because it is used exclusively in formal settings it is considered english and very impersonal, and should thus only be used in formal settings where it would be improper to address someone the normal way. As an added bonus, □□□ is also commonly understood to be two seemingly completely opposite things. On the one hand, it is the *glossary*, *glossary*, formal word for "you", and on the other hand it also means "you" in a highly *glossary* relationship, akin to the English terms "dear", "darling" or "honey" being used by couples to call each other.

Lastly, while □□□ means "who", it is considered a distal and reserved interrogative. The plain version of "who" is the pronoun japanese, which is not associated with any □□□□ series.

□□□□	meaning
japanese	english (I/me/you/him/he/her/she).
japanese	english (him/he, her/she).
japanese	that person over there (you).
japanese	english (english).

In addition to the □□□ (etc.), □□□ (etc.)and □□□ (etc.) series, we also have this series available for referring to people. Where the former are all reasonably polite in some way, this series actually borders on derogatory, so you should probably try to avoid using it. However, it's also frequently used in the expression ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎, meaning "each and every one" in the sense of people:

□□□ □□□ □□
□□□

2.5 Special verbs

There are a number of special verbs that deserve a bit of extra attention as they are used so frequently in the language that it would be a miss to not highlight their roles.

2.5.1 english: japanese

Before you can say something "is" something else, it first has to "english" this something else. In Japanese, the process of english is expressed with the verb ⊠⊠, which can be used to describe english (such as "becoming cold") through the use of state nouns or adjective-derived adverbs, as well as being usable to describe english (such as "becoming an adult") by using it with nouns. Finally it can of course also be used to describe the process of "becoming" itself, (such as "to quickly become […]") by using proper adverbs.

The verb ◎◎ is a ◎◎ verb, without any irregularities, meaning its bases are ⊠⊠, ⊠⊠, ⊠⊠, ⊠⊠ and ⊠⊠.

While typically used in combination with the verb particle english, it can also be used in combination with the particle english (not in its role as noun lister), in which case its meaning changes from "become" to "be" (often interpreted as the immediate future "will be"). This can be illustrated with some ◎/◎ comparison sentences:

◎◎◎
◎ ◎◎◎◎◎◎
"(This) will become (our) strength".

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"(This) will be (our) strength".

◎◎◎◎◎ ◎◎◎ ◎◎◎◎◎◎
◎◎◎◎ ◎◎ ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"The band's performance will be set to (literally: become) May the 24th."

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"The band's performance will be on May the 24th."

2.5.2 english: japanese, japanese, japanese, japanese

We already looked at ◎◎ and ◎, but we haven't really looked at how they fit together with other *glossary* verbs, and how each differs from the other.

Where in English the verb "english" is used as both a english (the verb that sets up definitions such as "A is B") and as a english (the verb that indicates existence somewhere, such as "A is [here]"), in Japanese these are two (or more accurately, three) distinct

roles. To indicate that "A is B", distinct copulae are used in Japanese. These include □, □□, but also several less frequently used copulae such as japanese, japanese and japanese.

The existential verb role, on the other hand, is actually performed by two distinct verbs in Japanese: one describing existence for *glossary* objects (such as humans, animals, and things that can be considered animate, like "AIBO" robot puppies and the like) and one describing existence for inanimate objects and abstract things. These are □□ (□□) and □□ (□□), respectively. To illustrate the difference between animate and inanimate, let's look at two sentences:

□□
□□□□□
"(There) is a dog."

□□
□□□□□
"(There) is a book."

In both sentences, □ marks the preceding part as subject of the sentence. Both sentences translate to "there is X", but in the first sentence X is a dog, which is an animate 'object', and because of this, we need to use □□. In the second sentence X is a book, which is rather inanimate, and thus □□ is used. Also, in both sentences, the word "there" is entirely implied. Because we are using verbs to mark existence and we are talking about actual instances of dogs and books, saying they exist means we also say they exist at some location.

If we only want to define something, i.e. say something "is" a thing, such as "it is a dog" or "it is a book", we use a copula instead. For most people used to western language, these verbs may at first glance seem to do the same as what □□ and □□ do; after all, the sentence "it is a dog" is essentially the same as the sentence "there is a dog" with the word "there" replaced with "it". However, there is a very important difference: in "there is a dog", we are saying that a dog exists somewhere, whereas in "it is a dog", we are defining some "it" to be of the category "dog".

Put concisely, definitions in Japanese can only be done using copulae, and marking existence can only be done using □□ or □□:

□□□□
"It is a dog."

□□□
"It is a book."

□□
□□□□□□□
"Books are rectangular."



“Dogs are animals.”

2.5.3 english: japanese

We’ve already seen ◎◎ as irregular verb, and it has been used in enough example sentences to let it be no surprise that it means “do”. However, this isn’t the only meaning for this verb. When used in combination with a direct object — as transitive verb — ◎◎ does mean “do”, but when used as intransitive verb, its meaning should be considered to be “decide on” or “choose”. To show this difference in meaning between the transitive (strictly speaking, japanese) and intransitive (strictly speaking, japanese) versions of ◻◻, two short sentences:



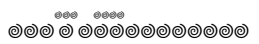
“What are (you) doing?”



“What will (you) pick?”

In the first sentence, english marks the preceding as direct object to the verb, while in the second sentence, english marks the preceding part as indirect object to the verb. The difference in meaning is striking.

There is a third meaning to ◻◻, when paired with the particle english, which is “to consider something …”:



“These are the things (that) I consider important.”

2.5.4 english: japanese

We’re not quite done treating ◎◎; while it means “exist” for inanimate things, this meaning also leads it to be usable for what in English is represented by “to have” in sentences like “I have a radio”. In Japanese, you don’t say you “have” something, but that “something is with you”. For instance, if I want to say that aside from my portable radio I also have a radio at home, instead of saying “I have a radio at home too” I would say “there is a radio at my house too”:

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"(I) have a radio at home, too."

Because of this double role, it's quite an important verb.

2.5.5 english: japanese

I know that ◎◎ is not a verb, but the reason it's in this list is because of ◎◎, which is very much a verb. Since ⊠⊠ means "exist" for inanimate things, and since the adjective ⊠⊠ means "not (exist)", there are actually (almost) always two interpretations possible when ⊠⊠ is used in a sentence, by virtue of ⊠⊠ having two possible interpretations:

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
1) "(There) is no radio."
2) "(I) do not have a radio."

So for this reason it has been included in the list of important verbs; if we look at it as the negative form for ⊠⊠, which we should, then it's a verb form, and a very important one at that.

2.6 More Verb Grammar

This covers the basics of verbal grammar. You should now be able to use most verbs in plain present affirmative and negative forms, as well as past tense, and hopefully be interested enough to move on to the next chapter, which will briefly recap the inflections covered in this chapter before moving on to the (rather extensive!) list of verbal inflections that are found in Japanese.

Chapter 3

More grammar

Having covered the basics in the previous chapter, we will revisit and elaborate on certain inflections and conjugations, as well as list all of the other inflections that are used in the Japanese language. This chapter treats the inflections one by one, starting with a recap of politeness and explaining how it applies to all verbs, then treating all the basic — but not yet covered — inflections, followed by the more advanced inflections that are used in Japanese.

Note that as of this chapter all the verbs and adjectives that have been used in the previous chapter, which we will continue to use in this one, will not come with furigana. At this point, you should know how they are read (and if you don't, just flip back to the previous chapter for the readings).

3.1 Revisits and simple inflections

3.1.1 english

Politeness, or the use of english as it is called in Japanese, revolves around using english and english. We saw these explained in the previous chapter, but for completeness their bases will be listed again here:

				english

Of these, the copulae are used in combination with nouns and verbal adjectives, and is used in combination with verbs (in their form). For both verb classes the procedure

is the same: the present polite is formed by adding ⬚⬚ to the ⬚⬚⬚, whereas the past polite is formed by taking the present polite, and turning ⬚⬚ into its past tense, ⬚⬚⬚:

⬚⬚	present polite	past polite
	⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	polite present ⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚

⬚⬚	present polite	past polite
	⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	polite present ⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚

⬚⬚	present polite	past polite
	⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	polite present ⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚	⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚
⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚ + ⬚

The irregular verbs ⬚⬚, ⬚⬚ and ⬚⬚ are regular with respects to using ⬚⬚, although of course ⬚⬚'s "◎" becomes "◎", and ⬚⬚'s stem gets pronounced "◎".

For nouns we use ◎◎, which is inflected to indicate tense:

noun	meaning	polite present	polite past
		noun + ⬚⬚	noun + ⬚⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚ ⬚⬚	friend	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚⬚ + ⬚⬚⬚
⬚⬚ ⬚	house	⬚ + ⬚⬚	⬚ + ⬚⬚⬚

For verbal adjectives, we also use ⬚⬚, but unlike nouns, verbal adjectives inflect to show tense, rather than ⬚⬚:

adjective	polite present	polite past
	□□□ + □□	past tense + □□
□□	□□ + □□	□□□□ + □□
□□□	□□□ + □□	□□□□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□	□□□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□	□□□□ + □□

A cautionary note: many beginning students of Japanese make the mistake of forgetting that verbal adjectives are verbal, and are themselves inflected, rather than using □□ for tense. One of the first mistakes (and arguably one of the biggest) made by beginning students is saying something like:

□□
□□□□□□□□

To mean "it was fun". Try, very hard, not to make this mistake. Remember for verbal adjectives "inflect first, then add □□ for politeness", not "add ◎◎ first, then inflect".

3.1.2 english

When something is attributive, it means that it is essentially doing what an adjective does: it attributes some quality to a noun. Verbs, verbal adjectives and nouns can all do this, but they do so in different ways.

For verbs and verbal adjectives, the english is attributive by its very definition (it is the "attributive" base). For verbal adjectives this seems fairly obvious, but for verbs, things are no different:

□□
□□□□□□□
"(he/she/it) is (a/the) good person."

□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(he/she/it)'s (a/the) coffee drinking person."

For nouns, things are a little trickier. There are two classes of nouns, namely the ones we already saw in the previous chapter, linking up using □, and "noun adjectives", which are nouns denoting qualities or aspects, and are used in combination with the englishfor english, english, as attributives:

□□
□□□□□□□□□□
"(this/it) is (a) clean/tidy room."

□□ □□
□□□□□□□
“(he/she/it) is (a/the) quiet person.”

The reason for this is that we want to use the qualities that these nouns express attributively. On their own, the qualities in these two sentences would be “◎◎◎◎”, “is clean”, and □□□, “is quiet”. When we wish to use these attributively, we must change □ from its □□□, or finalising form, to □□□, which is the attributive form. So:

□□□□ □ □□□□[noun]
□□□ □ □□□[noun]

For these kind of nouns, using □ as in “◎◎◎◎[noun]” or “◎◎◎[noun]” would be incorrect, because □ is not used to attribute qualities. Sadly, without any prior knowledge it is essentially impossible to tell whether a noun will require □ or □ when it is being linked with other nouns. Sometimes you can guess, based on the fact that the noun marks some quality or aspect, but often you cannot.

3.1.3 Adverbial

In addition to the attributive, which attributes qualities to nouns, there are english, which attribute qualities to verb actions. There are three word classes that can do this, namely the english, the english (the ones that take □) and, of course, english.

True adverbs are easy, since they do exactly what you’d expect:

◎◎ ◎
◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
“(I, you, he, she, we, they) read(s) (a) book(s).”

english◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
“(I, you, he, she, we, they) sometimes read(s) (a) book(s).”

Here, the adverb □□, ‘sometimes’, also written □□ (the symbol □ indicates kanji repetition) qualifies the action of reading to apply only sometimes, rather than in general.

We can achieve the same effect of qualifying the verb action by using verbal adjectives in □□□ form:

□□
□□□□□□
“(I, you, he, she, we, they) will fix (it).”

□□
□□□□□□□
“(I, you, he, she, we, they) will fix (it) quickly.”

In this sentence, the adjective □□, ‘fast’ (not to be confused with □□, ‘early’), is turning into the adverb ‘quickly’ by using its □□□.

With noun adjectives, which do not inflect but must be paired up with the right particle to show their use in a sentence, we must use □, instead of □, to use them as adverbial words:

□
□□□□
“divide (up).”

□□□□□□□
“divide cleanly/neatly”

You might recognise this english from the section on verb particles from the previous chapter. When used with quality or aspect nouns (and noun adjectives in general), using □ leads to the noun being interpreted as a verb detail, which we grammatically term as being used adverbially. However, when the noun is a true noun, □ does something very different. To illustrate this, two sentences:

□□□□ □
□□□□□□□

□□□□
□□□□□□□

The first sentence has a noun that describes an aspect, □□, meaning ‘complete’. Thus, because it is paired with □, this noun is being used as an adverb to □□□, ‘lose’. This sentence translates to “Losing completely”. On the other hand, □□ does not describe a quality or aspect, it just means ‘friend(s)’. As such, when it is paired with □ it becomes a verb detail: “(I, you, he, she, we, they) lost to (my, your, his, her, our, their) friend(s).”

So be careful. If the noun you’re using is not a noun ‘adjective’, you can quite easily say something completely different from what you intended to say.

3.1.4 english

Not just nouns can act as nouns: verbs and verbal adjectives, too, can be inflected so that they act like nouns. In the same way that we can either “walk” through a neighbourhood, or take “a walk” through a neighbourhood in English, so too in Japanese can verbs be used as nouns, provided we use their □□□:

□□ □
□□□□□□
"(It)'s my loss."

Here, the noun □□, "loss", comes from the □□ verb □□□, "to lose". By using its ◎◎◎, it can be used as a noun in a sentence. Both □□ and □□ verbs follow this rule.

For verbal adjectives, things are a bit more complicated, because english requires you to know what kind of noun you want to use. For instance, in English we can turn the adjective "deep" into the noun "depth". This noun is then ambiguous in meaning: do we mean a measurable depth, like the depth of a crevasse or a lake, or do we mean the immeasurable quality of "depth" of paintings or poetry, for instance? In Japanese, this ambiguity doesn't exist, because the two different interpretations are expressed through different noun forms: turning a verbal adjective into a measurable (quantifiable) noun requires adding english to the stem, whereas turning it into an immeasurable (qualifying) noun requires adding english to the stem:

adjective	meaning	english	meaning
□□ □□	high	□□	height (e.g., of a mountain)
□□ □□	deep	□□	depth (e.g., of a lake)

adjective	meaning	english	meaning
□□	high	□□	height (e.g., of an achievement or position)
□□	deep	□□	depth (e.g., of a poem or painting)

In addition to these two, there's also ◎, □ or □ (all pronunciations for english), which instead of creating a quantified noun or qualified noun, creates a noun that stands for "having the english of". To use this in a sentence, it is used as a noun adjective (as □ itself is a noun adjective):

adjective	meaning	impression noun	meaning
□□ □□	cold	□□□ □□	the sense/feeling of being cold
□□ □□□	dangerous	□□ □ □□□	the sense/feeling of danger
□□ □□	firm, honest	□□□ □□	instilling a sense/feeling of honesty

There are two notes to this scheme. The most important one is: "this does not apply to all adjectives". That may sound odd, but it comes down to the fact that while grammatically these rules are valid for all verbal adjectives, Japanese has been in use for many

centuries and verbal adjectives for which this kind of *glossary* made sense have long since been accepted as words on their own, while verbal adjectives for which this nominalising was simply not required simply aren't accepted as natural speech when you use them.

Secondly, the two irregular verbal adjectives, □□ and □□, have their own forms. The □□ (□□) form exists, but □□ does not, and rather than some □□, there is □□□. For □□, there is no □□, except in the pattern □□□□, which will be treated in the section on impressions and likeness, and there are no □ or □ variants either.

More english: □□□ + english

A more subtle noun form for verbs is the "english …" noun form. For instance, "the way one reads" in English is a full noun phrase, but in Japanese it's a compound noun consisting of the verb "read" in □□□, paired with the noun □ (pronounced □□ in this use) meaning "way". Thus, □□, meaning "read", becomes □□□, meaning "way of reading".

□□□

quite frequently in *glossary* (in its ▨▨▨ form ▨) and even more often in daily speech as part of the polite negation in the form of ▨ at the end of ▨▨▨.

bases	form
▨▨▨	english
▨▨▨	english (english)
▨▨▨	▨

Technically, the ▨▨▨ for this classical helper verb can be placed at the end of any verb's ◎◎◎, to form a english. While not in use in standard Japanese, this use is still prevalent in several modern Japanese dialects, such as Kansaiben. In addition to this, it is used for the negative of the helper verb of politeness, ▨▨, to form its (polite by very definition) negative form ▨▨▨.

The ▨▨▨ form, ▨, is used frequently to form a rather special kind of word: the adverbial negative. Added to a verb's ◎◎◎, and paired with ▨ (as it acts as a noun adjective) it turns the verb action into a 'not-taken' verb action instead. To illustrate this, an example:

▨▨ ▨▨ ▨ ▨
▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"I came (over) without eating (my) breakfast."

In this sentence, the phrase ▨▨▨▨▨▨▨ acts as adverb to ▨▨▨▨, so that we can say that "◎◎◎◎ is performed in an ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎ manner". In this sentence, ▨ itself has no temporal aspect, so it gets its tense from whatever follows. As such, present or past tense comes from the final verb:

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"I came (over) without eating (my) breakfast."

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"I will come (over) without eating (my) breakfast."

This is considered an elegant form of negation, and is in formal and semi-formal settings preferred to the negative continuative for ▨▨, which for our example sentence would be:

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"I didn't eat (my) breakfast and came (over)."

We will look at continuative forms that use this '◎' in detail later in this chapter, when looking at continuatives.

3.1.6 Basic inflections summarised

With the knowledge of what □ does, we can now (finally) look at the complete inflection schemes in terms of plain and polite, present and past, and affirmative and negative forms. First off, english; since □□ is inherently polite, it only has four forms we need to know:

	affirmative	negative
present	□□	□□ + □
past	□□ + □	□□ + □ + □□□

Second, english. This too is inherently polite, so again we see four forms, two of which are contractions with a corresponding full form:

	affirmative	negative
present	□□	□□□□□□□
		□□□□□□□
past	□□□	□□□□□□□□□□
		□□□□□□□□□□

Then, english. As this is the plain counterpart to □□, it has no inherent politeness forms, although two forms are contractions with a corresponding full form. However, because the negative forms rely on □□, and because □□ is a verbal adjective, this copula can also be made polite (at least for its negative forms) by adding □□. It will make the inflection more polite than plain form, but not as polite as the corresponding negative form for □□ itself.

	affirmative	negative
present	□	□□□□(□□)
		□□□□(□□)
past	□□□	□□□□□□(□□)
		□□□□□□(□□)

Next up are the english. Verbal adjectives have one polite affirmative form, using □□, and two polite negative forms, because we can either use □□, or the polite counterpart to □□: □□□□□ (the polite negative form of the verb □□). This leads to the following inflection table:

		affirmative	negative
present	plain	□□□	□□□ + □□
	polite	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□ + □□
	polite (2)		□□□ + □□□□□
past	plain	□□□ + □□□ (c)	□□□ + □□□□
	polite	□□□ + □□□ (c) + □□	□□□ + □□□□ + □□
	polite (2)		□□□ + □□□□□ + □□□

In this table, (c) has been used to indicate that a contraction occurs.

For completeness, the two irregular verbal adjectives get their own tables. First, english (which is really english):

		affirmative	negative
present	plain	□□, □□	□□□□
	polite	□□□□, □□□□	□□□□□□□
past	plain	□□□□	□□□□□□
	polite	□□□□□□	□□□□□□□□

(of the two possible □□□□, □□ is considered normal, while □□ is considered formal)

And then finally, the helper adjective of negation, english (□□):

		affirmative	negative
present	plain	□□	□□□□
	polite	□□□□	□□□□□□
past	plain	□□□□	□□□□□□
	polite	□□□□□□	□□□□□□□□

Note that while technically □□ has negative forms, they need pretty specific context before they make any sense.

Then the verbs: while the polite forms are the same for the two verb classes (as well as the irregular verbs), all verb classes will have all forms listed for completeness.

First, □□ verbs, except for □□:

		affirmative	negative
present	plain	□□□	□□□ + □□
	polite	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
past	plain	□□□ + □ (c)	□□□ + □□□□
	polite	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□

In this table, (c) has been used to indicate that a contraction occurs, depending on whether it's a ◎, □, □, □, □, □, □ or □ □□ verb. It should also be noted that the verb □□ has an irregular past tense: □□□ instead of □□□, and that the rather rare verbs □□, □□, □□ and □□ get □ suffixed to their □□□, not □□□.

For english, the scheme is subtly different:

		affirmative	negative
present	plain	□□□	□□
	polite	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
past	plain	□□□ + □ (c)	□□□□
	polite	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□

Then, the ▨▨ verbs, including english

		affirmative	negative
present	plain	▨▨▨	▨▨▨ + ▨▨
	polite	▨▨▨ + ▨▨	▨▨▨ + ▨▨▨
past	plain	▨▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨ + ▨▨▨▨
	polite	▨▨▨ + ▨▨▨	▨▨▨ + ▨▨▨▨▨▨

(The stem for ▨▨ changes: its ▨▨▨ is ▨, its ▨▨▨ is ▨, and its ▨▨▨ is ▨ - however, inflection uses the same rules)

And finally, the irregular verb english:

		affirmative	negative
present	plain	▨▨▨	▨-▨▨▨ + ▨▨
	polite	▨▨▨ + ▨▨	▨▨▨ + ▨▨▨
past	plain	▨▨▨ + ▨	▨-▨▨▨ + ▨▨▨▨
	polite	▨▨▨ + ▨▨▨	▨▨▨ + ▨▨▨▨▨▨

And so, with these basic inflection tables finally complete, we can move on to genuinely new inflections, to examine the rest of what can be done with verbs and verbal adjectives in the Japanese language.

3.2 Further inflections

3.2.1 english

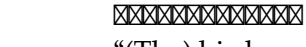
Conjunctives are words or constructions that join up two or more phrases. For instance, in the English sentence "The birds are singing, the flowers are blooming; spring had arrived properly", the comma between 'the birds are singing' and 'the flowers are blooming' acts as a conjunctive, as does the semi-colon between 'the flowers are blooming' and 'spring had arrived'. In Japanese, this particular kind of conjunction can be done in a remarkably simple way: each sentence that is to be "englished" with the next has its final verb put in english, and we're done:

▨▨ ▨
▨▨▨▨▨
"(The) birds sing."

▨▨ ▨
▨▨▨▨▨
"(The) flowers bloom."


"Spring is here."

If we change the final verbs in the first two sentence from  to , then we can join them up to form the translation for our original English sentence:


"(The) birds are singing, (the) flowers are blooming; spring is here."

For added emphasis, we can also place a Japanese comma after each of the conjoined sentences:



While not required for the sentence to be grammatically correct, the addition of a comma can make a sentence easier to read. When translating this kind of conjoined sentence, one can usually either use a comma, or the conjunctive "english". However, it should be noted that the real meaning is just a comma or a semi-colon: since this construction creates a sentence where the second part of the full sentence is merely a continuation of a story started in the first part, there is no real "and" to speak of. Typically in English the word "and" will look like it belongs there, but you should remember that the Japanese sentence only faintly implies it. As such the following translations are all possible, but not all of them sound like natural English.



"(The) birds are singing, (the) flowers are blooming; spring has arrived."

"(The) birds are singing and (the) flowers are blooming; spring has arrived."

"(The) birds are singing, (the) flowers are blooming and spring has arrived."

"(The) birds are singing and (the) flowers are blooming and spring has arrived."

A further note on translating "and": even though a Japanese conjunction can be translated to "… and …", going the other way — from English to Japanese — typically means you cannot translate "and" with this  construction. The reason for this is that conjunction is a very specific thing, whereas the word "and" performs many roles in English:

“I ate breakfast and went to school”	english
“I bought juice and tomatoes”	english
“It’s my car, and don’t you forget it”	english

Typically, when you encounter “and” in an English sentence, the Japanese sentence (unless you’re translating to formal Japanese) will not have it mapped to a ◎◎◎ construction.

In addition to this conjoining of sentences, the ▯▯▯ conjunctive also works for certain word combinations, which we shall look at here.

english conjunctions

The most common conjunction is the verb/verb conjunction. This takes two verbs, and forms a compound verb with them, by placing the first verb in ▯▯▯ and combining it with the second verb in its normal form. There are plenty of examples to choose from for this type of conjunction:

first verb	second verb	compound verb
▯▯, “fly”	▯▯, “take out”	▯▯▯▯, “come flying out”
▯▯, “walk”	▯▯, “go round”, “turn”	▯▯▯▯, “walk around in circles”

When verbs are conjoined this way, it is quite common for the english (the hiragana that indicates inflection on verbs and verbal adjectives) of the first verb to be omitted: ▯▯▯▯ may be written as ▯▯▯, but is still pronounced ▯▯▯▯, and ▯▯▯▯ may be written as ▯▯▯ but is still pronounced ▯▯▯▯▯.

A lot of the time, compound verbs created this way have a meaning which is readily guessable. However, sometimes the compound verb is one that’s been in use for ages and its meaning has changed over time. This is a good reminder that while the grammar explains forms, it doesn’t necessarily explain semantics (i.e., the actual intended meaning). Be careful when creating your own compound verbs - it’s not unlikely you will come up with a combination that already means something else in some subtle, or even not so subtle way.

english

There are a few common verbs which, when used in this fashion, add a specific meaning to the compound. These are:

english — ‘Fix’, ‘correct’, ‘repair’

Used as second verb in a verb/verb compound, this verb creates a “to re-[…]” verb, such as:

original verb	meaning	joined verb	meaning
□			
□□	write	□□□□	rewrite
□□	do	□□□□	redo, do over

english — ‘Crowd’, ‘fill up’

This verb helps create compound verbs that calls forth a mental image of something going into something else, such as something being filled up, something entering something else, or even something being invested in something else. Examples of this are:

original verb	meaning	joined verb	meaning
□□			
□□	enter	□□□□	go into (someone’s) house/room
□			
□□	roll, wind	□□□□	become involved/entangled in

english — ‘Cut’

Used in compounds, □□ can mean anything from cutting physically to cutting conceptually, such as cutting off someone’s speech, cutting a meeting short, or doing nothing but that one thing (which can be thought of as cutting off any other action). A few examples are:

original verb	meaning	joined verb	meaning
□			
□□	say	□□□□	declare, assert
□			
□□□	understand	□□□□□	to fully understand

english — ‘Come out’

When used in compounds, □□ roughly speaking indicates the inverse of □□, signifying something is going or coming out of something else. This can be objects from a container, words from a mouth, or even thoughts from a cloudy mind:

original verb	meaning	joined verb	meaning
□□			
□□	think	□□□□	to suddenly remember
□			
□□	say	□□□□	to break the ice (i.e., to start talking)

english conjunctions

There are three adjectives that are commonly used in verb/adjective compounds, being english, english and english, used to mean "english" and "english" (twice). For instance, if a book is easy to read, then this can be said in Japanese by combining the verb for reading, ▯▯, with the adjective easy, ▯▯, to form ▯▯▯▯, meaning "easy to read". In English this is a noun phrase, but in Japanese this is still an adjective, and can be used to describe objects, such as for instance:

▯ ▯▯
▯▯▯▯▯▯
An easy to read book.

And of course the same goes for ▯▯:

▯ ▯▯ ▯▯
▯▯▯▯▯▯
Something that is hard to say.
(literally: "a hard-to-say thing")

Unlike the verb/verb conjunctions, this type of conjunction never drops the verb's okurigana.

While both ◎◎◎ and ◎◎◎ signify "hard to …", ▯▯▯ is a more modern reading; most things that are "hard to …" in modern Japanese will use the ▯▯▯ reading. Examples of the ▯▯▯ reading are found in for instance ▯▯ ▯▯▯▯, which is commonly known as paired with the verb ▯▯▯▯▯, with which it becomes ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯, meaning "thank you".

english conjunctions

This conjunction is a very nice one, because it shows an elementary simplicity in the creation of some of Japanese's nouns: compounding. By combining a verb in ◎◎◎, which we know can act as a noun on its own, with another noun, we can form a new compound noun. This particular conjunction can be seen in some words that one would not immediately think of as compound nouns:

verb	meaning	noun	meaning	conjunction	meaning
▯ ▯▯	wear (on the body)	▯▯ ▯	thing	▯▯▯ ▯▯	kimono
▯ ▯▯	board, get on	▯ ▯	place	▯ ▯ ▯▯▯	a stop (i.e. bus stop)

3.2.2 english: english

The continuative in Japanese is also commonly referred to as the "◎ form", because it relies on the english of the classical helper verb for completion, english, which is □. This inflection is used for at least three things in Japanese, of which verb chaining is probably the most frequently used. Aside from this, it is also used to issue (implied) imperatives, and it can be used in combination with several special verbs to create special constructions.

bases	form
□□□	□
□□□	□
□□□	□
□□□	□ (or □)
□□□	□□
□□□	□□

For □□ verbs, the combination of □□□ with □ leads to contracted forms in modern Japanese, with different contractions occurring for the different □□ verbs, just like for the plain past tense □. The following table again lists which contractions occur, and what the "change rule" is:

□□	english	english	english
□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: no change
□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
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□□□	□□□+□: □□□□	□□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□
□□	□□□+□: □□□	□□□	□ verbs: □□ □ □□

And again □□ is an exception:

irregular verb	□□□	english	english
□ □□	□□	□□□+□	□□□

For the □□ verbs, as well as verbal adjectives, no contractions occur:

□□	continuative
□□	□□□+□: □□
□□□	□□□+□: □□□
□□□	□□□+□: □□□

irregular verb	□□□	continuative
□□	□	□□□+□: □□
□□	□	□□□+□: □□

And finally, no contractions occur either for the small set of formal literary verbs that use their □□□ instead of their □□□ for this inflection:

verb	meaning	continuative
□ □□	ask, question, accuse	□□□
□ □□	□	□□□
□ □□	ask	□□□
□ □□	□	□□□

As we saw earlier, the □□□ conjoins sentences, and so it should be relatively obvious that this construction conjoins sentences too, but in a slightly different way from the plain □□□. Rather than simply joining sentences in such a way that there's no order in which verb actions take place, the □ form explicitly preserves the order in which the actions occur. For instance, the following two sentences say different things, in terms of which actions follow which other actions:

□□ □□ □ □□□ □ □□□ □
□□□

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) read a book and listened to music.”
(‘read’ is past tense in this sentence)

english continuative

Verbal adjectives, too, can be chained in this way by using their □□□ + □:

adjective	□ form
□□	□□ + □
□□□	□□□ + □
□□	□□ + □
□□□	□□□ + □
□□ (□□)	□□ + □
□□	□□ + □

This lets us write the previous “book” sentence in the following manner, using the adjectives □□□, big, □□, red and □□, heavy.:

□□ □□ □□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“This is a big, red, heavy book.”

Just like with verbs, the actual inflection of the adjectives in □ is determined by the final adjective. To illustrate, the following sentence is entirely in past tense affirmative:

□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(It) was a big, red, heavy box.”

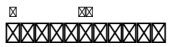
To make everything english, we take the plain negative form of adjectives, ending on □□, and simply use □□’s ◎ form:

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
“(It)’s a not big, not red, heavy book.”

Of course, since they’re both just ◎ forms, we can even mix the two:

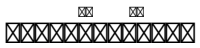

“(It) was a big, not red, heavy box.”

This “placing ◎◎ in ◎ form” to form the negative ☒ form for verbal adjectives also applies to verbs, by first forming their plain negative form, ☒☒☒ + ☒☒, and then turning this negative into a ☒ form:

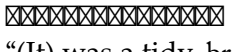

“(I) didn’t eat, and went home.”

english continuative

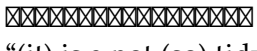
For nouns, which rely on copulae for inflections, we do not use the ☒☒☒ for ☒, but instead rely on the ☒☒☒ for ☒☒, which is english:

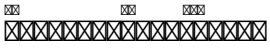

“A tidy, bright room.”

As with the verbal ☒ form, tense and polarity are expressed by the final verbal (which can be either a verb, verbal adjective or a copula), so that if we want to place the previous sentence in past tense, we need only change the tense for ☒☒☒:


“(It) was a tidy, bright room.”

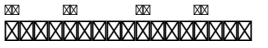
The negative form for this continuative uses ☒☒☒☒ (or ☒☒☒☒), which due to it ending on ☒☒ uses the adjectival ☒ form. So far so good, but this is where things get a little complicated: because ☒☒ is a verbal adjective, and verbal adjectives can be paired with ☒☒, we can actually choose between two “◎” forms. One is the regular ☒ form, ☒☒☒; the other is ☒☒ + ☒☒☒ of ☒☒, giving us ☒☒☒ instead. Both are used, but depending on the speaker’s intention, one is usually preferred over the other. For regular chaining, ☒☒☒ tends to be preferred; for a chaining with an implied contrast of sorts, ☒☒☒ is typically preferred. To illustrate:


“(it) is a not (so) tidy, (but) bright room.”
(no real contrast, although in English the phrasing makes it sound like one)

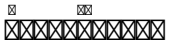


“Rather than quiet, it was a very lively atmosphere.”
(real contrast, explicit “rather than X, Y instead” connotation)

Of course this continuative also works for verbal adjectives and verbs in plain negative form, as these end on ▯▯:



“(It) was a big, not red, heavy box.”



“(I) didn’t eat, (then) went home.”

As mentioned in the section on negatives in this chapter, the negative continuative ▯▯▯/▯▯▯ is actually similar in role to using a verbal ▯▯▯ + english + ▯, meaning “without …”, but there is the subtle difference: ▯▯▯ is a verb form, while -▯▯ is an adverbial form. Chaining many affirmative and negative verb actions using the negative ▯ form is possible, while ▯▯▯+▯▯ doesn’t allow you to ‘chain’:



“[I] didn’t eat, went to school, didn’t take the bus and arrived.”

We can interpret this sentence as the more natural sounding “I went to school without eating and (then) arrived without taking the bus.” but this misrepresents the actual Japanese, which chains four verb phrases. For actual Japanese that reflects this English sentence, we must use the following:



In the ▯ form sentence, we’re chaining four different actions, namely not eating, going, not boarding, and arriving. However, in this sentence using -▯▯ we are listing just two actions, and both of these are adverbially constrained: ▯▯▯▯▯▯ is “going without eating” and ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯ is “arriving without having taken the bus”.

3.2.3 english

We’re not quite done with the ◎ form yet, because there are a number of special ▯ form combinations with verbs that should not be taken literally, but should be considered idiomatic:

they mean something different from what the used words would normally imply themselves. These combinations only work for verbs in □ form, and do not apply to verbal adjectives in □ form or nouns followed by □ (or □□□).

Special conjunctions: english/english

Combining the □ form with □□ and □□ profoundly changes the verb's meaning in terms of its grammatical role. Using these two verbs as helper verbs lets us turn any verb into a *glossary,* a present *glossary* form or an *glossary* act, depending on whether the verb is transitive or intransitive, and whether we use □□ or □□. The table of which combinations can imply which constructions is as follows:

	□+□□	□+□□
transitive	1. english (implying something or someone caused the state)	1. english 2. english
intransitive	(impossible combination)	1. Habitual 2. Progressive 3. Resultant state

Looking at the table, we see that the □+□□ form is used to indicate that something is in a particular state, and that this state was caused by someone or something. Examples of this "resultant state" are for instance:

□□
□□□□□□□□□□□

"The button is (in an) unfastened (state) (because someone unfastened it)."

□□□ □
□□□□□□□□

"The car is (in a) stopped (state) (because someone stopped it)."

This construction describes the state of something, just like a normal intransitive verb would, but also implies that someone is responsible for this state. The reason for this is the fact that a transitive verb is used as basis: a transitive verb describes an action being performed by something or someone. Thus, even if the something or someone that performs the verb is left off, the fact that a transitive verb was used is in itself enough to tell us that something or someone must have performed it.

On the other hand, the resultant state that is created using the □+□□ form does not imply this additional "someone did it", because it uses an intransitive verb instead, which merely passively describes the current state of the world without any implications of how it might have come to be this way:

□□□□□□□□□□□
“The button is (in an) unfastened (state)”

□□□□□□□□□□
“The car is (in a) stopped (state).”

One principal difference is that while □+□□ operates on transitive verbs for resultant state, □+□□ operates on intransitive verbs. Another difference is that while □+□□ can only be used to create a resultant state, □+□□ can also be used to create the progressive verb form, as well as to indicate a habitual action. Both these forms can be made with either transitive or intransitive verbs:

□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) am watching a film right now.”
Form: transitive progressive

□□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) frequently read the newspaper.”
Form: transitive habitual act

□□
□□□□□□□□□□
“(The) window is opening.”
Form: intransitive progressive

□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“That door often creaks.”
Form: intransitive habitual

To make sure there’s no mistakes possible: ◎+◎◎/ ◎+◎◎ can both do resultant state, but they operate on transitive and intransitive verbs, respectively: “*A*ru, Tr*A*nsitive - *I*ru, *I*ntransitive”. In addition to this, □+ □□ can also signify progressive state and habitual form of any verb.

Colloquially, the □+□□ form is often shortened by dropping the □, to create english instead. This means that the following two sentences are technically the same, but the first is formal, and the second less formal:

□□
□□□□□□□□□□
□□□□□□□□□
“What are [you] doing?”

Special conjunctions: english/english

Another important pair is the □+□□/□+□□ pair, where □□ is sometimes written or pronounced as □□ instead (this is not wrong, but simply an older, alternate way to write and say □□, used a lot in songs, poetry and still commonly used in many dialects). These two constructions stand for a english directed either towards the speaker in some way, or heading away from the speaker in some way. This towards/away can be either a physical process or an abstract process such as "it feels like her mind is slowly slipping away":

□□
□□□□□□□□
"It's (gradually) becoming night."

□□
□□□□□□□□
"It has (gradually) become spring."

□□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□
"Mt. Fuji is (gradually) coming into view."

When used in this way, □□ or □□ are usually written □□ and □□ instead of using kanji.

Note that these "gradual process" interpretations do not always apply. For instance, […]□+□□ is also a common pattern used in combination with activity verbs to indicate "english". For example, □□□□□ means "going to buy something (and then come back afterwards)" or □□□□□ means "going (somewhere) (and then coming back after whatever one had to do there is done)".

Note that a verb can sometimes be interpreted in two or three ways:

□
□□□□□□
Interpreted normally: "(He) came flying over."
As a gradual process: "It came flying into view."

□□ □
□□□□□□□
As a gradual process: "It's coming out (into view) right now."
As 'do and come back': "(I'm) going out (to do something, and will then come back) now."

Special conjunctions: english

This construction signifies a semi-formal english, something which we will look at in more detail when treating verbs for giving and receiving in the chapter on language patterns. For now it suffices to say that using □+□□□ turns a verb into a polite command or request:

□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□
"Please open the window."

□
□□□□□□□
"Please eat (this)."

Special conjunctions: english

The construction □+□□□ is a very interesting construction. It lacks an adequate corresponding construction in English, but indicates that some action has been irrevocably performed. This can either be a good thing ("we are done working on this project"), a bad thing ("I broke the radio…") or something of which one might wish it wasn't irrevocable ("I finished reading this series of books… I wish there were more"). Because of this, translations for this construction are highly context sensitive:

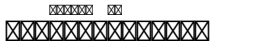
□□□□□□□□□□□……
"Oh (man), now (you)'ve said it…"
literally: "Ah, you've said it (even though it would have been better if you hadn't, but you can't take it back now)"

One can expect to hear something like this when someone says something that everyone knows, but no one had dared say because of the repercussions, such as telling the boss that everyone in his department is better suited for his job than he is.

□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I) broke the radio… (and that's something I wish I hadn't)."

In this line, it should be obvious why the fact that □□□, "break", having been completed is a bad thing.

Colloquially, □ + □□□ can be contracted into english or english, (with □ + □□□ contracting to english or english respectively) resulting, for instance, in:

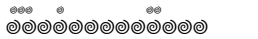


"Ah! (I) forgot (my) textbook…"

Again, it is clear that □□□, "forget", is a bad or regrettable thing when completed, especially in relation to needing your textbook in class.

Special conjunctions: english

Also important is the □+□□ construction. On its own, the verb □□means "to put [something] [somewhere]", but when paired with a verb in □ form, it creates a construction meaning "to do something with the intention of leaving it that way [for whatever reason]". This may sound a bit cryptic, so let's look at an example for clarification:



"Please turn on the lights."

This sentence uses the ◎ form of ◎◎ for a polite command (using ◎◎◎), and asks for the lights to be turned on without there being a need for them to be on right now, other than it saving having to turn them on later. Literally this sentence would read "Please turn on the lights and leave them that way". Colloquially, the combination of □+□ is often changed to english instead, so the following two sentences are the same, except that the first is more formal, and the second more colloquial:





"(I)'ll open the windows (now, rather than having to do it later when it becomes genuinely necessary)."

Special conjunctions: english

Another construction that changes the meaning of the suffixed verb is the □+□□ form. □□ (□□) alone means "to see", but suffixed to □ forms, this construction means english:



"Won't (you) try eating (some) sushi?"

Here a negative question is asked as a more polite way of offering a suggestion, and the □□□□□ part stands for "trying to eat, to see what happens". In this case, the "to see what happens" is probably related to "seeing if you like it".

◎◎◎◎◎ ◎ ◎◎◎◎
◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"(I) tried to ride a bicycle, but failed horribly."
literally: "but (it/I) was no good at all."

Here, the act of riding a bicycle was tried to see what would happen, but we can conclude from the remainder of the sentence that riding a bike isn't for this particular speaker.

3.2.4 english: english

If, instead of chaining, you want to only list representative actions for which order doesn't matter, such as "Today I read my book, played some video games and walked the dog" in which you probably did all those things a few times in no real order, then the □ form is of little use. Instead, the classical helper verb □□ is the one you want to be working with. This verb has the following bases:

bases	form
□□□	english
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□

Just like □, the □□□ of □□ is used, and just like for □ and □, contractions occur when used with □□ verbs (with □□ having an irregular contraction, and □□, □□, □□ and □□ inflecting via their □□□ rather than □□□). However, unlike the □ form, which can pair up with any 'final verb' for its inflection, □□ gets its inflection specifically from the verb □□, meaning "to do":

◎◎◎ ◎◎◎◎ ◎ ◎◎◎◎◎ ◎ ◎◎ ◎
◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎ ◎◎ ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"Today (I) went to school, went to class and ate."

This sentence literally reads "Today I did: going to school, going to class, eating", without any distinction in which action occurred when, in relation to other actions; we're literally only summarising activities performed.

Verbs in ◎◎ form can also be used on their own in a sentence, in which case it translates to "doing things such as", and still get closed off by □□:

□□□ □□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Yesterday (I) did things like reading a book."

The negative □□ form is constructed by placing a verb in plain negative form first (□□□ + □□) and then turning this verbal negative into a □□ form by the same formula: □□□+□□ (with

a contraction just as for past tense), forming □□□ + □□□□□.

3.2.5 english: english, english

In the same series of inflections that contract with □□ verbs (□, □ and □□), we find □□, which is the *glossary* form, or english, for □. It combines in the same way as □, □ and □□ do, being added to the □□□, and contracts with □□ verbs as well as with verbal adjectives:

□□	conditional
□□	□□□□
□□	□□□□
□□	□□□□
□□	□□□□
□□	□□□□
□□	□□□□
□□	□□□□
□□	□□□□
□□□	□□□□□

Noting the exception for the verb □□:

irregular verb	conditional
□□	□□□□

No contractions occur for □□ verbs:

□□	conditional
□□	□□□
□□□	□□□□
□□□	□□□□

And the irregular verbs get their own table:

irregular verb	□□□	conditional
□□	□	□□□
□□	□	□□□
□□	□□	□□□□
□□	□□	□□□□

For verbal adjectives we see contractions:

verbal adjectives	conditional
▨▨	▨▨▨▨▨
▨▨▨	▨▨▨▨▨▨
▨▨	▨▨▨▨▨
▨▨▨	▨▨▨▨▨▨

And for nouns the copulae inflect instead:

nouns	past tense
noun + ▨	noun + ▨▨▨▨
noun + ▨▨	noun + ▨▨▨▨

So what does it do? In simple terms, this construction sets up an english condition:

▨ ▨▨▨ ▨▨▨
▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"If (you) walk around town, (you) will see many interesting sights."

This can also be used for actions that are constrained by some condition, such as:

▨▨▨ ▨▨▨▨
▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"I'll go study 2 hours from now"

Here, the act of studying is constrained by 2 hours of something else needing to pass first.

In less simple terms, the ▨▨ construction is a "english". That is, it sets up a hypothetical future in which some action has already been taken, about which comments are then made. Looking at the previous sentences using this explanation, we get some rather conceptual translations:

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"In a future where you are walking around town, you see lots of interesting things"

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"In a future in which I have spent 2 hours doing (something), I will (then) go study."

This explanation doesn't quite work for noun conditionals, which use english. This is the ▨▨▨ for the copula ▨, rather than for the conditional form of the helper verb of past tense, and rather than a hypothetical future past, is essentially just a plain if[…]then[…] construction:

□□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"I'm sure the teacher will understand."
literally: "If the teacher, (he/she) will understand."

There are a few more conditionals in Japanese, so (much like with "and" and the □□□) when translating from Japanese to English, translating □□ with "if … then …" is fine, but translating an English sentence that has an if/then construction to Japanese requires figuring out exactly which style of if/then is being used.

For instance, "If you walk around town, you will see many interesting sights" is an example of a conditional pertaining to a current situation, "If you get fired, I'll quit too" is a conditional pertaining to a hypothetical situation, and "If you're late for the exam, you fail it." is actually not a conditional but a factual statement ("if A, then B as well").

Of these, the first uses □□ as conditional, the second uses the hypothetical construction -□□ (explained later in this chapter) and the third uses the simultaneous action marker, □ (possibly the most abused particle by beginning students), which is explained in the chapter on particles.

3.2.6 english

english: english

Unlike the previous constructions starting with the syllable □, this inflection doesn't involve a classical helper verb, but a helper adjective, □□ (which has a kanji form, english, but this is not used in modern Japanese). This also means that unlike the previous -□, -□, -□□ and □□ constructions, no contractions occur with □□ verbs, which makes forming the first person *glossary* very easy. Since this is an adjective, rather than a verb, it has a slightly different set of bases for further conjugation:

bases	form
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□□

However, as an inflection the first person desirative is about as simple as it gets, pairing with □□□:

□□ verb	first person desirative
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□

□□ verb	first person desirative
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□□	□□□ + □□

□□ verb	first person desirative
□□	□ + □□
□□□	□□ + □□
□□□	□□ + □□

irregular verb	first person desirative
□□	□ + □□
□□	□ + □□

You may have noticed that □□ and □□ are not listed here. The absence of □□ is easy to explain because it is the copula, and one cannot want something to have a particular property in Japanese using the copula (this uses the adjective □□□ instead, explained later in this section on desiratives). The absence of a □□ form for □□ is more subtle: there is no □□ form for □□ because using □□ to express one's desire is intrinsically selfish, and thus mutually exclusive with polite phrasing. To make a statement that expresses desire that is less selfish, the Japanese use a construction that expresses "I think I want/would like to …", using the particle □ and the verb □□, which makes the actual desire less strong because it's only a thought, rather than a 'genuine' desire:

□□□ □□□ □ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"I think I would like to buy a new car."

This is a very civil way of expressing one's own desire, compared to the plain:

□□□□□□□□□□□
"I want to buy a new car."

Because □□ is an adjective, it can also be followed by □□ to make it more polite, in which case the translation stays the same, but the perceived strength of the desire is tuned down just a bit, although not as much as when the desire is turned into a thought using +□+□□:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"I want to buy a new car."

To say one doesn't want something, all we have to do is form the negative of ☒☒, which we know is ☒☒☒☒:

☒☒☒ ☒☒
☒☒☒☒☒☒☒☒☒☒☒☒
"I don't want to do anything today."

english: english

Because of the way Japanese works, and the way the world is interpreted and thought about in the Japanese mindset, one never presumes to truly know what's going on in someone else's head. Because of this, you cannot say that "Bob wants an apple", because even though he might give off all the signals that he does, and even though he may have said so himself, you might still be interpreting the signals wrong, and he might have only said he wanted one instead of really wanting one. Because of this, rather than using ☒☒ for second/third person desiratives, the classical helper verb ☒☒☒ is used.

bases	form
☒☒☒	☒☒☒ / ☒☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒☒ / ☒☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒☒

Like ☒☒, this form does not suffer from contracted inflections, and is added directly to the ☒☒☒:

☒☒ verb	second/third person desirative
☒☒	☒☒ + ☒☒☒
☒☒	☒☒ + ☒☒☒
☒☒	☒☒ + ☒☒☒
☒☒	☒☒ + ☒☒☒
☒☒	☒☒ + ☒☒☒
☒☒	☒☒ + ☒☒☒
☒☒	☒☒ + ☒☒☒
☒☒	☒☒ + ☒☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒☒ + ☒☒☒

☒☒ verb	second/third person desirative
☒☒	☒ + ☒☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒ + ☒☒☒
☒☒☒	☒☒ + ☒☒☒

irregular verb	second/third person desirative
▨▨	▨ + ▨▨▨
▨▨	▨ + ▨▨▨

Again ▨▨ and ▨▨ are missing. Not unlike ▨▨, ▨▨▨ can be considered somewhat rude as it presumes to know something about someone else. This construction can be made less rude by adding the noun adjective ▨▨ to the ▨▨▨, to emphasise that this is merely an impression:

▨▨▨ ▨
▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"It seems Kimiko wants to leave."

However, note that the following is also possible, using ▨▨ with the ▨▨▨:

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"It seems Kimiko wants to leave."

When english follows a ▨▨▨, it generally does not mean the same thing as when it follows a ▨▨▨. Normally, ▨▨ following a ▨▨▨ expresses a form of english, implying the information's been read somewhere or has been told to the speaker by someone, and ▨▨ following a ▨▨▨ expresses the concept of something "being english …" or "english be …". While generally two different things, both can be used due to the nature of ▨▨▨, but the different uses have difference nuances:

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"It seems Kimiko wants to leave (I know this because she for instance told us, or someone else told me this was the case)."

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"It seems Kimiko wants to leave (this is my impression, because she's giving off all the signs of someone who wants to leave)."

The negative form for ▨▨▨ is a normal verb negative, being either ▨▨▨▨▨ or ▨▨▨▨▨▨.

english: —english

Unlike the previous two desirative forms, there is also the 'desire for something to be in a particular state' that was previously hinted at. For instance "I want this door to be red" cannot be expressed with the previous two forms, because they cannot express this state, but can only express verb actions or processes. To express a state desirative, the verbal adjective ▨ form plus the adjective ▨▨▨, a verbal adjective for indicating that something is desirable, is used:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) want this door red.”

Note that because these are verbal adjectives, we use the particle □, not □. Even though “desire” is a verb in English, it is an adjective in Japanese, so rather than saying “I want this door red”, the more literal translation would be “this door is (more) desired (when) red”.

In terms of politeness, □□□ is just as direct and selfish as □□, and it can be softened by adding □□:

□□□□□□□
“[I] want it made.”

□□□□□□□□□
“(I) want it made (being said in a less direct manner than the above sentence)”

Since □□□ is a normal verbal adjective, we can inflect it further like any other verbal adjective:

bases	form
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□□

3.2.7 english: □□/□□

The *glossary* is used for three things, which are called the *glossary* (“it’s probably the case that…”), the *glossary* (“will/shall …?”) and the *glossary* (“let’s …”).

english / english

These forms, as mentioned in the outline for Japanese, turn the □□□ into something that ends on an □ sound through a contraction. There are both a normal and a polite form of this construction, with the polite form simply being the verb in polite form, with □□ turned into a pseudo-future.

The way in which the direct pseudo-future is constructed differs for the two verb classes: □□ verbs get □ added to the □□□, but the combination of the □□□ □—row syllable and the □ changes the pronunciation (as well as written form) to an □—row syllable instead, so □+□ becomes □□, □+□ becomes □□, etc. To see why this happens we have to look back at english,

where the combination of an □—row syllable and an □ always changed the pronunciation to that of the corresponding □—row syllable; not just for □□□ constructions, but for any written combination of the two. While the language reforms of the mid 20th century changed many of the rules for written language so that it would correspond to spoken language more, constructions involving the □□□ have generally been left alone (another □□□ 'quirk' can be found in □□ verbs ending on □, which becomes □ rather than □).

□□ verb	pseudo-future		polite pseudo-future
□□	□ [□ □ □] + □	= □□□	□□ + □□□□
□□	□ [□ □ □] + □	= □□□	□□ + □□□□
□□	□ [□ □ □] + □	= □□□	□□ + □□□□
□□	□ [□ □ □] + □	= □□□	□□ + □□□□
□□	□ [□ □ □] +□	= □□□	□□ + □□□□
□□	□ [□ □ □] + □	= □□□	□□ + □□□□
□□	□ [□ □ □] + □	= □□□	□□ + □□□□
□□	□ [□ □ □] + □	= □□□	□□ + □□□□
□□□	□□ [□ □ □] + □	= □□□□	□□□ + □□□□
□□	□ [□ □ □] + □	= □□□	□□ + □□□□

For □□ verbs, we simply add □□ to the □□□, and for the irregular verbs and copulae we see special cases:

□□ verb	pseudo-future	polite pseudo-future
□□	□ + □□	□ + □□□□
□□□	□□ + □□	□□ + □□□□
□□□	□□ + □□	□□ + □□□□

irregular verb	pseudo-future		polite pseudo-future
□□	□ + □□		□ + □□□□
□□	□ + □□		□ + □□□□
□□	□□ + □□	= □□□□	already polite
□□	□□□ + □	= □□□□	already polite
□	□ + □□□	= □□□	×

For verbal adjectives, the plain pseudo-future is formed by (once again) combining the adjective's ◎◎◎ with ◎◎, this time in pseudo-future form. The polite version is simply the adjective followed by □ or □□ in pseudo-future form:

adjective	pseudo-future		polite pseudo-future
□□	□□ + □□□	= □□□□	□□ + □□□/□□□□
□□□	□□□ + □□□	= □□□□□	□□□ + □□□/□□□□
□□	□□ + □□□	= □□□□	□□ + □□□/□□□□
□□□	□□□ + □□□	= □□□□□	□□□ + □□□/□□□□

For nouns, there is little choice: they are followed by □ or □□ in pseudo-future form:

noun + □	□	noun + □□□
noun + □□	□	noun + □□□□

Using the pseudo-future is fairly straight forward:

□□ □
□□□□□□
“Let’s go to the beach.”

□□□□□□□
“Shall [we] go to the beach?”

□□□□□□□?
“Where could it be?”

□□ □□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) wonder if that book (over there) is interesting.”

□□□□□□□
“Let’s do so.”

english

The presumptive form uses the pseudo-future of the copulae to turn verbs into presumed acts. While this form uses the □□ of the copula verb, the verb conjugation itself is actually technically a □□ conjugation, and therefore is explained in more detail in the section on □□. For now, it suffices to say that it lets us say things like “This computer will probably still work” or “I am sure my coffee isn’t cold yet” and similar presumptive statements in Japanese:

□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“The coffee’s probably cold by now.”

□□ □□□ □□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(he/she)’s probably a teacher.”

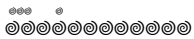
The englishs

One of the special things about the pseudo-future is that when combined with several verbs, the intuitive meaning isn't always preserved. We can distinguish at least two such cases: the pseudo-future + ◎ + ◎◎ and the pseudo-future + ◎ + ◎◎. While […]+◎+◎◎ normally means "to consider something […]", the meaning changes to "at the point of doing […]" when combined with a pseudo-future:



"As (we) were about to eat, the phone rang."

Similarly, on its own ⊠⊠ means "to think", but when used with the pseudo-future, the combination becomes more nuanced, expressing "to think about [doing …]":



"(I)'m thinking about writing a letter."

english

Since the pseudo-future doesn't quite end on a verb that can be placed in a ◎◎◎, creating the negative form cannot be done using english or english. Instead, the negative pseudo-future uses the classical helper verb english. To make matters slightly more confusing, while ⊠⊠ verbs use their ⊠⊠⊠ as base form, ⊠⊠ verbs use their ⊠⊠⊠ as base form for the negative pseudo-future.

⊠⊠ verb	negative pseudo-future	polite negative pseudo-future
⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠
⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠
⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠
⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠
⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠
⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠
⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠
⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠
⊠⊠⊠	⊠⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠
⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠

⊠⊠ verb	negative pseudo-future	polite negative pseudo-future
⊠⊠	⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠
⊠⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠
⊠⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠ + ⊠⊠

irregular verb	negative pseudo-future	polite negative pseudo-future
□□	□□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□	already polite

And some example sentences:

□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) do not expect (him) to understand such matters…”

□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“Should (I) go see that film, or not see that film…”

□
□□□□□□□□□□□
“That shouldn’t stretch regardless of what (you) do.”

For verbal adjectives, the negative pseudo-future uses the verbal adjective in negative form, —□□□, with □□ in pseudo-future form, —english:

adjective	negative pseudo-future	polite negative pseudo-future
□□	□□ + □□□□	□□□□□□□ + □□□/□□□□
□□□	□□□ + □□□□	□□□□□□□□ + □□□/□□□□
□□	□□ + □□□□	□□□□□□□ + □□□/□□□□
□□□	□□□ + □□□□	□□□□□□□□ + □□□/□□□□

For nouns the idea is, again, to inflect english or english appropriately:

	negative pseudo-future	polite negative pseudo-future
noun + □	noun + □□□□ + □□□	noun + □□□□□□□ + □□□
noun + □	noun + □□□□ + □□□	noun + □□□□□□□ + □□□
noun + □□	noun + □□□□ + □□□□	noun + □□□□□□□ + □□□□
noun + □□	noun + □□□□ + □□□□	noun + □□□□□□□ + □□□□

However, for the negative pseudo-future form for nouns the typical pattern involves the copula □□□ instead, and its (small) table is as follows:

negative pseudo-future	polite negative pseudo-future
noun + □□□	noun + □□□□□

However, the negative pseudo-future is a pattern that you will likely not hear too often, as there are other, more frequently used constructions that express negative expectation.

3.2.8 english: english

The hypothetical construction, hinted at earlier in the section on ▨▨, is created by adding the particle ▨ to the english, forming the english, known as the hypothetical form. The negative hypothetical is formed by adding ▨ to the ▨▨▨ of the plain negative form, as the following tables show:

▨▨ verb	hypothetical	negative hypothetical
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨▨	▨▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨ + ▨

▨▨ verb	hypothetical	negative hypothetical
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨▨	▨▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨▨	▨▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨▨ + ▨

irregular verb	hypothetical	negative hypothetical
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨ + ▨
▨▨	▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨▨ + ▨

For english, the negative hypothetical is a bit different, since its negative uses the classical helper verb english:

	hypothetical	negative hypothetical
▨▨	▨▨▨ + ▨	▨▨▨ + ▨

For verbal adjectives, the same rules apply as for verbs:

adjective	hypothetical	negative hypothetical
□□	□□□ + □	□□□□□ + □
□□□	□□□□ + □	□□□□□□ + □
□□	□□□ + □	□□□□□ + □
□□□	□□□□ + □	□□□□□□ + □

For nouns, the hypothetical construction has three possible affirmative versions, two using the □□□ for □, which is english, either with or without english, and a third using a slightly different copula: □□□, of which the □□ part is the familiar verb.

	hypothetical	negative hypothetical
noun + □	noun + □□	noun + □□□□ + □□
	noun + □□ + □	(noun + □□□□ + □□ + □)
noun + □□	noun + □□□ + □	noun + □□□□□ (□□□□□) + □

Note that the noun + □□□□ + □□(□) forms are possible due to the fact that □□ is a verbal adjective; while it may not be followed by □, it may be followed by □□. In this case, we cannot substitute □□□□□ for □□, as this is a normal verb form and can therefore never be (directly) followed by a present tense copula. Also, while "noun + ◎◎◎◎ + ◎◎ + ◎" is technically a valid negative hypothetical, it isn't really used, as the polite form "◎◎ + ◎" is considered not to mix with the plain form "◎◎◎◎".

So which is what? For the affirmative, in increasing order of politeness: □□, then □□□, and then □□□□. For the negative: □□□□□□, then □□□□□□, then □□□□□□, and then finally the overly formal □□□□□□□□ and □□□□□□□□. As a word of caution, do not use these last two unless you know why you are using them. They will typically be considered clumsy speech.

How do we interpret the hypothetical? The simplest explanation is that this creates an if/then construction, with the note that the specific type of conditional created is one that is best thought of as meaning "should [X] be the case, then [Y]". The following two example sentences should illustrate this quite clearly:

◎◎◎◎

not really “if” or “when”, but is really only a hypothetical conditional: “supposing that …” or “should …”. The danger in using the word “if” lies in the fact that it implies a more general kind of truth: compare “If it rains, we get wet” to “assuming that it rains, we’ll get wet”. The first states a truth under all circumstances, the second gives a possible truth for only one instance. Similarly, “when” carries the implication that something will definitely happen, being only a matter of time before it does. The ⊠⊠⊠ implies neither of these things.

3.2.9 english

There are two kinds of commands, namely imperative commands (things one should do) and prohibitive commands (things one should not do). There are a number of ways in which to issue imperative and prohibitive commands, and we’ll look at all of these.

english

Imperative commands are quite easy to form in Japanese: for ◎◎ verbs, simply take the english and you’re done:

◎◎ verb	imperative form
◎◎	◎◎
◎◎	◎◎
◎◎	◎◎
◎◎	◎◎
◎◎	◎◎
◎◎	◎◎
◎◎	◎◎
◎◎	◎◎
◎◎◎	◎◎◎
◎◎	◎◎
◎◎	◎◎

For ◎◎ verbs there is a bit of choice, as one can either use the english, or the english, depending on how strong the imperative should be:

⊠⊠ verb	imperative form	alternative form
⊠⊠	⊠ + ⊠	⊠ + ⊠
⊠⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠
⊠⊠⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠	⊠⊠ + ⊠

What is the difference between these two forms for □□ verbs? In standard Japanese, the -□ imperative is a true command. If someone says □□, you look. The second is more of an instruction than a command. For instance, if you're browsing though a dictionary and there is a footnote telling you to see page 214 for further information, this will typically use □□, rather than □□. However, this distinction only applies to english, or english, which is the "dialect" spoken in the english region, which is where Tokyo lies. North of this region, the -□ form is typically used to issue imperatives, whereas South of this region the -□ form tends to be used instead.

Not unexpectedly, the irregular verbs have their own □□□:

verb	imperative	alternative
□□	english	english
□□	english	english

However, there is also another verb with an irregular commanding form, namely the □□ verb □□□ (usually written in hiragana rather than using its kanji form). This verb is part of the set of verbs used in giving and receiving, and is thus vitally important to know. It only has one imperative form:

verb	imperative
□□□	□□

To illustrate the use of the imperative command, some example sentences:

□□□□□□□□□
"Everyone, listen up!"

□□
□□□□□
"Hurry up!"

□
□□□□□□□
"Oh come on, wake up already!"

There is a second way to issue imperative commands, using the verb english, which is the (normally) honorific counterpart to the verb english. This verb belongs to a set of verbs with a deviant □□□ and □□□, so to see how these differ, let's briefly look at the bases for all five verbs in this set:

	◎◎◎	◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎
meaning	do	issue	be, come, go	say	be
◎◎◎	◎◎◎	◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎
◎◎◎	◎◎◎	◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎
◎◎◎	◎◎◎	◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎
◎◎◎	◎◎◎	◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎
◎◎◎	◎◎◎	◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎◎◎	◎◎◎

This set tells us several things: first, it tells us that english in the special ◻ form -◻◻◻◻◻ is the ◻◻◻ for ◻◻◻◻. Second, it explains why english would become english: its ◻◻◻ is simply ◻◻◻. Third, it tells us what we need to know to form a command using ◻◻◻. If we add the ◻◻◻ for ◻◻◻, english, to a verb's ◎◎◎, we get a command that is less direct than a plain ◻◻◻ (and thus, more formal/polite), but is still a command:

◻◻ verb	◻◻◻ imperative
◻◻	◻◻ + ◻◻◻
◻◻	◻◻ + ◻◻◻
◻◻	◻◻ + ◻◻◻
◻◻	◻◻ + ◻◻◻
◻◻	◻◻ + ◻◻◻
◻◻	◻◻ + ◻◻◻
◻◻	◻◻ + ◻◻◻
◻◻	◻◻ + ◻◻◻
◻◻◻	◻◻◻ + ◻◻◻

◻◻ verb	◻◻◻ imperative
◻◻	◻ + ◻◻◻
◻◻◻	◻◻ + ◻◻◻
◻◻◻	◻◻ + ◻◻◻

irregular verb	◻◻◻ imperative
◻◻	◻ + ◻◻◻
◻◻	◻ + ◻◻◻

And finally, ◻◻, ◻◻ and the copulae do not have this imperative form.

For verbal adjectives, the idea of an imperative is a bit odd, but that doesn't mean we can't form one. Relying on ◎◎◎ + ◎◎ for the inflection again, we can form the imperative command for verbal adjectives. We can either leave these as is, or contract them. The difference is subtle: the uncontracted form is considered an adjectival statement akin in use to, for

instance, the English "be faster!" (in Japanese: □□□□□). Contracted, this is an adverbial statement (□□□□), which has no English equivalent and is thus harder to explain; it is experienced as an adjectival statement in the same way that the past tense for verbal adjectives is still an adjectival statement.

adjective	imperative form	contracted
□□□	□□□ + □□	□□□□
□□□□	□□□□ + □□	□□□□□
□□□	□□□ + □□	□□□□
□□□□	□□□□ + □□	□□□□□

The same goes for the copula, for which we must use english (since neither □ nor □□ have a commanding form of their own):

copula	imperative form
□□□□	□□□□

english

If you want to tell people to not do something, then the form of the command is much simpler: simply add the particle english to the □□□ of any verb:

□□□ verb	prohibitive form
□□□	□□□□
□□□	□□□□
□□□	□□□□
□□□	□□□□
□□□	□□□□
□□□	□□□□
□□□	□□□□
□□□	□□□□
□□□□	□□□□□

□□□ verb	prohibitive form
□□□	□□□□
□□□□	□□□□□
□□□□	□□□□□

irregular verb	prohibitive form
□□□	□□□□
□□□	□□□□
□□□	□□□□

And finally □□, which has a negative imperative based on □□: □□□.
Even easier than the normal imperative command, some example sentences are:

□□ □
□□□□□□□□
"Don't come (round here) a second time!"

□□□□□□□□□□
"What, don't look (at me)."

(□ is an *glossary* particle, added to the end of a sentence as an extra level of "I am telling you …". This particle will be treated in more detail in the chapter on particles.)

In addition to this rather simple prohibitive, we can also turn the □□□ + □□□ imperative into a prohibitive, by using □□□ + □□□ + □. However, while grammatically sound, practically speaking this form is very rarely used. This works for any verb, except for □□, which is technically the same verb as □□□ but at a different formality/politeness level. Rather than using □ + □□□ + □, just □□□ + □ is used.

3.2.10 english: english, english

english

We already saw that we can use the verb □□□ + □□□□□ to form a request,

□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Two coffee, please."

But we can also use the plain □ form to form an informal request, or plea:

□
□□□□
"Wait (please)"

□
□□□□□□□
"Buy this (for me)?"

Of course, like all requests, they can be made to sound demanding, so intonation counts. If we say □□ instead of □□□, cutting out the stop in the middle to sound curt, then rather than a request this may very well be experienced as a command instead. Similarly, saying □□ in a stern tone might be less commanding than □□, but will still be experienced as a command more than as request. However, using this plain □ form (rather than paired with

□□□□) can be experienced as curt, or even impolite language, depending on the setting it is used in, so be careful.

english

This kind of requesting can of course also be done in a prohibitive manner, in which case we rely on the continuative form for □□ using □□, english:

□
□□□□□□
(Please) don't go.

In this sentence the "please" is implied, and depending on intonation and context this form may be experienced as anything between a mandate (such as a police officer asking you not to come too close to a crime scene) or a plea for someone to not do something (such as a friend in need asking you not to leave quite yet). We can also use an explicit "please" in the form of □□□□:

□□
□□□□□□□□□
Please don't go.

Again, depending on intonation and context this might be experienced as anything between a mandate and a plea.

3.2.11 english: english/english

glossary constructions are, as their name implies, constructions which describe actions in a passive voice. Unlike "I eat dinner" or "The cat is playing with the squeaky toy", which are in *glossary* voice, they refer to phrases like "Dinner was eaten by me" or "The squeaky toy was played with by the cat". In Japanese, this english, called english, is achieved through the use of the two helper verbs □□ (for □□ verbs) and □□□ (for □□ verbs), which are added to a verb's ◎◎◎:

◎◎ verb	passive
◎◎	◎◎ + ◎◎
◎◎	◎◎ + ◎◎
◎◎	◎◎ + ◎◎
◎◎	◎◎ + ◎◎
◎◎	◎◎ + ◎◎
◎◎	◎◎ + ◎◎
◎◎	◎◎ + ◎◎

◎◎ verb	passive
◎◎	◎◎ + ◎◎
◎◎◎	◎◎◎ + ◎◎

◎◎ verb	passive
◎◎	◎ + ◎◎◎
◎◎◎	◎◎ + ◎◎◎
◎◎◎	◎◎ + ◎◎◎

irregular verb	passive
◎◎ (1)	◎—◎◎◎ + ◎◎, forming □□□ (most common)
◎◎ (2)	◎—◎◎◎ + ◎◎◎, forming □□□□
◎◎	◎ + ◎◎◎

The helper verbs involved are both ◎◎ verbs, so they can themselves be conjugated further by using their appropriate base:

bases	□□□	□□
□□□	-□□	-□
□□□	-□□	-□
□□□	-□□□	-□□
□□□	-□□□	-□□
□□□	-□□	-□

Thus, a simple phrase like □□□□, meaning “(I) eat”, can be made passive: □□□□□□, “(something) is being eaten (by someone)”.

This change from english to english comes with two complications in Japanese: first, what was first the direct object has now become the verb subject instead. This is no different from English, except because in Japanese the grammatical roles are explicitly written, we must make sure we use the right particles:

□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) eat dinner.”
Active, verb uses □ in relation to □□.

□□□□□□□□□□□□
“Dinner is being eaten (by me).”
Passive, verb uses □ in relation to □□.

Second, what used to be the english has become a english instead. In English we see

this expressed by the fact that the verb actor moves to being part of a preposition phrase ("I" becomes "by me", for instance), and from the section on verb particles in chapter 2, we know that these kind of phrases are marked with english in Japanese:

□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"I eat dinner."
Active, actor is marked with □.

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Dinner is being eaten by me."
Passive, actor is marked with □.

□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(A) dog barked (at me), (and that) was scary."
Active, actor is marked with □.

□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I) was barked at by (a) dog, (and that) was scary."
Passive, actor is marked with □.

In addition to the regular passive construction, these verbs are also used to form what is known as the english, or "english". A somewhat inelegant name, this specific passive is used to indicate that some action (taken by someone) has inconvenienced you, or someone else. Let us look at how this works:

□□ □□□□ □□□□□ □□
□□□□ □ □□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Someone stole my (younger) brother's bicycle."
Active, verb uses □ in relation to □□□□.

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"My brother's bike was stolen by someone."
Passive, verb uses □ in relation to □□□□.

However, this "form of bother" only applies to actions that were taken by someone, which inconvenienced you (or someone else). In the following sentence, for instance, the verb form is merely passive rather than a "passive form of bother":

◎◎ ◎
◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"(I) was rained on."

While inconvenient, this is not a □□□□□, because the rain isn't actively inconveniencing you — it is simply something that happens. Remember that for a passive to also be a ◎◎◎◎◎, the act has to have been performed, intentionally, by someone.

In addition to describing the passive and passive form of bother, the helper verbs □□ and □□□ are also used to form *glossary* verb constructions, as well as honorific verb forms, and we shall look at these later on in this chapter.

3.2.12 english: english/english

Causative constructions are, as their name implies, constructions which indicate something was caused by someone. In English, this comes down to statements such as "I was made to do the dishes by my mom", and in Japanese, these constructions use the verbs □□ (for □□ verbs) and □□□ (for □□ verbs). These are paired, like □□/□□□ with the □□□.

(□)□□ follow the □□ scheme:

bases	□□□	□□
□□□	-□□	-□
□□□	-□□	-□
□□□	-□□□	-□□
□□□	-□□□	-□□
□□□	-□□	-□

As mentioned, the way these two helper verbs are added is identical to the way (□)□□ are added:

□□ verb	causative
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□	□□ + □□
□□□	□□□ + □□

□□ verb	causative
□□	□ + □□□
□□□	□□ + □□□
□□□	□□ + □□□

irregular verb	causative
▯▯	▯—▯▯ + ▯▯
▯▯	▯ + ▯▯

Again, we should take note that we use the correct particles, except in this case we cannot rely on a parallel with English: the person doing the causing is marked with english, because they are the verb actor, the person(s) affected are marked with english, and the direct object is left as such (if there is one):

▯▯ ▯▯
▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯
"The mother made (her) children eat breakfast."

Some more examples:

▯
▯▯▯▯▯▯
"(I) made you wait, (didn't I)?"

▯▯▯ ▯
▯ ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯
"My (younger) sister woke me up."

In addition to being a causative, this construction is also a "english", which just means that it's a construction that indicates english to "english something":

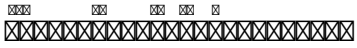
@@@@ @
@@ @@@@@@@@@@@@@@@@@@
"(The) CEO let me take on (the) project."

This sentence could technically also mean "The CEO caused me to take on the project" or "The CEO made me take on the project", so context is all-important. However, in most cases where it could either be a forced action or a permission, it's usually a permission.

3.2.13 english: english/english

The title sounds like a combination of the causative and the passive, and that's essentially what it is. It's long, and its use is not rare. In English, this form reads "have been made to do …" and is also quite long. So, just like in most western language, the more nuance you want to place in your verb conjugation, the longer it'll get.

However, because this is a passive, we must make sure to use particles accordingly:



“The children were made to eat breakfast by their mother.”



“(I) was made to redo (my) homework by (the) teacher.”

3.2.14 english

english: english

As mentioned in the section on the passive, one of the other roles that ⬚⬚/⬚⬚⬚ can play is that of the (long) potential. The potential form of a verb in English is typically constructed using the auxiliary verb “english”, such as when turning “I swim” into “I can swim”, but in Japanese this is a conjugation instead. The reason this form is called the “long” potential is that there exists a shorter potential form for the ⬚⬚ verbs, which will be discussed after this section. Forming the long potential is no different from forming the passive, except that it is generally not used for ⬚⬚ verbs:

Formation of the long potential form is the same as for the passive form:

verb	meaning	potential	meaning
⬚⬚	see	⬚⬚⬚⬚	be able to see
⬚⬚⬚	stretch	⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚	be able to stretch
⬚⬚⬚	eat	⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚	be able to eat
⬚ ⬚⬚	come	⬚ ⬚⬚⬚⬚	be able to come

There is one striking exception to this potential form, and that’s the irregular verb english, “do”. Rather than inflecting, this verb is simply replaced entirely with the verb english, which literally means “be able to do”.

We need to be mindful of particles again: verbs in potential form are always intransitive, and so any direct object it might take in normal use becomes a verb subject instead, requiring the use of english rather than english. However, quite often in colloquial Japanese, the direct object particle ⬚ will be heard used in combination with these verbs, rather than the subject particle ⬚, not because this is grammatically correct, but because it “feels right”. If you are a beginning student of Japanese, however, it is recommended you stick with proper grammar until you have mastered it to a level that allows you to interact with native speakers, so that you get a feel for what is “right” through exposure to the language as it is used by people.

You may also hear people using english rather than english, but at the moment this is discouraged language abuse: the idea behind it is that the short potential form for ⬚⬚ verbs always ends on ⬚—row syllable + ⬚, and so using ⬚⬚ for ⬚⬚ verbs “does the same thing”. However, while they might sound the same, ⬚⬚ is a classical helper verb, whereas the ⬚—row

syllable + □ sound for □□ verbs is actually a contraction from what used to be □—row syllable + □□, so they have completely different background. So until the Japanese language authorities start accepting this highly colloquial "short potential for ◎◎ verbs" as right and proper, you're best off avoiding it; at least outside of colloquial interaction with Japanese people who use it.

Note that because this is a potential form, □ has to be swapped for □:

A: □□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

A: "Please stop the car."
B: "(I am) sorry, but (I) cannot stop the car right now."

Also note that this potential form is one of a temporary nature. For instance, rather than meaning "I can see" in general (because you have eyes that work), □□□□ means "I can see (whatever I am supposed to see right now)". Similarly, □□□□□ means "(I) can eat (this)", rather than the more general "(I) can eat". If we want to say that we have an inherent ability to do (or not do) something, we have to use □□□ + □□□□□□, which will be explained after we cover the short potential form.

Finally, some verbs are not inflected to form the potential form, instead requiring the use of a related, but different verb. For instance, while □□□□ is a valid long potential form, you will find the verb □□□ is often used, instead. Similarly, there are □□ verbs for which alternate potential forms exist, such as the verb □□ ("to hear/listen"). Rather than the normal potential form, explained in the next section, the verb □□□□ ("to be able to hear") is used. This highlights an important rule: when learning new verbs, make sure to learn to inflect them correctly; some inflections may in fact use a different verb entirely!

english: □□□ + english

The short potential form is called "short" because it is simply a lot shorter than the full □□□+□□□ version of the potential. However, in modern Japanese, this construction only exists for □□ verbs. For □□ verbs, the only grammatically correct potential form is the □□□ potential form. To create the short potential form, the □□□ is paired with the verb □□, meaning "to acquire", to form an "attainable" form of verbs.

In this combination, the final □—row syllable of the □□□ for □□ verbs has become contracted with the □ sound from □□ over the course of history, becoming an □—row syllable instead. To illustrate:

verb	meaning	english	contracted via	modern inflection
□□	meet	□□□□	□□□□	□□□
□□	read	□□□□	□□□□	□□□
□□□	understand	□□□□□	□□□□□	□□□□

While this construction in modern Japanese is a contraction, there are a handful of verbs in which this contraction never occurred, and as such are still in use today in the uncontracted form. Verbs such as □□□□ (from □□) or □□□□□ (from □□□, "to occur") are examples of this. Interestingly, this potential form can also be seen in certain modern □□ verbs that have traditionally been paired with □□, such as □□□, "to (be able to) see", from the □□ verb □□, or □□□, "(be able to) boil", from the □□ verb □□.

Just like with the □□□ potential form, verbs placed in this short potential form become intransitive, which means that technically they can only be used in relation to subjects, and no longer in relation to direct objects.

□□ verb	short potential form
□□	□□□
□□	□□□
□□	□□□
□□	□□□
□□	□□□
□□	□□□
□□	□□□
□□	□□□
□□□	□□□□
□□	□□□□

Some examples to show this potential form:

□□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Because of (my) illness, I can't walk that well (at the moment)."

□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"I wonder if this will do."

The english in this second sentence is actually a fairly important word to know. While strictly speaking the short potential form of □□, its meaning of "being able to go" has become overloaded with the figurative meaning of "something being able to go well". As such, □□□ means "being fine", "being good" as well as noting that something "will do" or "is acceptable".

Note again that because this is a potential form, □ has to be swapped for □:

A: □□□□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

A: “How much do you read?”
B: “Good question. (I) have plenty of time, so (I) can read a lot of books.”

english

A third way to form the potential, for any verb, is by using the construction □□□ + english. □ literally means ‘concept’, and we already saw that □□□ means “be able to do”, and this in combination with a verb in □□□ creates a generalised ability.

For instance, as mentioned earlier, □□□□ means “being able to see (something) (at this moment)”. Similarly, □□□ means “being able to walk (at this moment)”. In contrast, □□□□□□□□ and □□□□□□□□ mean being able to see, or walk, in general. Particularly with negatives, this difference is striking. For instance, a person whose glasses are so dirty they can’t really see any of the things we point out to them might say:

□□□□□□□
“I can’t (really) see (it).”

This is hardly anything to worry about as the potential form used is one associated with temporary impairment. However, if they had used:

□□□□□□□□□□□□

We would have good reason to apologise for telling them to look at something; they’re blind.

3.3 Formal speech patterns

In addition to being polite, an important aspect of formal Japanese is to use the right mix of english (english) and english (english) speech patterns. In part, this is expressed by picking the right words to use, but in part it also depends on which verb inflections you pick. One can argue whether this belongs in a reader that should serve as introduction to Japanese, as it’s a rather advanced subject, but I would argue that in terms of how verbs can generically be made humble or honorific, the rules are relatively straight forward. What makes it an advanced topic is not how to do it, but how to do it in such a way that a native speaker doesn’t

raise an eyebrow at it. And that's hard enough to make even Japanese people get it wrong once they need to start using it.

Humble and honorific patterns are significantly different from politeness. This can be made fairly obvious by using an English example. Compare the following sentences:

1. "I would like to humbly offer my apologies."
2. "I do apologise."
3. "I'm sorry."

Of these, the first sentence is humble, polite English. The second sentence is merely polite, and the third is essentially neutral. It's not really polite, nor is it humble, but then it's not offensive either. Of course, we can mix these patterns to produce something that sounds odd to our ears:

"I humbly am sorry."

This sentence mixes humble form with neutral terms. This sounds very odd to an English speaker, and likewise mixing humble or honorific speech without using appropriate politeness will sound odd in Japanese, but it can be done; just like in English.

3.3.1 english

When one addresses someone who stands much higher on the social ladder than oneself (in a particular setting), it is customary to lower one's own status by using humble speech. Humble speech applies to everything that has to do with oneself; not just verb actions, but also opinions and things requiring copula statements.

The way to turn any old verb into a humble variant is relatively straight forward: the honorific particle english (pronounced □ for most verbs, and □ for noun+□□ verbs where the noun uses english reading), is prefixed to the verb in □□□ form, and suffixed either with □□, or the explicitly humble counterpart to □□, english. When □□ is used, the honorary prefix can sometimes be omitted for a slightly less formal humble form, but when □□ is used, it has to be present.

□□ verb	□ + □□□+□□	□ + □□□+□□
□□	□ + □□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□
□□	□ + □□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□
□□	□ + □□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□
□□	□ + □□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□
□□	□ + □□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□
□□	□ + □□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□

□□ verb	□ + □□□+□□	□ + □□□+□□
□□	□ + □□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□
□□	□ + □□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□
□□□	□ + □□□ + □□	□ + □□□ + □□

□□ verb	□ + □□□+□□	□ + □□□+□□
□□	□ + □ + □□	□ + □ + □□
□□□	□ + □□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□
□□□	□ + □□ + □□	□ + □□ + □□

For the irregular verb □□, the humble version is (necessarily) □□, since this simply is the humble counterpart. However, in addition to □□, there are several other verbs for which an established humble counterpart exists, typically being preferable to the □ + □□□ + □□/□□ construction:

verb	meaning	humble counterpart
□ □□	come	english
□ □□	go	□
□□	be/exist (for animate objects)	english
□ □□	say/be called	english
□□	do	english
□ □□	know	english
□ □□	see	english
□ □□□	eat	english
□ □□	drink	□
□□ □□	receive	□
□ □□	ask	english
□ □□	listen	english
□□ □□	give	english
□ □□	meet	english
□ □□□	show	english

For verbs consisting of a noun + □□, the noun gets prefixed with the honorific □, pronounced □, and □□ is either left as is, or replaced with □□ for a more humble pattern:

verb	meaning	humble counterpart
□□□□ □□□□	pay attention to	□□□□□ or □□□□□
□□□□ □□□□	guide (someone)	□□□□□ or □□□□□
□□□□ □□□□	contact (someone)	□□□□□ or □□□□□

One confusing result of using these humble patterns and humble counterparts is that humble speech still means exactly the same thing as the normal verb form. The following seven sentences illustrate this idea: they all mean exactly the same thing, but express this meaning with an increasing degree of humility and politeness:

□□□ □□□
"(I, you, he, she, we, they) refuse(s)."
Form: plain.

□□□□□
"(I, you, he, she, we, they) refuse(s)."
Form: polite.

□□□□□□
"(I, you, he, she, we, they) refuse(s)."
Form: polite, but only marginally humble, using noun form + □□.

□□□□□□
"I refuse."
Form: humble, but plain form. As this is humble form, the only person this can apply to is first person, so 'I' has become explicit.

□□□□□□□
"I refuse."
Form: humble polite.

□□ □□□□□□
"I refuse."
Form: more humble, but plain. This sounds a tad odd, as using □□ typically implies a need to be polite, too.

□□□□□□□□□
“I refuse.”
Form: more humble, polite.

While the copulae have, strictly speaking, no humble counterpart, there is a more polite copula that tends to be used in setting where humility is required: english, used in the form english. This copula does exactly the same thing as english, english and english, except its high level of politeness makes it particularly suited for use in humble speech patterns:

□□□□□□□□□ □□□□□ □□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“Kimura, second year student at the university of Tokyo.”

Careful observation reveals that this sentence is actually not humble, merely very polite, and as such it could have been spoken by the student in question, or by someone doing a formal introduction to someone else, whose social position requires a humble, or at the very least properly polite, form of speech.

3.3.2 english

While speech pertaining to oneself is humbled, things pertaining to the person of higher social status are elevated by using honorific patterns. Similar to how verbs can be made humble by using the □ + □□□ + □□/□□ pattern, nearly all verbs can be made honorific by using a similar pattern involving either □ + □□ or english, similar to the humble choice between □□ and □□:

□□ verb	□+□□□+□+□□	□+□□□+□□□
□□	□ + □□ + □ + □□	□ + □□ + □□□
□□	□ + □□ + □ + □□	□ + □□ + □□□
□□	□ + □□ + □ + □□	□ + □□ + □□□
□□	□ + □□ + □ + □□	□ + □□ + □□□
□□	□ + □□ + □ + □□	□ + □□ + □□□
□□	□ + □□ + □ + □□	□ + □□ + □□□
□□	□ + □□ + □ + □□	□ + □□ + □□□
□□	□ + □□ + □ + □□	□ + □□ + □□□
□□□	□ + □□□ + □ + □□	□ + □□□ + □□□

□□ verb	□+□□□+□+□□	□+□□□+□□□
□□	□ + □ + □ + □□	□ + □ + □□□
□□□	□ + □□ + □ + □□	□ + □□ + □□□
□□□	□ + □□ + □ + □□	□ + □□ + □□□

Again, there are several verbs for which this pattern is essentially inferior to using an appropriate honorific counterpart instead:

verb	meaning	honorific counterpart
□		
□□	come	english
		english
		english
□		
□□	go	□□□□□□
		□
		□□□□□□
		□□□□□□
□□	be/exist (for animate objects)	□□□□□□
		□□□□□□
□		
□□	say/be called	english
□□	do	english
□		
□□	know	english
		english
□		
□□	see	english
		english
□		
□□□	eat	english (english means ‘summon’ here)
□		
□□	drink	□□□□□
□		
□□	sleep	english
		english
□□		
□□	think	english (normal honorific pattern also possible)
□		
□□	wear (on the body)	english (english means ‘clothing’ here)

For compound verbs consisting of a noun paired with □□, the noun gets prefixed with the honorific □, pronounced □, and □□ is either replaced by □□□ or □□□:

verb	meaning	honorific counterpart
□□□□		
□□□□	pay attention to	□□□□□□ or □□□□□□
□□□□		
□□□□	guide (someone)	□□□□□□ or □□□□□□
□□□□		
□□□□	contact (someone)	□□□□□□ or □□□□□□

When using a copula while being honorific, rather than using the polite □□□□, the properly honorific english copula, in the form english, is used instead:

□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“How old is your child(/son/daughter)?”

In this sentence, □□□ is an honorific for the noun □, "child", and □□□□□□□□□ acts as honorific form of □□. The word □□□, meaning "how old" in this sentence, can only be used for children that are (or seem) younger than ten (the reason for this being that it is a question word used for counting statements using the counter □, which can only count up to and including nine. Anything higher uses the counter english, also written english, with corresponding question word english). Given this information, we see that the sentence is actually identical (in meaning) to the following, plain form, sentence:

□□□□□□□
"How old is (your son/daughter)"

In the plain form sentence, we can drop the fact that we're asking this in relation to some child, because the use of english should be enough information for the listener to figure this out. Being much shorter than the honorific form, we once more see a confirmation of the general rule for politeness when it comes to Japanese: the longer a statement is, the more formal polite it will be.

As with the humble pattern, there is no change in actual meaning when going from plain form to honorific, other than ruling out single person as implied actor or subject (since one cannot honour oneself).

□□□
□□□
"(I, you, he, she, we, they) refuse(s)."
Form: informal.

□□□□□
"(I, you, he, she, we, they) refuse(s)."
Form: formal polite.

□□□□□□
"(I, you, he, she, we, they) refuse(s). "
Form: more formal than formal polite, using noun form + □□.

□□□□□□□
"(you, he, she, they) refuse(s)."
Form: plain honorific. As this is honorific form, this can no longer apply to first person single or plural.

□□□□□□□□□
"(you, he, she, they) refuse(s)."
Form: polite honorific.

□□□□□□□
“(you, he, she, they) refuse(s).”
Form: plain, but more honorific than when using □+□□.

□□□□□□□□□
“(you, he, she, they) refuse(s).”
Form: polite honorific.

□□□□□□□□□□□
“(you, he, she, they) refuse(s).”
Form: (present progressive) polite honorific.

3.4 english

This final section is not about how classical adjectives inflect, but is actually about what happens when we pair modern verbal adjectives with certain special verbs, such as english and english. While these very rarely get used on their own, there are certain set uses for them, where they pair up with specific adverbs, derived from verbal adjectives. In these cases, the adverbial form of the verbal adjective actually undergoes a sound change, the □□□ □ becoming a □ instead, and leading to four possible classical pronunciation changes (meaning they will potentially change the pronunciation of the adjective with blatant disregard of their kanji):

If the syllable preceding the □□□ □ is an □ row syllable, the adverb gets an —□□ sound instead:

□□ becomes □□[□→◎], which contracts to □□.
□□□ becomes □□□[□→◎], which contracts to english.

If the syllable preceding the □□□ □ is an □ row syllable, the adverb gets an □-glide instead:

□□□ becomes □□[□→◎], which contracts to □□□
□□□ becomes □□□[□→◎], which contacts to □□□

If the syllable preceding the □□□ □ is an □ row syllable, the adverb gets a long □:

□□ becomes □[□→◎], which does not contract and so stays □□

If the syllable preceding the □□□ □ is an □ row syllable, the adverb gets a long □ by virtue of the □—row syllable + □ already being a long □ sound:

□□□□ becomes □□[□→◎], which does not contract and so stays □□□

And hopefully you noticed the first two entries, which are precisely the ones you may know from the phrases □□□□□□□□, translating to “good morning”, and □□□□□□□□□□, translating to “thank you very much”.

Chapter 4

Particles

english, called english, or more affectionately referred to as english (after the verb □ form and the three quintessential particles □, □ and □), are the fundamental glue that holds Japanese sentences together, indicating how words (or blocks of words) relate to each other. There is no overstating how important particles are in using Japanese: without them, there is no Japanese language.

Most particles are suffixes, meaning that they follow whatever it is they are marking, but there are a small number of prefixes. In this chapter, we will first look at some common prefixes, then look at what is generally considered the bulk of Japanese particles, followed by an entire chapter dedicated to a rather special set of particles: counters.

4.1 Prefixes

4.1.1 The english

One of the most used prefixes is probably english, pronounced either as □, □, □, □□, or □□, depending on what it is being used with, and for:

The reading □ is used to make words with a english (english) honorific.

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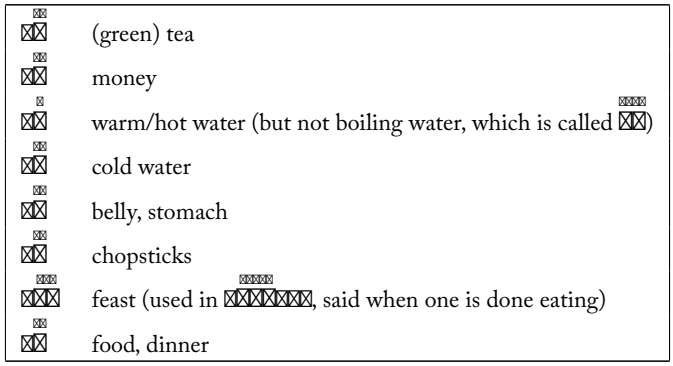
The reading □ is used for imperial and english. In addition, it can be used as a stylistic reading to make words sound more poetic.

The reading □□ is a rare reading used mainly as a english. It can be considered a very formal version of the □ reading.

The reading □□ is also rarely used, and is used exclusively for english.

This prefix is essential in various honorific and humble constructions, as we saw in the sections on humble and honorific verb constructions. It should be noted that some words,

when used in daily speech, always get this prefix. A by no means exhaustive list of such words includes:



4.1.2 english

There are also various common prefixes that negate, void or otherwise create a counter-concept word when used: , , , and .

We know english from the verbal imperfect base, the . This prefix indicates a "not yet" or "has yet to be realised" aspect, which explains what it's doing in a word like , but there are many other words in which we find this prefix:

word	meaning	composition
	future	"not yet arrived"
	incomplete	"not yet finished"
	unmarried	"not yet married"
	pending	"not yet arranged"
	prior	"not yet begun"

When english is used, it expresses a noun negative, similar to the English prefixes "un-", "im-", "a-" or "de-". Examples of this prefix are:

word	meaning	composition
	impossible	"no possibility"
	(economic) depression	"no business"
	disobedience	"no obedience"
	ignorance	"no knowledge"

When english is used, it expresses a non-existential, similar to “non-”, “not …” or the terms “without” or “devoid of” in English. Examples of this prefix are:

word	meaning	composition
	unsigned	“without signature”
	invalid	“without validity”
	atheism	“without deity”
	unauthorized	“without permission”

Finally, english is used to indicate the equivalent of the English “non-”. Examples of this prefix are:

word	meaning	composition
	non-profit	“not commercial”
	unrealistic	“not realistic”
	emergency	“not usual”
	incompatible	“not compatible”

4.1.3 Assorted prefixes

Aside from these four negating prefixes, there are also a few other common prefixes that you will encounter frequently enough to deserve at least mention here, even if we don’t look at example words for each of them:

prefix	meaning
english◎	“all …”, “every …”
english◎	“every …”
english◎	“new …”
english◎	“big” (two possible common pronunciations)
english◎	“small” (two possible common pronunciations)
english◎	“re-”
english◎	“most …”
english◎	“super-”
english◎	“anti-”, “counter-”
english◎	“semi-”, “demi-”, “incomplete”
english◎	indicates a boundary or limit
english◎	an intensifying prefix

(Note that the consonant double ◎ in ◎◎ becomes an ◎ when this prefix is paired with words starting with a ◎—column or ◎—column syllable, such as □□□□)

There are more, mainly due to the fact that many nouns in Japanese are compound nouns. Thus, any part of a compound noun that gets used by several words in roughly the same meaning can be considered a prefix of sorts.

4.2 english

What most people consider proper particles actually cover a number of subcategories of particles. There are the grammatical particles, which map to grammatical interpretations such as direct objects, verb phrase subjects, disambiguation, etc. They lack any form of translation to languages that leave grammar implied, and as such can be a bit tricky to learn initially, as they require actively learning grammar in order to properly understand what they do (something which most people have not really been exposed to in their general education). Aside from these grammatical particles, there is the set of particles which perform roles similar to what prepositions do in, for instance, English. However, because of the way the Japanese language describes things happening or being in the world, a single Japanese particle in this category might map to a number of prepositions when translated, depending on the context in which it is used. Then there are the various particles for emphasis in all its forms, so it should be clear that we have quite a bit of ground to cover.

The list of particles covered in this chapter is not an exhaustive list of all particles used in the Japanese language, but does represent the bulk of particles that you might encounter. They have been ordered in three sections, the first covering the absolutely essential particles, the second and third covering less frequently used and even several 'rare' particles and particle combinations.

4.2.1 Essential particles

The essential particles list consists of the particles □, □, □, □, □, □, □, □ and □ (as well as □, which is not essential but belongs in this list because of the way it contrasts with a particular use of □). Traditionally, □ would be considered part of this list, but we already extensively covered □ in the verb section on the □ form.

The particles in this section are considered "essential", because they cover the absolute minimum of grammatical roles that you need to understand before you understand Japanese at a basic conversational level. While the list seems short, a mere 10 particles, most of these particles — in terms of what you might be used to from English — do many different things. While there is typically some unifying idea for that describes what the particle does "in concept", in practice this means having to remember several roles per particle, and being able to identify which one is used when.

english — english

This particle is sometimes called the Japanese equivalent of the question mark, but this is not entirely true. While it acts as the question mark when used at the end of sentences, it actually acts as a general questioning particle. It usually ends a sentence, because most of the time the entire sentence is the question, but you can find it used inside sentences as well, where it turns only part of the sentence into a questioning phrase. The 'question mark' role is fairly easily demonstrated:


"(I, you, he, she, it, we, they)'ll go."


"Will/shall (I, you, he, she, it, we, they) go?"

The more interesting functions of are found when it is used in subphrases instead, such as in the following example:


"(I) thought (about) whether I should do (it)."

Let's take this sentence apart and look at why it means what the translation says it means. First, this sentence consists of two parts: and […]. The first is the dubitative form of , with the questioning particle , so that "let's do" becomes "will/shall (I, you, he, she, it, we, they) do?". This is then combined with the past tense for […]◎◎◎, "think […]" or "think about […]" to form "think about [will shall … do?]". This isn't natural English, so we need to rewrite it using appropriate words: a dubitative question in English uses the word "whether", so going from Japanese to literal English to natural English, we arrive at "think about whether (or not) to do (something)". And since this is a past tense we arrive at the translation that was initially given.

The more complete version of "whether (to) […]" is the pattern "whether or not (to) […]", and Japanese has an equivalent to this: […]english:


"(I) have no idea whether he'll come over or not."

We can even form more elaborate yes-or-no, be-or-not, do-or-not, etc. questions, by using two separate questions. This might be a bit confusing at first, as in English we always put our choices in a single sentence, but in Japanese a double question pattern is in fact quite common:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“Will (you) have coffee, or tea?”

While the English translation shows that this is just a normal “or” question, the Japanese sentence joins up the otherwise separate questions □□□□□□□□□, “will you have coffee?” and □□□□□□□, “will you have tea?”, into a single choice question. Answers can range from □□□□□□□□□ (‘coffee, please’) to ◎◎◎◎◎◎ (‘either is fine’) to things like ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎ (‘no, that’s okay (I shall have nothing)’).

However, □ can also be used as a direct translation for “or”, but a very specific one: the english. There is a rather big difference between the english and the logical “or”, in that the latter doesn’t ask about which choice to go with, but whether at least one of the choices listed is correct:

A: “Would you like coffee, or tea?”
B, interpreting ‘or’ naturally: “Coffee, please.”

A: “Would you like coffee or tea?”
B, interpreting ‘or’ logically: “Yes, please.”

What happened in this second conversation? Rather than interpreting ‘or’ as the natural version, B decided to interpret it as the logical connective, meaning he answered the question “would you like [coffee or tea]” — the logical ‘or’ doesn’t give you a choice, it connects the choices into a single option, which is picked if any one of the otherwise individual choices is picked, or isn’t picked if none of them work. In Japanese, using □ to list choices in this way means offering people this kind of logical ‘or’ choice:

A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□

A: “Will (you) have coffee, or tea?”
B: “Coffee, please.”

A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

A: “Will (you) have coffee or tea?”
B: “No, (I) think right now something cold (literally, ‘a cold drink’) would be nicer.”

This can potentially lead to confusion, or seemingly incomplete answers:

A: □□□□

Using □ with english

There is one more thing we need to look at when looking at □, and that concerns its combination with interrogatives. When paired with an interrogative (words such as 'how', 'why', 'when', 'where', etc.) the particle □ creates a vaguely specific answer to that interrogative. The easiest way to understand what that means is to just look at what happens:

interrogative	meaning	with □	meaning
□□	what	□□□	something
□□	who	□□□	someone
□□	where	□□□	somewhere
□□	when	□□□	sometime, eventually
□□	why	□□□	for some reason
□□	how	□□□	in some way or another

These words act as nouns, and can be used like any other noun in sentences:

□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I)'ll become good (at it) eventually."

english — english, english, english, english

We already saw □ in chapter 2, in the section on verb particles, where it was explained that it could mark verb actors and subjects. In addition to this, □ can be used for weak emphasis, usually translating to the English weakly emphatic "but", such as in the question "Excuse me, but do you know the time?", where its role is mostly to "ease in" the main statement. Similarly, □ eases in the main statement, although rather than getting a comma in front of it like 'but' does, it gets a comma after:

□□ □□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Excuse me (but), what time is it?"

Again like the English 'but', □ can be used as a more proper contrastive:

□□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"That is true, but (the) problem consists of more than just that (issue)."

This sentence consists of the sections □□□□□□, 'that is (also) true' and □□□□□□□□□□, 'the problem is not just that (issue)', joined with □ for contrast. These sentences use the

particles □ and □□, since it's hard to illustrate a proper contrastive without using a moderately complex sentence: ◎ marks similarity, and □□ (roughly) translates to "just/only". We will look at ◎ in more detail later in this particle section, and we'll examine ◎◎ in the next particle section.

On a final note, in classical Japanese, □ has the same role as □ does today. As such, you may encounter 'set' phrases that use □ in a genitive meaning.

english — english

This particle is a nicely complex one. The grand unifying role that it plays is, actually, unification, but the way in which it does it is usually experienced as doing completely different things. We already saw □ being used to create an english in chapter 2 in the section on noun particles, but this role extends not just to things, but to people as well. In the same way that [X]□[Y]□[Z] is an exhaustive noun list (i.e., the unity of all these things), if we use people instead of Xs and Ys, we end up with a unified group:

□□□ □□□ □□□ □ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Honda and Sakaki are going to go see a film."

In this sentence, the "noun list" □□□□□□□□ exhaustively lists all the members of the group of people that will go see a film.

An interesting feature is that □ can unify a english, or a group of things in general, leaving the central, contextually obvious noun implied. For instance, examine the following sentence:

□□□ □□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

In this sentence, □□□□□□□□ means "(I, you, he, she, it, we, they) went to Tokyo", and □□□□□ looks like an incomplete noun list. However, this is one of those aspects of Japanese where context is important: we can leave off a contextually obvious "thing" in a noun list, and expect people who understand Japanese to fill this in themselves: in this case, the most obvious interpretation is that 'I' or 'we' went to Tokyo with Kimura. However, just because it is the most obvious, that does not mean it's the only interpretation possible. If, say, we're discussing what a mutual friend of ours has been doing over the holiday, without that friend present, and one of us utters the phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□ then the contextually omitted person would be our mutual friend, rather than either of us.

There are several ways to make the omitted 'thing' explicit. One of these is to use the disambiguation particle, english:

□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Ishida (rather than someone else) went to Tokyo with Kimura."

However, this only makes sense if the sentence would otherwise be ambiguous. If instead we only want to reiterate the person's identity, we would use english:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Ishida went to Tokyo with Kimura."

In this sentence, □□ has been explicitly mentioned as primary verb actor, and because he's already been mentioned, can be left implied in the □ listing that follows.

Finally, we can do the most unnatural thing possible, and form a 'proper' exhaustive list without any implied nouns or people:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Ishida and Kimura went to Tokyo."

I say unnatural, because if someone has already been established as contextual subject or actor, you either leave them implied, or you mention them as actual subject or actor. If this was an opening sentence in a conversation, however, this sentence would be fine, as no context will have been established yet.

Being able to tell whether a noun listing has any implied items is rather simple: if it ends on □, instead of on a noun, it has an implied item. It doesn't matter how long the noun list is for this; if it ends on ◎, something has been left off:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Ishida and Kimura went to Tokyo."

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Ishida, Kimura and (I, you, he, she, it, us, they) went to Tokyo."

Of course this explanation so far has focussed on people, but the same goes for plain old object nouns:

□□□□□□□□
"(I, you, he, she, it, we, they) bought (it) with (a) credit card."

So it doesn't really matter what category the nouns are; as long as you're using ◎ for exhaustive listing, a full list is always of the form:

[X]□[Y](□[Z]□[…])

And a list with an implied item is always of the form:

[X]⊠([Y]⊠[…]⊠)

With this list explicitly ending on ⊠. However, make sure to add direct object particles when using ⊠⊠⊠ verbs (or rather, when using verbs in a ⊠⊠⊠ role, taking direct objects):

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
“(I, you, he, she, it, we, they) bought (it) with oranges.”

This sentence is not incorrect, but it says that we bought something in a place where oranges are considered a currency. This is probably not what we meant to say, and instead we wanted to say this:

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
“(I, you, he, she, it, we, they) bought (it) along with (the) oranges.”

Note the ⊠ in this sentence, which leads to a normal phrase “(something)◎◎◎◎”, where the “(something)” is our list with implicit items.

There are more things that ⊠ can do, and some of these involve a [noun]⊠ construction, so try to remember that just because an exhaustive listing with an implied item has the form [X]⊠, not everything that fits the pattern [X]⊠ has to be such an exhaustive listing with implied item. In fact, looking at further roles of ⊠ this becomes immediately obvious.

In addition to noun listing, ⊠ can be used in combination with sound or state words, properly called english, english, and english, english respectively, to form english. For instance, if it was a starlit night and we wanted to say that all the lights were causing the lake to sparkle, we would say something like the following:

⊠⊠
⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
“The lake sparkled.”

In this sentence, the word ⊠⊠⊠⊠ is a state description word (called ‘mimesis’ in English), which paired with ⊠ becomes an adverb to the verb ⊠⊠. Literally, then, this construction would say that the lake is ‘doing’ ⊠⊠⊠⊠. Sound description words (called ‘onomatopoeia’ in English) are treated in the same way:

⊠⊠ ⊠
⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
“The rain came pouring down.”

Here, the onomatopoeic word ⊠⊠ is not found in the translation, because in English

— as in most Western languages — we do not use such words to any serious degree. In Japanese, however, these words are an essential part of natural sounding language: the translation states that rain came "pouring down", because ⬚⬚ is the sound that rain pouring down makes. Before you now go thinking up all kinds of onomatopoeia yourself, Japanese has been in use for centuries, and virtually any onomatopoeia you might come up with already exists, in a very specific form. There are in fact ⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚ dictionaries which will list all of them by category and meaning (you may find one online on www.nihongoresources.com, for instance), so you're not free to come up with your own; there are several hundred well established onomatopoeia and mimeses, each typically with at least a handful of interpretations depending on what they relate to, leading to well over a thousand different uses. It is not surprise, then, that a mastery of onomatopoeia and mimeses is typically seen as having mastered conversational Japanese.

In fact, this adverbial marking of things using ⬚ extends beyond just the ⬚⬚⬚ and ⬚⬚⬚, and through this extending becomes a bit more complex too: a popular way to explain this is to call ⬚ the english particle, and give an example such as the following to illustrate this:

⬚⬚ ⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚ ⌋ ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"(I, you, he, she, it, we, they) said (I, you, he, she, it, we, they)'ll be coming over right now."

This clearly demonstrates a quote being recited, but things are not quite that simple; ⬚ will work with a much wider variety of things than just quotes, as the following examples should illustrate:

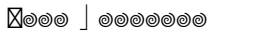
⬚⬚⬚ ⬚ ⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"(I, you, he, she, it, we, they)'re thinking about buying a car."

⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚ ⬚⬚⬚ ⬚⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"Let's think of (my, your, his, her, its, our, their) weakness(es) as (one of my, your, his, her, its, our, their) strength(s) (instead)."

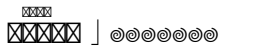
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⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"(I, you, he, she, it, we, they) consider (my, your, his, her, its, our, their) hobby (my, your, his, her, its, our, their) work."

What ⬚ is actually doing is marking all these things — the quote ⬚◎◎◎ ⌋, the *glossary* act ⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚, the concept ⬚, and the activity ⬚⬚ — as somehow being adverbial to the verbs in question; ⬚⬚, ⬚⬚, ⬚⬚⬚, and ⬚⬚. The actual interpretation of what ⬚ is doing depends entirely on the interpretation of what's being marked as adverbial, and the interpretation of the verbs used. For instance, ⬚⬚ means 'to say', but it can also mean 'to call'. As such, we can actually

translate our first sentence in two radically different ways:


"He said he'd be right over."
"He was called Imaiku."

The second translation sounds quite unlikely, but if we replace with , we get exactly the same possible translations:

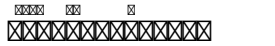

"He said 'Tanimurasan'."
"He was called Tanimura."

Suddenly the first translation sounds quite unlikely, although nothing really changed.

So how does differ from english, the direct object marker? Actually, sometimes we can use either, but for some verbs the meaning changes radically when we use , as opposed to when we use . A good example of this is the verb , which we looked at in chapter 2, in the section on important verbs. This verb changes its meaning from "to become" to "to be" when we use rather than , so there is an important choice to be made about which particle suits our need best. Another example is the verb , which means "to think" when used with , but "to think about" when used with .

Hopefully you spotted what happens here: rather than the verb and the direct object being distinct things, using unifies the verb and thing it works with into something that means something different from the sum of the parts. For instance, you cannot split up "to be [X]" into "to be" and "X" without changing the meaning of the verb. The same goes for "to think about [X]", or "to consider [X] something", or "to dream about [X]". While it is easier to explain as a series of separate things for all these different verbs, it's really doing the exact same thing for all of them, even though there is no simple rule in Western grammar that we can map it to so that it makes sense given what we know from our own every day language use.

To make matters even worse, we're not there yet. One more thing that does is act as a english. We already saw english acting as logical 'or', and is basically the english equivalent. If we want to express that two things are simultaneously the case, we would use :

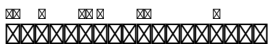

"With aeroplanes, the idea is that if you're late, you can't board."
literally: "for aeroplanes (rather than something else): if you're late, you can't board."

It is easy to mistake what happens in this sentence for just an english, so let's look

at what this sentence is doing before illustrating this use of ◎ with a more drastic example. Aeroplanes, with their strict schedules, have a very simple rule, being that if you are late for the flight, then too bad for you. The plane doesn't wait for people. As such, "being late" and "not being allowed on the plane" are simultaneously true. The moment you are late, immediately and irrevocably you are also unable to board. We can make this more obvious with the promised more drastic example:


"If my friend gets fired, I quit."

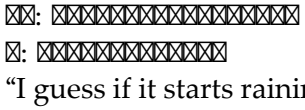
Here, it is crucially important to notice the ⊠, and realise that we're talking about englishs. This sentence does not say "if my friend gets fired, I shall put in my resignation", it says that right there and then, the moment he gets fired, you're quitting. It also doesn't leave any ambiguity, because you're asserting a fact. Since ◎ is acting as a logical 'and', statements involving ⊠ don't concern opinion, hearsay, or guesswork, they state plain and simple true english, so the following is correct use of ⊠:


"It's raining at the moment. If you go out now, you'll get wet without an umbrella."

But this next sentence is simply wrong:


"If it rains, we'll get wet."

The reason this second sentence is wrong is because ⊠ expresses a universally true fact. However, if you have an umbrella, or you're indoors, or you might be in any one of a number of situations in which it is raining but you don't get wet, this sentence is simply false, and as such stating it as a universal fact is plain wrong. Usually students will mistakenly use ⊠ in this way when what they really want to say is something pertaining to a particular, specific situation. For instance, if you're looking out the window, and you know you have no umbrella with you, you might want to say "if it starts raining now, I'll get wet", with the implication that this will happen if you go outside, not that you'll magically get wet inside if it starts to rain outside. Instead of using ◎, these kind of musings require the use of ⊠ or ⊠⊠ conditionals:


"I guess if it starts raining I'll get wet"

with the ⬚⬚/⬚⬚ endings signalling that you're saying something rhetorical, but you'd like whoever is listening to acknowledge you anyway.

This factual consequence is also found in unfinished sentences such as the following:

⬚⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
literally: "Not leaving now (means…)"
meaning: "(I, you, he, she, it, we, they) have to go."

⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
literally: "Not doing so (means …)"
meaning: "(I, you, he, she, it, we, they) have to do so."

These sentences are unfinished in the sense that they omit the — contextually obvious — generally negative consequences of the "not doing" of something.

english — english, english

The role of ⬚ is technically two-fold, although some people consider the ⬚ form of english, which is also written english, a particle, in which case there would be three roles.

The first role is that of *glossary*. In English, this is things like "by", "with" or "using" in relation to some instrument, in sentences like "This was written with a red pen" or "We came to the U.S. by aeroplane". In Japanese, the role these words play is performed by ⬚:

⬚⬚ ⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"(It)'s written with a red pen."

⬚⬚⬚⬚ ⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"(We) came to America by aeroplane."

A second important role that ⬚ plays is that it signifies the location of a verb action, or event. For instance, in English the sentences "We played in the park" and "The knives are in the cupboard" use the same preposition "in". In Japanese, these are two very different things: the first sentence focuses on an event, while the second focuses on a location. Consequentially, the first sentence requires ⬚, while the second sentence uses another particle, ⬚.

⬚⬚⬚⬚ ⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"(We) played in the park."

This use of □ is quite nice when one says something that in English would be ambiguous such as "We stayed at a hotel." In English, it is not possible to tell whether this would be an answer to "what did you do?" or "where did you stay?", without more information available to us. In Japanese, this distinction is immediately obvious:

□ □□□□□□□□□□
Decomposes as: "At the hotel, we did: staying."

□□□□□□□□□□
Decomposes as: "we did: staying a a hotel."

As mentioned, □ can also be said to have a third role, namely as the continuative form of the copula □□, which is □, although this is somewhat mixing different things because they sound the same. In the following example sentence, for instance, □ is not a particle, but the continuative form of □□:

□□□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"She's pretty, and has good style too, don't you agree?"

It should most definitely not be read as if □ was an instrumentalis, whereby the sentence would read something akin to "She's got good style thanks to being pretty".

english — english, english, english, english

This particle is a very versatile particle because of the way the Japanese interpret processes and states in and of the universe. The principal function of this particle is to describe points or frames in time space. This sounds complicated, so running through examples for all the combinations might help clarify things:

□□□ □
□□□□□□□□
"(I) will head out at 3."

This example indicates a english, namely the specific moment 3 o'clock. In contrast to this, a time frame rather than a point in time can also be indicated with □:

□□□□□ □□□□ □□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I) exercise twice a week."

Here, instead of an exact moment, a english is specified in which something happens.

However, □ is not restricted to just time:

□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"The cat's napping on the couch."

Here □ is used to indicate a english, namely a spot on the couch (remember from the section on □ that if we wanted to focus on the act of napping itself, □ would have had to be used instead). Just as for time, □ can also indicate an english:

□□ □ □□ □□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"There's a different world on the other side of the ocean."

The "other side" of the ocean isn't really one location, it's very much indeterminate. However, it is a location, and that's why we can use ◎ for it.

A second role that ◎ plays is to indicate a english of some action. When used in this fashion it typically follows a verb in ◎◎◎:

◎◎ ◎ ◎
◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"(I)'m going out to buy rice."

Here the "going" is done for the purpose of □□, "buying".

◎◎◎ ◎
◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"Won't (you) go watch a film (with me)?"

Here the "going" is done for the purpose of □□, "seeing".

A more general pattern for this "doing something for a purpose" is the pattern english, which explicitly states purpose through the noun □, and can be used with a wider variety of verbs and statements. This construction will be explained in the nominalisers section in the chapter on language patterns.

The last role that □ plays we have already seen extensively used in chapters 2 and 3, when dealing with english that translate to adverbial and prepositional phrases, so we shall consider this aspect thoroughly explained by now.

english — english

Before we look at the role this particle plays, it should be emphasised that the particle □ is always pronounced □.

Sometimes confusion arises about when to use english and when to use □ when it comes to directions and destinations. The answer is surprisingly simple: when you want to

indicate a direction, use ☒. When you want to indicate a destination, use ☒. The real problem isn't which to use, but when it doesn't matter which you use. For instance, take the following two sentences:

☒☒☒☒ ☒
☒☒☒☒☒☒☒
"(I) will go to Tokyo."

☒☒☒☒☒☒☒☒
"(I) will go to Tokyo."

While in English the sentence "I will go to Tokyo" can both mean that Tokyo is the destination, or that Tokyo is just the most identifiable point in indicating a direction of travel, in Japanese there is a subtle difference:

☒☒☒☒☒☒☒☒
"(I) will go to Tokyo. This is my destination (for it is marked as a location)."

☒☒☒☒☒☒☒☒
"(I) will go in the direction of Tokyo (this is not necessarily my destination, for it is not marked as a location)."

Sometimes it doesn't matter in a conversation whether you say something is a destination or just a general direction of travel, and even Japanese will use them interchangeably under those circumstances, but there are also examples in which it's impossible to use one instead of the other. For instance, if you want to say where you've been during your vacation, you can only use ☒, because you're talking about locations you've visited, not directions you travelled in. Similarly, when you're navigating your way through a forest and want to go west, there's no specific or even general location you want to go to, you only want to head in a particular direction, so you can only use ☒ to describe this.

In questions, it's typically customary to answer with the particle that was used in the question. Thus, if someone asks you a question with ☒, you answer with ☒, and if you get a question with ☒, you answer with ☒, of course observing that you're using the right words to match the particle.

english — english

We already covered ◎ in chapter 2 when we talked about noun particles, but there is one more thing that it does that requires a bit more explanation, and that's nominalisation. This is a very powerful 'feature', because it lets us talk about phrases as if they were nouns. It lets us say things like "I didn't like walking around town today", where "walk-

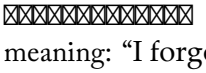
ing around town today" is technically treated as a nominalised *glossary*, and thus acts as a noun.

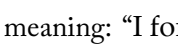

"(I) didn't particularly enjoy today's walk about the city."

In this sentence, the clause , "to walk the city", has been turned into a *glossary* (a gerund is the noun form of a verb: "to walk" "(the) walking") by : meaning "the specific 'walking of the city' that was done", as a noun. With this noun form we can then make all sorts of comments in relation to it.

However, this nominalisation is restricted to events that are in-topic. If some activity or event is a context to a conversation, then can be used to nominalise it, but if we want to talk about events or activities in general, we have to use english. We can actually use either english, or without the , to say two different things. Comparing all three with a series of examples, we see the following:


meaning: "I forgot to post the letter."
because: , "posting a letter" as a specific activity, was forgotten.


meaning: "I forgot how to post a letter."
because: , "posting a letter" as the concept in general, was forgotten.


meaning: "I forgot about the letter."
because: , everything contextually relating to "our letter", in this case posting it, was forgotten.

As is evident from the example sentences, using (as a back referral) lets us talk about a specific instance of an activity, lets us talk about the same specific instance, but as an abstract concept rather than the activity, and just talks about the general activity, rather than some specific instance. Also, note that we can only use after nouns, despite being able to use both and separately after verbs (in).

In addition to its roles as a noun lister and referral particle, can be used as a question softener. Used on its own this is considered reserved speech, bordering on effeminate, and men tend to use instead.

□□□□□□
□□□□□□□
“What happened?”

For answers to questions that ask for a reason to some situation, □ softens this reason:

□□□□
A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
□□□ □
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□

A: “Why are (you) still at work?”
B: “(it is because) (I)’m not done with (my) work yet.”

Again, this use is considered borderline effeminate, so men tend to use this construction in conjunction with the plain copula □, with or without contracting the □ to an □ to form □□ or □□. The polite version, □□□, will be treated in the section on more particles later in this chapter.

Pairing □ with the copula □

When pairing □ with phrases, we are basically using those phrases attributively to the noun that □ refers back to. While a simple description, this has some repercussions when those phrases end on □, because of its base forms.

As already highlighted in the section on attributives in the previous chapter, □ still has a □□□ form, signifying a finalised sentence, as well as a □□□ form, signifying it is being used attributively. So, if we pair □ with a phrase ending on □, it must be changed from finalised form to attributive form, and so is used as □ instead. This is why, when a plain copula statement is paired with □ as a back referral, you will never hear □ followed by □, but always □ followed by □.

english — english

As already explained in chapter 2, in the verb particle section, □ (pronounced □) is used to disambiguate statements. Let’s look at what this means in terms of what ◎ does, compared to english or english. Imagine that we’re having a conversation and we’re talking about watching films in the cinema, DVD rentals, and TV shows, and the following sentence is used:

□
□□□(…)□□□□□□

Where for (…) we either find □, □ or □. While all three would translate to "(I) watch TV a lot", their connotations are very different.

1) □□□□□□□□□□

When we use □, the sentence is fairly plain information. Whoever of us says it wants to convey that they watch TV a lot, and nothing more.

2) □□□□□□□□□□

When we use □, the sentence is still plain information, although using □ rather than □ emphasises that whoever is talking about TV, is talking about TV. This using □ as an emphasis marker is a fairly common practice, although you need to know why you're emphasising, of course.

3) □□□□□□□□□□

By using □, everything has changed. The speaker has indicated that the information in the sentence requires disambiguation in terms of what it applies to. In this case, the "watching a lot" only applies to TV. While □ and □ told us only one thing, namely the plain information that TV was being watched a lot, □ tells us two things. First, the basic information, that someone watched TV a lot. However, because the speaker felt they needed to make sure that we know it only applies to TV, it also tells us that it explicitly does not apply to films or DVD rentals.

This makes □ very powerful, and also makes it very easy to misuse: If you only want to state some information, you should not be using □. However, if you want to make sure that the context for some information is unmistakable, □ is exactly the particle you want to use.

One very common use of this is in the form of social commentary, by pairing it with verbal □ forms, followed by something that represents a negative commentary such as the word english, indicating that something "won't do", or the word english, indicating something is bad:

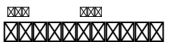
□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
literally: "(you) not coming over today will not do".
"(You) have to drop by today."

□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□
literally: "Eating it is no good."
"(You) may not eat this."

In these sentences, the negative repercussion is explicitly said to apply only in the

situations marked by . Also, because is used, we know that they don't apply if whatever is suffixed to doesn't apply.

Of course, sometimes it will feel like isn't doing this strict disambiguation, such as in simple sentences like the following:


"Nice weather today, isn't it?"


"Actually, I'm horrible at Japanese."

In both sentences, the looks perfectly innocent, but it's actually still doing the exact same thing. In the first sentence, the fact that has to be mentioned means that the situation of good weather is implicitly being contrasted to some previous, poor weather. Similarly, in the second sentence it seems like , 'truthfully' or 'actually', is fairly innocent, but the fact that it has been explicitly mentioned and marked with means that the information that follows only applies in the context of 'true information'. Even when sounds like it's just sitting in a sentence as a common courtesy, it never loses its additional connotation.

So in summary, we can characterise as: [X][Y] in the context of [X], [Y] applies, and outside the context of [X], [Y] does not apply. Put concisely, not only tells us the applicable context, but also the inapplicable context.

Because of this, you will typically find referred to as the 'context' particle (or 'topic' particle) in literature, but this is dangerous terminology, as it makes it really easy to forget that in addition to indicate context/topic, it also indicates the inverse at the same time. never just marks applicable context, it always — always — also gives the inapplicable context simply by virtue of being used. If you don't want to also imply inapplicable context, use — or — instead.

(Almost) needless to say, this also means you never use for things you're asking questions about. For instance, in the following example sentences, the first sentence is fine, and the second is very, very wrong:


"Who came (over)?"


"Who, as opposed to someone else, came (over)?"

This second sentence makes absolutely no sense, and you should never ever mark subjects of questions with . Ever.

That said, you can use in a question to disambiguate just fine, as long as it does not

get used for the actual question subject:

□□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Who's recently been coming (over)?"
literally: "Lately [rather than during some other time frame], who has come (over)?"

english — english

This particle plays two important roles in Japanese. The first is that it acts as a similarity marker, and in this use it replaces the subject □ or disambiguation marker □:

□□□ □□ □
A: □□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□

A: "I like books."
B: "I also like books."

Like english or english, it can also be used to form lists:

□□□□
A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□

A: "Do (you) like books, or do (you) like music?"
B: "(I) like both books and music."

However, □ marks a similarity to something previously mentioned, so you cannot use the particle □ out of the blue. It requires a prompt either by someone else, or by something you yourself just said. Interestingly, this can even be something in the same sentence:

□□ □□ □□□□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Young and old, welcome."

Here the fact that □ is used twice (and it can be used more times) means that the similarity is between all the marked parts of phrase.

Because normally □ is reserved for responding to some kind of prompt, it's usually a good idea to consider ◎ the Japanese counterpart to the English "too", in the sense of "also", without considering it a valid counterpart to the word "also", since that can be used without any real prompting.

A second use of □ is as an emphatic *glossary* particle, meaning something like the English "even [if/by] …". In this use, it typically follows □ forms:

□□□ □ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Even (by) leaving now, (you) probably won't make it."

A special english is the english (□□) construction, which asks and grants permission:

□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Feel free to use (the) computer."

Or as part of a (short) conversation:

A: □□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□

A: "May I sit down?"
B: "You may."

Using □ with the □ form also means we can use it with □ form for the copula, which is □, forming □□:

□□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Even the teacher says so."

In addition to these things, □ can — like english — be combined with english to form a specific kind of answer to these interrogatives. While □ creates a vaguely specific answer, □ creates an all-encompassing answer:

interrogative	meaning	with □	meaning
□□	what	□□□	anything
□□	who	□□□	anyone
□□	where	□□□	anywhere
□□	when	□□□	anytime
□□	how	□□□	in any possible way

Unlike for □, however, when these interrogatives are followed by □ they can lead to some confusion when translated: they may be translated differently depending on whether they are followed up by an affirmative, or negative verb form. In Japanese, words like □□□ or □□□ don't carry any affirmative or negative aspect, relying on the verb they're being used

with to impart this meaning instead. So, while the same word is used in the following Japanese sentences, the English translation uses two seemingly different words:

□□
□□□□□□
"(I) will do anything."

□□□□□□□
literally, "(I) won't do anything"
"(I) will do nothing."

Likewise:

□□□□□□
"(It) exists anywhere."

□□□□□□
literally, "(It) doesn't exist anywhere."
"(It) exists nowhere."

This is a good example of how translations may create wrong impressions: even though in English these words are answers to the interrogative, coming in different versions while the verb stays the same form, in Japanese it is the exact opposite, with the answer words to the interrogative staying the same, and the verb coming in different versions depending on which polarity (affirmative or negative) is needed.

On an equally important note, when used with interrogatives this way, many additional particles come between the interrogative and □:

interrogative	+ particle	combination
□□□	□	□□□□
□□ □□	□	□□ □□□
□□ □□	□	□□□

english — english

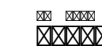
The last particle in the list, but also the simplest to explain. In modern Japanese, this particle marks a direct verb object, and acts as indicator for "what is being traversed" in traversal verbs. We have already looked at both of these roles in chapter 1, in the section on verbs, as well as in chapter 2, in the section on verb particles; the particle is always pronounced as □, and there isn't really anything else to say about this particle that hasn't been said already.

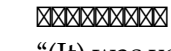
4.2.2 english

There are a number of particles which should be known in order to be able to communicate more than rudimentary ideas, in addition to the previous essential particles — that is not to say we cannot create complex constructions with the previous 10 particles, but to properly express ourselves we need a few more. The following list is divided into two sections; the first focussing mostly on sentence ending emphatic particles, and the second focussing on more general grammatical particles.

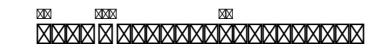
english — english, english

This particle is most often found at the end of statements, where it marks information as being either english, or contrary to the listener's belief. While tempting, this particle should not be translated with an english, as isn't actually an exclamation, but only emphasises the "new information"/"contrary information" aspect. For instance:


"(It) was very fun."


"(It) was very fun (you didn't know or expect this, so I'm telling you it was)."

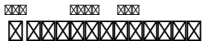
When is used to emphasise contrasting information, the situation is usually some kind of misunderstanding:


"No (emphatic). The new ones (go) here, the old ones (go) over there (emphatic)."

While it would be temping in this use to translate with an exclamation mark anyway, care should be taken not to overdo things. A stern lecture from a boss, for instance, might never involve any yelling or even exclamations, but might be interspersed lavishly with .

english — english

This particle is placed at the end of a sentence, when the speaker wants to provoke the listener into agreeing with them. This is a english though, and using means you already expect the response to be something that sounds like an affirmative muttering:



“Sakaki is really beautiful, isn’t she?”

The unlikely event of hearing “no” as a response to this type of rhetorical confirmation seeking is typically met with much surprise and disbelief, sparking new depths of conversation since you responded differently than what was expected of you.

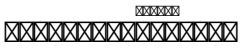
This particle can be drawn out to form english (also found written english or english), in which case it does the same thing, but expecting less of a response:



“Holiday’s nice isn’t it…”

A response to this is typically just something simple like “english” (a colloquial “yes”), or “english” (in meaning similar to “indeed”) without the response having been given much thought.

A secondary use is mid-sentence, to draw the attention of the listener(s). This use is, sadly, completely and utterly untranslatable, so the translation in the following sentence has mapped to a commentary instead:



“Sakaki (are you still listening to me?) is actually from Oosaka.”

This use can be overdone, too, similar to how the ungrammatical use of “like” is common in spoken English, but sticking it in every other word makes you positively obnoxious:



“So like, then, like, once I got there like, Matsuda had been like, waiting for over half an hour, apparently.”

english — english

Using instead of is a more assertive way to do the exact same thing, somewhat rhetorically english. Because this is a more assertive particle, it expects more of a response more than does. However, this particle has a problem as sentence ender, because (as was explained in chapter 3 in the section on imperatives) after a can also mean a *glossary* command, such as in:



“Don’t open (that).”

The way to tell whether ▯ is a prohibiting command or a confirmation-seeking particle is by intonation. If ▯ is accented, it's the confirmation seeking version. If it's unaccented, it's a prohibiting command. We can also find ◎ at the end of a sentence when it's following a ◎◎◎, in which case it can be considered a short version of the ▯▯▯ + english commanding form:

▯
▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯
"Will you get up already?"

Luckily, this type of command is typically issued in a very stern voice, so it's very hard to mistake it for the other two roles that the sentence ending ◎ can have.

Like ◎, ▯ can have its vowel sound drawn out, to form english (also written english or english), and just like ▯ it can be used mid-sentence as an attention grabber.

english — english, english

As a sentence ender, ▯ is a more emphatic version of ▯, purely being informative. Where ▯ is used either to present new information or contrary information, ▯ is only used for new information:

▯▯▯ ▯▯▯▯▯ ▯ ▯▯▯▯
▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯

english — english

This particle is used when english that back up some (possibly merely implied) statement:

[illegible]…
"(Well) it wasn't fun. (I) told (you) (I) didn't want to go, didn't (I)? It was cold, (I) couldn't really hear it all that well…"

An example of where the conclusion is already implied requires more of a conversation:

A: [illegible]
B: [illegible]…
A: [illegible]

A: "So, (you) didn't buy it?" (the speaker here is only guessing)
B: "Well, it was expensive, (and) not something that (I) particularly needed…"
A: "Ah…(is that how things are)"

We see here that, while left implied, speaker B clearly did not buy whatever the conversation was about.

While it will often suit the translation to combine multiple -[illegible] reasons with "english", as this is the word used for compounding in English, a better translation would be "english" or "english". Be careful not to take this word "more" too literally, as [illegible] can occur without the actual statement such as in the previous example.

english — english

This particle is an excessively contracted form of the constructions english and english, and it can be used in a fashion similar to the quoting particle english:

[illegible]
"What did (you) say?"

Somewhat confusingly, it's sometimes also used as a replacement for english in its quoting role:

[illegible]
"Even though (you) said (you) would come over, why didn't (you)?"

Finally, it can also act as a stand-in for the rather cumbersome □□□□□, which roughly translates to "that which is known by the term …" or "everything that is generally covered by the term …":

□□□□ □□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□
"(Everything that is encompassed by the term) humans are interesting."

english — english

This is a particle that is used when english such as when trying to recall something, as well as when asking someone to give an answer that you know they already have:

□□□□□□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□
"Now what was the phone number again…"
"What was the phone number again?"

english — english

This is a combination of the questioning particle english and the strong confirmation seeking english. Combined they mean something like "english"/"english":

□□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□(□)□
"(I) guess Uematsu won't be coming either, huh?"

□□□□□ □□
□□□□□□□(□)□
"(I) wonder if (I)'m free Thursday…"

english — english

english is the effeminate version of □□, reserved for women (as well as effeminate homosexuals and transvestites, in all fairness). While most particles can be used by either gender but may make someone sound effeminate, using this particle as a man makes you sound gay. Quite literally, in fact, as it means you are letting people know that you consider yourself effeminate and wish others to know this. Of course, using this particle as a woman is perfectly fine.

english — english

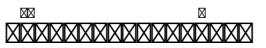
This combination of the particles english and english is used to indicate a english, or english, such as in for instance:


“It’d be nice if today had good weather too.”


“(She)’ll call today, (I) think (I hope)…”

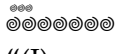
english — english, english

There are two roles that plays. The first is as open, or non-exhaustive, noun lister, used similarly to english:


“As for drinks, I got (us) (amongst other things,) whiskey and rum.”

Unlike , which presents an inclusive list, leaves this list open, typically in a way that allows us to interpret it as meaning “these things, and other things like them”.

In addition to being the non-exhaustive noun lister, we can also use as a sentence ending particle, where it signifies a english to one’s fate in the face of hardship:


“(I) guess there’s nothing (I) can do about it..”

Finally, at the end of a sentence is in many regions in Japan considered a copula, replacing english. In these regions, you may also find it inflected as negative, as english. However, in this use (both affirmative and negative inflections) it is simply a copula, not indicating resignation of any kind.

english — english

As sentence ender, this particle leads two lives. In standard Japanese, is used as an emphatic sentence ender, similar to english, but is considered an effeminate particle and as such is used a lot by women, but avoided by men. In the more rural parts of Japan, and most readily recognisably in the Kansai area, is also used as , but is not considered effeminate in any way and is prolifically used by everyone.

In addition to acting as a sentence ending particle, □ can also be used in a role similar to the noun particle english, in which case it is an emphatic open listing particle.

4.2.3 Further particles

english, english, english, english — english

A combination of the genitive english (permissibly contracted to □) and the copula, this "particle" — or rather, set of particles — can be used as a way to give a reason for something without explicitly stating so. This means you present a normal statement and finish it with a form of □□□, turning it into something close to a factoid, which can be interpreted by the listener(s) as a reason for a situation, or an explanation of a prior statement. That's perhaps a little abstract, so an example:

□□
A: □□□□□□
□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
A: □□□□□□□

A: "You look sleepy."
B: "Yeah, (it is due to the fact that) I fell asleep on the train."
A: "Ah, I see."

The "it is due to the fact that" part in the translation for line B is the conceptual translation for □□□, and is usually best simply left out, or if really needed translated with "as" (meaning something similar to "because", but subtly different by leaving out the explicit causal link described by "because"). While it's tempting to translate ◎◎◎ or its other forms ◎◎◎, □□ and □□ as "because", this is not what it means. There is nothing in □□□ that actually translates to an explicit "because", so whenever possible do not use this word when translating.

□□□ can also be used to ask for a reason, paired with a question that would otherwise warrant a yes/no answer. First, without □□□:

A: □□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□

A: "Is it okay this way?"
B: "Yes."

And then with □□□:

A: □□□□□□□□□□□
□□ □□□ □□□ □□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

A: “Is it okay this way?”
B: “(We)’ll do the rest tomorrow, so (yes,) I think we can call it a day.”

We see here that a normal —□□□ question is a simple “is it?” english, but that using english not only asks for a yes/no answer but also the motivation for the yes/no answer (the mixed politeness form between the two lines here may indicate a *glossary* talking to their boss).

Be careful not to start over-using □□□, ending up using it in situations in which it doesn’t actually make any sense such as in the following example:

A: □□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□

A: “What will you have?”
B: “As I want ice cream.”

In this case, using □□□ is plain and simply wrong. Rather than stating that you want ice cream, □□□□□□, the addition of □□□ suddenly forces the listener to interpret this phrase as a reason for something, leading to what is basically a nonsense phrase, so be careful: only use □□□ or a variant when there is something to reason about, or you need more information than a simple yes/no answer to a question.

english — english

This is essentially the continuative form for □□□, and means “it is that …” in an unfinished sentence, which is in English typically translated as “english”. There is an important distinction between “due to” and “because” that deserves some special attention: “due to” typically cannot be used to indicate things such as explaining *glossary* action (I am doing this because…), reasons for requests (I would like … because), personal opinions (I think … because), commands (do … because), and invitations/suggestion (should … because). The same holds for □□: it cannot be used for any of these.

You’d almost forget there are other things beside these categories, but the most fundamental one, english, is still there and is exactly what this particle is used for:

□□□ □□ □□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

“Due to it being a holiday today, the shop is closed.”

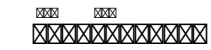

“Due to it being broken, (you) will (have to) use another one.”

Because of the fact that this particle can only be used for factoids, and cannot be used to express one’s own opinion, volition or suggestions, it is considered more polite than the next particle, english, which acts as a general “because”. ◎◎ is used frequently in official documents and formal settings, where stating something as something other than a factoid might lay responsibility for the statement with someone.

english — english, english or english origin

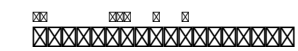
The broadest definition that can be given for ▯▯ is that it signifies the english of anything, be it space related (starting from some point), time (starting at some time), events (starting from the moment after you undertake a particular action), or even reasoning (making an argument that is grounded in a particular perspective). Because of this, it’s a very versatile particle. To see this versatility, let’s look at several examples to illustrate the different uses of this particle, in translation:


“(We)’re heading from Kyoto in the direction of Nara.”


“(I) work, starting at 6 o’ clock.”


“(I)’ll be a university student as of next month.”


“After (I) have done the laundry (I)’ll go throw out the garbage.”


“Because (I) was late, (I) couldn’t take the exam.”


“Because Mr. Kurogane is a teacher, he can also explain (things) well.”

You may have noticed the difference between the english in example sentence four, and the past tense english in example sentence five. The first construction uses an open state-

ment (an unfinished event if we remember what □ stands for) that acts as point of origin for a new event, while the second uses a closed statement as a point of origin for a reasoning. The easy way to remember this is that a □ form isn't a finished verb action, so no conclusions can be drawn from it, while a □□□ is for all intents and purposes done, and can be used for drawing conclusions and commenting on.

english — english, english or english extent (inclusive)

The counterpart to □□ is the particle □□, which signifies the english and thus end of something, rather than the origin. To be more specific, □□ signifies an "up to and including" extent:

□□ □
□□□□□□□□
"(We)'re going up to Nara."

□□□ □□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I) work till 6 o' clock."

□□□□ □□□□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I)'ll be a university student until next month."

□□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I)'ll be throwing out garbage until (I) start doing the laundry."

□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(You)'ve gone too far…"
literally: "(How can you) say (something) (to that extent)?"

This last sentence is incredibly sparse in terms of actual translation, having much more implied translation than literal, but illustrates the conceptual 'extent', where you cannot physically measure saying something, but can only conceptually say someone is saying something that is either insignificant or grave in consequence.

Of course, english and □□ can be used together in the typical "english" pattern:

□□□□ □□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(We)'re going from Kyoto up to Nara."

□□□ □□□ □□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I) will exercise from 6 to 7 o' clock."

1999□□□2004 □□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) was a student from 1999 to 2004.”

But don’t let the following sentence trip you up:

□□□□ □ □□ □□ □□□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ □□ □□□□□□

This sentence does not mean “I will not do homework from the moment my friend arrives until he leaves”, but actually means:

“Because my friend has dropped by, I will not do homework until he leaves.”

This sentence is not a “from … up till …” sentence, but a reason marked with □□, where the conclusion happens to contain □□. Be careful, and pay attention to whether something is -□□□ or -□□□!

english — english, english or english extent (exclusive)

The combination of □□ + □ is a subtle restriction of the normal particle english:

□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(We)’ll assemble until 9 o’ clock.”

□□□□□□□□□□□□
literally: “(We)’ll assemble up until 9 o’ clock.”
meaning: “(We)’ll assemble before 9 o’ clock.”

While □□ indicates “english”, □□□ indicates only “english”, or “english”. This difference between including the last moment and excluding the last moment can be critical, as for instance in the previous example phrases. If we imagine a situation where a group of people are assembling in order to set off on a journey by bus at 9, forgetting the innocent looking □ will make the difference between people enjoying a nice holiday, or standing stranded at the bus stop because they missed the deadline and the bus already left.

english — english (english)

Before explaining the modern use, it might be useful to explain that □□ used to play the role that english plays today. In fact, in legal documents □□ is still used instead of □□. Now, this may not have been a very lengthy explanation, but it does make understanding why □□ does

what it does in modern Japanese easier: in modern Japanese, ▯▯ is used to label something as a reference point for a comparison:



Literally this line reads "Anpan (◎◎◎◎), with respect to dinner bread (▯▯▯▯), is sweeter (▯▯)." which makes the somewhat abstract explanation earlier clearer.

Typically, ▯▯ gets translated with "rather than", but this can be confusing because ▯▯ usually does not link the two things being compared, as in English, but links the reference point and the quality. In the previous sentence, for instance, ▯▯▯▯ is the reference point, and the quality is ▯▯, sweet. We could even leave the compared item out entirely, relying on context to make it clear what it was supposed to be:

▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯
"(it) is sweeter than dinner bread."

The reason we can do this is because qualities, as you hopefully remember from the section on attributive and comparative use of adjectives, can be either attributive (attributing their quality) or comparative (being used to indicate they apply more to one thing than another). As such, ▯▯▯▯ doesn't just mean "it is sweet", but can mean "it is sweeter" just as easily. When paired with ▯▯, considering the adjective a comparative is the better interpretation.

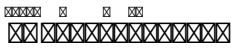
english — english

This particle, which follows a verbs in ▯▯▯, or verbal adjectives and nouns directly, signifies that two actions are taking place at the same time, for the same duration of time. This particle is sometimes translated with "while", but this is typically more confusing than helpful because of the way Japanese clauses are ordered (the most important clause coming last):


"(I) ate dinner while watching the TV."

The second part, ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯, is the *glossary* action here, which is why it comes last. In English, however, we tend to list the dominant action first, mentioning the other thing we're doing almost as an afterthought.

On a timing note, ▯▯▯ implies that the two actions are roughly of english, and we cannot use it for something like "I did some shopping while visiting Tokyo today". Instead, the particle ▯▯▯ is used for this kind of momentary simultaneous action, if a particle is used at all. Rather, usually a continuative is used instead, such as:


“I went to Tokyo (and) did (some) shopping (while there).”

In addition to the obvious interpretation, ▯▯▯ can also be used to mean ‘but’ or ‘even though’, especially when paired with the noun english, “unfortunate”:


“I’m sorry, but matters are not that simple.”

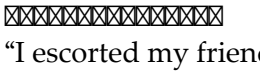
english — english

Like ◎◎◎, ▯▯▯ comes after verbs in ▯▯▯ or directly after verbal adjectives and nouns, but unlike ▯▯▯, it does not claim two actions to be perfectly synchronous. english, the verb in ▯▯▯ + ▯▯▯ indicates the longer verb action, with the sentence finalising verb indicating the shorter one. This might seem odd, since it might seem to contradict the practice of putting the most important part last, but actually the short action is dominant: since the long verb action is going on anyway, the shorter action represents more specific, and thus more important, information:


“While bringing (my) friend to the station, (we also) did (some) shopping.”

▯▯▯ can also be written english, explicitly using the particle ▯ to mark the act as a time frame in which the more specific act takes place.

As mentioned in the section on ▯▯▯, often a continuative verb form is used rather than ▯▯▯, but this does come at a price: using the ▯ form means we also indicate a sequence of events, so that we cannot rephrase the previous sentence as follows, without changing its meaning:


“I escorted my friend to the station, (and then) did (some) shopping.”

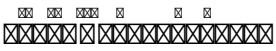
english — english

As the last particle for indicating “doing something while something else is the case”, we find the particle ▯▯. This particle is more general than ▯▯▯ or ▯▯▯ in that there are no time constraints of any sort (this particle follows verbs in ▯▯▯):



"Do you intend to deny (it), while knowing full well it was (your) own fault?"

Note that because this particle has no time aspect to it, we can also use it for things such as:



"The shop is straight on, with the station to your left."

english — english: "english"

While the English "however" comes at the start of a sentence and is followed by a comma, the Japanese english comes mid-sentence (and may also be followed by a comma). Strangely enough, they both mean the same thing, but the way they do it is just syntactically different.

English: "This is true. However, there are more things at play."
Japanese: 

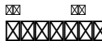
In this sentence, the pause is after ⬚, which is simply a contracted form of ⬚. In fact, ⬚ has four variants: english, english, english and english. In classical Japanese these all had subtly different meanings, ⬚ being a combination of the verb form ⬚ (the ⬚ for ⬚) and the classical compound particle ⬚, but in modern Japanese they can be used essentially interchangeably, as long as the "the longer, the more polite" rule is observed. That said, both ⬚ and ⬚ contain the emphatic ⬚, while ⬚ and ⬚ do not, which makes ⬚ and ⬚ more contrastive than ⬚ and ⬚.

All of these, however, follow ⬚ phrases.

english — english

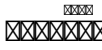
This particle is not so hard to use, but it has a particular pattern of use that sometimes confuses people when they first learn it. For this reason, it's probably easiest to say that ◎ stands for 'extent' of actions, consequences, or even of properties. For instance, english would translate to "the extent of doing". Similarly, ⬚ would be 'the extent of the height', etc.

This marking of extent is quite useful when comparing items: where the construction english gives a similarity, and the construction english makes Y more "something" than english marks the extent of Y the being same as for X. For instance:



literally: “To the extent that it is pricey, it is tasty.”
meaning: “As tasty as it is pricey.”

In effect, this english sets up a proportional relation between the concepts X and Y. Another example to illustrate this:



literally: “To the extent of doing it, one gets better (at it).”
meaning: “Getting better the more (you) do it.”

Hopefully this makes the following sentence understandable:



Before offering the translation, I’ll give you the translation for the individual words, in the hope that what I end up offering is a translation that seems obvious: ⊠⊠ means art, ⊠⊠ means ‘to watch/to look at’ and ⊠⊠⊠ means beautiful. Literally this sentence would come down to “Art, should one look at it, to the extent of looking at it, it’s beautiful”. The trick is now of course to turn this literal translation into something that actually makes sense in English:

> “As far as Art is concerned, the more (often) (you) look at it, the more beautiful it is.”

Hopefully at this point you’ll go “yes, that’s obvious”. If so, then good. If not, then that’s in line with what many people experience when they first come across ◎◎ used in this particular sense. The pattern used here is quite particular: with [X] a verb and [Y] some statement, “([X] in ◎◎◎+◎) [X] ◎◎ [Y]” translates to “The more one [X], the more [Y]”.

Another example using this pattern is:



“The more (you) hear it, the better (you)’ll understand it.”

The reason it means this is that the extents of the initial verb action ◎◎ and the conclusion ◎◎◎◎◎ are linked by ◎◎.

Negative extent

Just as ◎◎ can be used for a "the more [X], the more [Y]", it can be used to construct a negative "The more X, the less Y" sentence:

□□□ □□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"The cheaper cars are, the less (well) they run."

One of the things that tends to trip up people a lot with □□ is the fact that even though the Japanese pattern has three verbs, the English translation has only two. The thing to remember is that [□□□□□ + □□□ + □□] is a single semantic block meaning "to the extend of doing X", so the Japanese may have the verb twice, but the translation only needs it once.

english — english, english

This particle is sometimes translated with "only", but when it is, it typically needs a very strange and contrived explanation. Instead, remember that □□ does not mean 'only', but means 'english' or 'english', as used in for instance "I didn't do a dang thing today, save/except eat":

◎◎◎ ◎ ◎◎
◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"Today (I) did nothing except eat."

That's really all there is to it. The only additional rule is that ◎◎ follows verbs in ◎◎◎, or nouns directly:

□□□□
□□□□□□□□
"(There) is no one but (the) teacher."

english — english

Unlike □□, □□ does mean 'english', and is typically followed by the instrumental particle english to indicate something is done in some restricted way:

□□□
□□english□□□□□□
"(I) did it just by myself."

The same idea can be expressed with □□, but then the phrasing needs to be drastically altered:

□□□
□□□□□□□□□□
"No one did it except for me."

Notice that these two phrases connote very different things, even though they share the same basic idea. Both claim that one person performed a task, but the sentence with □□ sounds far more positive than the one with □□. The second sentence sounds almost *glossary*, which is a direct consequence of the fact that □□ means save, and thus needs to be used with a negative verb, as well as with an unnamed party in this case.

□□ can also be used with verbs in □□□ form:

□□□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(He) understood (it) with just one word."

However, while □□ is used to indicate a particular instance, for the habitual or repetitive version of just/only, such as in for instance "why do you always only eat caramel flavoured ice cream?", the particle □□□ (or its variants □□□□, □□□, □□□□ or □□□) is used.

Special use

The verb □□□, "to be able to do" in combination with □□ creates a special word: english. This word is special because it's part of a pair that expresses almost the same thing, but not quite: □□□□□ and english. Both express "english" but there's a subtle difference:

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"Please come as quickly as possible."

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"Please come as quickly as possible."

The difference between the two is that ◎◎◎◎◎ expresses "english", whereas □□□□ expresses "english" or even just "english". The first essentially works as a command, saying to drop everything and do whatever the sentence says to do, provided this is at all possible (hence the □□□), while the second doesn't demand quite this much, due to the words that it's made up of: a combination of ◎◎, to become, and the □□□ of the classical, very odd, verb □□ (which defies modern word classes), used to indicate a social expectation.

Inverting using english

The meaning for □□ can also be inverted by adding english, the continuative of □□ followed by the □□□ of □□, to form a construction meaning "english" or "english":



literally: "Not just (at) driving, but also at (the) mechanics, he's a really competent driver."
meaning: "(He)'s a driver who's not just good at the wheel, but also knows his way around the mechanics of a car."

english — english, english

As mentioned in the explanation of ◎◎, □□□ is used for things that are repetitive or drown out everything else, such as in the following sentence for instance:



"(I) hate people who only tell lies."

In this sentence, □□□ has to be used if we want to indicate not just telling a lie once or twice, but always telling lies, i.e. only telling lies rather than truths.

Another use is with verbs in plain past tense, to indicate that the verb action has been completed only, or just, moments ago:



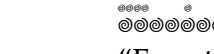
"cookies that have just been made"

□□□ can also be written english, in which case it carries just a bit more emphasis. It may also be used as english or english without any serious difference, other than that □□□ sounds a bit more effeminate than □□□. Finally, □□□□, or □□□□ can be further contracted to the highly informal english, not to be confused with the popular term english, used when someone messes something up.

Like □□, english's meaning can be inverted by using english.

english — english

This particle is actually a combination of the continuative form of the copula ◎◎, □, and □ as contrastive emphatic marker. Together, they form a strong emphatic marker that can be translated with "even", "regardless of" or "but even then":



"Even the teacher doesn't know."

[illegible]
"[I] bought a new one. But this one has a problem too."

Like ◎ and ◎, this combination can be used in combination with english, in which case it forms english:

interrogative	meaning	with [illegible]	meaning
[illegible]	what	[illegible]	anything at all
[illegible]	who	[illegible]	anyone and everyone
[illegible]	where	[illegible]	wherever
[illegible]	when	[illegible]	whenever
[illegible]	how	[illegible]	however ("in whichever way")

It should be noted that while technically, as with [illegible], particles come between the question word and [illegible], it is not uncommon to place them after the combination of interrogative + [illegible]:

[illegible] + [illegible] can become either [illegible] or [illegible]
[illegible] + [illegible] can become either [illegible] or [illegible]
[illegible] + [illegible] can become either [illegible] or [illegible]
[illegible] + [illegible] can become either [illegible] or [illegible]

However, for most of these combinations there tends to be a preference for one or the other, so english tends to be preferred over [illegible], while [illegible] tends to be preferred over [illegible].

english — english

This particle should not be confused with a loose combination of [illegible] and [illegible], such as in the following sentences:

[illegible]
"It seems like there's something written on Ishikawa's (something)."

[illegible]
"Let's have that tasty looking one."

However, as a 'fixed' combination particle [illegible], the interpretation is rather different:



“Despite being only 10 years old, (she)’s incredibly proficient at playing the piano.”

(note that, in this sentence, the preceding is the form of the copula)

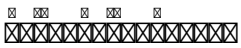
What happens here is that sets up a fact, about which a commentary is made, with the fact marked as details to the commentary by using . In this use, the commentary is always something constrasting or unexpected/unlikely.

english — english

This particle is used in the same way as english or english, acting as a noun lister. When used, it sets up a english, and because it’s representative only, it can be used for either a single term, or for multiple terms:



“(I) hate things like sashimi.”

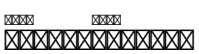


“(I) went to buy stuff like food and drinks.”

english — english

This is a rough listing particle, similar to in use. This particle has come from through to the current english. Like , it can be used either for listing, or for single representative statements.

The colloquial version of this particle is, somewhat surprisingly, english. This colloquial version is not used for the listing version of , but only for its single use:



“(I) don’t care for (things like) cheap stuff.”

english — english

This particle indicates an element of english in the speaker, such as for instance:

□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“It looks like (we) somehow made it in time, doesn’t it?”

It acts similar to □, used after english to create a vaguely specific answer to the interrogative:

□□ □□ □□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“There seems to be something white floating (there).”

This has the same meaning as □□□□□□□□□□□□, but is considered more formal literary. Other than □□, forming □□□□, there are essentially no interrogatives that are used with □□ in spoken Japanese.

english, english — english

This particle is used to estimate an extent of quantity, duration, frequency or even reasoning:

□
A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
A: “(I) need to read about 50 pages for now.”

□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
B: “Let (me) read for about 30 minutes.”

□□□□ □□□
C: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
C: “(I) read about 3 hours a day.”

□
D: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□
D: “(I) understand that much (now explain the parts I don’t understand yet).”

The difference between the normal unvoiced version, □□□, and the voiced version, □□□, is that the second is a more colloquial, relaxed version of the first. This means that the context in which they’re used is subtly different. The best way to get a feel for which to use when is to hear them used often enough.

english, english — english

While ◎◎◎ is used for estimation of extent, ⊠⊠ is used for estimation of a moment in time. For instance "I need to be at work around 9" would be an instance where ⊠⊠ rather than ⊠⊠⊠ would be used, since this does not concern some measurable extent, but a clock time.



"Mom said she'd come to pick (us) up around 3."

Similar to ⊠⊠⊠, the use of ⊠⊠ vs. ⊠⊠ is mostly dictated by whether or not it's okay to use a colloquially relaxed version. Again, the best way to learn when this is is to hear it used often enough to get a feel for it.

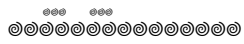
english, english, english — english, english

⊠⊠, and its voiced and stopped versions ⊠⊠ and ⊠⊠⊠ are used to "single things out". They've come from english, to cut, and this is an indication of how they're used. Added to a clause, it indicates that a "this and only this" clause is in effect. To make this a bit more clear, a few examples:



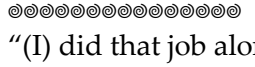
"(I) have been to Japan (only) once."

Here the act of "going to Japan" has been performed once, and ⊠⊠ is used to indicate that this once is understood as "once and only once", rather than the "once" as used in for instance "I've been there once when it was hot, and …" which actually doesn't preclude having gone to a place multiple times.



"(I) did that job all (alone) by (myself)."

Here, ⊠⊠ is used to make it explicit that there was no one else to even do the job other than "myself". If we compare this sentence to a similar sentence that uses ◎◎ instead we see:



"(I) did that job alone."

We see that this sentence doesn't actually rule out the possibility that others may have been available to help out, and that in this case we did it ourselves for whatever

reason. In contrast, the line with ⬚⬚ says that at the time of doing this job, there was just me, and no one else.

"(I)'ve only met that person once, (I) haven't been with them since."

Here ⬚⬚ is used to indicate that the event of meeting this person was a singular event.

The difference between using ⬚⬚, ⬚⬚ and ⬚⬚⬚ is mainly a colloquial one, related to 'what sounds good'. In colloquially relaxed speech, ⬚⬚ will work better than ⬚⬚, and if one wants to put extra emphasis on the "singling out", ⬚⬚⬚ works better than ⬚⬚. It is mostly a question of hearing it often enough to develop a feel for which is best in which setting.

english — english

This particle is used to indicate some equal distribution of something, over something else. For instance "These oranges are 80 yen a piece" or "Every pair will share 1 book". In the first line, there's an equal distribution of price over every orange:


"Oranges are 80 yen a piece."
literally: "Oranges are per one (being the same for each), 80 yen."

In the second line, there is an equal distribution of how many items are distributed over a certain number of people, using …⬚…⬚⬚:


"Each pair will (have to) share one book."
literally: "As for the books, to two people, one book (to each group of two) will be shared"

english — english, english

This particle can be considered similar in function to english, except instead of just likening two things to each other, ⬚⬚ can also "shift" the properties of the original to the instance it is suffixed to instead. This may sound a bit strange, so an example will hopefully make it clearer:


A: ⬚⬚⬚

A: “Ah, I’m sorry, Not looking at where I was going and just walking into you like that…”
B: “No, no, it should be me who should be apologising. If I had paid more attention to what was going on…”

Aside from an embarrassing moment, speaker B uses ▨▨ with ▨▨▨ (which is used to refer to himself in this case) to make the act of apologising apply to him more than to speaker A, thus “shifting” the need to apologise from A to B instead. ▨▨ can also be used on its own, in which case it is perceived as contrasting the stated to everything else, typically being translatable with “exactly” or “precisely”:

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
“But that’s precisely why (I) came over.”

english — english, english, english

▨▨ is used to conceptualise something as real, be it english*glossary* or english*glossary*. Because of this, it can fulfil a few roles, such as listing an experience:

▨▨▨ ▨▨▨ ▨▨ ▨▨ ▨▨
▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
“We were raised properly when we were children.”

Here ▨▨ indicates that ▨▨▨▨▨ is a real, albeit intangible, thing. Because it is past tense, the only real thing it can be is the speaker’s own experience. When used with present tense, the only way intangible things can be real is if they are somehow common place, or social customs:

▨▨ ▨▨▨
▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
literally: “It is a thing to ‘not be a bother to people’.”
“One should not cause problems for others.”

Colloquially, ▨▨ can be shortened to ▨▨, but this typically makes the speaker sound “childish”:

A: ▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
B: ▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨

A: “Why the heck do you always eat anpan?”
B: “Because I like it.”

english — english

The particle ◎◎ is actually the expression english with the verb left off. This construction is used to indicate something 'might be' the case, and is used quite frequently in every day language:

A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

A: "Eh? You're going to buy it? Don't you think it's (a little) expensive?"
B: "Maybe… But then again, isn't it exactly (what we want)?"

There is no functional difference between using □□ and using □□□□□□□, although again the "the longer it is, the more formal polite your speech" rule applies, so □□ is less formal than □□□□□ which is less formal than □□□□□□, which in turn is less formal than □□□□□□□. Typically, you'll either use ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎ or ◎◎.

4.2.4 Enrichment

The following set of particles conists mostly of "interesting" particles, and rare or literary particles that you may encounter every now and then. However, they go well beyond basic Japanese and you can safely ignore them if you wish. They have been included mostly for completeness, given that you will invariably run across them every now and then while reading Japanese books or manga, or watching Japanese films or TV.

english — english, english

Typically used preceded by english, □□ is yet another "even", being similar to □□, or □□. However, where □□ means "only" in the "just" way, □□ means "only" in the "at least"/"as long as only" way:

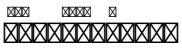
□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Even children know this."

□□□ □□□□ □□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Even Confucius was not free of flaws."

□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"As long as (you) (just) have money, (you) can take it easy."

english — english

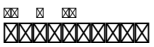
This particle is related to ⊠⊠ in a way similar to how ⊠⊠ and ⊠⊠ are related, and is followed by a negative to express a "not even" construction:


"(I) cannot even write a letter to (my) satisfaction."

This particle is considered rather literary.

english — english

This particle, while a combination of ⊠ + ⊠, doesn't actually act as a similarity marker as you might expect, but instead is actually used to stress the preceding noun or noun phrase in a sentence:


"It's (exactly) as you say."

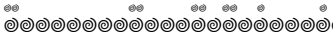
This particle comes after ⊠⊠⊠ constructions.

english — english/english, english

This particle can mean two things, depending on whether it's used on its own or as a two-item "list":


"When (you)'re troubled, (you) should talk to either (your) mother or father."
literally: "When troubled, the concept is to consult (your) father or mother."

This list use is very different from the singular use:


"Because (she) was tired, (she) went to bed the moment (she) got home, without having dinner."

Here the literal translation would be "Because (she) was tired, the moment (she) got home, (she) went to bed without eating dinner."

english — english

This combination particle is quite interesting; the combination of ⊠⊠ with ⊠ is functionally equivalent to the particles english and ⊠⊠:

> ⊠MacBook ⌋ ⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚
> "Even though (I) bought a MacBook, (I) actually don't know how to use it at all."

This sentence isn't significantly different from the same sentence using ⊚⊚ or ⊚⊚:

> ⊚MacBook ⌋ ⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚
> "Even though (I) bought a MacBook, (I) actually don't know how to use it at all."

> ⊚MacBook ⌋ ⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚
> "(I) bought a MacBook. However, (I) actually don't know how to use it at all."

The similarity will typically be closer to ⊚(⊚)⊚(⊚) than to ⊚⊚, as the use of ⊠⊠ creates a factoid, and the ⊠ is used to relate the concluding remark to this factoid, in a manner that could be described as genitive:

> (「 MacBook ⌋ ⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚) ⊚ (⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚)
> ("I bought a MacBook")'s ("I do not know how to use it at all")

english — english

This is simply the sentence ending ⊠⊠, used to indicate a custom or social expectation of sorts, followed by the question particle english in its "Like I …" meaning:

> ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
> "Like (I) would (be expected to) know something like that!"

As mentioned in the explanation of ⊠, this is one of the rare instances where you will nearly always be able to translate the construction with an exclamation mark, due to the use of this particularly expressive ⊠. Notice that this sentence is almost the same as:

> ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
> "Like (I) would know something like that!"

The only difference is that the use of ▨▨ makes the statement question the expectation, rather than the act:

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"Like (I) know something like that!"

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"Like (I) (should) know something like that!"

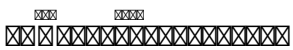
english — english

This is just the particle ▨▨, used to indicate a custom or social expectation, paired with the continuative form of the copula, english, to create an implicit reason:

▨▨▨ ▨▨▨▨ ▨▨▨ ▨▨ ▨▨
▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨

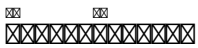
english — english, english

This particle is typically used in the pattern […], to indicate an english:



"Being this busy, it's impossible (for me) to go on a trip."

It can also be used in a way similar to english to indicate an extent:



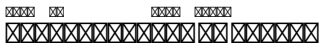
"No need to cause a fuss over this problem."

This sentence is somewhat hard to properly translate due to , and a more literal translation would be "this isn't [something that should be] caused a fuss [over] to the extent that [you are] troubled".

This is technically a voiced version of english, which will be treated in the section on nominalisers in the chapter on language patterns.

english — english

This particle is somewhat akin to english, except it only applies to events or circumstances, and is much stronger than . It creates a construction that can be translated with "Instead of …, [something which implies the total opposite]" by following the :



"Instead of going out with (my) friends, (I) spent the entire night working on (my) homework."

english — english

This particle hangs somewhere between english and english when making a list. It creates a list of items, but also implies that this list is english of something. For instance:



"Dogs, cats, we keep all sorts of pets."

While the list doesn't actually imply that there may be more than just dogs and cats, unlike , the list alone is already considered something representative of, in this case, "all sorts of". And unlike , this list doesn't have to be inclusive. It could be that whoever says this may also have birds and rabbits, but then again, they may just as well not.

english — english

This is the literary equivalent to the instrumental and location of an event marking particle □ (but not the □□□ for □□).

english — english

This is a reasonably simple combination of the particle english and the disambiguating particle english, but it deserves special mention because a lot of people new to Japanese abuse it a lot, using □□ instead of just □. A good example of this would be for instance:

□□
□□□□□□□□□□
"There is a book on the table."

There will be people who after a while start to ignore that this is a proper sentence, and instead say things like:

□□□□□□□□□□□
"There is a book on the table (as opposed to the floor, or the couch, or the shelf, or whatever context it might be contrasted to)."

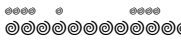
It should always be remembered that □□ disambiguates. It doesn't just specify a location or point/frame in time, but also adds a contrast between this location or time and every other. This is a very important distinction that you should try not to forget. If you're tempted to use ◎◎, first ask yourself if you actually need to disambiguate anything. If not, just use □. Don't use the additional ◎ because you think it "sounds good", because it adds a lot of extra meaning that you probably don't intend to add. That said, a proper use would for instance be:

□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(We) don't have those kind of things here."

In this sentence, the □ makes sense, because no doubt there will be other places where "those kind of things" can in fact be found. Just not "here".

english — english

This particle is similar to english in that it is used to talk about two actions taking place in succession. It can be translated as 'english' or 'english'. It's a relatively rare particle, but then that's what enrichment is all about. It follows ◎◎◎ constructions:


“No sooner than they had graduated, they got married.”

This is considered a fairly literary particle, and is found more in writing than in speech.

english — english

While considered a colloquial emphatic version of english, this particle is actually a contraction of the copula english and the classical particle english, which has functionally been replaced in modern Japanese by english/english.


“Even grandpa knows that.”

In this role, it’s not really different from ◎◎.

◎◎◎ can also be used in a listing fashion, in which case it stands for a pattern similar to “english […], it’s all the same”:


“You, me, we’re all friends.”

(the translation of ◎◎ is actually more nuanced than ‘friend’, referring to being part of the in-group)

As can be seen from this sentence, the final clause applies to all the “items” listed using □□□ in this fashion.

A final role played by □□□ is as sentence ending particle, in which case it acts as a english that the speaker is surprised about:


“(She) said it was because (she) had a date with him on Saturday. Hadn’t those two broken up?”

In this sentence the speaker expresses a surprise over hearing what is being quoted, and explains this surprise with the following sentence. Notice that these are two separate sentences; the full stop is very much required after □□□ in this use.

english — english

Similar to how □□□ is considered a variant of □□, □□□ is considered a variant of the verbal — english. Just like the □ form, this "particle" contracts with verbs whose —□/—□ forms have contractions, so for instance □□, "play", becomes □□□□□.

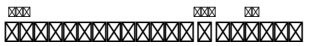

"Even if (you) say so now, it's too late (now)."

Also, when written as english this particle stands for the contraction of □□□□□. Used in this way, its meaning is similar to □□□□□ or □□□□:


"It's pointless to try to fix it now."

english — english

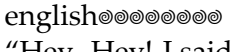
A combination of □□ + □, this compound particle expresses "english …", "english …" similar to english.


"Because (I) I hadn't been expecting it, (I) was most delighted."

Literally, this sentence uses the noun form for 'being delighted'.

english — english

This particle is a contraction of english, and like the next particle, is used to catch someone's attention if you've been talking to them and they're being unresponsive. This is a very informal way to grab someone's attention as well as to point out that they should listen to you:


"Hey. Hey! I said hey!"

english — english

This particle is a contraction of english ("when talking about …") and is often used to grab someone's attention, similar to ⊠⊠⊠:


"Hey, are (you) listening or what? Helloooo? I said, hello!?"

english — english

This particle is essentially the question word english paired with the quoting particle english, to create an emphatic "what" such as in "what a pretty bird" or "you did what??":


"What a pretty starry sky."

A special word involves this particle paired with -◎◎, the ⊠⊠⊠ for ⊠⊠, forming the word english, meaning "english":


A: "Why did (you) hit (him)?"
B: "Eh, (I) just felt like it."

(This is a semantic translation, literally B says "For no (good) reason", as an open sentence)

The colloquial version, english, can also be used to mean english, and is typically used in an exclamatory fashion:


"What (on earth) did (you) do?"

english — english

This is just ⊠⊠ combined with the emphatic ⊠, to create a construction signifying extreme extent, similar to english:


literally: "Up to the extent of (some specific thing), (you) would do so?"
meaning: "(You) would go that far?"

can be used with the question words (when) and (where) to create the words english, meaning "up to any moment in time" ("until when") and english, meaning "up to any place" ("up till any place"):


literally: "Up to which moment in time do you intend to watch TV?"
meaning: "Just how long do (you) plan on watching TV?"

Note that when is paired up with a verb in form, is split up:

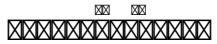

literally: "Up till any point you can hypothetically look at, it's blue sky."
meaning: "No matter where (you) look, it's blue skies."

english — english

Similar to , indicates only one course of action or only one option:


literally: "Having come this far, there is nothing to be done other than continue."
meaning: "Having come this far, we can only press on."

For this role, is often found in the pattern english, meaning "nothing other than …", used adjectivally (remember that the is attributive as well as sentence ending in modern Japanese):


"This is something only he can do."

4.3 Translating english

Japanese doesn't really have prepositions like a lot of western languages do. You've already seen that quite a few particles fulfil the role that prepositions play in other languages, but this still leaves the question of how to say something in Japanese that in

western languages uses prepositions that are not covered just by particles. For this reason, this final "particles" section will cover translating english.

There are two categories that preposition translations fall under. The first is the list of prepositions that have particle or verb construction counterparts, though since you have already encountered these in the previous sections, these will not be treated in detail. The other category is those prepositions that have temporal or location nouns as their Japanese counterparts. I say conceptual because some concepts that are multiple words in western languages are the same conceptual temporal/location noun in Japanese. These nouns will be treated in more detail and will, where needed, be accompanied by examples.

4.3.1 english

English preposition	Translated into Japanese using…
english	□ in its role as indirect object
english	□ or □, depending on whether it concerns a thing or an event.
english	□ or □, depending on whether it concerns location or instrumentalis
english	□□
english	□□□ particles □□□ or □□□ for strict or loose simultaneous action, □□ for atemporal, or verb continuative (□ form)
english/english	□□, □□ or □□
english	Either the indirect object □ or the nominalising □□□□
english	Either the indirect object □ or □□
english	□
english	A resultant state form of verbs that denote "to go off of"
english	□□, □□
english	□
english	□ as indirect object, □ as destination, or □ as direction
english	□
english	This is done with either a verb in □□□+□, or using (□□□) □□□/□□□

4.3.2 english

The conceptual nouns used to stand for what in western languages is done using prepositions, are all used in the following pattern:

english

where [X] can be any noun or verb clause, [Y] is a conceptual noun, and [Z] a verb activity or a state. The □ in this pattern is enclosed in parentheses, because it can be omitted

in some cases, but has to be used in others. Typically, when [X] is a noun phrase, □ is used, and when it is a verb phrase, □ is omitted, but there are exceptions to this; each conceptual noun entry in the list below will show the pattern(s) it can be used in.

To illustrate this pattern before we move on to the list itself, let us replace [X] with □, station, [Y] with □, before, and [Z] with □ □□□, "there is a store". Doing so, we get the following sentence:

□□□□□□□□□
"station" [genitive] "before" [location] "there is a store"

The natural translation, "There is a store in front of the station", follows readily from this pattern.

As a note, the choice of whether to use □ or □ is dependent on whether a location or an event is focused on. In the previous example a location was focused on, but if we were to use the same sentence with [Z] being replaced with □□□□□□□, "(I) met (my) friend", then we get a sentence that can focus on the event "meeting", and this focus can be made explicit by using □ instead of □:

□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I) met (my) friend in front of the station."

4.3.3 The conceptual nouns list

english — english, english, english, english

The kanji for this word already hints at the fact that this noun signifies a conceptual location 'above' something. It does not literally mean any of the words "above", "on", "up", "english" or the likes, but simply implies them all, given a specific context. For instance:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"There is a beautiful flower arrangement on the table."

Since flower arrangements typically rest on a surface, □ in this case means "on". However, if we look at the following sentence, we see a different context, and a different meaning:

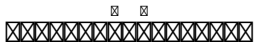
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"There's a window above the table."

Since windows don't typically rest on surfaces but are part of walls, □ can only be interpreted as meaning "above" in this context.

english — english, english, english, english

In the same way that means the conceptual location above something, means a conceptual location below something. Again, context dictates what preposition is best used in the translation:


“There’s a cat underneath the table.”


“There are drawers under the table.”

In the first sentence, refers to well under the table, on the floor, while in the second sentence means on the underside of the table itself.

english — english

Having covered above and below, the two orientation directions left and right. First up, right:


“The post office is to the right of the station.”

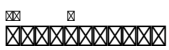
english — english

And then, of course, left:


“The post office is to the left of the station.”

english — english, english, english

When referring to something before, or preceding, something else, the conceptual noun is used. This can be used for both time and space:


“(I) waited in front of the station.”

This example, similar to the one given in this section’s pattern explanation, states

something being in front of some location. If instead we want to indicate something as happening or being the case before some verb activity, then □ follows the □□□:


“(I) cleaned up before going out (on errands).”

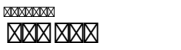
In this sentence, the event “going out [on errands]”, □□□□, indicates a particular time, even if it’s not sharply defined like clock times.

english — english, english

There’s one more “front” that has a special word for it in Japanese: the facing side of something. For instance, the title side of a book’s cover is the ◎, the ‘store front’ side of a store is the □, and the front side of a T-shirt is the □.

english — english

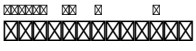
The conceptual noun □ means several different things depending on its use, and has different pronunciations for each different use. When used directly after nouns that denote some activity, it is pronounced □□□, and is used to indicate that the verb action or verb state that follows it applies during the period that the activity noun describes. This may sound a bit abstract, so an example:


“(I) am in the middle of a delivery.”

Clearly a delivery takes time to perform, and the □ indicates that something is the case, or takes place, during this time.

english — english, english

When used with location nouns, the meaning for □ changes to “cross-…” such as “cross-country” or “nation-wide”, and the reading changes to □□□, such as in for instance:


“The world over, people are born and people die.”

english — english, english, english, english, english, english

And finally, when used in the pattern that does not have omitted, is pronounced , and can mean a wide variety of things that are associated with being located inside something. When focusing on locations, is used as the follow up particle, but when refers to abstract concepts such as "amidst [a collection]" or "among [things]", it is followed by english instead, such as in for instance:


"From (amongst) food, (I) like Japanese food best."

Here refers to something being located inside a category. Since this is an abstract location, the particle is used. However, when there is no abstract location but a real location, like the hollow of a tree, or the inside of a box, is used:


literally: "There was a watch in the box"
meaning: "The box contained a watch."

The pattern english will be explained further in the constructions section, when dealing with open choices - something that quite obviously requires being able to indicate something as existing within a greater (abstract) collection.

english — english

The noun is used to indicate that something is located behind something else. Be careful though: unlike , which corresponded to "before" both in the location and time sense, only means "behind", and stands for a location; it cannot be used to mean "after" in the context of time. To indicate the concept of "after", a different noun () is used, which can be pronounced in three different ways, meaning three slightly different things.

An example of the use of would be:


"The mice hid behind the refrigerator."

english — english, english side

Much like how is a special kind of , , is a special kind of , meaning "the non-facing side" of something. For instance, the side of a book's cover that doesn't carry the title is the , the back of a store is the , and the back side of a T-shirt is the .

english, english, english — english

When indicating something happens after a certain time or event, □ is used. However, depending on whether this "after" refers to "occurring at some time after", or "occurring from then on" a different pronunciation is used; when one only wishes to indicate something will happen after some specific time or event, the reading for this noun is □□:

□□□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□
"(I)'ll do (my) homework afterwards."

In this sentence the act of "doing homework" will be done at some point after some contextually implied event, typically whatever the speaker is doing at the moment of saying a sentence like this. On the other hand, when indicating that something will stay in effect after some specific time or event, the reading for this kanji is □:

□□□ □ □ □ □□
□□□8□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(My) job ends at 8, after that (I)'ll be available."
literally: "…, after that is leisure."

Because the reading for the noun □ is □ in this sentence, it clearly states that this person won't be free for just a while after 8 o' clock, but will be free from 8 o' clock onwards until some indeterminate time (being probably when they go to bed).

There is a third reading for □, being □□, but this is a literary reading used as a replacement for □□, with as extra feature that it can be used to stand for "the afterlife"; the ultimate concept of "afterwards". However, this reading is also used in the common formal time indicator english meaning "english", "english", "english" or even "english".

english — english, english

The opposite of ◎, □ stands for the broad and undefined location that is the world outside:

□□ □□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Our cat's playing outside."
literally: "… outside the house."

english — english

Literally, this noun stands for the concept of "in an interval", where this interval can be either temporal or spatial:



"There are public phones located between the bank and the post office."
literally: "… in the interval (bank - post office)."

As can be seen from the example, the list of locations between which some verb action occurs, or some verb state is the case, is created using the standard inclusive noun listing particle .

For time, on the other hand, the english pattern is used, because this lets us specify an interval with an explicit beginning and end:



"The culprit (managed to) escape between the hours of 2 and 3."

english — english

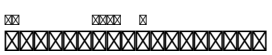
This is actually the noun form of the verbal adjective english, 'near', and is used for locations only. This noun is (fairly intuitively) used to indicate something is close to some location or object:



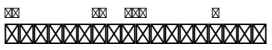
"It's close to the cinema."

english — english, english, english, english

In Japanese the idea of "across", "opposite from" and "beyond" are all variations on the same theme of something facing something else: something opposite to us clearly faces us, something that is for instance across the street faces us from across the street and something that lies beyond the darkest night is something that faces us from this theoretical location:



literally: "I expect my friends to be waiting …"
"(My) friends should be waiting for [me] across the street."



"(I) heard that across the ocean lies a different world."

english — english, english

The noun □ literally means “english”, and when used as a conceptual location noun, means “near”, “english”, and the like:

□□□□ □□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) lost (my) wallet somewhere near the fish shop.”

english and english — english, english

While in most western languages when two objects are placed side by side, they are said to be “beside” or “next to” each other, Japanese requires you to pick the right word for this spatial relation depending on whether or not these two objects are of a similar category. For instance, placing two apples or two bikes next to each other means you can use the noun □ to indicate that one is next to the other:

□□ □□□□□ □□□□ □
□□□□□□□ □ □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“I left my bike standing next to my (younger) brother’s.”

This is perfectly valid use of □ (not to mention valid use of □ for back referral, immediately followed by □[location noun]), as the two objects in question are clearly of the same category.

However, for the following example we need to use □ instead of □:

□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“Everyone was playing games and stuff next to the pond.”

(note that using □ stresses the location rather than the act in this sentence)

Here, since □□□ are of a category “people”, and □ is of category “pond”, there is no way □ can be used, since these two things aren’t even remotely alike. In effect, □ can be thought of as not just meaning “next to” but having the added meaning “next to the other [object category]”, while □ only means “beside” or “next to”.

Compass directions

In addition to the obvious locations, there are four more that are usually overlooked: the compass directions.

direction	noun
english	english
english	english
english	english
english	english

And of course their permutations:

	NE
	NW
	SE
	SW

english — english

This is not so much a conceptual noun as a suffix for several of the nouns listed so far. Suffixed to various of these words, signifies "side", so that means "above", but means "the top side" (although it is then pronounced); means "right", but means "the right (hand) side". The list of nouns modified in this way is:

noun	side	meaning
	english	the english
	english	the english
	english	the english, the english
	english	the english, the english
	english	the english
	english	the english
	english	the english
	english	the english
	english	the english, the english
	english	the english
	english	the english
	english	the english
	english	the english

4.4 In Summary

And so we've reached the end of the particles chapter. This chapter covered quite a number of particles, some of which are essential, some of which good to know, and some of which are downright rare, as well as showing you which constructions to use when particles aren't used.

What does this leave? While we've certainly covered enough particles to last you quite a while in your study of Japanese, there's one particular kind of particle that wasn't covered in this chapter, the counter particle. This isn't really just one particle, but a category of particles, with a basic set that is large enough to warrant an entire chapter being dedicated to them. In order to do any kind of counting in Japanese, a knowledge not just of numbers, but also of counter particles is essential, and we shall be looking at this in the next chapter.

Chapter 5

Counters and counting

Counting in Japanese is everything but apparent or easy if you're used to western counting. To count in Japanese, two things are required: a number, and a categorical marker that indicates what is actually being counted. This makes counting in Japanese not just a matter of knowing which words stand for which numbers, but also which counters stand for which countable categories.

The categorical marker for items is usually not the item noun itself, but a different word acting as categorical counter particle instead. For instance, bottles, pencils and legs are all counted using the categorical counter for "long round object", and birds are counted using the categorical counter for "things with wings". However, clock hours are counted using the specific counter for hours, and the number of times something happens is counted using the specific counter for occurrences.

The challenge is then to learn three things in order to successfully count in Japanese:

1. which numbers exist and how to construct numbers yourself,
2. which specific and categorical counters exist, and
3. which to use when you don't actually know which you should use.

Just like for regular particles, there exist dictionaries that contain lists and lists of which word can be used as a counter for which category of items, and if you wish to become a counting machine, it is recommended that you buy one and go over the lists in it as you will not find a truly exhaustive list here. Instead, the following list will only contain those counters that are considered reasonably essential to know in order to do basic counting (and that's already quite a few).

5.1 english

Before we look at the counter particles, let's briefly look at counting itself. In the outline on Japanese, I mentioned three different ways to count from one to ten, and this

comes from the fact that Japan, while it borrowed the Chinese kanji and readings, also had its own language prior to knowing anything about China. Not surprisingly then, counting was done with completely different words in pre-China Japan. However, unlike this pre-China native Japanese counting system, the Chinese derived series for one through ten is reasonably simple:

number	written and pronounced
1	english, □ in formal writing.
2	english, □ in formal writing.
3	english, □ in formal writing.
4	english — More commonly pronounced □□, a native Japanese reading.
5	english
6	english
7	english — More commonly pronounced □□, also a native Japanese reading.
8	english
9	english
10	english, □ in formal writing.

The reason why 1, 2, 3 and 10 have special formal kanji stems from the use in legal documents, where changing an □ into a □ or □ into □ was rather easy, while turning an □ into a □ or a □ into a □ was a lot harder. There are similar counterparts for 4 through 9, but these are rarely used: □, □, □, □, □ and □ respectively. Larger numbers in the Chinese system are written either using Arabic numerals (like 1,890,298,345), or — when they're decently clean or small enough to write out in full — written in kanji.

Using kanji forms to english relies on a fairly simple rule of composition, as you should be able to tell from the following examples:

20 = 2 × 10 = □□
90 = 9 × 10 = □□

100 = english, formally written as □
120 = 100 + (2 × 10) = □□□
780 = (7 × 100) + (8 × 10) = □□□□

1000 = english, formally written as □
1300 = 1000 + (3 × 100) = □□□
4826 = (4 × 1000) + (8 × 100) + (2 × 10) + 6 = □□□□□□□

10000 = english, formally written as □.

The rules for composition are actually reasonably close to the western system of writing large numbers, except that instead of replacing the english (the "1" in 1, 10, 100, 1000, etc.) with the factor ("2" in 20, "8" in 800, etc.), the english is simply added in front of the order, effectively indicating a multiplier.

However, one significant difference is found in english: in western systems we raise by a power of 1000 for large numbers (i.e. a million is 1000 × 1000, a billion is 1000 × 1000 × 1000, etc.), but in the Chinese counting system large numbers are powers of ⊠, english:

> 9,999 is ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎, 10,000 is ◎. The biggest number that still uses ◎ as highest order is 99,999,999: ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎. The number that follows this is a number equal to ◎ × ◎, called english, with a value of english. The next order number is ⊠ × ⊠, which is english. The next order number is ⊠ × ⊠, which is english.

There are in fact quite a few of these higher order counters, although of course the higher you go, the less likely people are to know the counter used, and the less meaningful the number becomes (because we cannot visualise such large numbers).

Aside from the numbers one through ten, there is also the 'number' zero, which is typically written in katakana as english when used on its own, or using the noun english when meaning "nought" or "null". An example of using ◎ is in things such as "0.0001", which can also be written as ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠, with ⊠ meaning "dot".

The english Japanese way of counting is a bit more complex:

number	pronunciation
1	english
2	english
3	english
4	english
5	english
6	english
7	english
8	english
9	english
10	english

While this doesn't look very complex, this series is also one you will likely never use as they aren't used for actual counting. It may be used when someone's trying to enumerate something from memory using their fingers, muttering "◎, ⊠, ⊠, ⊠, ⊠…" while touching fingers in succession, but that's about it. Instead, slightly different pronunciations are used when paired with counters for actual counting statements. The native Japanese read-

ings are used with only a handful of counters, but these are quite important counters: those used for general counting of items, and for counting days.

number	counting things: english	counting days: english (pronounced)
1		— special readings: and
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		
8		
9		
10		

If we ignore the reading for (for which means "the first day of the month" and means "one day (in duration/length)") we see that these two series don't use the same readings for the numbers, and that neither are quite the same as the previous table for native readings. The readings that you see for the counter can be considered the 'dominant' readings, used with a few other native Japanese ( ) counters, with the readings for being fairly unique and not used by other counters.

Before we move on to the counters list, we need to finish looking at what numbers do when paired with counters, and this involves looking at how their readings may change when they are paired with certain counters: they may contract, and the counter may become voiced. There are a few general rules that apply, although of course — as always — there are a few exceptions to these general rules (when a counter has such an exception, this will be highlighted in its section).

5.1.1 english

When followed by a counter starting with a syllable from the —, — or —column, becomes :

+ becomes
+ becomes
+ becomes

When followed by a counter starting with a —column syllable, becomes and the counter voices to a ‘p’ sound:

+ becomes

5.1.2 english

When followed by a counter starting with a —column syllable, that syllable voices to a ‘b’ sound:

+ becomes

5.1.3 english

When followed by a counter starting with a —column syllable, becomes :

+ becomes

When followed by a counter starting with a —column syllable, becomes and the counter voices to a ‘p’ sound:

+ becomes

5.1.4 english

When followed by a counter starting with a —, — or —column syllable, becomes :

+ becomes
+ becomes
+ becomes

When followed by a counter starting with a —column syllable, becomes and the counter voices to a ‘p’ sound:

+ becomes

5.1.5 english

When followed by a counter starting with a □—, □— or □—column syllable, □□□ may become □□ or □□□:

□□□ + □ can become either □□□ or □□□□
□□□ + □□ can become either □□□□ or □□□□□
□□□ + □□ can become either □□□□ or □□□□□

When followed by a counter starting with a □—column syllable, □□□ can become either □□ or □□□ and the counter voices to a 'p' sound:

□□□ + □□ can become either □□□□ or □□□□□

The choice between which of the two possible pronunciations to use is mostly one of style. The "proper" pronunciation is □□[…], but is also becoming more and more dated Japanese, with many people using the pronunciation □□□ these days. Depending on whose company you are in, you'll have to pick the pronunciation that will raise fewest eyebrows.

5.1.6 How many?

In addition to counting statements such as "three oranges" or "seven samurai", it also helps if we know how to ask "how many oranges?" or "how many samurai?". This is done using two question words: english, pronounced □□—, and english, pronounced □□—. These are used in the same way that numerals are used, being paired with a counter to turn it into a questioning statement. Different counters use different question words, with the rule generally being that if native Japanese readings are used with the counter, the question word will be □—, whereas if Chinese readings are used with the counter, the question word will be □. Thus, we can ask for "how many oranges?" by using □□:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"How many oranges are (there)?"

And we can ask how many samurai there are by using:

□□□□ □□□□
□ □□□□□□□□□
"How many samurai are (there)?"

(note the difference in verb; □□ for oranges, □□ for samurai)

english

When followed by a counter starting with a □—column syllable, the counter voices to a 'b' sound:

□□ + □□ becomes □□□□

5.1.7 The rules in summary

In summary, there are four different numeral readings:

numeral	General reading	native reading	with □	with □
□	□□	□	□□□	×
□	□	□	□□□	□□□
□	□□	□	□□□	□□□
□	□ or □□	□	□□□	□□□
□	□	□(□)	□□□	□□□
□	□□	□	□□□	□□□
□	□□ or □□	□	□□□	□□□
□	□□	□	□□□	□□□
□	□□□	□	□□□□	□□□□
□	□□□	□	□□	□□□

And the english when numerals are paired with counters:

numeral	reading	+□	+□	+□	+□
□	□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□
□	□				
□	□□	□□□			
□	□, □□				
□	□				
□	□□	□□□			□□□
□	□□, □□				
□	□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□
□	□□□				
□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□
		□□□□	□□□□	□□□□	□□□□
□	□□	□□□			
□	□□				

5.2 english

Number ranges are really easy in Japanese, involving nothing more than using □ between two numbers, so that □□□ indicates the range 1 through 7. Typically ranges like these will use actual numbers, rather than kanji forms, purely for aesthetics. While ranges in English have their own pronunciation (“X through Y” or “X to Y”), in Japanese there is no special word between the start and the end of a range:

□□□ □□□□□ □□□□□□□ □□□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
Please read chapters 11 through 20 for next class.

The construction □□□□□□□ is simply pronounced □□□□□□□□□□□□, and when the resulting written form is unambiguous, the □ symbol may even be left off, in this case forming □□□□□□ (of course, still pronounced □□□□□□□□□□□□).

The start and end of ranges can, if needed, be explicitly marked as such by using □□ and □□, but doing so carries the same difference in nuance as explicitly marking a start and end in English carries:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
Please read from chapter 11 up to chapter 20.

Rough ranges, or estimations, are even easier. These simply consist of all the numbers in the estimation, in succession (similar to rough ranges in English):

□□□□□□
□□□□□□□
“I walked 1 (or) 2 minutes.”

This can be a bit confusing when someone says something like □□□□□□□, which could either mean “I walked 11 (or) 2 minutes” or “I walked 11 (or) 12 minutes”. Disambiguation is typically left to context, so that in this case it would be odd that someone walked either 11 or 2 minutes, when the alternative is 11 or 12. However, there may be instances where more than one interpretation seems reasonable, and you’ll have to apply some analytical thinking to determine which is the correct interpretation.

5.3 english

When actually counting, or just enumerating things, we need to combine numbers with counters. This can be done in two different ways, depending on whether the focus is on the thing that’s being counted, or on the count itself:

Focus on item: [X] □ [Y] □/□ + verb
Focus on count: [Y] □/□ [X] + verb

For instance, in the statement □□□□□□□□□□□□□, translating to "please give me two oranges", the focus is on oranges (because it comes later in the sentence). If we rearrange this to form the sentence □□□□□□□□□□□□□ the focus is on the count: "oranges, give me two, please".

As mentioned, counters can be split into specific and general counter categories. Specific counters cover things like units of time or distance, and general counters cover categories like 'bound objects' or 'pieces of [something]'. Rather than just using these two categories, a list of common numerical orders, which act as counters too, is presented first. This list is followed by the other counters, split up into four categories: general article counters, counters for living things, counters for occurrences, and time related unit counters.

In addition to counters, a list of adverbs used for *glossary* is included in this chapter. While strictly speaking these are not counters, they are used when you need to quantify actions without being able to rely on a counter, such as when you "read books often".

5.3.1 Numerical counters

english — english (A hundred)

As mentioned in the section on counting, the numerical orders in Japanese are technically counters too, with their own set of pronunciations:

□	(□□)	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□	(□□□□)	□□□□	□□□□	□□□□	□□□□

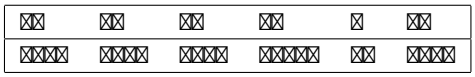
□□	□□	□□	□□	□	□□
□□□□	□□□□	□□□□	□□□□	□□	□□□□

Note that □□ isn't used unless it needs to be stressed that it's one hundred, rather than some other factor of a hundred. Also note that quite obviously "ten hundred" doesn't exist. Instead this is ◎, 1000.

english — english (A thousand)

The counter for a thousand has an irregular pronunciation for 3, and the question counter:

□	(□□)	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□	(□□□)	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□

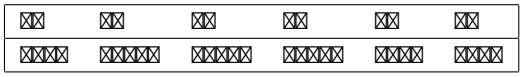


Again, unless the factor 1 needs to be stressed, rather than is used. And again, there is no "ten thousand", there is the counter instead.

english — english (Ten thousand)

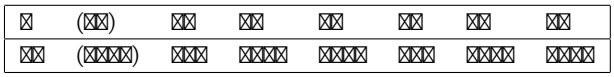
The highest "low order" order counter, stands for ten thousand. Because it is the highest "low order" order counter, it is used in combination with 10, 100 and 1000 to indicate a hundred thousand, a million and ten million respectively. 100 million is a new counter, .

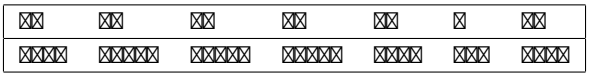




english — english (A hundred million)

The biggest "useful" number, is still a realistically large number in, for instance, prices for houses, luxury yachts or fancy sports cars. The pronunciation is wholly unremarkable:





english

While slightly ridiculous, there are counters for 10 to the power minus 21, which is the truly insignificant number 0.00000000000000000001, up to the incredibly huge number 10 to the power 68, or 100,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000. Now, while for normal purposes these are of course ridiculous numbers, they're quite useful for science. The list of all available counters, plus their western abbreviated counterparts, is as follows:

counter	value	equivalent term
□□□□□ □□	10 to the power -21	zepto, z
□□□ □□	10 to the power -20	
□□□□ □□	10 to the power -19	
□□□ □□	10 to the power -18	ato, a
□□□ □□	10 to the power -17	
□□□□□ □□	10 to the power -16	
□□□ □□	10 to the power -15	femto, f
□□□□□ □□	10 to the power -14	
□□ □□	10 to the power -13	
□□ □	10 to the power -12	pico, p
□□□ □	10 to the power -11	
□□ □	10 to the power -10	
□□ □	10 to the power -9	nano, n, 1/1,000,000,000
□□ □	10 to the power -8	
□□ □	10 to the power -7	
□ □	10 to the power -6	micro, □, 1/1,000,000
□□ □	10 to the power -5	
□ □	10 to the power -4	
□□ □	10 to the power -3	milli, m, 1/1,000, 0.001
□□ □	10 to the power -2	centi, c, 1/100, 0.01
□ □	10 to the power -1	deci, d, 1/10, 0.1

counter	value	equivalent term
□□□ □	10 to the power 1	deca, da, 10
□□□ □	10 to the power 2	hecto, h, 100
□□ □	10 to the power 3	kilo, k, 1000
□□ □	10 to the power 4	
□□ □	10 to the power 8	
□□□ □	10 to the power 12	tera, T
□□ □	10 to the power 16	
□□ □	10 to the power 20	
□□□□ □	10 to the power 24	yotta, Y
□□□ □	10 to the power 28	

counter	value	equivalent term
□	10 to the power 32	
□	10 to the power 36	
□	10 to the power 40	
□	10 to the power 44	
□	10 to the power 48	

The measures for mega (M), giga (G), peta (P) and exa (E) are missing from this set because these correspond to 10 to the powers 6, 9, 15 and 18 respectively, none of which are divisible by 4.

For orders higher than 48, there is a curious problem where in the rigid counting system the order keeps going up by 4, so that the five terms refer to 10 to the power 52, 56, 60, 64 and 68 respectively, but can also stand for older Japanese numbers, in which case they refer to 10 to the power 56, 64, 72, 80 and 88 respectively. While it is unlikely you will ever hear about these numbers ever again, these numbers have a very high trivia factor:

counter	value
english	10 to the power 52, as well as 56
english	10 to the power 56, as well as 64
english	10 to the power 60, as well as 72
english	10 to the power 64, as well as 80
english	10 to the power 68, as well as 88

5.3.2 General counters for articles

english — english

The first counter in this list isn't actually a counter, but an ordinal prefix. It's quite frequently used, so it's important you've learned it, and it's relatively easy to wrap your head around: if some counter statement says "… somethings", then prefixing □ to it will create the statement "the …th something" or "something (number) …":

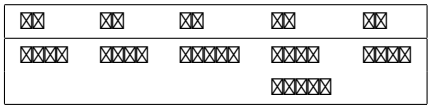
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"This book has 17 chapters."

□□□□□□□□□□, □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Chapters 1 through 10 are easy, chapters 11 through 17 are hard."

english — english

When you want to count cylindrical objects like pencils, bottles, or arms, 本 is used. As a noun this word means "book" or "origin", but as a counter it obviously means something completely different. The pronunciations for this counter are:





An example of its use is counting bottles of cola on the table:

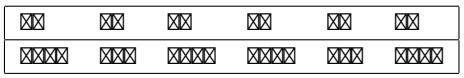

"How many bottles are there?"

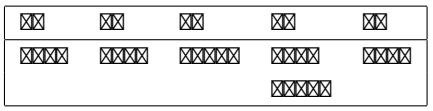

"There are 3 bottles of cola on the table."

Interestingly, phone calls can also be counted using this counter, the "logic" behind this being that telephone horns used to also be cylindrical (think of the classical phone with a rotary number dial).

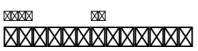
english — english

This counter is used for counting bound objects like books, magazines, notebooks and the like. The pronunciations are:





And an example of use would be:


"There are 5 books on the bookshelf."

(In this sentence, □ is used as a normal noun, not a counter.)

english — english

This counter is used to count volumes in a series of bound volumes. For instance, a twenty volume encyclopedia comprises □□□ worth of books. The difference between □ and □ is that □ only means bound volume. A stack of reading material consisting of a magazine, a newspaper, a novel and a text book on Japanese consists of □□, but since these are each completely different works, the stack does not consist of □□.

english — english

This counter is used to count sections in a (text) book, or lessons in a lesson programme. On its own, □ technically means "division", but is understood within the context of something educational, so mostly translates to chapter, lesson, section, or even (educational) department.

english — english

This counter is used to count sheet-like things, such as sheets of paper, plates, planks, or even things like folded up T-shirts. The pronunciations are:

□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□□	□□□	□□□□	□□□□	□□□	□□□□

□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□□	□□□□	□□□□□	□□□□□	□□□□
(□□□□)				

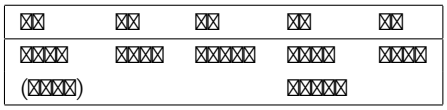
And an example of use would be:

□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"How many pages (literally: sheets) is this big book?"

english — english

This counter is used to count cups of drink, such as glasses of wine, cups of tea, glasses of beer and the like. The pronunciations are:

□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□□	□□□	□□□□	□□□□	□□□	□□□□



An example of use would be:

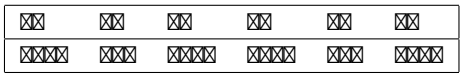


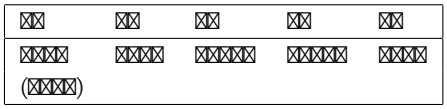
“2 glasses of red wine and 1 glass of beer please.”

Note that english can mean two things: as a counter statement it means “one cup [of something]”. However, it can also be used as a quantifier, in which case it means “plenty” or “full”, depending on the context. When used to mean “one cup”, the pronunciation drops in pitch on “◎◎◎”, whereas when it is used to mean “full”, the pronunciation has a rising pitch on “◎◎◎”.

english — english

This counter is used to count mechanical or electrical machinery of all sizes. This would include things like cars, televisions, pianos, cameras, sewing machines, and the like.





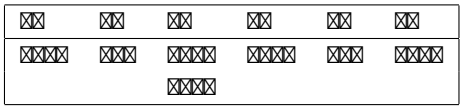
An example of use would be:

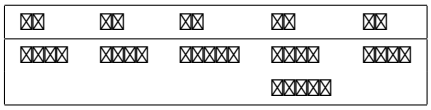


“(My) friend Hiroshi said he had three computers.”

english — english

This counter is used to count floors or levels of a building, and has a special pronunciation for 3:





An example of use would be:



“The bedrooms are on the second floor.”

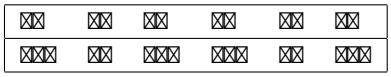
For floors underground, the prefix english (literally meaning “underground”) is added to this counter:

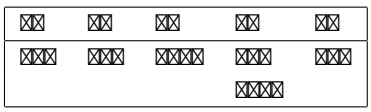


In addition, there are also two useful words to know when it comes to floors, being english, meaning “english” and english meaning “english” (a ‘floor’ between first and second floor).

english — english, english

This is a general purpose counter used to count “numbers of [something]”, such as the number of eggs needed for a specific recipe, or the number of bricks in a wall. The pronunciations are:





And example of use would be:

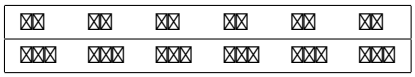


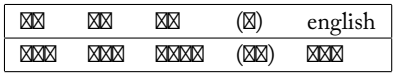
“How many eggs should (I) add?”

This counter is a typical fall-back counter when you do not know the proper counter for something, although with the note that it only makes sense for things that can be measured in units, or instances. So eggs and bricks are fine, people or thoughts are not.

english — english

This is a special english for counting items. Because this counter creates statements such as "I will have four [items]", it's typically omitted in translation because it doesn't indicate what kind of items are counted at all, merely that they are being counted. The pronunciations for this counter, as mentioned in the counting section, are what make this particle special, since it uses the native Japanese pronunciations for 1-9, and has a special question word:





Important to note is that doesn't actually have ◎ as counter at all. Also, the question word for this counter can be used not just to ask "how many items", but also "how many years [of age]" someone is, although this only applies to the age of young children, as the counter only really goes up to 10. For children that are older, as well as adolescents and adults, the regular question word (english / english), which is the question word for the counter for years of age, is used instead.

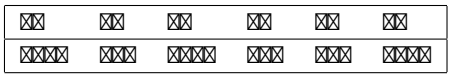
An example of use would be:

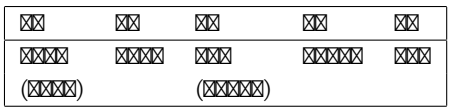


"There were 2 oranges left."

english — The english

This counter is used for english, the Japanese currency. This counter has special pronunciations for 4 and 9, and also has a special question word:





An example sentence would be:



"This pen was 50 yen."

Note the different readings ▯▯▯ instead of "◎◎◎◎" and ▯▯▯ instead of "◎◎◎◎◎". Also note that the question word for "how many yen" is actually the question word meaning "how much", and is remarkably similar to ▯▯▯ in that it can be used to refer to either quantity, duration or frequency. Thus, the question ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯, "how much do you read?", can mean three different things, reflected in the possible answers to it:

▯▯▯▯▯ ▯▯▯▯
▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯
"(I) read 1 book every 2 weeks."

▯▯▯▯ ▯▯▯▯
▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯
"(I) read 2 hours a day."

▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯
"Oh, (I) don't really read that much."

Of course, in the context of currency ▯▯▯ is always understood as meaning "how much (money)".

Other major currency counters are english, english, english, the english, and english, english.

english — english

Traditional Japanese houses, or traditional rooms in apartment buildings or flats in Japan (called ▯▯▯▯, literally 'Japanese style room'), are never counted in terms of square feet or meters, but in terms of how many tatami mats, english, it will fit. This unit of measure is one of the 'common knowledge' units of surface measure, so it's generally a good idea to know it. The size of tatami mats depends on the region, ranging from 0.955 meter by 1.91 meter in the Kyoto area to only 0.88 meter by 1.76 meter in the Tokyo area. Thus, a ▯▯ room may be bigger or smaller, depending on where in Japan you find it.

The counting table is fairly simple, with a different reading for 9:

▯▯	▯▯	▯▯	▯▯	▯▯	▯▯
▯▯▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯▯

▯▯	▯▯	▯▯	▯▯	▯▯
▯▯▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯▯
(▯▯▯▯▯)		(▯▯▯▯▯▯)		

Typically, however, there are only three counts for ▯, namely the common room di-

mensions for Japanese style rooms: english (four and a half), english and english. When indicating actual counts of individual tatami mats, such as when purchasing replacement mats or for outfitting several rooms, the counter english is used instead. The reason for this is that rather than indicating surface measure, you are now counting flat, sheet-like objects, which must of course be counted using the counter for flat, sheet-like objects.

5.3.3 Counters for living things

english — english

This counter is used to count small animals. "Small" should not be taken too literally, as this counter applies to cats, squirrels, mice, or fish just as it does to great Danes (a particularly huge kind of dog) or even moderately sized alligators.

The pronunciations are:

()				

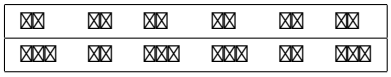
An example sentence would be:

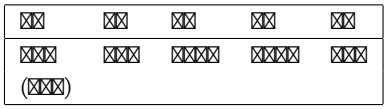
"Not even a single mouse should be able to get in (here)."

english — english

This kanji means "wings" when pronounced english, and as a counter is used to count birds. As a peculiarity, this counter can also be used to count rabbits (although is more common these days), because of an interesting bit of Japanese history: from the 6th century until the mid-19th century, Japanese people were — by decree — forbidden to eat several kinds of meat between April and October. However, birds and adult fish could still be eaten, so in order to be able to eat meat anyway, people started calling certain animals by different names, referring to them as birds or fish. Boars, for instance, became "land whales" (whales still being considered fish at the time, rather than the mammals we now know them to be), and rabbits became "birds" on account of their floppy ears, so these animals were counted using the counters that applied to these animals instead. This practice lasted until 1872, when the english embraced a number of Western views and customs, and eating meat was allowed all year round again after a more than 1300 year period of decreed abstinence. That said, rabbits can of course also be counted using .

The pronunciations for this counter are wholly unremarkable:





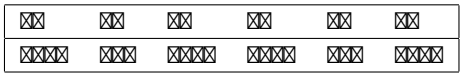
A fun example sentence for this counter is a classic:

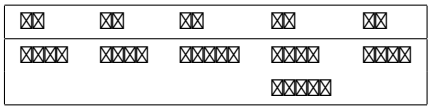

“There are 2 chickens in the garden.”

The pronunciation for this sentence is “”, which is always a good reason to use this sentence whenever appropriately possible.

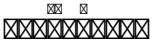
english — english

This kanji on its own means “head”, and for reasons about as inexplicable as why  is used for cylindrical objects, is used to count large animals such as sheep, cows, horses, elephants, giraffes, salt water crocodiles (which are astoundingly huge), etc. The pronunciations are:



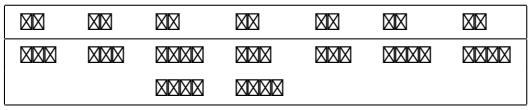


An example sentence would be:


“(I) can see 1 horse.”

english — english

It should be noted that there are special pronunciations for 1 person and 2 people, using the reading , but that 3 and up are all counted using the pronunciation :





An example sentence would be:



“Are those two (people) over there a (married) couple?”

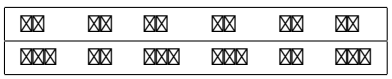
The polite counter for people, as used by, for instance, waiters or receptionists, is , which has a very polite counterpart: . However, don’t use these counters unless you find yourself serving patrons in a restaurant or something similar. For normal counting of people, stick with .

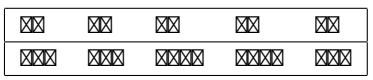
5.3.4 Occurrences and ranking

english — english, english

As a counter for occurrences, this counter is principally used only for counting once, twice and thrice. For something that occurs more than three times, is used instead.

Aside from being used for occurrence, is also used to count english, and english (such as a 90 degree angle, or GPS degrees). The pronunciations are:





Example sentences would be:



“Could you please say that one more time?”



"It's hot today, don't you think? I wonder what temperature (literally: how many degrees) it is."

This particle is also a noun on itself, pronounced english, which is used as a nominaliser for turning clauses into occurrences, which will be explained in the next chapter, in the nominalisers section.

While strictly speaking not genuinely related to counters, a special note for this counter involving the indicator , meaning "now" and read as , should be added: can either mean "now", or "next time":



"Oh, now what?"



"(See you) next time!"

english — english

Where is used for once, twice and thrice, can be used for any number of occurrences. The pronunciations are:

()				

An example sentence would be:

"(I) already tried (and failed) three times…"

The same oddity for exists, when pairing with :



"Oh, now what?"

□□□□□□□□□□
“Let’s do (that) next time.”

english — english

This counter is used to indicate a number in a ranking. This counter has a different pronunciation for 9, so the pronunciations are:

□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□□	□□□	□□□□	□□□□	□□□	□□□□

□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□□	□□□□	□□□	□□□□□	□□□□

An example sentence would be:

□□□
□□□□□□□
“I’m (up) third.”

The first count in this series, english, is the same □□ that is used in the adjectival superlative in Japanese, since it literally means “first” and thus also means “most”.

english — english

This counter is used to count issues, such as magazine or newspaper issues, or number in a series, such as room numbers on a floor, or the number of a limited series prototype car. Like □, it has a different pronunciation for 9, so the pronunciations are:

□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□□	□□□	□□□□	□□□□	□□□	□□□□

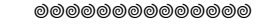
□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□□	□□□□	□□□	□□□□□	□□□□

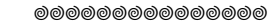
An example sentence would be:

□□□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“My parents live at number seventeen.”

The combination of □ and □, english, is used to indicate a ranked "number", such as a phone number, registration number or product serial number, where the number doesn't particularly indicate a rank on its own, but does sit at a particular position in the greater list of all numbers of its category.

It can also be used to change the number from an absolute value, such as "17 Thornhill Street" to a position in an ordered list, such as "the 17th house after you turn left":


"My parents live at number seventeen."


"My parents are the seventeenth door."

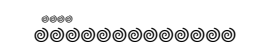
In the second sentence, "seventeenth" is understood to be from some kind of (contextually obvious) reference point, like the start of the block, or from the floor's staircase.

english — english

This is technically not a counter, but can be added to rank counters to indicate english — that is, it indicates an item's position in some ordered set. Being very specific: adding ◎ to a counter changes the count from a *glossary* number to *glossary* number.

For instance, it can be used in combination with □ to create the counter □□, changing the meaning from "… days" or "day … of the month" to "the …th day (relative to some arbitrary time)":


"We stayed at the hotel for three days."


"We stayed at a hotel on the third day."

It's also frequently combined with ◎ to create the counter english, which changes the meaning from a number in a ranking, to number of appearance. For instance, a runner with the back number "214" could be the first person to start in a relay, in which case the runner himself would be indicated using 214□□□□□□ (or 214□□□□□□) but would also be the □□□□□□□□, because he's the first runner.

Another example of this difference can be shown in the context of waiting for a bus:


“Please take the no. 5 bus at this bus stop.”

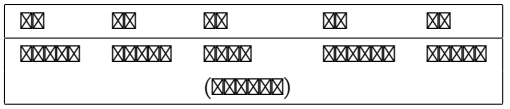

“Please take the fifth bus at this bus stop.”

5.3.5 Counting time related units

english — english

Counting seconds in Japanese uses ⊚, for which the pronunciations are:





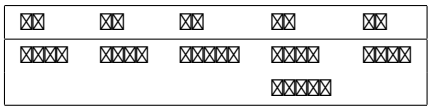
An example sentence would be:


“How long will it take? 20 seconds, half a minute?”

english - english

Moving from seconds to minutes, the counter for minutes has different pronunciations for 3, 4, and the question word:





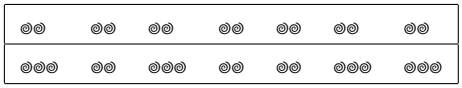
An example sentence would be:


“It’s now 5 minutes to 3.”

Also, the measure “half minute” (as used in the example sentence for seconds) is english, using the same pronunciation as for and .

english — english

Don’t confuse clock hours with durational hours. Clock hours are things like “three o’ clock” and “seven in the evening”. Durational hours are “it took 3 hours” or “I went home after waiting an hour”. This counter is for the first category and indicates the hours of the day:





Note the pronunciations for 4 and 9, both being the short pronunciations. An example sentence would be:


“What time is it?”

The indicators for a.m. and p.m. are english and english in Japanese, indicating whether a time is before or after the “hour of the horse”, which corresponds to the period from 11 a.m. to 1 p.m. according to the classical Chinese system. These are prefixed to the time:


“It is 3 p.m.”


“Let us convene at 9 a.m.”

To make the “useful words” list complete, english is english, and english is english.

english — english

By adding the durational particle □ — literally “interval” — to the counter □, we get the durational counter for hours. The difference between clock time and duration is striking:

□□□□□□□
“What time is it?”

□□□□□□□□
“How long is it?”

This difference is also very important for actual counting statements. Quite often, people starting with Japanese will mix up □ and □□, creating sentences such as the following:

□□□□□□□
“It’s three hours long.”

When they really mean to say □□□□, “it’s 3 o’ clock”. Similarly, they might say:

□□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) studied at 2 o’ clock.”

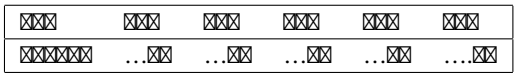
while meaning to say □□□□□□□□□□, “I studied for two hours”.

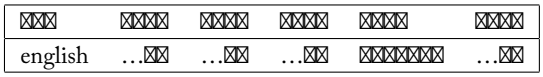
english/english — english

Moving up from hours to days, we reach a rather interesting counter. As explained before, this counter is special in several ways. Firstly, counting 1 to 10 days uses the counter □ in its pronunciation □, paired with native Japanese readings for the numbers. 14 and 24, too, use □ pronounced as □, but use a mixed Chinese/Japanese reading for the number, and “20 days” has its own special word. The rest of the days are counted using □ in its pronunciation □□, with Chinese read numbers:

□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□

□□	□□	□□	□□□	□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□□	□□□	□□□□□□□	…□□	…□□







The reading for ▯▯ differs depending on what it's used to mean: english refers to the first day of the month, but the reading english is also possible, in which case it refers to a single day in duration (including 'my day' in, for instance, "my day consists of doing …"). Also, for every other number under 32, ▯ refers to both day of the month and length of duration in days. Any number above 31 automatically only means "days of duration", since months only go up to the 31st at best. Because of this, 34, 44, etc. have the pronunciation ▯▯(▯)▯▯ instead of ▯▯▯▯.

An example sentence would be:



"(We) stayed 2 days and one night."

In this sentence a counter that won't be treated separately, english, is used which means "nights of stay".

There are two question words regarding dates; we can be either use english, which means "when", or we can use the counter question word english. We can also ask about the length of duration in days, for which we can use two question words too: english, for approximate duration, and ▯▯, for exact duration.

Aside from being able to count days, it's also good to be able to name the immediate past and future days:

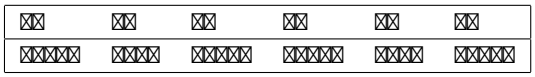
english	english (2 days before yesterday)
english	english
english	english
english	english
english	english
english	english
english	english (2 days after tomorrow)

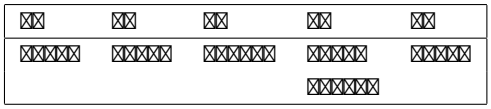
You may sometimes head the word english being used to mean "today" (or, less frequently, "yesterday" or "tomorrow"). However, this word is only used when there

is some contextual day that is tied to a specific date. The word ⬚⬚ literally means “english”, and can be taken to mean “today” (or “yesterday” or “tomorrow”) only when the event’s “day in question” coincides with “today” (or “yesterday” or “tomorrow”).

english — english

Increasing the scale further, we reach weeks, indicated with ⬚. Like ⬚, ⬚ on its own just refers to the yearly week, with ⬚⬚ referring to length of duration as measured in weeks. The pronunciations are:





An example sentence would be:



“This year’s festival is in week 18.”

The words for the immediate past and future weeks are:

english	the english
english	english
english	english
english	english
english	the english

english — english

Like ⬚, ⬚ has to be followed by ⬚ to turn it into a durational counter:



“The exams are in about two weeks.”

english — english

Like ⬚ and ⬚, ⬚ alone refers to english of the year. While western languages typically have named months, the Japanese — not too long ago in fact — gave up on named months in

favour of the Chinese system of numbered months, resulting in:

□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
english	english	english	english	english	english
January	February	March	April	May	June

□□	□□	□□	□□	□□□	□□□
english	english	english	english	english	english
July	August	September	October	November	December

The names of the months have been added here to stress that these are not so much numbered months, but calendar months. Remember them as such! Also note that there are specific readings for April, July and September. You can't use another reading for the number for these words — these "counts" are very much fixed in the Japanese language as nouns. The question word for month of the year is english.

The words for the immediate past and future months are:

english	the english
english	english
english	english
english	english
english	the english

And finally, in the interest of satisfying human curiosity, the old names for the months are:

□□	□□	□□	□□	□□	□□
english	english	english	english	english	english

□□	□□	□□	□□	□□□	□□□
english	english	english	english	english	english

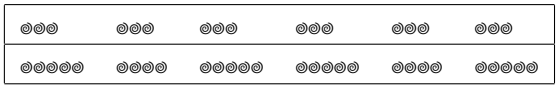
english — english

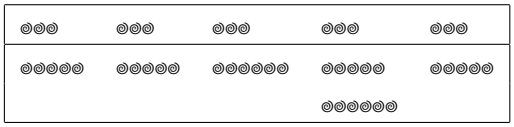
When read as □□, and paired with the native Japanese readings for numbers, this counter expresses duration in terms of lunar months, and is typically only used for indicating 1 to 3 months of duration. This is a slightly poetic counter, but is also used in formal writing to indicate the 1-3 month durational range:

□□	□□	□□
□□□□	□□□□	□□□

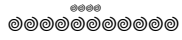
english — english

While — like □ and □ — □ on its own means "month of the year", the suffix □ cannot be used to turn □ into a durational counter. Instead, the prefix □ is used, but be careful: this is not the katakana □, but actually a simplified kanji form of □. You can tell this difference by looking at the size of the kanji: □□ (□□□) vs. □□ — the katakana □ is much bigger than the simplified version of □. Why exactly this kanji got simplified to this deceptive form is not entirely clear, but it has, which means you'll need to be able to recognise it as a counter. The standard contractions occur in the pronunciations:





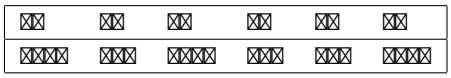
An example sentence would be:

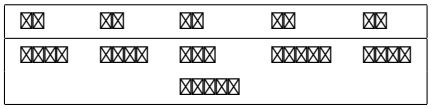


"I will be abroad for three months."

english — english

Once more, there is the distinction between years in an era, □, and years of duration, □□. The pronunciations for □ are:





An example sentence would be:



"This book is from 1877."

(The □□ era ran from 1868 to 1912, so with 1868 being the first year, the 10th year of the Meiji era is 1877 — more on this later, in the section on time and dates)

The words for the immediate past and future years are:

english	english (2 years before last)
english	the english
english	english
english	english
english	english
english	the english

english — english

Listed as a separate counter only because this counter will be relevant to you as a student of Japanese, □□ indicates "year of study", so that an □□□ is a first year student, and a □□□ is a fourth year student:

□□□□ □□□□□ □□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I) am Himura, 2nd year student at Tokyo University."

english students are referred to as english, and englishs as english.

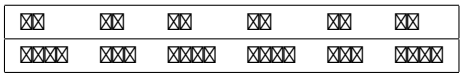
english — english

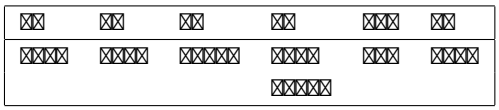
Once more, adding □ turns the counter into a durational counter:

□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(He) kept with his title (literally: 'seat') as champion for three years."

english/english — english

The one thing □ cannot be used for is to indicate years of age. For this, two special counters are used: □ and its simpler counterpart □. While simpler, it's generally not a good idea to use it in every instance where writing age is required; because it is simpler, using it is a sign that you're not quite good enough at kanji yet to write the "real" kanji form. The pronunciations are the same as for any other □-counter:





The reading ▯▯▯ for ▯▯, while technically possible, should be avoided, since it sounds identical to ▯▯, meaning "smelly/stinky". Also note that there is a special word for twenty years of age, english, just like there is a special word for twenty days, english.

An example sentence would be:



"My father will turn 61 tomorrow."

There is a special counter that is used for the ages 20 through 90, being ▯, and using native Japanese numbers (with ▯ pronounced ▯), although typically only 30 through 60 are actively used:

age	count	reading
20	▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯
30	▯▯▯	▯▯▯
40	▯▯▯	▯▯▯
50	▯▯▯	▯▯▯
60	▯▯▯	▯▯▯
70	▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯
80	▯▯▯	▯▯▯
90	▯▯▯	▯▯▯▯▯

In addition to these counts, there are numerous terms and titles associated with virtually each age, but listing all of these goes well beyond the scope of this book.

5.3.6 Additional words for english

There are also several adverbs that are used to english without relying on numbers. Some of these english can only be used with verbs or verbal adjectives in positive or negative form, and whenever this is the case, this will be explicitly mentioned.

english — english/english

As mentioned in the particle section on ⊠, this word doesn't mean two different things in Japanese, but merely gets translated with two different words depending on whether it's followed by a positive or negative verb.


literally: "(You)'re always saying only those kind of things."
meaning: "(You)'re always saying the same thing."


"Why is it (you) know (how to do it) when (you) never do it (in the first place)?"

english — english, english

When indicating something happens 'most of the time', or 'usually', ⊠⊠⊠ is used. There's not much else to say about it other than that it's usually used in combination with a positive verb form:


"(I) usually get up at 7."

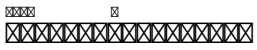
english — english

We've already covered this adverb by virtue of it being the adverbial form of ◎◎. In a quantifying role, it signifies a frequent occurrence of whatever verb it's being used with:


"(I) often swim."

english, english — english / english

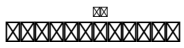
This adverb actually comes from the ◎◎ verb english, meaning "to be left over", and is the counterpart to ⊠⊠. It is typically only be used when followed by a negative verb or verbal adjective:


“(I) don’t like (red) tea very much.”

There is no real difference between english and english, but the latter sounds slightly more emphatic.

english — english

This quantifier only works when followed by a positive verbal adjective:


“This is very cheap isn’t it?”

This quantifier can be emphatically intensified by sticking a in, to form :


“That was really, really fun.”

english — english

The kanji form should already give it away, but when activities are performed from time to time, is used:


“We all go to the cinema together from time to time.”

The construction may frequently be found written as instead. The choice on whether to use a kanji or kana form depends mostly on intended style. In literary material the kanji form is preferred, while in informal writing the kana form is used more.

english — english

Like , this quantifier is usually followed by a negative verb or verbal adjective:

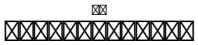

“(I) don’t mind at all.”

However, it derives its negative meaning only from these verbals — there is no rule that says this word cannot be used with affirmative verbals instead, in which case it trans-

lates to "completely". Like the ⊚⊚⊚⊚+(⊚)⊚ words, the meaning of ⊠⊠ itself is merely this "complete"-ness, connoting "not at all" only because it is paired with a verbal negative.

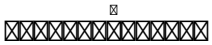
english — english, english

Like ⊠⊠⊠, this quantifier only works when followed by positive verbals:


"This is rather expensive, isn't it?"

english — english

Like ⊠⊠⊠ and ⊠⊠⊠⊠, this quantifier is typically followed by a negative verb:

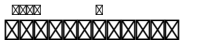

"(I) don't understand this at all."

However, on its own english just means "clean" or "neatly", again highlighting the fact that most quantifiers associated with a negative quantity only do so thanks to the negative verb form.

english — english

Literally, this quantifier means "in small part", and is usually followed by a positive verb:


literally: "Waiting for a little while is okay, isn't it?"
meaning: "Could (we) wait for just a bit?"


"I understand Japanese a little (bit)."

english — english

This quantifier can be followed by either a positive verb or verbal adjective in normal statements, or by negative verbs and verbal adjectives when used in the form of a question. When used in a negative question, the full sentence actually connotes a positive, as can be seen in the following examples:


“Isn’t it a little cold?”

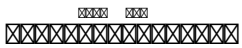

“Shall (we) take a little walk?”

Used with a positive, there is nothing remarkable to note:


“This is a bit expensive, don’t you agree?”

english — english, “english”

Mentioned in the counter section for , this quantifier can only be used with positive verbs:


“(I)’m sorry, but today is fully booked.”

Remember that this is only a quantifier if pronounced with the part in raised pitch. If pronounced with the part in a lower pitch, it means “one cup (of something)”.

english — english

Used as the comparative for adjectives, as well as comparative for verb actions, this quantifier can only be used with positive verbs and verbal adjectives:


“It looks like it’s still not enough. (Please) add in (even) more (of the) ingredients.”

english — english

This quantifier is only used with positive verbal adjectives:


“She’s much prettier than any model.”

This word actually translates to a wide spectrum of words, because of what it's composed of: the mimesis ◎ paired with ◎. This mimesis represents a straight, through and through somethingness, so that it can be translated as "very much", "completely", and even "forever", depending on the context.

english — english, english

This quantifier means "all" or "wholly" by virtue of its literal meaning "all parts":


"(I)'ve spent almost all my money."

Beginning students will often mistakenly use this quantifier when meaning ◎◎, which means "every(thing)" rather than "all", or vice versa, so make sure you picked the right one.

english — english, english

This quantifier is usually paired with positive verbs (and should not be confused with ▯▯):


"(I)'ve (sadly) read every book on (my) shelves."

5.4 english

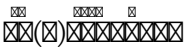
In addition to knowing what to call numbers and which particles to use for counting statements, there are two important "number" subjects that deserve special mention: telling time, and arithmetic. In this section we shall look at these two subjects in depth.

5.4.1 english and english

Times and dates are closely related subjects, so we'll treat them in one go. We've already looked at time for a bit in the counter section, where we discovered that time counters and duration counters are two different things, leading us to guess at how to properly tell time, but let's review these particles in a more specific setting of actually telling time. The Japanese time format can be represented either in a 'before noon'/'after noon' system or using the 24 hour clock (but unlike the regular concept of '24 hours', the Japanese clock can go beyond the number 24. For instance, a TV show that's on at 1:20 in the early morning, may air at 25:20 in Japan). The Japanese way of formatting times is similar to the western system, namely: first the hour, then minutes, then seconds. As an example:


5:20′50″

As mentioned in the counters section, the english and english indications in Japanese are english and english, which precede the actual time:


“(I) will come at 2:30 p.m.”

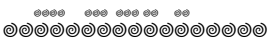
There are two things to note here. One is that is optional. It can be left out, in which case the statement is slightly less formal. In fact, the whole / indication is optional, since typically it will be obvious whether you mean in the morning or in the afternoon. The other thing to note is the use of the suffix english which indicates “half”. In Japanese, adding this indicates an additional half hour (unlike in some western languages, where the indicator ‘half’ means removing half an hour from the time):


7:30

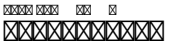
This is of course the same as saying , but using is shorter.

Unlike some western languages, Japanese doesn’t have indicators for the quarters before and past the hour. Instead, it has a “before” and “after” marker if the time is anywhere from 10-ish minutes before the hour to 10-ish minutes past the hour, and respectively. Literally, means “before” or “in front of”, and is the noun derived from the verb , “to be past (some conceptual point)”. Two examples of their use are:


“It’s already 10 past 4, are we still going to wait?”


“That programme will start 5 (minutes) to 1.”

But telling time alone isn’t everything. If you don’t want to use or , you can also say whether you mean in the english, english, english or english, by using the nouns english, english, english and english respectively:


“(I) leave the house every morning at 7.”

The prefix english, as you may remember from the outline, is a prefix used to indicate "every […]" and is used here to indicate frequent behaviour rather than just a single event. When you want to specifically refer to "this" morning, afternoon, evening or night instead, the words to use are english, [nothing], english and english respectively. There's no real reason why there is no word for "this afternoon", but there just isn't any. Instead, english meaning "today" is typically used. Also notice the readings for 'this morning' and 'this night', which might be different from what you would expect.

If we want to be more specific, we might add a date to the time we're stating. The Japanese format for this is "biggest counter first", so the format is:

era □ year □ month □ day □ (day by name)
□ hour □ minutes □ seconds

The era bit is important here, as the Japanese calendar doesn't actually correspond to the western calendar. While the Japanese will use the Gregorian calendar when necessary, the "proper" Japanese way to count years is to name the era to which you are referring, and then count the number of years since its epoch. Since these are reasonably important to know, the list of most recent eras — ordered most recent to oldest — is as follows:

The english english is the current era, which started in 1989 and will last as long as emperor Akihito remains emperor.

The english english was the era before the current era, running from 1926 till 1989.

The english english is the last most recent era still covering the 1900's, running from 1912 till 1926.

The english english is the first of the "recent" eras, starting at the Meiji restoration in 1868 running till 1912.

The numbering for eras is reasonably intuitive: the first year of an era is the year the era started. Thus, "□□ 1" corresponds to 1912, and "□□ 30" corresponds to 1955. If we write out the full date for when this section was first written, we get:

□□□□□□□□□□□(□□□□)□□□□□□□□□
Heisei 17 (= 2005), May 24th (Tuesday), 2:19′55″

While using kanji for the numerals is a perfectly valid way to write full dates, it's easier to read if numerals are used instead:

◎◎17◎5◎24◎(◎◎◎◎)2◎19◎55◎

It might also be a good idea to list the days while we're at it. The Japanese english is as follows:

english	“sun day of the week”	Sunday
english	“moon day of the week”	Monday
english	“fire day of the week”	Tuesday
english	“water day of the week”	Wednesday
english	“wood day of the week”	Thursday
english	“metal day of the week”	Friday
english	“earth day of the week”	Saturday

While many of the western days of the week derive their name from Norse mythology (more specifically, the names of the Norse gods), the Japanese — as well as several other Asian countries — use the elements for their day naming, with the sun and the moon to complete the set of seven. These two “come first”, so the Japanese week conceptually starts on a Sunday, even if the first day of the work week is Monday.

When indicating day-series such as “mon-wed-fri” in English, the Japanese use two syllable pronunciations for the days in question. However, days with only a single syllable before the ⊠⊠ part will have their vowel doubled:

⊠⊠⊠	mon-wed-fri
⊠⊠⊠	tue-thu-sat

Note that contractions occur when pairing ⊠ with ⊠, because of the ⊠ in the pronunciation for ⊠.

5.4.2 Basic english

One of the most useful things you can do with numbers is turn them into other numbers, by applying such wonderful operations as addition, subtraction, division and multiplication. These four operations sum up the basic mathematical operations one can perform on numbers, and covers what most people consider enough when it comes to doing maths. While, of course, explaining all mathematical operations is well beyond the scope of this book, we will also look at powers and roots, in addition to the four basic arithmetic operations.

english

Addition is the root of all things maths related. The idea of addition is a childishly simple one: you have something, you get more, you have more. The mathematical part of this concept is to determine how much more you have, and for this we need three things: numbers, something that states addition, and something that marks an outcome. Luckily (though not

unexpectedly) Japanese has all three of these. Numbers we have already seen plenty of, the outcome marker is simply ⬚, and the verb that we use for addition is english.

⬚ ⬚ ⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
“One plus four is five.”

In this use, ⬚ acts remarkably western in that even though ⬚ is used in ⬚⬚⬚, and should thus be attributive, ⬚⬚⬚⬚ does not say “a one-added four”, but merely says “one plus four” (this is also the case for the verb used for subtraction).

We can also use ⬚ on its own, for such obvious things as:

⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚ ⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
“If (you) add 20 yen, that’ll make it (a) round (number).”

Where ⬚⬚⬚⬚ is a nice little word meaning ‘exact’ or ‘precise’. In this sentence, it is interpreted as “round number”, because in the context of numbers, a precise number corresponds to a ‘clean’ number, which can either be a round number, or a number without a decimal fraction.

english

For subtraction, english instead of ⬚ is used:

⬚⬚⬚⬚ ⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚ ⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
“300 minus 53 is 247.”

english

Division in Japanese is done in the same way as in western maths, but the phrasing is somewhat confusing if you don’t pay attention: in western maths, the number that results from 3 × ⬚ is pronounced “three fifths”. In Japanese, this ‘factor, then denominator’ order is the reverse, so instead of saying “three fifths”, in Japanese you say “five’s three”:

◎◎◎ ◎◎
◎◎◎◎◎
literally: “three five-parts”
“⅗”

This uses the genitive ◎ to link ◎, 3, as genitivally belonging to ⬚, ⬚.

One thing to note here is that in this use, english is pronounced ⬚, and this is the reason why the counter series for minutes has an oddity for three, where ⬚ becomes ⬚

instead of ⬚⬚:

kanji	pronunciation	meaning
⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚	Three minutes
⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚	A third

english

A final simple operation is multiplication, which uses the noun ⬚⬚. This is actually a rather interesting word, because on its own it means "two fold", such as in for instance:

⬚⬚⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"(Our) problems doubled."

Interestingly, this noun can also be used in combination with other numbers (except of course the number 1) to indicate any random multiplication:

⬚⬚⬚ ⬚⬚ ⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"7 times 5 is 35."

Here, the literal statement is "the five-fold of seven is 35".

This is basic multiplication, but there's also another word that's used for the x-fold for one through ten involving the counter english, which is pronounced in various different ways this role:

⬚⬚	⬚⬚	⬚⬚	⬚⬚	⬚⬚	⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚	x	⬚⬚⬚	x
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚

⬚⬚	⬚⬚	⬚⬚	⬚⬚	⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚⬚	⬚⬚	⬚⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚		⬚⬚⬚⬚		
		⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚		

You may have noticed that this is perhaps the most bizarre counter series the language has; the counter has three different possible readings, has a mix of possible native Japanese and Chinese readings for the numbers, and the native reading used for 10 is very rare one, not to mention the question word uses ⬚ instead of ⬚.

Needless to say, this counter series is "special". In fact, it's so special that it's a mainly literary counter for "-english", where it depends on the context which reading is used. In eloquent language, ⬚ is more likely, and in technical literature, ⬚⬚⬚ will be used more.

5.4.3 More english

While there are many topics that we could treat here, this isn't a book on mathematics in Japanese. Treating all mathematical topics would take up too many pages, and would for the most part be rather boring. Instead, we'll look at two more "simple", but less basic, mathematical constructions before moving on to "real" language patterns.

english and english

There are two special words for squaring (x^2) and cubing (x^3), english and english, used to indicate squared and cubed units respectively. For instance, when indicating something is 500 square kilometres, one would say:

500□□□□(□□□□)□□□
"(It) is 500 square kilometres."

Or, if one wanted to say a particular vehicle has a 12 cubic meter interior, one could say:

□□□
□□□12□□□□□□□□□□
"The interior fits 12 cubic meters."

english and english

Going beyond squares or cubes, and raising numbers to an arbitrary power in Japanese uses the counter english, and is used in the following way:

□□ □□□□□ □□□□□□□□□□□
□□□□□ □□□□□□ □□□
"7 to the power 3 is 343."

The inverse of this operation is taking the root of some power, which is done with the "counter" english, which is just the counter for raising power paired with the noun for 'root':

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎ ◎◎◎◎◎◎ ◎◎
◎◎◎ ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"The square root of 49 is seven."

And that's it, that's all the mathematics you will probably care to know how to work with, so let's leave the numbers as what they are and move on to the next chapter, which deals with more general language patterns.

Chapter 6

Language patterns

So far we've covered verbal grammar, particles, and counters, as well as a handful of related "handy words" that fill in some of the gaps. However, that still leaves quite a number of constructions that you should be familiar with if you want to use Japanese to any serious degree, and so in this last chapter we will look at the rest of the useful Japanese that we still need to cover.

In this chapter, we'll look at how to draw comparisons between things, making choices, indicating possibilities, talking about trying things and having things done, how to nominalise statements so that we can talk about them objectively (not an unimportant trick!) and the exceedingly important rules for the core of true Japanese social language patterns: giving and receiving, and humble and honorific speech.

6.1 englishs, englishs and english

Comparing and choosing are two very related subjects. Making a choice is essentially the same as making a subjective comparison, where one thing is more favourable than the other. In Japanese we see two types of choices: the binary choice, and the open choice.

6.1.1 englishs

The *glossary* choice is simply a choice between two things. One's preference can swing one way or the other, or one can indicate that either choice is fine, or both are to be rejected. This binary choice concept in Japanese uses the word □□, literally "direction", in the following questioning pattern:

> [X]□[Y]□□□□□(□□□)□□□(some judgement call)□□□□
> "Which is more (something); X, or Y?"

Note that this uses a two item, inclusive list, with either two □ particles, or a comma

after the second choice item (though typically commas are avoided). Because of the use of □□□□□ or □□□□□ (the first being more formal than the second) this pattern literally asks "A and B; which direction is [more] [something]?" and can be applied to virtually anything:

□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Which do (you) like best, hamburgers or chicken sandwiches?"

□□□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"Which is faster? The train or the bus?"

Remember that adjectives in Japanese act both as attributives as well as comparatives, so the translation for the last line could also be "which one is fast, the train or the bus?", but it is far more likely that the speaker means "which one is faster?" because of the fact that a choice is being used in the question.

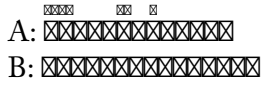
There is always the possibility that the answer to this question is "both" or "neither", which use the same words in Japanese: english, or the more colloquial english followed by a positive or negative evaluation (recall this from the section on interrogatives paired with □), or alternatively the noun □□□ meaning "either [option]" suffixed with □:

□□□□
A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□
□□
C: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
□□□□□ □
D: □□□□□□□□□□

A: "Which music do you like best, jazz or classical?"
B: "I like either."
C: "I don't particularly like either."
D: "I don't (really) know either of the two."

6.1.2 englishs

If you want to have a larger collection of items to choose from, or you want to ask a categorical choice, then □ cannot be used. Instead, a choice pattern involving english, meaning "from amongst …" must be used. This pattern can be used for anything, such as specific lists of items, or just categorical nouns asking the person who is offered the choice to pick something that falls into the category. For instance:



A: “Music-wise, what do you like?” (literally: “from music, what do you like?”)
B: “Hmm. I like jazz.”

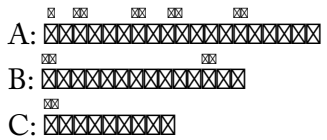
This is an example of a english where the respondent actually gives a specific answer. Questions like “What food do you like?” and “Which cars are fast?” fit this pattern.

There is an exception to using this pattern which involves open choices for englishs, such as “Which cities in Europe have you been to?”: as ◎ is already a marker for location, the ⬚⬚ part is dropped when asking location questions:



“Which cities in Europe have you been to?”

Again, it might be that none of the choices are good, or that they’re all equally fine. Instead of using ◎◎◎◎, ⬚⬚⬚⬚ or ⬚⬚⬚, english or english are used for this particular pattern, to indicate “everything” or “nothing”, depending on the verb form that follows being positive or negative:



A: “Which foods are tasty?”
B: “I don’t think there’s anything particularly tasty about food.”
C: “Everything’s tasty!”

6.1.3 Comparison through english, and englishs

Closely related to choices is the concept of comparing things. After all, if you cannot make comparisons, you cannot determine preference. There are quite a number of ways in which to compare things in Japanese, with varying degree of strength in the comparison, and varying nuance in the exact way the likeness (or contrast) works. You have already seen some ways in which to do this, such as ⬚⬚ and ⬚ in the verb and particles sections, but there are quite a few more, which we will now look at.

english — english (□□□, □□), english (□□□)

The noun adjective □□ (a □□□□ word) paired with a verb in □□□ or a verbal adjective's stem, is used to create the construction of "appearing to be (at the point of) …" or "seems to be … (to the speaker)". And example of this using a verb is:

□□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"It looks like (you)'ll be able to perform this job."

And examples of using verbal adjectives are:

□□□
□ □□□□□□
"It seems warm."

□□ □□□
□□□□ □ □
"A fast looking car."

For □□ and □□, this construction is slightly different. Rather than □□□ (remember that □□ is just the alternative □□□ for □□) and □□□, these two adjectives become english and english respectively.

Note that this "□□ as likeness" only works with verbs in □□□, and verbal adjective stems. □□ can also be used in combination with verbal □□□, but then it means something quite different: rather than indicating impression, this combination indicates second hand information:

□□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"I heard you'd be able to perform this job."

□□□
□□□□□□□□
"They say it's warm."

□□ □□□
□□□□□□□□
"They say that's a fast car."

This kind of second hand information is also called "english", although this term should not be taken too literally; it equally applies to second hand information from reading a book or watching a documentary on television, not just having been told something. As long as it's strictly speaking unverified information, it counts as hearsay.

For nouns, a fully qualified statement involving the plain copula is used:

□□□□□□□□□
“I heard he’s a teacher.”

english — english, english, english

To explain this word, we must briefly look at classical Japanese, in which the noun □, pronounced □□, was used to indicate a “seemingness”, which we still see in expressions such as □□□□ or □□□□. These mean, respectively, “having the appearance of being a hardship” and “having the appearance of being a feast”. This meaning is preserved in modern Japanese through the use of ◎ still, but read as □□.

This noun adjective combines with □□□ to create a conceptual likeness, relating two manners or behaviours to each other:

□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
connotes: “Please go about your business in a manner that makes it appear as if you didn’t hear that.”
meaning: “Please act like you didn’t hear that.”

A special use of this likeness adverb is with the □□□□ series □□, □□, □□ and □□, with which it sets up an explicit “manner” indicator:

english - english
english - english
english - in that manner like so
english - english

Very similar in meaning to the □□, □□, □□ and □□ series, the decision of whether to use □□ or □□□□ (or □-, □- and □- equivalents) is mostly decided by what one’s intention is. When you need to be instructive, or want to highlight a specific act and the performing of it, □□ is used. If one instead wants to illustrate or describe, □□□□□ (etc.) is used. As such, both of the following sentences are possible:

□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□
“This is how (you) use chopsticks.”

□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“This is how (you) use chopsticks.”

However, the first sentence is instructive (telling us what to do), whereas the second

sentence is illustrative of a process, not so much telling us what to do, but telling us how things are. To highlight the difference, imagine that some instructor says [illegible], and then picks up a pair of chopsticks to demonstrate how to hold them, and how to pick things up. For the second sentence, the instructor has already demonstrated how to hold them, and is in the middle of showing how to pick things up with them when he says [illegible]. In the first setting, the sentence acts as a set-up for the actual process, whereas in the second setting, the sentence summarises what's already going on.

This also means that ◎◎◎◎◎ (etc.) can be used in certain situations where ◎◎ (etc.) do not make sense, such as in purely illustrative settings.

[illegible] + [illegible] + english/english

[illegible] can also be used in the special combination [illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]. This construction literally translates to "Doing, in a way that is akin to …", which is a bit cryptic, so an example to demonstrate the use:

[illegible]
[illegible]
literally: "(I) will do (something), in a way that is akin to telephoning".
meaning: "(I) will try to call (you)"

However, do not confuse this —[illegible]+[illegible] with —[illegible]+[illegible], which indicates something ending up like something else, rather than trying to do something:

[illegible]
"(I) tried to (make sure to) call (you)"

[illegible]
"(I) ended up calling (you)"

english — english, english

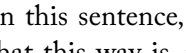
The noun adjective [illegible], like [illegible], likens something to a particular manner. It closely translates to 'way', or 'style', and this meaning is evident in words like [illegible] meaning "modern" ('the now-a-day style') or ◎◎, "good customs" ('good style'). A special set of words with this likeness adverb is its combination with the ◎◎◎◎ series ◎◎◎ (etc.):

english - in this english/english
english - in that english/english
english - in that way/style like that
english - in which english/english

This combination is used when one wants to focus specifically on a way something is (or has been) done. It is, effectively, a rhetorical adverb, qualifying a verb action with itself. That may sound a bit cryptic, so an example:



literally: "Even by talking (to me) in that fashion, things that cannot be done, cannot be done."
meaning: "Ask (me) any way (you) want, (I) cannot do what (I) cannot do."

In this sentence, the  highlights the way something was said, without saying what this way is, instead relying on the listener to know "in which way" the verb action occurred.

english — english based on secondary information

Similar to likening something to something else, impressions are one's own projections of likeness onto something. For instance, if we have the impression something is tall, then we can also describe it as "being like something that is tall". As such, impression words are also quite important to know.

When we have an impression of something based on secondary information, or indirect observation, we can use the verbal adjective  to indicate this, by using it in combination with verbal , or following a noun phrase:



It seems that this book is Yamada's.

In addition to this, can be used to indicate that something generates a certain impression:



literally: "That way of speaking (plus what was said), is just like (what) Kimura (would use)."
meaning: "That's so like Kimura."

There are two possible situations here. If we are dealing with someone other than Kimura saying something, then the commenter's use of ◎◎◎ indicates that they are reminded of how Kimura would talk or behave in that situation. Of course, if Kimura herself was the one talking, then the use of □□□ indicates that this fits Kimura's expected behavioural pattern.

english — english based on direct observation

When commenting on an impression based on direct observation, the noun adjective □□□ is used after □□□ clauses, as well as noun phrases:

□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(He) looks likes (he)'s tired, doesn't (he)."

Because □□□ is a noun adjective, it can also be used to form (complex) attributive phrases:

□□
□□□□□□□
"(He is a) strict teacher."

□□□□□□□□□□□
"(He is a) teacher who looks like (he)'s strict."

□□□ is very similar to □□□ and □□.

□english — english adverbs

This is a noun adjective that is used primarily as a noun suffix, to create "-ly", "-al", or "-ive" nouns for comparisons, such as:

adjective	meaning	from noun	meaning
□□□□□ □□□	"basically"	□□	"basis".
□□□□□□ □□□	"practical"	□□	"the way things are now".
□□□□□□ □□□	"subjective"	□□	"subject", "constituent".

These comparative nouns are used like normal noun adjectives for comparisons:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"It would basically be uninteresting."

english — englishs, english

This noun suffix is comparable to the English suffix "-ish":


"Kimiko's kind of a tomboy, isn't she?"

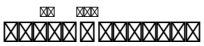
This sentence literally reads "Kimiko's mannish, don't you think?"
This suffix also works to indicate traits in something:


"Don't you think this food tastes kind of French?"

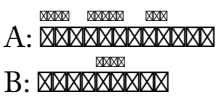
This sentence literally reads "Don't you think this food is French(ish)?"

english — english (in some way)

The adjective ⬚⬚ is actually an odd word, a remnant of the classical Japanese ⬚⬚⬚, not quite fitting in the modern verbal adjective class, nor quite fitting in the noun adjective class. Using the construction [X]⬚⬚⬚⬚ is the strongest possible comparison that can be made, as it doesn't so much liken two (or more) things to each other, but explicitly claims they are identical in some way.


"This room is the same as the neighbouring one."

While this is a noun adjective, rather than using ⬚⬚ + ⬚ when we want to use it adverbially, we use the verbal adjective adverbial form: english:


A: "I am Ishida, 2nd year university student."
B: "I am Uematsu, also a 2nd year university student."

Of course, B literally says "I am Uematsu, the same", but unlike in for instance English, it is not impolite in Japanese to omit this contextually already present information, since Japanese is a language in which context is presumed to remain known throughout a conversation.

Basically all you have to remember is that for all intents and purposes, ⬚⬚ is the noun and ⬚⬚⬚ the adverb. If you can remember that, you should be fine.

english — english

Closely related to likeness, the noun adjective ⬚⬚ is used to compare something in the "prone to" way. While a noun adjective, there are some instances where ⬚⬚ can be used with ⬚, rather than with the ⬚⬚⬚ for ⬚, ⬚, as well:

⬚⬚⬚ ⬚⬚⬚ ⬚⬚
⬚ ⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"My (younger) sister is someone who's prone to illness."

However, there are no clear rules on when one can use ⬚, so typically it's best to stick with using ◎◎ as a normal noun adjective, using ⬚.

For verbs and verbal adjectives, this suffix is added to the ⬚⬚⬚:

⬚⬚⬚ ⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"This clock tends to run fast."

english — english

A final way to indicate likeness is by using the verb ⬚⬚ meaning "to resemble" or "to be similar". Typically used in - ◎◎◎ form, this verb is used in combination with the particles ⬚ or ⬚, where the choice of particle determines the nuance of likeness. Using ⬚ makes the statement describe near-exact likeness:

⬚⬚⬚ ⬚⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"Those ideas are like the ones I had."

⬚⬚ ⬚⬚ ⬚⬚⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"The colour of gold is (sort of) the same as brass."

Using ⬚, on the other hand, makes the statement describe general likeness, or a likeness in a particular (but unspecific) way:

⬚⬚⬚⬚ ⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"(She) really takes after (her) mother."

□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"That mountain (kind of) resembles a duck, doesn't it?"

6.1.4 Discussing english

Related to choices, comparisons and likeness, there is the subject of possibilities. In English, we can indicate possibility in a variety of ways; things "may" or "might" be, "can" or "could" be, they're possible, likely, unlikely, or even "stand a chance to be". In Japanese, too, there are a number of useful ways to describe possibilities, which we shall look at in this section.

english — english

The first, and probably most used, is the construction □□□□□□. This construction technically consists of the particles □ and □, followed by the negative short potential of □□, to know, or be informed; □□□□. This construction translates to "it could be that …", implying that the speaker doesn't actually know, but is not ruling out that something could be the case.

A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

A: "Didn't he say he wasn't coming?"
B: "He might have said something like that."

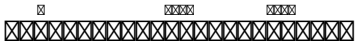
As can be seen from the previous example, □□□□□□ can also be used as english — they're just different politeness levels. Further alternatives are the highly colloquial english, and just the particles, english:

A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□

A: "Did Ishida lose his glasses?"
B: "Maybe he (actually) threw them away."

english — english

When a speaker suspects something to be the case, but they're not 100% certain, they will use □□ to indicate this. Looking at just the kanji, the word literally reads "great part", and that's pretty much what it means, too.



“We’ve not quite decided yet, but we’ll probably head off to Osaka for the summer.”

english — english

You can, of course, also be more literal when talking about the possibility of something, by using the actual noun for “possibility”,  (often also used to refer to an available “option”). Usually this is paired with the verb  , to indicate that the speaker believes there is the possibility of something, in a way that is more literal than using .



“Now, this thing might self-detonate, so be careful.”

Of course,  can also be used with negative statements, usually involving :



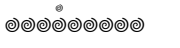
“There’s not even the possibility of failing.”

6.1.5 Discussing english

In addition to objective possibilities, there’s also the more subjective idea of certainty. There are a number of words that express this more subjective kind of “possibility”, which deserve just as much mention as the previous set of words.

english — english

When a speaker is hopeful that something is the case,  can be used. Associated with a positive kind of wishful thinking, it is typically translated as “surely”:



“I am sure (they)’ll show up!”

In this sentence, the speaker can either be confident, or can be hoping strongly for the outcome they are talking about, even if there’s the possibility that this will not be the case.

english — english

When a speaker is positively certain of something, then ⊠⊠ can be used, which translates to "necessarily" or, more in keeping with the ⊠ negative it really is, "without fail":


"(They)'re certain to show up."

In this sentence, the speaker is highly confident in the outcome, even if their certainty is based purely on subjective information.

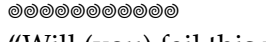
english — english

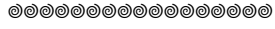
Finally, there will be times when you are not so much certain, but actually uncertain about english something is the case, or will happen. For this, we can use a construction we already saw in the particle section on ⊠, namely [X]⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠:


"I don't know whether or not I'll make this year's grade."

The way this is formed is very simple. The clause about which uncertainty is to be expressed is followed by ⊠⊠⊠⊠, which is basically the double question mentioned in the particle section for ⊠, creating (essentially literally) "[clause] or what?" The final verb then comments on the fact that it's not clear which of the two choices are actually to be picked.


"(I) will fail this year."


"Will (you) fail this year or…?"


"(I) don't know whether (I) will fail this year or not."

6.2 english

Nominalisers are those words that turn words that aren't nouns, or entire phrases, specifically into noun phrases, so that they can be used in larger sentences as topics, subjects, direct objects or what have you. We have already seen some nominalisers in the particle

section (such as □, □□ and □□), and these will be further explained in their roles as nominalisers in this section. It should be noted that most nominalisers require specific particles to follow them in order to work the way they do, so when studying nominalisers, don't just study the words, but also remember which nominalisers take which particles.

6.2.1 english, using english

The simplest nominaliser is just the nominalising □. This turns any clause that precedes it into a back referral to something either previously mentioned, or previously established as the topic somehow. Say we have the following sentence:

□□□□□ □ □
□□□□□□□□□□
"Going to an art gallery."

We can nominalise this sentence into a back referral using □ by appending it to this sentence:

□□□□□□□□□□

This has no direct translation on its own, but requires a bigger context to operate in; on its own it can mean anything that can be approximated with "the [going to the art gallery]". Only when used in a bigger sentence will this noun clause really make sense:

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"Going to (the) art gallery (today) was fun."

Here, the noun phrase has been turned into a back referral to something that happened.

6.2.2 english, using english

The noun □□ is used to turn clauses into an *glossary* thought, rather than the actual thing. For instance:

□□□□□ □ □□ □□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I) have not yet seriously considered whether or not to go to America to study."

Here, the clause □□□□□□□□□□□, "to go to America to study", has been turned into an abstract idea, about which the comment "I have not yet really thought about it" is made.

Another example of the use of ⊠⊠ can be seen in the following example:

⊠⊠⊠ ⊠ ⊠⊠ ⊠ ⊠⊠
⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
"Would (you) like to add anything to what (I)'ve said?"

In this sentence, there are two abstractions going on: one is the abstraction of ⊠⊠⊠, "said", to ⊠⊠⊠⊠ , "the thing that was said", and the second from ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠, "to add" (a compound verb coming from ⊠⊠⊠, "to attach", and ⊠⊠⊠, "to add"), to ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠, "(a) thing to add".

It should be noted that these are genuine abstractions; ⊚⊚⊚⊚⊚ does not only refer to the actually spoken words, but also the thoughts that they stood for, and ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠ likewise stands not just for words, but for thoughts that can be added to the already existent thoughts on whatever was being discussed.

This plain past tense + ⊠ is also used to ask whether or not someone has experience with something, in the pattern [plain past tense] + ⊠⊠⊠⊠:

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
"Have (you) ever been to France?"

This sentence differs significantly from the direct question:

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
"Did you go to France?"

This direct question implies a context in which someone has gone somewhere, and you're asking them where they went. Instead, by using ⊠, the concept of "having been to France" is turned into a generalised abstract concept. Rather than the specific "having been to France (when you went on your trip)", the question is now about "having been to France", in general.

6.2.3 english, using english

As mentioned in the outline, ⊠, often written as ⊠⊠, conceptualises real, but not necessarily tangible, things. For instance, the following sentence is about a very intangible, but very real thing:

⊠⊠⊠ ⊠⊠
⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
"(You) can't keep that secret hidden forever."

Here, ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠, "to be able to keep a secret a secret" is conceptualised using ⊠⊠ to form ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠, which translates to "that which is 'being able to keep a secret a

secret'". This is different from an abstraction using ◎◎ (◎):

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
The concept 'being able to keep a secret a secret'

◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
The concept 'being able to keep a secret a secret forever'

This concept can be talked about as, for instance, 'being hard' or 'being impossible', or even 'is unnatural'. However, using ⊠⊠ such as in:

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
That which is 'being able to keep a secret a secret'

or

⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
That which is 'being able to keep a secret a secret forever'

only lets use say that it exists or not, and that's roughly all it allows us to say; the concept of being able to keep a secret hidden from the rest of the world is something abstract, while the actual act of being able to keep some secret hidden is concrete. For the abstract idea, ⊠⊠ is used. For the concrete event, ⊠⊠ is used.

6.2.4 english, english or english, using english

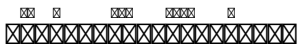
When you want to illustrate an occasion, circumstance or situation, you use the nominaliser ⊠⊠⊠, which is typically followed by the particle ⊠ to indicate point in time. Used as a noun on its own, ⊠⊠ has these same meanings:

⊠
⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
literally: "It is different depending on circumstances"
meaning: "It depends on the circumstances."

Used as a nominaliser, it turns the preceding part into a circumstance, which can be commented on, by connecting it to either a noun phrase using ⊠, or directly to verbal ⊠⊠⊠:

⊠ ⊠⊠⊠
⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
"(We)'ll consider your case an exception."

In this sentence, the clause □, a personal pronoun meaning “you”, has been paired with □□ to create “your circumstance”, about which a comment is made. □□ can of course also be used for verb phrases, in which case it follows the □□□:



“In case (I) don’t have enough money, (I)’ll borrow it off (my) friends.”

In this sentence, the clause □□□□□□□, “(I) do not have enough (sufficient) money”, has been turned into a circumstance, with a comment concerning that circumstance, should it arise.

6.2.5 english, using english

If we look at the kanji form of this nominaliser we see □, meaning “next”, and □ meaning “number” or “instance”. The combination ◎◎ means “when [some event], [something else]”. For instance:

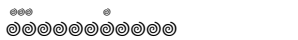


“Please let (me) know the moment (you) find out”

This sentence turns the clause ◎◎◎, the □□□ for □□□□, “to discover/find out”, into a moment of opportunity should it occur, where the action to then take is to let someone know of this discovery.

In this use, □□ follows verbs in □□□. It can also come after □□□ forms, but when used this way, the meaning of □□ is the same as that of □□ (□), treated later on.

When paired with nouns □□, often also found written as □□□, tends to be translated as a “dependence on”:



“I’ll buy it, depending on the price.”

However, in this use there is no □ between the noun and □□□. In fact, adding one will radically change the meaning of the phrase, as the noun □□ means “agenda” or “programme” :



“Due to the pricing programme (being the way it is), I’ll buy it.”

6.2.6 english, using english

If you want to describe something that occurs or can occur at times, then □, also often written as □□, lets you say something general about these occurrences. This is in part obvious because of the meaning of the kanji □, which is typically pronounced □ and meaning "… time", such as □□, "one time" or □□, "three times".



"Whenever (I) look up at a starry sky, (I) remember that (special) night."

Here, the clause □□□□□, "looking up at a starry sky" is presented as something that occurs with some frequency, and a comment on what is associated to this occurrence is then given. □ nominalises sentences in □□□, and is followed by □, as it marks a time.

6.2.7 english or english, using english

japanese, also often written as just □□, means "time" on its own, which explains why it does what it does. This nominaliser can be used either by itself or followed by □ or □, and follows sentences in □□□:



"When (I) first came to Japan, (I) was only 18."

Here the clause □□□□□, "came to Japan" is modified with □□□, "for the first time", and turned into a specific time/event using □□, after which a comment about this specific time/event is made.

Be careful when using □ with present tense □□□, because this will be interpreted as a general "english" statement.



"Every time I come to Japan, I get excited."

The reason for this is that □ needs to refer to some event, but there cannot be a specific event when using present tense, as this describes either the present (in which case you would not refer back to it), or the immediate future (in which case, the event wouldn't have even occurred yet). The only event, then, that □ can refer to is the general event of whatever you're describing. In the case of ◎◎◎◎◎, this means the general event "coming to Japan", rather than some specific instance of having come to Japan.

6.2.8 english, using english

In English, which is the language this book is written in, there are two interpretations possible for "should": it can mean "must", such as in "you should clean up your room", and it can mean "expect", such as in "she should be showing up any minute now". In Japanese these are very different concepts, and for the second kind of "should", the nominaliser □ is used (often also written as just □□), marking expectation. It follows □□□ and noun phrases:

□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
literally: "It should be that everyone will come today."
meaning: "Everyone should be coming today."

Here, the clause □□□□□□, "everyone will come", is turned into the expectancy that everyone will come, using □□.

6.2.9 english or english, using english

Where □□ is used to indicate the expecting "should", □□ is used to indicate the somewhat imperative "should". Now, this is a genuinely strange word, unclassifiable using the modern Japanese word classes.

It comes from □□ (with a □□□ form □□), an overloaded classical verb with "two" sets of conjugational bases; one for □□, and one for the derived "verb" □□□, which is itself a contracted version of □□□□, in which the □□ part comes from □□… Basically, none of this is important to know in the slightest (unless you're also taking classical Japanese), as long as you can remember its modern bases:

	classical □□	classical □□□	modern
□□□	□□□	□□□	□□□
□□□	□□	□□□	□□
□□□	□□	×	□□
□□□	□□	□□□	□□
□□□	□□□	×	not used

In modern Japanese, this word is so curious that there's no real way to describe it. ◎◎ is used as a noun, with its inflections being constructions using the copulae (□, □□, etc.), but its negative adverbial form can still be formed in the traditional □□□+□ way, giving us english. This word, then, is actually a remnant of classical Japanese that defies modern word classes, so we're kind of left with exploring it as the need arises. In this case, as the nominaliser □□, where it turns phrases in □□□ into a social expectation:

□□ □□□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"You should have taken responsibility."

Here the clause □□□□□, "to take responsibility", is illustrated as being something that is socially expected from someone in whichever context this phrase was said in. Sometimes this social expectation is a given, or common sense, but sometimes the expectation is very context dependent, such as:

□□□ □□□ □□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(You) should study English seriously."

Here the clause □□□□□□□□□□□, "to study English seriously", is turned into a social expectation because of the behaviour of whoever it is said to right now. Probably, they are goofing off, while a "proper" person would be studying hard in order to meet the social standards.

This sentence also shows a special contraction when using □□ with □□, in that it turns into □□□ instead of □□□□ as expected.

Like □, □□ has both a □□□ and a □□□, and this should make it reasonably obvious when to use which: if you're ending your sentence on it, □□ must be used. If, on the other hand, you're using it as an attributive, then □□ must be used.

Truly, there is nothing simple, or ordinary, about this word.

6.2.10 english, using english

This word takes a clause and turns it into a nominalisation representing a point in space time. For instance:

□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"The ceremony will start soon."

This sentence literally says "We will soon be at the point where the ceremony starts".

◎◎◎ ◎◎◎◎ ◎
◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"Just as (I) was (together) with my boyfriend, (I) was imposed upon by a friend."

This sentence literally says "at the point of being with my boyfriend, I was …". While ◎◎◎ on its own means "place", and can be followed by several particles, as a nominaliser it is typically followed by either □ or □, depending on whether the focus of the sentence has to do with the place or time, or with the event that occurs. Also note the use of □ □□□□, which should be interpreted as a "passive form of bother" here.

6.2.11 english, using english

Derived from the verb english, "to intend", the nominaliser ▨▨▨ turns a ▨▨▨ clause into an intention:

▨▨▨ ▨▨▨▨ ▨
▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"(We) intend to go up to Wakayama today."

In this sentence, the clause ▨▨▨▨▨▨▨, which translates to "going up to Wakayama", is turned into an intention. Notice that this nominaliser really only states intention. Planning, rather than intending, is indicated using the noun ▨▨▨, "plan", instead. To indicate a negative intention, generally the statement "(I) don't have the intention to …" is used:

▨▨ ▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨ ▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"If he has no intention of giving it his all, he will be fired."

Literally, this sentence reads "Should he have no intention to work hard, it'll be his head". Aside from this nice reference to how being fired was handled in the old days, it also shows how a negative intention is used.

6.2.12 english, using english

This nominaliser is somewhat interesting in that it is next to impossible (or often even necessary) to translate, because it denotes situational commentary. In English, we leave the situation outside our conversations, but in Japanese you can use this word to indicate you are directly commenting on the situation at hand, commenting on it in an explanatory or reasoning manner.

Typically a translation works just fine with ▨ (also often written as just ▨▨) left untranslated, but its presence in a Japanese sentence makes quite a difference in terms of nuance:

A: ▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
B: ▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨

A: "(He) has not been proven guilty yet."
B: "(it's not as if he)'s been proven guilty yet."

The first sentence states that some "he" hasn't been proven guilty yet, as a factoid. The second sentence, however, states the same but does so in order to counter something that was said or was concluded that might imply the opposite. A good way to further illustrate this is by looking at a proper conversation:

A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□
A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□…
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
A: □□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

A: “I heard Ishida got fired.”
B: “Yeah, he did.”
A: “If only he’d worked harder…”
B: “No, that’s not the reason why.”
A: “Then why?”
B: “The company has cut back on production so several people were laid off.”

In the fourth line, B literally says “no, the just-said (□□□□) is not the reason [for the situation we are talking about]”. If we were to omit the construction with ◎, instead using the negative form of □□ to form □□□□□□□□, B would instead be saying “However, (I) am not saying (that)”, something rather different.

In fact, this use of english is fairly standard, and indicates a description of the situational comment. Imagine a situation where someone is being held accountable for low grades on their language courses, and they are asked to explain why:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□



“Please tell (her) to bring (her) textbook.”

Literally, in this sentence turns , “to bring (along) (one’s) textbook”, into a way some action may be performed, and then qualifies the act of “saying” as this particular way, thus creating the (now somewhat elaborately translated) statement “please tell her in such a way as to effect her bringing along her textbook”.

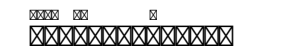
We also saw that can be used adverbially in combination with to create a construction similar to “try to …”:



“To try to make it class.”

In this sentence, the act of , doing, is likened to the act of , to attend class. This in effect creates the phrase “To do in a manner that is like going to class” which is interpreted as “trying to go to class”.

Aside from nominalising verb phrases, is also used as manner-conceptualiser when paired with , in the pattern […]:

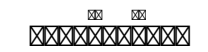


“The message reads as follows.”

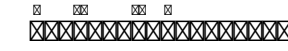
Literally, this sentence turns the very short noun phrase , meaning “next” or “following”, into the manner , meaning “as follows” or “like what follows”, and qualifies , “being written (by someone)” as being done in this “following” manner.

6.2.14 english, using english

Unlike , actually specifies an exact manner. It takes a clause and specifies that what follows occurs in the exact same fashion. It follows nouns, linked with , or verbal :



“Please continue like that.”



“(We)’ll let him go or stay as he decides to.”

In this second sentence, , “to decide”, is turned into an exact way of decision, and linked to “him”, (), to create “the way he decides (on something)”, . Note that

while □□□ is a verb, □□□□□ is, by the very role of □□ as nominaliser, a noun phrase, and thus can be used in a genitive □ linking.

Another example, this time with a Japanese past tense that maps to an English present progressive, is:

□□□ □□□□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(One) shouldn't enter the classroom while wearing (their) hat/cap."

The literal (though rather ungrammatical) translation of this sentence would be "in the manner of wearing one's cap, it is not the social thing to enter a classroom".

6.2.15 english, using english

When stating the purpose of a particular action, □□ is used. This nominaliser takes a clause and links it up to a verb in the pattern [clause](□)□□□[verb], where □ is used if the clause is a noun phrase, and is omitted when it's a verb phrase in ◎◎◎:

◎◎◎◎◎ ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
◎◎ ◎◎◎◎◎◎ ◎◎◎◎◎ ◎◎ ◎◎◎◎◎
"(I) give studying (my) all so that (I) will graduate."

In this sentence, the purpose of □□□□ (to study) is □□□□ (to graduate). Another translation would be "in order to graduate, I give my all at studying", but the concept of purpose is the same in both translations. In pairings between a noun and □□, the noun is typically a general concept noun, such as in:

□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I) will do anything for love."

In this sentence, the purpose of □□ is the noun □, giving rise to the obvious translation.

6.2.16 english, using english

The noun □□ literally means imitation, and it is typically used to indicate apparent (and insincere) behaviour. When an observer knows that certain behaviour is not typical, or is uncertain about whether it is genuine, □□ can be used to show they are not sure that what they are observing is sincere. This usually comes down to □□ being used in qualitatively negative (meaning it's the opposite of 'positive', rather than of 'affirmative') statements, implications or questions:



"Stop acting like an adult."



"It's just weird (how) she always pretends to be upset (at the smallest things)."

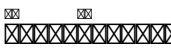
Of course, it can also be used for blanket questions such as , which literally asks someone to explain their behaviour, with the implication that the actions are perceived as not being sincere or genuine. Translations for this can vary wildly, due to the fact that it refers to behaviour, but typical translations are "What do you think you are doing?" or "What's going on here?".

6.2.17 english, using english

There is one last nominalising statement we need to look at, and that's the nominaliser that lets us make comments regarding "somethings". In English, a sentence such as "The beach is a crowded place" can be interpreted in two different ways - the first as a specific statement pertaining to a particular beach, the second as a commentary on beaches in general. In Japanese, these two different interpretations use different grammatical patterns, with the first being a simple [X][Y] statement, and the second using :



"The beach is (so) busy."



"The beach (in general,) is (a) busy (place)."

The difference in interpretation comes from what literally means: [X] translates to "that which we call X". can be suffixed with , , and to do the expected things, and usually is:



"He, having come from a rural area, had never (even) seen anything like (what we call) the beach."

To demonstrate the contrast, the sentence without means something subtly different:

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"He, having come from a rural area, had never (even) seen the sea."

In the sentence without ▨▨▨▨▨, the crucial "what we call" is missing, changing the meaning of ▨ from what we generally understand as being called "the beach", to its literal meaning of "sea".

This construction is also quite convenient when you want to ask questions:

A: ◎◎◎◎ ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
B: ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎ 「 ◎◎◎ 」 ◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎

A: "Shall we have a Japanese kaiwa?"
B: "I'm terribly sorry, but what is a 'kaiwa'?"

This "using ◎◎◎ in order to turn a specific thing into a general statement" is a very common practice in Japanese, and you'll be hearing it a lot, which makes this both an important construction to know, as well as not that important to learn; since you're going to be continuously exposed to it anyway, you're most likely to learn it through pure conditioning.

6.3 english patterns

In addition to language constructions, it is also important to know how to talk to other people. Social status and respectfulness are important facets of the Japanese culture, and thus are reflected in the Japanese language. In fact, the Japanese language is so interwoven with social levels that the rest of this chapter is devoted to it, foucssing on such matters as giving and demanding face (a concept akin to showing and demanding social respect), addressing others, giving and receiving, and steering people's behaviour through suggestions and recommendations.

6.3.1 english and english

In Japan, and thus when using Japanese, you must constantly be aware of what your relation is to speakers and listeners with respect to social position. You do not speak to your boss in the same way that you speak to your friends, but you will not speak to the visiting boss of a different company as you will speak to your own boss. While you might speak informally with your friends, if one of your friends shows up as part of an ambassadorial delegation, you will be required to speak to him as part of the ambassadorial delegation, not as your friend — the style of Japanese used heavily depends on which group you are in, and whether others are in the same group or not.

The english and english groups

Whether you're at home, at school, at work or at play in your own time, there is always the concept of the *glossary*, or english, and the *glossary*, or english. These words also literally mean "in" and "out", respectively, and are highly relevant to deciding what levels of politeness and humble or honorific speech are required in your speech.

Familiar speech can only be used with people in your familiar in-group. This group may include family, or good friends. Speech patterns such as highly contracted speech, plain form and same-level giving or receiving may be used, and you may refer to people in this group by a nickname or by their name either without any title suffix or with an affectionate suffix such as □□□ or □□. However, for older in-group members, simply by virtue of them being older and thus deserving more respect, it is customary to show face by using someone's title (such as for parents or older siblings) or their family name suffixed with ◎◎ (for friends that have earned a measure of respect). This means that a younger sibling might call her brother ◎◎◎◎, using his title, but he might in turn refer to her by her given name, or given name suffixed with □□□, instead.

The formal in-group constitutes people who you are associated with through your daily activities, work, hobbies or through some other means of direct association. With these people, and in the setting of that association, politeness is the key. If you work with several people, two of which are good friends of yours, then you may use informal speech when talking only to them, but when the discussion involves other co-workers, the setting changes to formal in-group, and formal polite speech is required. Just as you cannot mix "proper speech" with "banter style" speech in most western countries, you should not mix speech patterns when using Japanese. Speech patterns in the formal in-group involve english, english speech, characterised by the use of □□/□□ form, making sure □□□□□ is always followed by □□□□□, and by using the appropriate name and title suffixes. People are referred to, directly and indirectly, by their family name suffixed with □□, and people in special positions are referred either by their title, or by using their family name suffixed with their title.

The informal english consists of people that you have no special relationship with. People that ask you a question in the street, the bus conductor, the fast food employee - all of these belong to the informal out-group, and when talking to them you are expected to use □□□, and address them if you must by using their family name suffixed with □□, or a title if it is apparent that their role deserves one.

The formal out-group is a complex group, because in this setting the social differences come into play. Anyone not in your in-group in a particular setting, who is of identifiable higher social status than you, is part of the formal out-group, and deserves to be spoken to respectfully. This does not just mean using □□□, but also english and english, the english and english speech patterns. For instance, while you may work at a company, the company's vice president will typically not be part of your work in-group, and certainly doesn't fall in the informal out-group. He should be spoken to using polite honorific forms, and when speaking about your own actions, you should humble yourself by using humble speech patterns.

Finally, there is one last group that needs mentioning: the "not relevant in terms

of social setting (yet)" group, associated for instance with small children, or newcomers to a school, job or club. People in this group may be referred to using affectionate terms such as ⊠⊠⊠ or ⊠⊠, but interpreting these as an indication that they are part of the speaker's familiar in-group would be a huge mistake to make. Instead, these terms indicate the they have no social value yet.

Moving between groups

While these group definitions sound relatively straightforward, transitions from english to english, or from formal to familiar in-group, are much harder to characterise, and can lead to considerable problems if one party believes a transition from out- to in-group or from formal to familiar has occurred, when the other party does not.

Imagine you have just accepted a job at a Japanese company. You are assigned a mentor, and at first the division is clear. You know nothing, are nothing, and your mentor is responsible for shaping you into a proper employee. To your mentor, you will rank as 'not on the social ladder yet', and to you, your mentor will sit in the formal out-group. This means that you may be addressed using ⊠⊠⊠ or ⊠⊠, and you will address him or her with their title, english, while you are being mentored.

Now we move the clock forward by half a year. You have been accepted into the workforce formal in-group, and have even made some good friends from within that group, going drinking on the weekends with them. You are still working with your mentor, but no longer under a mentor/trainee relation, but as a co-worker relation, and you decide that it is time you start to use their name suffixed with ⊠⊠, rather than keep calling them ⊠⊠, and in doing so you have made a critical and relationship-breaking mistake.

Moving people from a group to a more intimate group always requires explicit permission from the person you're moving — if your mentor never indicated that he or she believed you were now well integrated into the workforce, then you could sing high or low, work there for six months or six years, but until they give notice that they consider you worth giving more face, they will stay a ⊠⊠, and unilaterally deciding that you no longer consider them one means that you are not showing them the right amount of face.

The same goes for making friends in school. You address people as if they're part of the informal out-group until they indicate that you may refer to them in a way consistent with the formal or familiar in-group. When the relation is between someone of higher social status and someone of lower social status, the permission has to come from the person of higher social status, but in situations where the social status is on equal footing, such as with classmates or co-workers, it typically involves a period of feeling around for the boundaries of your personal relationship, and at some point at least indicating that you do not mind if they refer to you in a way that corresponds to a closer group.

english

If things go wrong, it would be wonderful if someone would just say that it did, but typically this will not happen. Instead, rather than explaining that they are uncomfortable with you

addressing them using the speech patterns belonging to a more intimate group than they expect to be in, their own speech pattern will become more distal. What was natural Japanese one day may suddenly be changed to formal and distant Japanese after your mistake, and that's usually the only clue you'll get that something went wrong. Rather than demand face, you will be confronted with the fact that you acted inappropriately by a change in speech pattern, and you would do well to notice it - making someone lose face, or not giving enough face, can only be compensated by observing the right levels of formality again until the incident has been forgotten, or at least left in the past.

This also means that you are responsible for demanding face yourself. Not demanding face because you're just that nice a person doesn't fly. You are responsible for behaving properly according to Japanese custom, and that means you must take responsibility when it comes to maintaining the social balance. If someone gets too familiar with you, a change from formal polite to distal polite language is the clearest signal you can give that certain boundaries have been crossed.

6.3.2 english

Certainly one of the things that is more important in Japanese than in a lot of western cultures, in terms of social language use, is picking the right pronouns and names when addressing people. Not because the terms are particularly difficult, but just because there are actually a great number to choose from. Personal pronouns and name suffixes play an important role in being able to navigate your way through interpersonal dealings, so a brief moment to examine which words can be used, and when, will go a long way to helping you stay on top of every day Japanese.

english

Some people may tell you that Japanese has no word for "you", based on the fact that the standard way to address someone in Japanese is to use their name, paired with a suffix to indicate their title, rank, or social relation to you. However, this would be drawing the wrong conclusion: one avoids using direct personal pronouns as much as possible in Japanese, but there are in fact a great number of direct personal pronouns that can be used when the need arises. The important thing to note is that because of the way in which people are normally addressed, using personal pronouns carries "extra weight" — all of them mean more than just "I" or "you". Specific pronouns connote differences in social levels, as well as different politeness levels.

As mentioned all the way at the beginning of this book, Japanese is a sparse language, and personal pronouns fall in the category of words that are omitted once established in a conversation. While in English, for instance, one would constantly use the personal pronoun "you" to indicate a listener or reader, in Japanese this is considered poor language skills and would be experienced as highly annoying to have to listen to. This goes for all personal pronouns; after they have been used, and while the conversation is focused on the person(s) they

indicate, they are left out of the conversation. Explicitly keeping them in is not just considered bad form, it can even be considered an insult, as it amounts to indicating that you believe your conversational partner is unable to understand what you mean if you leave them out.

That said, sometimes you simply need personal pronouns, and for those occasions it serves to know which can be used in which setting.

english pronoun - "english"

english — an overly formal version of "I". This personal pronoun is typically too formal for any situation you will be in.

english — the gender-neutral, formality-neutral personal pronoun for "I" or "me".

english — a female-only version of the formality-neutral person pronoun

english — the formality-neutral personal pronoun for "I" or "me" used predominantly by elders.

english — literally, this noun means servant. Used predominantly by men, this personal pronouns means you humble yourself in respect to the listener. While predominantly used by men, it can be used by women too, and due to its meaning as noun, may actually also be used to mean "you" when addressing servants (although this does make the speaker look down upon whomever □ is used for).

english — a boastful first person personal pronoun, which is used when you are confident that sounding boastful is accepted. Predominantly used by men, this can also be used by go-getting women.

english — a classical personal pronoun meaning "I". You are most likely to hear this pronoun used in samurai drama, rather than in every day Japanese.

english pronoun - "english"

english — a version of "you" that contains a slight element of looking down on someone. You are technically placing yourself higher on the social ladder when you use it.

english — a crass and almost rude way to say "you"

english — the distal, deferred way to say "you". Because it is very formal, it can also be considered impolite outside of very formal settings. Remember from the □□□□ section that □□□ can also be used as an intimately familiar personal pronoun.

english — the shortened version of □□□, this is roughly the same as using □□.

english — something to avoid. While □ means "precious" or "honor", and □ is an honourable suffix, this word has made a half turn from being used as a classical honorific pronoun to a modern day *glossary* pronoun, and is as close to a curse word as possible without actually being one.

english — another pronoun to avoid. While classically this pronoun meant "you", its meaning has shifted to an accusative pronoun instead, similar to □□.

english — a classical personal pronoun meaning "you". You are most likely to hear this pronoun used in samurai drama, rather than in every day Japanese.

english pronoun - "english/english"

english — while a neutral "he", this word should be avoided simply because it is considered bad practice to use personal pronouns. Because of this, it is slightly *glossary* to the person you're referring to if you know them by name.

english — when used as personal pronoun, has the same connotation as □, except for girls. However, in addition to being a personal pronoun it can also mean "girlfriend" as a regular noun (with the noun version of 'boyfriend' being □□□□).

english — A derogatory gender neutral third person pronoun. This pronoun is generally associated with □□□□, literally "speaking evil of someone", meaning talking (derisively) about someone, behind their back.

Japanese has no explicit plurals, so you might think that expressing "english" or "english" might require separate words too, but this is not the case. There exist "group suffixes" in Japanese that can be used with personal pronouns to turn the single person "me" into the group "we", the single person "you" into the group "you [people]" and the single persons "he"/"she" into the group "them". There are two in common use in modern Japanese, the first of which is □english, which is used to turn virtually all personal pronouns into personal group pronouns. The second, which is used with a few specific pronouns, is □english. This is an older suffix, and can be used to turn □□ ('you') into english (plural 'you'), □ ('he') into english ('them') and ◎◎ (accusative 'you') into english (plural accusative 'you').

When using english for ◎ or ◎◎, it depends entirely on the gender of the first person in the group that you refer to. If there's a group of mixed gender but you were just talking about a female member of the group, then the entire group can be referred to using □□□. Similarly, if a male member of the group was talked about, □□ will refer to the exact same group. It should be noted that these markers are not true plural markers. □□ literally means "the group I am part of", and can refer to either a physical group gathered at some point in time at a specific location, or can refer to someone's in group. Similarly, □ is also a group marker, where for instance □□□ means "the group you are part of". It is important to remember this, as some translations for sentences that have plural personal pronouns cannot use these □/□ markers:

"As the committee on social affairs we have decided to …."

This kind of sentence, in which someone speaks for an entire group, requires the "group representative" personal pronoun □, pronounced either as □, in the pattern english□[…] or as □□ in the pattern english□[…]. To turn this pronoun into a group pronoun, the special word □□ is used, rather than adding the group suffixes □ or □.

However, the most important thing to remember is that you should try to use personal pronouns as little as possible. Instead, if you're referring to someone of whom you know the name, use their name suffixed with □□, or a more specific name suffix instead. If you do not know their name, find out what it is. The only polite way to refer to people is as people — avoid referring to them as mere objects by using pronouns.

english

There are various name suffixes that indicate different kinds of social relations, and using them out of place can have an effect anywhere from sounding like you're joking around a bit, to simply insulting someone. For this reason, it's a good idea to go over the list of common name suffixes, and see what they do. Also important is to note that people in Japan refer to each other by their family name, suffixed with the appropriate name suffix, and not by first name until there is a clearly defined friendship.

–english

This is the english that is used across Japan to refer to, as well as to call the attention of, people to whom you have no particular relationship.

–english

An honorific suffix, this name suffix is used when someone is of considerably higher status, used to indicate a master in a master/servant relation, or a patron in a patron/proprietor relation. This suffix is also used when writing someone's name as recipient on a letter or card, where it can be followed by □ to indicate that this name is to be the recipient of the communiqué.

–english

A classical honorific suffix, that is in use today principally for formal addressing in writing. Like □, □ can be used on letters and cards for indicating the recipient.

–english

This name suffix is used to indicate that someone is a representative of a specific house or has a particular lineage, similar to the official English title "sir" or "distinguished gentleman". Historically this name suffix has only been used for men, as women did not act as representatives of a house, and this gender specific use has not changed to date.

–english

Commonly associated with meaning "english", someone who is referred to with ⊠⊠ is not necessarily a teacher by profession. For instance, a doctor is a ⊠⊠, as is a school teacher, a lawyer, or an expert on politics. When someone is called upon for their knowledge, then in this role they are addressed with ⊠⊠.

–english

While typically associated with little girls, —⊠⊠⊠ is actually an affectionate suffix. It can be used for boys, girls, men and women alike, but only when there is a relation that is close and/or amiable. While it can be used for anyone, it does deserve mention that it is indeed used for women more than for men.

–english

This suffix is an amicable suffix, similar to ⊠⊠⊠, but has a slightly different connotation. While ⊠⊠⊠ finds it origin in young children who cannot say ⊠⊠ yet, and thus is readily associated with little kids and other cute things, ⊠ doesn't actually come "from" anything, but is a word on its own, also used to mean "junior", both in the naming sense as well as the social hierarchy system. While still being used for this, it has also picked up the added meaning of being a suffix used amongst equals who have an amicable relationship.

english

This is not so much a suffix as the complete opposite: the practice of ⊠⊠⊠⊠ refers to calling someone by just their name, without any suffix, and the word refers to discarding (⊠⊠⊠) formalities when calling (⊠⊠) each other.

Nicknames

A final, drastically different, approach is to come up with a nickname for someone based on their name, a habit, some personal feature, or whatever random thing you can think of that might make good material for a nickname. This practice is fairly obviously reserved for close relationships.

6.4 Acknowledging social status

The most important way in which to acknowledge social status, and differences in status, is through your choice of phrasing when it comes to asking for things, or doing things for people. These are not trivial subjects, and the next two sections will explain this in (perhaps excruciating) detail.

6.4.1 english and english

Giving, or doing something for someone, and receiving, or taking a liberty (i.e., helping oneself to something) are concepts that seem simple if you're used to the English way of expressing yourself, but in Japanese, these seemingly trivial things require quite a bit of explanation, as they are dependent on relative social status and the direction of giving or receiving, as well as involving a careful choice in particles to use. Involving both plain verb forms and ☒ form conjunctions, the acts of giving, or doing for someone, and receiving, or taking a liberty or having someone do something, cover some of the more complicated verb constructions in the language.

What makes things so complicated is that the verb used, and its implied meaning, can make the difference between respectful behaviour and rather blatant indirect insults; confidently using the wrong verb can pretty much declare that you experience your status relative to your partner very differently from what they thought it was. In the best case, this can lead to short lived misunderstandings, but more often than not it will result in a suddenly much more distal relationship.

So, let us look at the right way, as well as the wrong way, to handle this culturally grounded practice.

english, or english

In Japanese, "giving" and "doing … for (someone)" are, at least grammatically, the same thing. However, while in English "giving" involves just the one verb, in Japanese things are not that simple: depending on the social status of the individual parties and who is doing the giving, different verbs are used. This comes down to two possible "directions" of giving/doing for, the first of which is giving 'away':

1. first person ("I" or "we") to second person ("you"), i.e. "I give to you",
2. second person to third person ("him", "her", "them" or "it"), i.e. "you give to her", and
3. first person to third person, i.e. "I give to them".

Giving or doing for, in this "direction", can be done using three different verbs, with the choice depending on the social difference between the giver and the receiver:

1. if the giving is being done to someone or something whose status is irrelevant (very good friends, young children, pets, etc.), (□□□+□+) english is used.

2. if the giving is being done to someone of equal or higher status, (□□□+□+) english is used. In writing, both kanji and kana forms may be used.

3. if the giving is being done to someone of greatly higher status, (□□□+□+) english is used. In writing, both kanji and kana forms may be used.

Now, this requires a bit more explaining because when it comes to giving, virtually any situation involves giving to "equal or higher status". Unless you intend to highly offend someone, basically anyone capable of normal interaction will, for the purpose of being given to, be of equal status at the very least. If we have never met before, and I have something to give you, then I will describe this giving from me, to you, using either □□□+□+□□□ (for the giving of an action, i.e., doing for you) or just english (for the giving of an object):

□ □□ □□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"I gave something-or-other to a person I don't know in the slightest."

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"I did something-or-other for a person I don't know in the slightest."

The reason that we are of equal status (at the least) is essentially one of politeness. Unless I despise you, any event in which I give you something means there is at least a modicum of respect, and as such I will indicate this by using the verb □□□, which literally translates to "lift (something)". By using this verb, and for the duration of the giving, I lower my own social status, and elevate yours. If you accept my gift, things go back to normal. However, in typical Japanese style, most gifts (even the gift of doing something for someone) between non-familiar people, meaning not good friends or family members, will at first be mock-refused. This is one of those interesting cultural patterns where behaving like a foreigner can cause serious problems: it is customary to kindly refuse any gifts or offers for help, so that the giver can insist. Only then will a gift or offer for help be accepted. Not because the receiver had to be persuaded, but because that's simply the only proper way to go about the issue of giving, in Japan. If you are offered tea, kindly refuse, then accept once offered again. Flat out accepting could easily be considered rude, and flat out rejecting quite possibly even more so.

So with that covered, a few examples of giving:

□□□ □□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
"(I) bought flowers for Kimiko."

□□ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“I threw the garbage away for my mother.”

□□□□ □□□□□ □□□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) gave my friend a really interesting book for (his) birthday.”

You may have noticed that all the parts of these sentences that translate to “for …” have been marked with the particle english. As mentioned in the section on verb particles in the chapter on basic grammar, this kind of prepositional phrase is simply treated as a verb detail in Japanese, and as such is marked with □. You may have also noticed that in the last sentence, □□□ was used on its own: when used alone, it strictly means “give”. When used in ◎◎◎+◎+◎◎◎ for, it typically means “doing … for (someone)”.

In cases of severe difference in status, such as a maid serving dinner for a household, or a clerk handing a CEO a report, □□□ is not enough. The more formal □□□□□ must be used. However, as you are unlikely to find yourself in a situation warranting this verb, □□□ (for actual gifts) and □□□+□+□□□ (for actions) should be all you need.

Before we move on, the previous example sentences may have created a wrong impression concerning who can do the giving when using this verb. As mentioned, this concerns giving from first to second, second to third, and first to third person, so in fact all the following translations are correct (in the absence of some disambiguating context):

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“I gave my friend a really interesting book for his birthday.”
“We gave our friends really interesting books for their birthdays.”
“You gave my friend a really interesting book for his birthday.”
“You gave your friend a really interesting book for his birthday.”
“I gave your friends really interesting books for their birthdays.”
etc.

The variations are quite numerous, but usually sentences such as these will be used in a setting where it is relatively easy to determine which of the multitude of interpretations is the most likely intended one, due to contextual information.

So that leaves the verb □□. We can be fairly brief about it: you do not use english, except in the rare event where the giving is done to something inherently without social status:

□□□ □□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) gave the children some candy.”

But even this is not without danger: if the children in this example sentence were, for instance, your boss’s children, then saying you got them candy using this phrase to your boss

would in fact be quite rude, as you have just implied his children are without social value. So, be careful, and if at all possible avoid using ⬚⬚ entirely.

⬚⬚ technically means "do", similar to english, but while it is possible to use this verb as alternative to ⬚⬚ in a highly informal intimate setting (with close friends, for instance), it's all too easy to accidentally use it with someone who was not aware you considered them part of the group for which status was irrelevant. So again, use with care, and if possible, simply do not use it.

With so much explanation, one would almost forget that this only covered the first of the two directions for giving. However, there's also the opposite direction:

1. third person to second person, i.e. "he gives to you",
2. second person to first person, i.e. "you give to me",
3. third person to first person or, i.e. "she gives to me", and
4. third person to (other) third person, i.e. "they give to them".

Giving, or doing for, in this "direction" can be done using two very different verbs, the choice of which — again — depends on the social difference between the giver, and the receiver:

1. if the giving is being done by someone of equal or higher status, (⬚⬚⬚+⬚+) english is used. In writing, both kanji and kana forms may be used.
2. if the giving is being done by someone you are on a familiar basis with, (⬚⬚⬚+⬚+) english is used. In writing, this typically uses the kana form.

This should be relatively obvious in terms of how to use it. If a teacher, a boss, or simply someone you don't know gives you something, or does something for you, ⬚⬚⬚+⬚+english is used:

⬚⬚⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"(I) received a gift from (my) mother"

⬚⬚⬚ ⬚
⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"(My) teacher showed (me) something quite good."

Rather than using ⬚, these are normal verb actor phrases, so ⬚⬚⬚ and ⬚⬚ are simply marked with english, or ⬚ if we need to disambiguate. If we wanted to use ⬚ (which is possible), then we would have to first make the sentence passive, so that the tense matches the particle:

⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚⬚
"(I) was shown something quite good by (my) teacher."

Now, again, the sentences might create the wrong impression that it all centres around third to first person. To once more show the multitude of possible interpretations in the absence of disambiguating context, a list of possible translations for the last phrase:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“My teacher showed me something quite good.”
“Your teachers showed them something quite good.”
“His teacher showed you something quite good.”
“Our teacher showed us something quite good.”
etc.

In a familiar setting, rather than □□□, which literally translates as “issuing (something)”, such as issuing orders to (lower ranked) troops, we can use the verb english. When talking to, or about, friends or even family members, this verb does exactly the same as □□□:

□□□ □□□ □□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“(I) got (this) wonderful (new) bag from Haruka.”

□□□□ □ □
□□□□□□□□□□□□DVD□□□□□□□□□
“(I) was bought the DVD (that I) wanted for a long time by (my) friend.”

Regardless of whether we use □□□ or □□□, we can explicitly add in the receiver, if that information is required. In this case, we are forced to use english to mark the recipient of the action, but do not confuse this for what □ does in the presence of a passive verb form:

□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“Haruka gave Kimiko a wonderful (new) bag.”

In this sentence, because it’s in the active voice, □□ is the verb actor, and □□ the receiver. If we use a passive construction instead, we get:

□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“Haruka was given a wonderful (new) bag by Kimiko.”

Here, because it is a passive voice, the buying was done by □□, and □□ is actually the subject of “having been bought for”, now being the receiver! Not only the verbs count, so do the particles!

english, english, or english

Receiving, luckily, only concerns one "direction" and uses the two verbs english and english or english (the choice of which kanji to use is mostly arbitrary, as in this use □□□□ and □□□ are typically written in kana, rather than using kanji forms):

a) third person to second person, i.e. "you get from her",
b) second person to first person, i.e. "I get from you",
c) third person to first person, i.e. "I get from them", and
d) third person to (other) third person, i.e. "they get from him"

Just like the verbs for giving, □□□ and □□□□ apply to different status levels respectively. While both apply to receiving from someone of higher or equal social status, the difference in social level determines which verb is used:

1) if the receiving is from someone of equal or higher status, (□□□+□+) english is used. The kanji form is rarely used for this verb.
2) if the receiving is from someone of significantly higher status, (□□□+□+) english is used. The kanji forms are rarely used for this verb.

You may recognise □□□□ from its polite present tense: english, which is used as a set phrase, spoken before starting a meal. Literally, this phrase means "I (humbly) receive (this food)" or "I will (humbly) help myself to (this food)". Both meanings are essentially simultaneously true, which highlights an interesting aspect of "receiving" in Japanese: just as "giving" and "doing for (someone)" are considered essentially the same thing, so too "receiving", "having done for" and "helping oneself to (something)" are considered the same thing.

When the verbs □□□ and □□□□ are used on their own, then the "receiving" as well as the "english" interpretation are possible, and when used combined with a □□□+□ combination, the interpretation is typically "having (something) done for (someone)":


"(I) got back from (my) aunt the book (I) lent (to her)."


"(I) got bought a new bicycle by my father."

When the activity in question involves direct contact, english may also be substituted by english, which rather literally means "from":

[illegible]
"(I) got back from (my) aunt the book (I) lent (to her)."

The interesting fact about these statements is that they can also be interpreted as quite selfish: both [illegible] and [illegible] have an element of prompted action to them. Rather than things being given, or acts being performed out of the kindness of people's hearts, we are in some way responsible for them being done for our benefit, which is why we can interpret these verbs as expressing taking a liberty, too:

[illegible]
"(I) got (my) aunt to return the book that (I) lent her."

[illegible]
"(I) got my father to buy (me) a new bicycle."

This may sound odd, but think of it this way: if the actions were genuinely unprompted, they would have been gifts. And for gifts we use very different verb constructions:

[illegible]
"(My) Aunt gave me back the book (I) had lent (her)."

[illegible]
"My father bought (me) a new bicycle."

Another good example of using [illegible] or [illegible] for taking a liberty is the following short conversation:

A: [illegible]
B: [illegible]
A: [illegible]
(A takes an apple)
A: [illegible]

Which translates to:

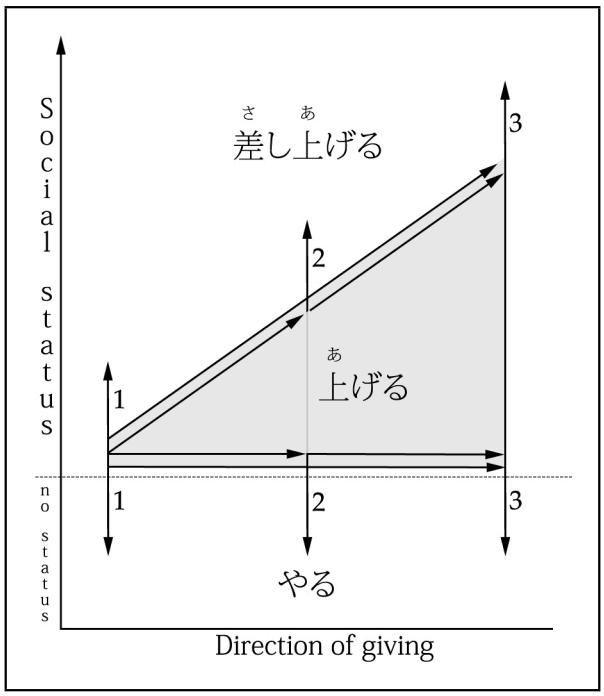
A: "Whose apples are these?"
B: "Oh, they're Keiko's."
A: "I see…"
A: "Well then, I'll just help myself to one."

It should be fairly obvious what's happening in this exchange: much like how the verbs ◎◎◎, □□□□ and □□□ can mean "give", □□□ and □□□□ can be used to mean "take".

In summary

To summarise these rather complex patterns, what follows are three images representing the three different acts: giving (something), being given (something), and receiving (something). Note that the numbers 1, 2 and 3 in the images represent "first person", "second person" and "third person" respectively:

Giving

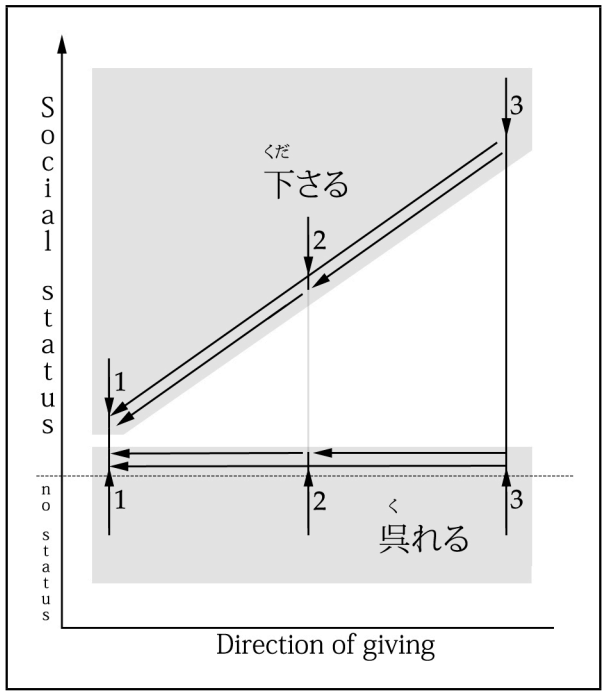


A schematic representation of verbs involved in giving in Japanese

We see three "areas" in this image:

1. When giving to someone socially much higher, we must use □□□□□,
2. when giving to someone who is either socially higher or equal, we must use □□□, and
3. when giving to someone (or something) without social status, we can use □□.

Being given



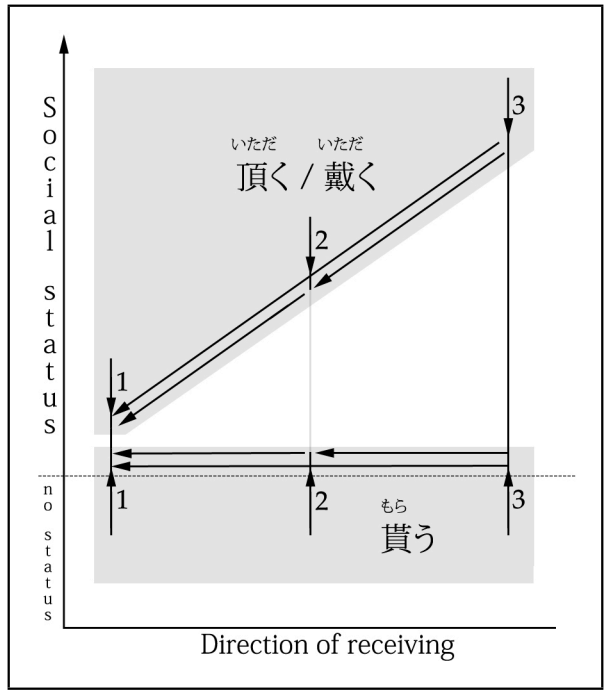
A schematic representation of verbs involved in 'being given' in Japanese

We see two "areas" in this image:

1. When being given something by someone who is socially higher, we describe their giving by using ⊠⊠⊠, and

2. when being given something by someone who is socially equal or lower, we describe their giving by using ⊠⊠⊠.

Receiving



A schematic representation of verbs involved in receiving in Japanese

We see two "areas" in this image:

1. When receiving something from someone who is socially higher, we describe our receiving by using ☒☒ or ☒☒ (the choice of which to use being essentially arbitrary, as ☒☒☒ is generally written in hiragana in this use), and

2. when receiving something from someone who is socially equal or lower, we describe our receiving by using ☒☒.

6.4.2 english

One of the important things in using Japanese is to be indirect whenever possible in formal situations. This entails asking indirect questions instead of direct questions, making indirect suggestions instead of telling people what they should do according to you, and stating assumptions rather than stating truths, even if they are truths. This section will explain how to turn direct speech into indirect speech, and for which constructions this is easily done.

Expressing english

One way to state something indirectly is by making explicit the fact that you only heard or read something somewhere, rather than it being something that you believe or know. As mentioned in the section on comparison and likeness, this is done using the noun adjective english, in combination with a clause in ▨▨▨, to form a hear-say construction. Compare the following two statements:

▨▨ ▨▨▨
▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"That popular group will disband."

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"I hear that popular group will disband."

While the first sentence implies that the speaker is certain of the stated fact, the second sentence states the information more carefully, stating that it seems the case that something is a fact, based on having heard or read it somewhere. This indirect form of stating something can only be done for second hand information, and should never be used to soften a statement that isn't actually hearsay.

english

Asking a negative question is, in many languages, a way to politely ask someone to do something. For instance, "won't you join us for dinner?" is an English phrase that has the implied meaning "please join us for dinner", rather than the literal "you will not be joining us for dinner, will you?".

In Japanese the same applies:

◎◎ ◎
◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"Won't (you) come over (for a social visit) again some time?"

(In this sentence ◎◎ is not used to mean "play" but "to spend time leisurely", hence the implied clause "for a social visit")

A more polite way to ask english is to use the ◎ form with a negative form of ◎◎◎:

◎◎ ◎ ◎◎
◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎◎
"Won't (you) have some tea?"

These negative questions can also be formed with plain negative form, but they become more informal that way:

[illegible]
"Won't you have some (literally: eat) cake?"

Giving answers to negative questions can trip up beginning students quite easily, as the following example illustrates:

[illegible]
A: [illegible]
B: [illegible]

A: "Won't you go (with me)?"
B: "Yes (I won't go with you)."

The problem lies with the fact that an affirmative answer to a negative question affirms the negative. Usually it is easier to answer with what you will be doing, rather than using yes or no:

A: [illegible]
B: [illegible]

A: "Won't you go (with me)?"
B: "I will."

An even better solution is to express your answer in the form of a motivation plus answer, when a negative question is asked, thus making it virtually impossible for your answer to be misinterpreted:

A: [illegible]
B: [illegible], [illegible]

A: "Won't you go (with me)?"
B: "Well, (I'm) free (anyway), (so) sure, I'll go (with you)."

english, using past tense + english

If we want to make a recommendation, there are various direct and indirect ways of doing so. One of the most common approaches uses a verb in plain past tense, paired with [illegible], which

creates a construction that essentially says “It might be better if you […]”.

A: ⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛ ⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛
B: ⊛⊛⊛ ⊛ ⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛

A: “(My) girlfriend is angry with (me) because (I) was late. What should (I) do?”
B: “Well, wouldn’t it be sensible (literally: good) to apologise (to her)?”

This kind of recommendation is fairly direct, and thus some care must be taken in making sure that your relationship to whomever you make a recommendation to allows for this level of directness.

english using english

A less direct way of recommending something is by offering your own opinion. Using a hypothetical conditional paired with your own opinion on how good or bad this situation would be is a less direct way to suggest a course of action to someone. For instance:

A: ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠
B: ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠

A: “Oh no, I’ve been writing mistakes all over the place.”
B: “Well, it won’t be that big of a deal if you just fix them?”

While this is of course still reasonably direct in the sense that you’re imposing your own opinion on someone, it is less direct than the previous past tense + ⊠⊠⊠⊠.

english using english

A truly indirect way of making a suggestion is by offering it as an option, without actually saying whether you think it’s the right course of action or not, effectively leaving the process of deciding whether it’s a good idea or not entirely up to the listener:

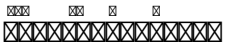
A: ⊛⊛⊛⊛ ⊛⊛ ⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛
B: ⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛⊛

A: "No matter how much I study I don't seem to understand this."
B: "Hmm. Well, what about asking the teacher?"

This is the most polite way of making a suggestion, because it only stays at making the suggestion, without adding a personal recommendation to it, meaning you do not decide what the other person should do.

Pseudo-future english and english

As you may remember from the section on the pseudo-future from chapter 3, the pseudo-future can be used for three things, namely the dubitative, english and english, and it turns out that these last two are ideal for use in indirect speech, as they guess at the world and leave the conclusions or decisions based on these guesses up to the listener, instead of imposing your own opinions on them:


"Shall (we) go (out) for sushi today?"

This question leaves the decision up to the listener, which is typically a polite thing to do, unless of course you're dealing with someone who is bad at making decisions, in which case using indirect speech is arguably not a good idea in the first place.


"The reason this computer is broken is (probably) because it's old (right?)."

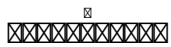
In this sentence, the speaker assumes that the computer in question is old, and leaves the matter of whether this assumption is correct up to the listener to decide, thus not providing potential disinformation to the listener. Of course, this is an over-analysis, and these forms aren't actually so much used to prevent disinformation as just used because indirect speech is polite, and that's what you use. However, the analysis does hold up to scrutiny for a good reason: not presuming to know better means you're never forcing anyone into anything, which makes you quite civilised.

english statements

In addition to these reasonably obvious suggestions, recommendations and opinions, we can also let our intentions shine through by using roundabout phrasing, thus softening our own convictions, opinions and intentions. The most common way this is done is by using double negative patterns, as described in the following sections.

english double negative

The regular double negative construction is essentially the same as in English, relying on the presence of *glossary* verbs (say, do, believe, promise, etc.):


"(I) cannot say (I) won't do it."


"I won't promise not to tell your boss."

Note that in this use, the double negative is set up using , in its role as 'quoting' particle.

However, there is a more frequently used double negative pattern in Japanese, used in a more subtle way to express an affirmative, which deserves special attention.

english double negative

Frequently used, but certainly confusing the first time one sees or hears it, is the double negative hypothetical construction + english + english/english. While it uses two negatives to do its job, it's actually used to imply an affirmative action instead. In a way, this makes sense: "I will not not-drink the coffee" has two negatives, but the first negates the second, so the sentence might as well read "I will drink the coffee". We see the same happening in the Japanese complex double negative, but with an added nuance:


literally: "It should not become a fact that I am not studying"
meaning: "I really should go study."

This construction requires some analysis: the construction is formed by inflecting a verb in plain negative form, + , and turning this into a hypothetical: + + . This negative hypothetical is then followed by either the negative form of , "become", or the negative form of , which is a verb that expresses the figurative "will do" such as in "Yes, that will do nicely". Because they express slightly different things, the choice of which to use depends on what a speaker wants to express.

Using + + (or polite, using) expresses that something "should" be done, i.e. that the negative verb action "should not come to be". Using + + (or polite, using) expresses that something "has to" be done, i.e. that the negative verb action simply "will not do". As such, typically translates to a "need" to do something, whereas typically translates to a "must":

㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙㊙
"I (really) need to practise piano (now)."

In this sentence, there are no additional connotations: the speaker simply notes that they should practise piano. They might need to do so in order to improve, or because a recital is coming up, but this is left in the middle.

▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨▨
"I must practise piano."

In this sentence, there is the additional hidden information that not merely should the speaker practise, but that not practising will have undesirable consequences. Rather than just needing to practise, this practice has to be done to avoid whatever these undesirable consequences may be.

Colloquially, there are shorter versions of ▨▨▨▨, namely ▨▨▨▨ and ▨▨▨. Because of the colloquial nature of the shorter forms, these are typically paired with the plain negatives ▨▨▨▨ and ▨▨▨▨, as well as even more colloquial ▨▨▨ and depending on who you talk to, ▨▨▨ or ▨▨▨. The first is strictly speaking the short negative form of ▨▨, rather than ▨▨▨; the second is a word often associated with the dialects spoken in the Kansai region, although it is also used in other parts of Japan.

6.5 More advanced grammar

While there are a lot more topics available in the discussion of Japanese grammar, a selection had to be made for a book titled an "introduction" to Japanese. This book already covers more than what you would traditionally find in an introductory reader on the language, and sticking in even more topics would make it a far more complete work, but also tremendously more voluminous. As such, this is the end of this introduction to Japanese syntax, grammar and language. For further grammar, I can recommend picking up copies of the Dictionaries of Basic, Intermediary and Advanced Japanese Grammar by Seichi Makino and Michio Tsutsui, and referring to them whenever you run across interesting grammar use in Japanese material, or going on in search of more specialised dictionaries and reference works — there are plenty available!

I hope you enjoyed this book, and I wish you all the best in your studies!

Appendices

Appendix A

Conjugation Schemes

This appendix focuses entirely on the conjugation schemes that have been treated in this book, organised in two sections. The first lists all the base forms for the various verbals treated in this book, the second lists the actual conjugation tables for all these verbals.

A.1 Bases

There are two sets of bases, one associated with english, classical (or literary) Japanese, and one associated with english, modern (or colloquial) Japanese. These are:

base	□□	□□
imperfect	□□□	□□□
continuative	□□□	□□□
sentence ending	□□□	□□□
attributive	□□□	□□□
perfect	□□□	□□□
commanding	□□□	□□□

In addition to these bases, all verbal words have a stem, called the english, which is that part of the verbal that does not change during inflection.

On a functional note, the term "dictionary form" used in this chapter (and preceding chapters) refers the modern □□□, which is the form used for listing verbal words in dictionaries. While synonymous, the term "dictionary form" will only be used to explain how to form bases. For everything else, the proper term □□□ is used.

A.1.1 Regular verbs: □□□ verbs

base	how to form
□□	remove final □—row syllable from dictionary form
□□□	final □—row syllable is replaced with the corresponding □—row syllable
□□□	final □—row syllable is replaced with the corresponding □—row syllable
□□□	dictionary form ending on the □-row syllable
□□□	final □—row syllable is replaced with the corresponding □—row syllable
□□□	final □—row syllable is replaced with the corresponding □—row syllable

A.1.2 Regular verbs: □□□□ verbs

base	how to form
□□	remove final □
□□□	remove final □
□□□	remove final □
□□□	dictionary form ending on □
□□□	replace final □ with □
□□□	remove final □

A.1.3 Irregular verbs: □□ (□□/□□)

base	□□	□□	□□
□□□	□, □, □	□, □, □	□
□□□	□	□	□
□□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□	□□	□□	□□
□□□	□(□), □(□), □□	□(□), □(□), □□	□(□, □)

The □□□ for these verbs follows special rules, because not all □□□ forms are used for all inflections that require this base.

For the classical negation:

□□ uses the □—□□□

□□ uses the □—□□□

For the (modern) passive and causative:

□□ acts as either an □□ or a □□ verb for these forms; □—□□□ + □□□ or □—□□□ + □□ to form the passive, □—□□□ + □□ to form the causative.

□□ acts as a normal □□ verb, using just the □—□□□, forming □□□□ for the passive and □□□□ for the causative.

□□ also acts as a normal □□ verb, forming □□□□ for the passive and □□□□ for the causative.

For the potential form, all three use □□□ instead.

A.1.4 Irregular verbs: □

base	kanji form	pronunciation
□□□	□	□
□□□	□	□
□□□	□□	□□
□□□	□□	□□
□□□	□□	□□

A.1.5 Special verbs: □□

base	form
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□

A.1.6 Special verbs: □

base	form
□□□	□□
□□□	□ (□□)
□□□	□
□□□	□
□□□	□□

A.1.7 Special verbs: □□

base	form
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□

A.1.8 Special verbs: □□

base	form
□□□	□□ (□□□)
□□□	□□
□□□	□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□ (□□)

A.1.9 Verbal adjectives

base	how to form
□□	Remove the □ from the dictionary form.
□□□	□□ + □
□□□	□□ + □
□□□	□□ + □
□□□	□□ + □□
(□□□	□□ + □□)

A.1.10 Special bases for □□□

base	form
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□

A.1.11 Special bases for □□□□□□

base	form
□□□	□□□□□□
□□□	□□□□□□
□□□	□□□□□□
□□□	□□□□□□
□□□	□□□□□□

A.1.12 Special bases for □□□□□

base	form
□□□	□□□□□
□□□	□□□□□
□□□	□□□□□
□□□	□□□□□
□□□	□□□□□

A.1.13 Special bases for □□□

base	form
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□

A.1.14 Special bases for □□□

base	form
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□
□□□	□□□

A.2 Conjugation schemes

A.2.1 Regular verbs: □□□ □□ verbs

Contractions in the inflections are indicated with (c)

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
present	informal	□□□	□□□ + □
			□□□ + □□
	formal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
past	informal	□□□ + □ (c)	□□□ + □□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
□ form	informal	□□□ + □ (c)	□□□ + □□□
			□□□ + □□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
past conditional	informal	[illegible] + [illegible] (c)	[illegible] + [illegible]
	formal	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
representative	informal	[illegible] + [illegible] (c)	[illegible] + [illegible]
	formal	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
pseudo-future	informal	[illegible] + [illegible] (c)	[illegible] + [illegible]
	formal	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
past pseudo-future	informal	[illegible] + [illegible] (c)	[illegible] + [illegible]
	formal	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
presumptive	plain	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
	polite	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
past presumptive	plain	[illegible] + [illegible] (c)	[illegible] + [illegible]
	polite	[illegible] + [illegible] (c)	[illegible] + [illegible]
hypothetical	neutral	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
	emphatic	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
	formal(1)	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
	formal(2)	[illegible] + [illegible]	
commanding	informal	[illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
		[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
		[illegible] + [illegible]	([illegible] + [illegible])
		[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]
	very formal	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]
requesting	neutral	[illegible] + [illegible] (c)	[illegible] + [illegible]
	formal	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]
passive, honorific, potential	informal	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
	formal	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
short potential	informal	[illegible] + [illegible] (c)	[illegible] + [illegible] (c)
	formal	[illegible] + [illegible] (c)	[illegible] + [illegible] (c)
causative	informal	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
	formal	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
causative passive	informal	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
	formal	[illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible]
humble	I	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]
		[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]
	II	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]
		[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]
honorific	I	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]
		[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]
	II	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]	[illegible] + [illegible] + [illegible]

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
		□ + □□□ + □□□□□	□ + □□□ + □□□□□□ □ + □□□ + □□□□□□

A.2.2 Regular verbs: □□ verbs

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
present	informal		(□□□ + □)
		□□□	□□□ + □□
	formal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
past	informal	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
□ form	informal	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□
			□□□ + □□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
past conditional	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□□
representative	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□□
pseudo-future	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□
past pseudo-future	informal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□□□
presumptive	plain	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□
	polite	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
past presumptive	plain	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□□
	polite	□□□ + □□□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□□□
hypothetical	neutral	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□□
	emphatic	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□
	very formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□
		□□□ + □□□□	
commanding	informal	□□□ + □	
		□□□ + □	□□□ + □
		□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□
		□□□ + □□□	(□□□ + □□□□)
	formal	□ + □□□ + □□□	□ + □□□ + □□□□□□
	very formal	□ + □□□ + □□□□□	□ + □□□ + □□□□□□
requesting	neutral	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
	formal	□ + □□□ + □□□□□□□	□ + □□□ + □□□□□□□□□
passive, honorific, potential	informal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
causative	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
causative passive	informal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
humble	I	□ + □□□ + □□	□ + □□□ + □□□
		□ + □□□ + □□□	□ + □□□ + □□□□
	II	□ + □□□ + □□	□ + □□□ + □□□□
		□ + □□□ + □□□□	□ + □□□ + □□□□□
honorific	I	□ + □□□ + □ + □□	□ + □□□ + □ + □□□□
		□ + □□□ + □ + □□□□	□ + □□□ + □ + □□□□
	II	□ + □□□ + □□□	□ + □□□ + □□□□□
		□ + □□□ + □□□□	□ + □□□ + □□□□□

A.2.3 Irregular verbs: □□ (□□/□□)

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
present	informal		□—□□□ + □
		□□□	□□□ + □□
	formal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
past	informal	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□
□ form	informal	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□
			□□□ + □□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
past conditional	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
representative	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
pseudo-future	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□
past pseudo-future	informal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
presumptive	plain	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□
	polite	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□
past presumptive	plain	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
	polite	□□□ + □□□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
hypothetical	neutral	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□□
	emphatic	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□
	formal (1)	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal (2)	□□□ + □□□□	

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
commanding	informal	□-□□□ + □	
		□-□□□ + □	□□□ + □
		□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□
	formal	□□□	□□□□□□
			(□□□□)
	formal (2)	□□□□□	□□□□□□
requesting	neutral	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
	formal	□□□□□□□	□□□□□□□□□
passive, honorific	informal	see note	□□□□
	formal	□□□□	□□□□□
causative	informal	see note	□□□□
	formal	□□□□	□□□□□
causative passive	informal	see note	□□□□□□
	formal	□□□□□□	□□□□□□□

inflection	replacement verb
humble	□□
honorific	□□□
potential	□□□

A.2.4 Irregular verbs: □□ (□□)

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
present	informal		□□□ + □ (□)
		□□□	□□□ + □□
	formal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
past	informal	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
□ form	informal	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□
			□□□ + □□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
past conditional	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□□
representative	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□□
pseudo-future	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□
past pseudo-future	informal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□□□
presumptive	plain	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□
	polite	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
past presumptive	plain	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□□

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
	polite	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
hypothetical	neutral	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□
	emphatic	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
	formal (1)	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
	formal (2)	□□□ + □□□□	
commanding	informal	□□□	□□□ + □
		□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□
		□□□ + □□□	(□□□ + □□□□)
	formal	□ + □□ + □□□	
	very formal	□ + □□ + □□□□	□ + □□ + □□□□□
requesting		□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
passive, honorific	informal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□
potential	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
causative	informal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
causative passive	informal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□

inflection	replacement verb
humble	□□
honorific	□□□□□

A.2.5 Special verbs: □□

Contractions in the inflections are indicated with (c), standard Japanese indicated with (□□□).

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
present	informal		□□ (□□□), □□□ + □□
	formal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
past	informal	□□□ + □ (c)	□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□
□ form	informal	□□□ + □ (c)	□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
past conditional	informal	□□□ + □□ (c)	□□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
representative	informal	□□□ + □□ (c)	□□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
pseudo-future	informal	□□□ + □ (c)	□□□ + □□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□
past pseudo-future	informal	□□□ + □□□ (c)	□□□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□□
presumptive	plain	□□□ + □□□	□□□□□□□□

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
	polite	□□□ + □□□□	□□□□□□
past presumptive	plain	□□□ + □□□□ (c)	□□□□□□□
	polite	□□□ + □□□□□ (c)	□□□□□□□□
hypothetical	neutral	□□□ + □	□□□□
	emphatic	□□□ + □□	□□□□
	formal (1)	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal (2)	□□□ + □□□□	
commanding	informal	□□□	
passive, honorific	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
potential	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
short potential	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
causative	informal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□
causative passive	informal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□□	□□□ + □□□□□□

inflection	replacement verb
polite	□□□

A.2.6 Special verbs: □/□□

inflection	politeness	affirmative	negative
present	plain	□	□□□□
			□□□□
	polite	□□	□□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□
past	plain	□□□	□□□□□□
			□□□□□□
	polite	□□□	□□□□□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□□□□
□ form	plain	□□□	□□□□□
			□□□□□
	polite	□□□	□□□□□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□□□□
past conditional	plain	□□□□	□□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□
	polite	□□□□	□□□□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□□□
representative	plain	□□□□	□□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□
	polite	□□□□	□□□□□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□□□□

inflection	politeness	affirmative	negative
pseudo-future	plain	□□□	□□□□□□
			□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□
	polite	□□□□	□□□□□□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□□□□□
past pseudo-future	plain	□□□□□	□□□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□□
	polite	□□□□	□□□□□□□□□□□
			□□□□□□□□□□□
hypothetical	I	□□	□□□□□□
	II	□□□	□□□□□□

Note that these verbs have special humble and honorific counterparts. For the humble copula, □+□□□ is used, and for the honorific copula, □+□□□□□□ is used. The verbs for these forms have special bases, which are listed in their own section.

A.2.7 Special verbs: □□

inflection	affirmative	negative
present	□□□	□□□ + □
past	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□□
□ form	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□
past conditional	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□□
representative	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□□
pseudo-future	□□□□□	□□□ + □□□□□
past pseudo-future	□□□ + □□□	□□□ + □□□□□□
hypothetical	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□
	□□□ + □	
commanding	□□□	

A.2.8 Verbal adjectives

Contractions in the inflections are indicated with (c)

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
present	informal	□□□	□□□ + □□
	formal	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□□
past	informal	□□□ + □□□ (c)	□□□ + □□□□
	formal		□□□ + □□□□□□□□

inflection	formality	affirmative	negative
□ form	informal	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□
	formal		□□□ + □□□
past conditional	informal	□□□ + □□□□ (c)	□□□ + □□□□□
	formal		□□□ + □□□□□□□□
pseudo-future	informal	□□□ + □□□ (c)	□□□ + □□□□
			□□□ + □□□□□
	formal	□□□ + □□□□	□□□ + □□□□□
			□□□ + □□□□□□□□
past pseudo-future	informal	□□□ + □□□□□(c)	□□□ + □□□□□
			□□□ + □□□□□□
	formal	□□□ +	□□□ + □□□□□□□
		□□□□□□ (c)	□□□ + □□□□□□□□□
hypothetical	neutral	□□□ + □	□□□ + □□□□
	emphatic	□□□ + □□	□□□ + □□□□
commanding	informal	□□□ + □□ (c)	

Classical adverb form

The following table shows the rules for using verbal adjectives as adverbs to classical verbs such as □□□ and □̊□□.

adjective written as …	becomes …
□□ ending in an □-row syllable + □	□□ ending in an □-row syllable + □
□□ ending in an □-row syllable + □	□□ ending in an □-row '◎' glide
□□ ending in an □-row syllable + □	the same □□ + □
□□ ending in an □-row syllable + □	the same □□ + □

Appendix B

Set phrases

Every language has its set phrases for things like thanking people, or excusing yourself, or phrases that are used idiomatically, meaning something other than what the words would literally imply, such as telling someone to "take a chair" or "make themselves at home". This appendix lists several common Japanese phrases, and per phrase gives the grammatical decomposition that can be made given all the material that has been presented in this book, with the phrases being ordered according to Japanese custom (starting at □ through □, and ending at □).

□ □□ □□□□□□□ — "Please come in"

Coming from the verb □□□ (□□□), this sentence literally says "please be raised". Its non-literal meaning comes from the fact that the traditional Japanese house has a raised floor at the entrance, where one takes off one's shoes and steps up into the house itself.

□□□□ □ □ □□□□□□ — "Thank you"

As mentioned in the adjective section, this is an example of classical adjective pronunciation, and is actually a long chain of conjugations:

□□ in □□□ + □□ in classical pronunciation + □□□ in □□□ + □□
□
□□ + □□□ + □□□ + □□
□
□□□□□□□□□□

This literally means "this is a difficult thing to accept", stemming from the concept of becoming indebted to someone who helps you. As becoming (further) indebted to someone

is always a hard thing to accept, this phrase is used instead of a separate word for thanking.

There are various ways to use this sentence, the most indebting being □□□□□□□□□□□□, which adds the word □□□ to the phrase, meaning "in all possible ways", coming from the question pronoun □□ (how, in what way) and the generalising pronoun suffix □.

Still formal indebting is □□□□□□□□□□. Just □□□□□, however, is not polite. It comes down to saying "thanks", and pays improper respect to people who do something for you and are of higher social status. Never just say □□□□□ to your teacher for instance. Always use □□□□□□□□□□.

This expression can either be used in present, or future, tense (□□□□□□□□□□) or it can be used in past tense (□□□□□□□□□□□), with the difference lying in when the thanking is being done: if it is after the fact, □□□□□□□□□□□ will be used, and if it's either prior to, or during whatever we're being thankful for, □□□□□□□□□□ is used.

□□□ — Disagreement

The Japanese version of "no". Alternatives to ◎◎◎ are the more colloquial ◎◎◎, and the more emphatic □□.

□□□□ — "Oh no", "this won't do"

This word is often used to express that something will not do, is about to be done wrong, or is at this very moment going wrong. It's technically the short potential form of ◎◎, □□□, and literally means "this cannot go". Used in this way, it is typically written in hiragana only.

□□□□□□ — Said when one is about to eat

This statement literally means "I will accept [this]", in the receiving meaning of accept, and is used when one is about to eat in the company of others. This is similar to, for instance, the Christian practice of giving thanks for the food about to be received, but without the religious aspect. When one is done eating, one uses □□□□□□□□ to indicate that one is done.

□ □□□□□□ — "I will go and come back"

This is said when one leaves a place that one expects to come back to. The most obvious example is when one goes off for one's job or school in the morning, when it is used to say goodbye to whoever is still in the house. The standard reply, if warranted, is □□□□□□□□.

□□□(□)□□□□□ — Said when someone who will return, leaves.

Literally this is the honorific version of the command □□□□□, "go and come back", where the speaker tells the listener to go on their business and come back afterwards. This phrase is said to people who are leaving a place where they are expected to return, such as their house, typically in response to □□□□□□. The first □ in the □□□□□□ part of □□□□□□□□ is typically omitted after a □ form, similar to how the □ in □□ is typically omitted when used with the □ form.

□□□□□□□□ — "Be welcome"

This is literally the commanding form of the honorific verb □□□□□□, and is used by tenants to welcome their customers into their place of business. It doesn't technically mean "be welcome", but that's what it has come to be considered to mean.

⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜ — "Welcome back"

This phrase is the typical response to ๏๏๏๏, and welcomes someone back home, or back to a place that can be considered a base of departure, such as your office, when you went out for a power meeting with management and have returned unscathed.

This phrase is technically the honorific commanding form of □□, "to return [to some base]":

๏ + ๏๏ in ๏๏๏ + ๏๏๏ in ๏๏๏
๏
๏ + ๏๏ + ๏๏๏
๏
๏๏๏๏๏๏

⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜ — "Thanks to you"

This phrase is a typical reply to the question ๏๏๏๏๏๏ ("how do you do?"), in which case it is usually preceded by an affirmative such as □□. It is also used frequently in situations where someone receives praise from someone who contributed to whatever the praise is for. Traditionally, a □ — meaning "shadow" or "shadow figure" — is used to mean someone who acts as the unseen driving force behind other people. Literally, saying □□□□ means "due to your being like a shadow for me", and can be interpreted as "because of [your] contributing actions, [I am where I am now, at this moment]".

⚜⚜⚜⚜ — "Get better", "stay well"

This phrase can be considered the statement ◎◎◎◎◎◎, "be well", with the ⊠⊠ left off. It is used as a general parting phrase with people who you will not be seeing the very next day, such as when seeing an incidental friend off, as well as a parting phrase for people who can use well-wishing, such as friends who seem a bit down.

⊠⊠⊠ — "How are you?"

This is a terribly misused phrase by people who start to take an interest in Japanese, who mistaken it for "hello".

◎◎◎◎◎◎ literally asks "are you ◎◎", which means that it asks whether someone is feeling good about things in general. This is something you do not ask someone every day, but only when you haven't seen someone in a while, or when there is a reason to ask them, such as when someone has just recovered from an illness. In this last case, the question may also be of the form ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠, meaning "are you ◎◎ again (already)?".

◎◎◎◎◎◎, people who are not ⊠⊠, are typically depressed, gloomy, glum, down and out, and for all intents and purposes a mood killer for everyone around them. Asking these people whether they are ⊠⊠ is a bit like driving home the point that they aren't happy with a big pointy stick, so instead the phrase ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠ is typically used, carefully remarking that they "do not seem very ◎◎".

⚜⚜⚜ — Said when leaving early

Said when leaving earlier than you normally would (namely when everyone else leaves), ⊠⊠⊠ literally says "before [you/everyone else]" and is short for ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠, itself short for ⊠⊠⊠[…]⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠ where the placehold is some action taken at a time that would be considered inappropriate. This can be met with three responses, namely either a set phrase such as ⊠⊠ ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠, ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠, or ⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠⊠ (in context typically translated as "okay" or "sure", rather than a literal "go ahead"). Or, of course, it might be met with surprise at the act of leaving early for no clear reason.

⊠⊠⊠ — Entering someone's house

The noun ⊠⊠ means obstruction or interference, and this sentence is a particularly good example of Japanese formality: this phrase is used when one is invited into a house. Courtesy demands that you indicate that even though you have been invited, you will intrude upon their home life by accepting this invitation and entering their house.

Because this phrase literally means "I'll be intruding", it can also be used when one really is intruding, such as breaking up an intimate conversation because you need to talk to one of the conversationalists, or when barging in on people.

□□□□□□ — Treating someone

□□ means caring, in the giveable caring kind of way. Paired with □□, the combination □□(□)□□ means "to give care to someone" in the positive sense, and is generally understood as meaning you will be treating someone to something. This phrase is used, for instance, when picking up the tab for someone (this will naturally be paired with some refusal by the treatee, and insistence on the part of the treater, but this is part of the Japanese process of doing things for people).

□□□□□□□□ — To be taken care of

Pairing □□ with the verb □□, "become", the combination □□□□□ means "to be taken care of by someone" in the positive sense. For instance, when someone is offering to do something for you like pay the bill after dinner, or take care of you when you're sick and you wish to oblige them, you use the phrase □□□□□□□□ to indicate that you will be taken care of in some way by them.

□□□□(□□) — "Take care"

□□ is a "valuable thing", in the figurative sense. When someone is told □□□□□□□□□, they are told to "please act in a way so that they are treating themselves as something valuable". This full sentence is often shortened to just ◎◎◎◎.

For instance, when saying goodbye to someone who you will not see in a while, you typically wish them □□□□ so that you may meet them again in good health at some point in the future.

□□□□(□□/□□□) — "You've worked hard"

□□□□ literally means "the appearance of tiredness", and comes from the noun form of the verb □□□, "to tire", prefixed with the honorific □ and suffixed with the more classical likeness suffix □. This statement is used when someone has performed a tiring job, or when one goes home after a day of working.

□□ □ □□□□□□□ — Being hungry

One states that one is hungry by saying their stomach has become empty. Variations on this theme are the plain past tense instead of formal past tense □□□□□□ or with the subject marker omitted, □□□□□. Colloquial versions are □□ □ □□□□□ (note the different pronunciation for □) or simply □□□□.

□□ □□□□□ — "Please"

Literally this phrase reads "(I) wish it", but is commonly interpreted as meaning "please" in the context of prompting someone to do something for you. It comes from the verb □□, to wish:

□ + □□ in □□□ + □□ in □□□ + □□
□
□ + □□ + □□□
□
□□□□□□

□□ □□□□□□□ — "Good morning"

This phrase doesn't actually contain the word "morning" in any way, which explains why it's possible to use this phrase at later points in the day. Literally, this is the statement □□□□, only in humble classical form:

□□ in classical form + □□□ of □□□ + □□
□
□□□□ + □□□ + □□
□
□□□□□□□□

This statement basically affirms that some meeting is reasonably early for when it occurs. For school goers, 8:30 am could be early; for bookmakers, 1 p.m. could be early. It all depends on when your daily routine day starts.

□□ □ □□□□□□ — "It's been a long time"

This phrase is actually grammatically quite interesting as it consists of a noun compound formed of the verbal adjective □□□, "long (timed)" and the verb □□, "to end/give up", which

as compound is turned into a noun and prefixed with the honorific particle □, covering all the major word groups (verb, adjective, noun and particle) in a single term:

□ + □□□ as □□ + □□ in □□□ (suffering from a voiced pronunciation as compound) + □□
□
□ + □□ + □□ + □□
□
□□□□□□□

This phrase is used when a silence between two people is broken after some time, be this in writing, by virtue of a phone call, or by actually seeing someone in person again.

□□□□□□□□□ — Congratulations

Literally this phrase is a combination of □□□□ (meaning auspicious) in classical form paired with □□□:

□ + □□□□ in classical form + □□□ in □□□ + □□
□
□ + □□□□ + □□□□□
□
□□□□□□□□□□

This phrase can be used with a million and one words to congratulate on any number of things, usually following the □ form of descriptions of what the congratulations are offered for:

□□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“Congratulations on getting married.”

□□□□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“Congratulations on your birthday.”

□□□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
“Congratulations on graduating.”

et cetera, et cetera.

□□□□□□ — “Good night”

This phrase is said when one goes to bed, and is repeated by those who wish you a good night. It is technically the honorific commanding form of □□, to rest, and is used to wish everyone else a good night too.

□ + □□ in □□□ + □□□ in □□□
□
□ + □□ + □□□
□
□□□□□□

□□□□□(□□□) — “Take care”, “Be careful”

Literally, this phrase instructs someone to apply □, in this case best translated as “vigilance”, to whatever it is they are, or will be, doing. It is used when you wish someone to be careful, such as when they are about to do something potentially dangerous — whether it’s rewiring a wall socket, or heading out in a storm at midnight without a torch — or when they’re going to be in an environment that may be hazardous in some way — be it starting a school term at a new school, or going off to do your job as a fireman.

□□□□(□□/□□□) — “Job well done”

Literally, this phrase doesn’t say “well done” at all, but actually translates to “it would appear that you have exerted considerable effort”, □□ (□□□), with the fact that this was actually “good” effort only being implied by the fact that you’re not being told you’ve done a bad job instead. This phrase can be used whenever someone has finished doing a tough job, or has had a rough day, but is typically reserved as a response to those of equal or lower standing.

This phrase is also used as a reply to □□□, when used by someone for whom it’s okay to leave work before others do (even if only by a few minutes). Colloquially the ◎ in ◎◎◎◎ can be replaced with ◎◎, to create the more relaxed sounding □□□□.

□□□□(□□□) — Said when one is done eating

This expression has no usable translation because it’s a customary saying. Literally this phrase means “it was a feast”, stemming from the noun □□ which means banquet and all

the things a banquet entails such as good food and decent entertainment, and the likeness suffix .

This phrase is the counterpart to the customary saying , said prior to consuming anything in the company of others.

— "Please excuse me"

This phrase is used in two common settings. The first is when hanging up on a phone conversation when you are the one hanging up, and the second is when you're entering a place which you know is someone else's, but you don't see anyone around. Literally, means dismissal, and this phrase asks for the listener to please dismiss your behaviour as it is intrinsically rude.

— "Please forgive me"

This construction is more oriented towards asking for forgiveness rather than just being excused. When you have done something wrong, and you know you did, apologise with .

This phrase is also used to turn down important offers, where the act of turning down the offer may lead to problems for the other party (such as when someone is depending on you, or when someone confesses their love for you).

When being specific about what you are asking forgiveness for, follows the description in form:

"I'm sorry for eating (your) cake."

— "Good day"

This is the particle (pronounced), added to the noun meaning "day" (pronounced instead of). It's technically an unfinished phrase just raising the topic of "today" and then saying absolutely nothing in regards to it, but this has become the standard way to say "good day" in Japanese.

— "Good evening"

Like , this is just added to , "this evening".

⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜ — "Farewell"

Realise the full meaning of this word before you use it: ◎◎◎◎◎ is short for ◎◎◎◎◎

forth. Because of all this dropping of terms, there are several statements that can be used which all mean the same thing, but varying in level of formality:

□□□□□□□□□□	formal polite
□□□□□□□□	formal polite
□□□□□□	casual polite
□□□□□□□	informal
□□□□□□	informal
□□□□	very informal

□ □□□□□ — “Thank you”, “Excuse me”

A prime example that Japanese conceptualises certain things differently, □□□□□ can actually mean “thank you” and “excuse me” at the same time when used. While meaning a simple “excuse me” if used when (for instance) bumping into someone in the street, it is also used when someone does something for you that will indebt you to them, such as catching your hat and handing it back if the wind catches it, or fixing some typos in an email you had written. Using □□□□□ in these instances means both “thank you for doing this for me” as well as “I’m sorry to have caused you to do this for me” at the same time.

This is technically the polite negative of □□, “to end”, indicating that the debt between the two parties involved remains unsettled. Variations on the theme include the more colloquial □□□□□ and very informal □□□□ and □□□.

When being specific about what you are thanking apologetically for, □□□□□ follows the description in □ form.

□□□
□□□□□□□□□□□
“Thank you for helping out, and sorry for somehow having made you do so.”

□□□□□ — “Is that so?”, “Really”, “I see”, “Aha”

This is a typical phrase that doesn’t mean what it seems to mean, even if half the time it does. Much like how half the time when a Japanese person says □□, they won’t mean “yes” but are only indicating they’re listening, □□□□□ is used to acknowledge that the speaker is still being listened to just as much as it’s used to genuinely ask “is that so?”.

Only the context of the conversation is an indicator whether it’s just a polite way to show that someone is still being listened to, or whether the listener is genuinely wondering about something said.

□□□□□ — Showing agreement

This phrase is often used when someone wants to emphatically agree in a conversation. It may also be used to indicate that the speaker has heard what has just been said and will respond to it, similar to □□. Misinterpreting it can lead to quite a bit of confusion:

A: □□□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

A: "Have you finished yet?"
B: "Ah, yes… not yet."

Here, B is first merely acknowledging that they heard the question, possibly even indicating that they think it's a good question, and the real answer comes after □□□□□.

□□□□ — "I'm back", "Right away"

There are three meanings to this phrase, although typically you will only be familiar with the first: when returning from something that one had to leave for (at which point an □□□□□□ would have been used), this phrase is used to signal the return. It is usually met with □□□□□□□, an idiomatic expression translating to "welcome back".

The second meaning is quite different. When given an order to perform some task, using □□□□ as response idiomatically translates to "right away". This use is typical in settings where someone is commanded to do something, such as in a master/servant relationship.

Lastly, □□□□ can also be used as a formal version of just □□, meaning "now". In this meaning, you may also find it used a lot in the expression □□□□□□[…], in which □□ is used in its classical (literary) meaning, being the same as the modern particle □□, with the expression translating to "starting now", "as of now" or "from this moment on".

⚜⚜ — "Please"

This is just the verb ◎◎, "to leave in someone's care", but is frequently used as an expression both when offloading something to someone else (which can be considered quite rude), to mean "please do this for me", or when someone offers to do something for you and is giving off all the signals that they're being serious instead of being polite, as an implicit "thank you".

⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜ - "Don't mention it", "you're welcome"

This phrase is used in response to an expression of gratitude. Similar to how in English one might be polite by responding to "Thank you very much" with "you're welcome" or "it was my pleasure", this phrase acts as both an acknowledgement of the gratitude, as well as an indicator that the gratitude should not be experienced to the degree that the person doing the thanking is expressing (similar to how in English one might go "no, no, it was nothing").

Grammatically speaking this construction is the humble version of ◎◎◎◎, but idiomatically these two expressions mean wildly different things, with ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯ being used to acknowledge or waive gratitude, and ▯▯▯▯ being used to enquire the "why" of something.

▯▯▯▯ — "What happened?"

Being a combination of the pronoun ▯▯, "how" or "in what way", and the past tense of ▯▯, this literally asks "by what way did […] happen?". However, it is interpreted to mean "what happened?", instead. ▯▯▯▯ is a short question to enquire what happened when someone seems upset, taken aback, or give off the impression that something happened that is unusual. A more formal way to ask this, though also more effeminate, is ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯.

▯▯▯▯(▯▯▯) — "Why?", "How come?"

This is the combination of ▯▯, "how", and the verb ▯▯ in ▯ form. Using just ▯▯▯▯ is technically an incomplete sentence, and implies that it should be finished with whatever verb best describes the situation that is being questioned. For instance, if someone refuses to help, the full sentence could be ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯▯, "why won't you help?", but just saying ▯▯▯▯ is enough to act as question.

▯▯▯ — Urging someone, "If it pleases you, …"

One of the power words in Japanese social language, ▯▯▯ is used whenever you wish to politely urge someone to do something. For instance, if one has just served tea to guests and wishes to urge the guests to start drinking, a ▯▯▯ combined with a sweeping hand gesture at the cups will convey the message that they should start drinking.

This word can frequently be heard in combination with urging requests, forming a more polite version of the request. For instance, the earlier entry ▯▯▯▯(▯▯▯▯) could be made more polite by turning it into ▯▯▯▯▯▯▯(▯▯▯▯).

□□□□□□ — "After you"

A common form of politeness in Japan (although arguably in any culture) is to repress your own feelings and desires so that others might benefit. Of the many ways in which this can be expressed, probably the most common way is letting other people do something before you get a chance to do them, such as opening a door for someone else to pass through first, or letting someone else queue up before you queue up.

The phrase combines □□□ with □□ ("before") in honorary form, translating to -- if we're translating the intention of the expression rather than the literal words -- "If it pleases [you], [allow me to let you do whatever I wanted to do] before [I do so, too]".

⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜⚜ — "Pleased to meet you"

"Pleased to meet you" is actually the "best cultural approximation" translation. The Japanese statement doesn't actually mean "pleased to meet you" at all, but relies on knowing what □□□□ means. Being a noun derived from □□□□, "agreeable/acceptable", this statement literally says that the speaker hopes that everything that is the result of this meeting is of a good nature. It's only used once, when you first meet someone in a setting where you will work together in some capacity, and is more accurately described as saying "please treat me well in our future dealings".

The more formal version is ๏๏๏๏๏๏๏๏๏๏๏๏๏๏๏, which adds the verb for "wishing" to the statement, thus expressing a sincere wish to be treated favourably in the future.

The short form, just □□□□, can be used in a broader setting to indicate you will leave something to someone under the assumption that all will be well, and is similar to □□ in this use.

□□(□□□) — "Why?"

This is the most direct version of "why", and is a pure interrogative; it's short, and literally means "what reason". Being the most direct, it's also quite rude, and there is no polite way to use this word, so it's best to try and avoid using it at all. Because it is technically a noun, it can be used in a softer form using □□, but even then this is still considered more direct than asking the other two versions of "why" with □□: □□□□□ or □□□□□□□.

□□(□□□) — "Why?"

This particular version of "why" is considered more direct than □□□□, but less direct than □□. It is indirect in that it literally asks "by which means [do you reason this way]?" or "by which means [did this situation arise]?", but is more direct because it's shorter than ๏๏๏๏ and thus sounds more curt.

□□ □□ □□□□□□□□□ — Being thirsty

When one is thirsty in Japan, one doesn't say "I am thirsty" but instead uses the less direct statement "my throat is dry", similar to how one could say "I am a bit parched" in English rather than saying "I'm a bit thirsty".

□□ — Acknowledgement

While generally understood to mean "yes", □□ actually signifies acknowledgement in general — it can be used as an acknowledging response to questions, in which case it means the same as "yes", but it can also be used to indicate that some speaker is still being listened to. Like □□□□□, this may lead to situations where □□ can be interpreted as either:

A: □□□□□□□□□□□□□
B: □□□□□□□□□□

A: "So, (you) know (what this means), (don't you)."
B: [acknowledges the question] "No."

Alternatives to □□ are the more colloquial □□ and the more explicitly acknowledging □□.

□□ □□□□ — A formal greeting used when meeting someone for the first time

Like □□□, this is technically an unfinished sentence, being the polite □ form of □□, "to start (something)", and comes from the original expression □□□□□□□□□□ literally translating to an acknowledgement that "this is the first time I have come before you". Consequently, □□□□ is used as a set phrase greeting when meeting someone for the first time. In a setting where there will be a lasting cooperation between you and whoever you say this to, the conversation will typically steer towards □□□□□□ or □□□□□□□□, depending on the whether you will be potentially relying on the other person a lot.

□□ □ □□□ — Getting upset

This phrase literally means "to raise [my] stomach", and is used to indicate something causes genuine upset or upset anger. Like being hungry or thirsty, being upset, too, is typically indicated by describing the physical feeling.

□□ □□ □□□□□□□□ — Extreme apology

Literally this phrase reads "[this is] not [a situation in which] saying [something] [is appropriate]". Effectively it means "I have no excuse [for what I have done]" and makes it clear that the speaker is genuinely at fault for something. Grammatically decomposing the phrase, we see:

□□ in □□□ + meaning/reason nominaliser □ + formal polite negation of □□
□□ + □ + □□□□□

Variations on this theme involve more, or less, formal versions of the verbs "to say" and "be", such as □□□□□, □□□□□, □□□□□□□□□, etc.

□□□□ — Said when picking up the phone

The story goes that this word was used because demons cannot pronounce it, and it would allow people to tell whether a real person had picked up the phone on the other end. Regardless of whether it's true (it's not, □□□□ comes from □□ □□□□, from the humble verb □□), it makes for a nice story to tell people when they get curious about the phrase that the Japanese use when they pick up the phone, or when it appears the signal has dropped during a conversation.

This phrase is also used to call someone's attention when they seem to be lost staring into the distance, similar to how one might yell "helloooo?" to someone who seems to have started day dreaming, in English.

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